

1. A Physicist in the Suburb

English

As a young **physicist** living in a quiet **suburb**, I, **myself**, kept a deep **curiosity** about how the ordinary world works. Every morning I would **go upstairs** to my small lab, switch on the **radio**, and study a **condenser**, watching the **current** flow and the way **conduction** and **induction** shaped each **particle** of charge. The work was **challenging**, yet **tranquil**, and I **cherish** it; I never **disclose** my methods carelessly. I would **polish** the glass until it began to **glitter**, take a **sample** of dust, and **locate** each **red flake** and speck of **soot** under the lens. My old dog would **wag** his tail and watch with me, as if he too felt the **itch** of inquiry. In **accordance** with an old habit, I kept a thick **volume** of notes, its pages an **abstraction** of every **consequence** I could imagine. A **beetle** once crawled across my **passport** on the desk, and I, the grateful **recipient** of so much quiet wonder, simply smiled. People in **retail** and **sociology** might call such labor **irrelevant**, but to me it felt **everlasting** and **relevant** to **existence** itself. I refused to be **disinclined** or **snobbish** about practical things; I had to **require** myself to keep an open **conscience**. A neighbor, a **programmer** who once worked **offshore**, would **invite** me for tea, and we would **mention** the news: a debate at the **United Nations**, the **abolition** of an unfair tax, an **exclusive** deal in **green** energy, and the **expulsion** of a corrupt official whose **bloody** schemes had begun to **stink**. **Provided** the weather held, I would walk down to a **triangle** of parkland near my **lodging**, where a bronze **puppet** show drew a crowd. I took an **oath** to myself that I would never let **exorbitant** ambition **mar** my calm. When a sudden **avalanche** of bad news arrived, I felt **perturbed**, but I would not go **mad**. I tried to **taste** each moment, to **pull** strength from small things, and to **commend** the **graceful** courage of friends. The **prince** of patience, my mentor used to say, is the person who can **multiply** small efforts into a **maximum** result. His **affirmation**, met with **unanimous** nods, was that a clear **conclusion** must **precede** any action. He warned that a single **token** gesture, a **silly bundle** of excuses, or a careless **tick** of the clock can **blow** away years of work. So I would **appreciate** the **upkeep** of habit, sit by the **grate**, and let the warmth seep into my **skin**, knowing the **resistance** of doubt would **ensue** but never win. I wrote a **prescription** for myself: stay curious, stay kind. Even when **ill**, I disclosed this much: that **spiritual operation**, the daily **relay** of hope across the **silicon** age, is what keeps a **tough** heart beating during a long **pregnancy** of ideas, and a **chap** can ask no more.

中文翻译

作为一名住在安静郊区的年轻物理学家，我自己对普通世界如何运作始终怀有深深的好奇心。每天早晨我都会上楼来到我的小实验室，打开收音机，研究一只冷凝器，观察电流的流动，以及传导和感应如何塑造每一个电荷粒子。这工作富有挑战性，却也宁静，我十分珍惜它。我会把玻璃擦到闪闪发光，取一份灰尘样本，在镜头下找出每一片红色的薄片和煤烟的斑点。我那条老狗会摇着尾巴和我一起观看，仿佛它也感到了探究的渴望。按照一个老习惯，我保留着一大卷笔记，那些书页是我所能想象到的每一个后果的抽象。一只甲虫曾爬过桌上我的护照，而作为如此多静谧奇迹的感恩接受者，我只是微笑。零售业和社会学界的人也许会说这样的劳作毫不相关，但对我而言，它感觉永恒，并且与存在本身息息相关。我拒绝变得不情愿或势利地看待实际的事；我必须要求自己保持一颗坦荡的良心。一位邻居，一个曾在海上工作的程序员，会邀请我喝茶，我们会谈起新闻：联合国的一场辩论、废除一项不公平税收、一桩绿色能源的独家交易，以及驱逐一名腐败官员，他那些血腥的阴谋已开始发臭。只要天气允许，我就会走到住所附近一片三角形的公园绿地，那里有青铜木偶戏吸引着人群。我向自己发誓，绝不让过度的野心损害我的平静。当突如其来的坏消息如雪崩般涌来时，我感到烦躁不安，但我不会发疯。我努力品味每一刻，从微小的事物中汲取力量，并赞美朋友们优雅的勇气。我的导师常说，耐心的王子，就是那个能把微小努力相乘成最大成果的人。他的论断得到一致点头认可：清晰的结论必须先于任何行动。他警告说，一个象征性的姿态、一堆愚蠢的借口，或钟表漫不经心的一声滴答，都可能吹走多年的心血。于是我会珍视习惯的维持，坐在炉边，让温暖渗入我的皮肤，明白怀疑的阻力会随之而来，却永远不会获胜。我为自己写下一张处方：保持好奇，保持善良。即使生病，我也透露这一点：那种精神上的运转，那种在硅时代里希望的每日接力，正是让一颗坚韧的心在漫长的思想孕育期里持续跳动的东西，而一个普通人别无所求。

2. The Adviser of Lowland Town

English

Supposing you ever visit the lowland town where I grew up, seek out the old adviser who once served the cabinet of the regional council. He was a wise practitioner of public life, a man of rare virtue, and he could numerate every family living within the perimeter of the valley. He would speak respectfully to each citizen, never trite, never proud, and he refused any abasement of his office. People said his judgment was precisely balanced, like a fine differential gear, and that he could exonerate the innocent and restrain the guilty with equal calm. The town had known real adversity. A bomb scare one chilly weekend had nearly crippled the local economy, and a long shortage of work left many jobless. The constabulary, stretched thin, leaned on him for recommendation and guidance. He did not panic; he simply built a clear guideline, a numerical plan that anyone could read in a book, and he would constantly remind us, "Do not let fear reign." By analogy, he said, a town is like a body: suppress one part and the whole will recede. His underlying belief was that good order is no mundane achievement but a daily practice. I remember the day a wealthy nominee from downtown arrived, hoping to manipulate the vote and claim a kind of sovereignty over our affairs. He was charming on the surface, with a fragrant cologne and a purple silk tie, yet wary eyes. He tried to tug the council toward his obsession with profit, hinting that he could afford whatever he liked. The adviser, disposed to fairness, was not impressed. He would not swear an oath he could not keep, and he warned the man that greed afflicts a community like an overdose afflicts a patient. "Your suggestion has nil merit," he said, to the astonishment of the room. The nominee, embarrassed, soon left. That evening, over a pot of tea poured from an old teapot, the adviser told me an aspect of his philosophy that I still cherish. Life, he explained, is heterogeneous and variegated; it cannot be reduced to one tie-up of interests. Some days are warm and others chilly; some are salty with grief. He spoke of a friend whose fracture of trust had never healed, and of a bridegroom whose joy, though tolerable to envy, was real. He believed every emotion, even the embarrassing ones, deserves a tolerable place. Then he showed me his diary, where each entry was a small display of honest thought, like an advertisement for decency. He told me to climb steadily, to make a reservation in my heart for kindness, and to apply a clean dressing of lint to every wound. As the glacier of years recedes, I think of him often. His example, met with promptly given respect, taught me that to compete well is to compete fairly, and that suppression of the weak is the opposite of strength. Even a grandchild of his still keeps that lesson, spraying it forward like fresh water on dry ground, a breakthrough of memory that no adversity can erase. It would astonish you how social intercourse and a simple exam of the books, especially under the law, can restore balance. The adviser, awfully tired, chose to delegate tasks rather than damn the staff or let stress afflict and cripple morale. He cut his caffeine intake, booked a massage, and avoided the rigid hierarchy. Inevitably, with countable wins and a plastic spray of optimism, the town recovered.

中文翻译

假如你有朝一日造访我长大的那座低地小镇，去找那位曾为区议会内阁服务的老顾问吧。他是公共生活中一位睿智的从业者，一个拥有罕见美德的人，他能数出住在山谷周界以内的每一户人家。他对每位市民都恭敬地说话，从不陈腐，也从不骄傲，他拒绝让自己的职位有任何屈尊降格。人们说他的判断精确而平衡，像一台精密的差速齿轮，他能以同样的镇定为无辜者昭雪、约束有罪者。这座小镇曾经历真正的逆境。一个寒冷周末的炸弹惊吓几乎使当地经济瘫痪，长期的工作短缺让许多人失业。警力捉襟见肘，便依靠他来获取建议和指引。他没有惊慌；他只是制定了一份清晰的方针，一个任何人都能在书里读懂的数字计划，并不断提醒我们：“别让恐惧统治一切。”他用类比说，小镇就像一个身体：压制其中一部分，整体就会衰退。他内在的信念是，良好的秩序绝非平凡的成就，而是一种日常的实践。我记得那天，一位来自市中心的富有候选人到来，希望操纵选票，声称要对我们的事务拥有某种主权。他表面上很迷人，带着芬芳的古龙水和一条紫色丝绸领带，眼神却充满戒备。他试图把议会拉向他利润的痴迷，暗示他想要什么都买得起。这位倾向公正的顾问并不为所动。他不会发一个自己无法信守的誓，他警告那人，贪婪折磨一个社区，正如用药过量折磨一个病人。“你的提议毫无价值，”他说，满座皆惊。那候选人尴尬不已，很快便离开了。那天晚上，就着一只旧茶壶倒出的茶，顾问告诉了我一个我至今珍视的他的哲学侧面。他解释说，生活是异质而斑驳的；它无法被简化为一种利益的捆绑。有些日子温暖，有些寒冷；有些咸涩着悲伤。他谈起一位朋友，其信任的裂痕从未愈合，也谈起一位新郎，其喜悦虽令人嫉妒却真实可容。他相信每一种情感，哪怕是令人尴尬的，都该有一个可容许的位置。然后他给我看他的日记，每一篇都是诚实思想的小小展示，像一则关于体面的广告。他叫我稳步攀登，在心里为善良留一份预订，并给每一道伤口敷上干净的软麻布。随着岁月这条冰河的退去，我常常想起他。他的榜样，连同迅速给予的尊敬，教会我：要好好竞争，就是要公平地竞争，而压制弱者正是力量的反面。就连他的一个孙辈也仍记着这一课，把它像清水洒在干涸土地上那样向前传递，一种逆境无法抹去的记忆的突破。你会惊讶于社会交往和对账目的一次检查，尤其是在法律之下，竟能恢复平衡。那位顾问累得要命，选择把任务委派出去，而不是责骂员工或让压力折磨并削弱士气。他减少了咖啡因的摄入，预约了按摩，避开僵化的等级制度。最终，凭着可数的胜利和一抹塑料般的乐观，小镇得以复苏。

3. A Team Studies the Changing Beach

English

Our research team spent one bright Saturday morning on a windswept beach, studying the environmental forces that shape the coast. The work was challenging, but the satisfaction was tremendous. We measured the diameter of eroded stones, charted the dimension and texture of the sand, and recorded the fluctuation of the tide with similar care to the way a banker tracks money. Our monitor blinked on the screen as a turbine offshore turned in the wind, its power feeding the village nearby. None of us was idle. The structure of the cliff, weary with age and decrepit in places, told a long story of nature's patience. A patch of bright fleece-like moss clung to the bronze-colored rock, and the fur of a curious seal glistened in the spray. I am similar in temperament to my colleagues: rarely uninterested, always eager to comment and seek the truth. We did not quarrel, though we did debate. One member, a seasoned statistician, advocated a cautious prediction; he disliked any guess that lacked proof. Another, more cynical, made a sarcastic remark and seemed almost hateful of optimism, but his firmness kept us honest. There was a tacit, demonstrative trust between us, an equivalence of respect that no establishment could mandate. We knew our employment depended on accuracy, so we sought to procure the most efficient instruments money could buy. By noon the boil of activity had eased. We paused near an old monument, a stone tablet erected by an Indian colony and an African trader who once met here to forge a trade route. The history of this outlet to the sea is rich; ships once paid a heavy fare to anchor, and a single seller could grow wealthy overnight. Now a scenic villa stands where the forge once roared, and tourists arrive by ferry to listen to the waves. I felt a tasteful satisfaction in the contrast. We did not let the cinema of the past distract us, yet it would be regrettable to ignore it. As an individual, I find that history and science alternate in my mind like the tide. Our employer, a member of parliament with a famous prejudice against waste, would not veto a satisfactory report, but he had warned us that any implicit error could ruin the project. So we worked to assimilate every fact, to fill each bucket of data, and to nail down conclusions firmly. The pedal of the survey cart squeaked as we pushed it along; my forehead was damp; my hands, scrubbed with shampoo that morning, were now gritty. Still, the cosmopolitan crowd of gulls overhead seemed to cease their cries in approval. By evening we walked the lace of the shoreline back toward dinner, weary but content, having watched vapor rise from the warm flats and a single crane wade through the marsh. The division of labor had worked. A great power, I realized, lies not in any one tremendous discovery but in the steady, greatly shared effort of a team that refuses to disappoint itself. Suppose, after a big game of badminton, the team gathered for a briefing that felt almost like a ritual or a sermon. One advocate would dislike the seductive but ostensible promises of easy profit; such talk could exasperate anyone. They discussed a paternity case, a pregnant pause in trade as the firm planned to reexport goods, and even the parking crisis, before each encounter ended in agreement.

中文翻译

我们的研究小组在一个明亮的星期六上午，在一片狂风拂过的海滩上度过，研究塑造海岸的种种环境力量。这项工作富有挑战性，但带来的满足感是巨大的。我们测量被侵蚀石块的直径，绘制沙子的大小尺度与纹理，并以银行家追踪钱财般的同样细致记录潮汐的波动。当一台离岸的涡轮机在风中转动、为附近村庄供电时，我们屏幕上的监视器闪烁着。我们没有人闲着。那悬崖的结构因年迈而疲惫，有些地方已经衰朽，讲述着大自然耐心的漫长故事。一片明亮、似羊毛的苔藓紧贴在青铜色的岩石上，一只好奇海豹的毛皮在浪花飞沫中闪光。我和同事们性情相似：很少不感兴趣，总是热切地评论、探求真相。我们没有争吵，尽管确实辩论过。一位经验丰富的统计员主张谨慎的预测；他厌恶任何缺乏证据的猜测。另一位更愤世嫉俗，说了句讽刺的话，似乎几乎憎恶乐观，但他的坚定让我们保持诚实。我们之间有一种心照不宣的、外露的信任，一种任何机构都无法强制规定的对等尊重。我们自己的工作取决于准确，因此设法采购金钱能买到的最高效的仪器。到了中午，活动的沸腾平息下来。我们在一座古老的纪念碑旁停下，那是一块石碑，由一个印度殖民地和一位非洲商人竖立，他们曾在此相遇以开辟一条贸易路线。这个通向大海的出口历史丰富；昔日船只只要付高昂的船费才能停泊，一个卖家可能一夜暴富。如今铁匠铺曾轰鸣之处矗立着一座风景如画的别墅，游客乘渡船前来聆听海浪。我在这种对比中感到一种高雅的满足。我们没有让过去的影像分散注意，但忽视它也将令人遗憾。作为个体，我发现历史与科学在我脑中如潮汐般交替。我们的雇主，一位以厌恶浪费而著称、怀有偏见的国会议员，不会否决一份令人满意的报告，但他警告我们，任何隐含的错误都可能毁掉这个项目。于是我们努力吸收每一个事实，装满每一桶数据，并把结论牢牢钉死。勘测推车的踏板在我们推动时吱呀作响；我的额头湿了；我那天早上用洗发水搓洗过的手，如今沾满沙砾。然而头顶上那群世界各地飞来的海鸥，似乎停止了鸣叫以示赞许。傍晚时分，我们沿着海岸线的花边走回去吃晚饭，疲惫却满足，看着温暖的滩涂升起水汽，一只鹤独自涉过沼泽。分工奏效了。我意识到，伟大的力量不在于任何一项巨大的发现，而在于一个拒绝让自己失望的团队稳定而广泛共享的努力。假设在一场盛大的羽毛球比赛之后，球队聚在一起开了个简报会，那气氛几乎像一场仪式或布道。一位倡导者会厌恶那些诱人却表面的轻松获利承诺；这种话能激怒任何人。他们讨论了一桩亲子关系案件、贸易中怀孕般的停顿（公司计划把货物再出口），甚至还有停车难题，最后每一次交锋都以一致同意收场。

4. A Risky Voyage to Scotland

English

It would be no exaggeration to say that my journey to Scotland was the most risky trip of my life, yet I would not trade it for anything. I had read an entire encyclopaedia entry about the region, written in such illegible old handwriting that I nearly gave up; but a single scenic paragraph about its barren moors and ancient empire of clans persuaded me to move. I packed light: a diary, a bottle of cheap perfume, a complimentary guidebook the agency gave me gratis, and an adequate supply of food. No reader could call me studious, but I do my homework. The voyage began on a crowded ferry. The captain, a civil man with a strong jaw, gave us a brief and reassuring address. "There is no menace today," he said, though static crackled on the radio and a sudden squall made the deck rotate beneath us. A van full of crates had to be lashed down with a jack and rope so it would not slide into the ditch of the lower hold. I felt my impulse to panic, but I would not plead for an early return. As we sailed, the sea began to sparkle. A crane lifted cargo on the far pier; gulls dove for crisp scraps; and the spray on my skin was cold enough to dazzle the senses. A fellow passenger, an immigrant from a distant empire, told me with an incredulous smile that he had once nearly drowned when a ferry sank, and he showed me, without spite, the proof: a long scar where a stake had nearly stabbed him. His story did not frighten me; it only sharpened my zealous wish to see everything. He spoke of the necessity of courage, and of the capacity of the human heart to recover. When at last we landed, the porch of the little inn glowed warm against the marsh. A sheriff with a sarcastic wit checked our papers; a bureaucracy of forms had to be edited and signed, and I had to magnify the tiny print with a lens to read it. The price of a room was high, but the owner, eager to guarantee my comfort, gave me a free pat of butter and a slice of bread with my dinner, and promised the rate would not rush upward. That night, by candlelight, I wrote in my diary about the strange snout of a wild boar I had glimpsed in the brood of trees, about the cement walls of a ruined chapel, and about the contemplation that fills a traveler's mind at rest. I confess my golf clubs stayed in their bag the whole trip; there was simply too much to see. A nuisance of midges plagued the doorway, and the running stream nearby never ceased its music. The static of worry faded. I learned that to magnify a small life with bold travel is no false promise but a real necessity, and that even a barren land can dazzle a willing heart. When the fury of the weather finally calmed and a ghastly fog lifted, I smiled, made one last assessment of my route, and began the long journey home. Along the road, the journey hit a snag. Our guide, once a pupil of an old conqueror's tale, tried to reassure us and converse calmly, though his nasal voice carried an uncomfortable edge. He would not edit the truth or add fluff: the arbitrary bill for the ferry was a pitfall, a real detriment to efficiency. To persuade the crowd, he raised an outcry against waste, explaining how industrialized agriculture could distend budgets. The implication was clear, sharp as a stab; even a disabled cart on our flank felt the hardness of the climb. They agreed to release the funds, and added a small suffix of thanks to the contract.

中文翻译

毫不夸张地说，我前往苏格兰的旅程是我一生中最冒险的一次，然而我不会拿它换任何东西。我读过整整一条关于该地区的百科全书词条，字迹是那种古老到几乎难以辨认的笔迹，我差点放弃；但其中一段风景如画、描写其荒芜的沼地和古老氏族帝国的文字，说服了我动身。我轻装上路：一本日记、一瓶廉价香水、旅行社免费赠送的一本导游手册，以及充足的食物供应。没有读者会说我是个勤学的人，但我会做功课。这次航行从一艘拥挤的渡船开始。船长是个下巴坚毅、彬彬有礼的人，给我们做了简短而令人安心的讲话。“今天没有威胁，”他说，尽管收音机里噼啪作响的静电干扰，一阵突如其来的飑使甲板在我们脚下旋转。一辆装满板条箱的货车必须用千斤顶和绳索固定，以免它滑进下层货舱的沟里。我感到想惊慌的冲动，但我不会恳求提前返航。航行途中，大海开始闪耀。远处码头上台起重机吊起货物；海鸥俯冲去抢酥脆的残渣；溅在我皮肤上的浪花冷得令人眩目。一位同船的旅客，来自遥远帝国的移民，带着难以置信的微笑告诉我，他曾在一艘渡船下沉时几乎淹死，并且毫无怨恨地给我看了证据：一道长长的伤疤，那里曾有一根木桩差点刺穿他。他的故事没有吓到我；只是让我热切想看遍一切的愿望更加强烈。他谈到勇气的必要，谈到人心恢复的能力。当我们终于登陆时，那间小客栈的门廊在沼泽映衬下散发着温暖的光。一位带着讽刺机智的警长检查了我们的证件；一堆官僚的表格需要修改和签字，我得用透镜放大那细小的字才能读。一间房的价格很高，但急于保证我舒适的老板，在晚餐时免费给了我一块黄油和一片面包，并承诺房价不会急速上涨。那晚，借着烛光，我在日记里写下：我在那片树林里瞥见的野猪奇怪的猪嘴、一座废弃小礼拜堂的水泥墙，以及旅人休息时心中充满的冥想。我承认我的高尔夫球杆整趟旅程都待在包里；要看的东西实在太多了。一群讨厌的蚊虫在门口作祟，附近流动的小溪从不停止它的乐声。忧虑的静电消散了。我懂得了：以大胆的旅行放大一段渺小人生，并非虚假的承诺，而是真实的必需，即使一片荒芜之地也能使一颗甘愿的心眩目。当天气的狂怒终于平息、一团苍白可怕的雾散去时，我微笑了，对路线做了最后一次评估，便踏上漫长的归途。沿着这条路，旅程遇到了障碍。我们的向导曾是一位老征服者故事的学生，他努力让我们安心，平静地交谈，尽管他带鼻音的嗓音透着一丝令人不适的意味。他不愿粉饰真相或添加废话：渡船那笔武断的账单是个陷阱，是对效率的真正损害。为了说服众人，他大声疾呼反对浪费，解释工业化农业如何让预算膨胀。其含义如刀刺般清晰；连我们侧翼一辆抛锚的残破推车也感受到攀爬的艰难。他们同意拨款，并在合同上加了一小段感谢的后缀。

5. The Polar Charity Gala

English

The presentation began at eighty seconds past eight, when the lights of the grand showroom clicked on and an ensemble of musicians struck the first notes of the national anthem. This was no ordinary night: it was a voluntary charity gala held to fight poverty and hunger, and every member of the committee had worked to make it perfectly run. I will not betray the names of our donors, but I can say their generosity was unprecedented. A famous youth choir sang in harmony while a screen behind them showed a polar landscape of ice, a lone dove circling above an icy grove of shrub and berry. The theme that year was "thirst for justice," and the emancipation of the poor from misfortune was on everyone's mind. Our host had the easy-going charm of a born performer. He asked the crowd, bravely, to dig deep. "It would be a shame," he said, "to detach ourselves from those in pain." He wore a neat vest and angled his body toward the back rows so no one felt ignored. Earlier that week we had to minimize costs; prices had begun to skyrocket, and the gap between our budget and our goal made my heart sink. I confess I felt the sting of doubt, the same sight of red numbers that can discourage any earnest organizer. One sponsor, an inept and snobbish man, scolded us for our methodology and tried to slander the cause, claiming our purity of motive was a sham. His bias was clear. But the testimony of the families we had helped, and the sheer harmony of the room, defeated his cynicism. A young woman, once arrested unjustly and later freed when the real bandit confessed, gave a speech that made the whole body of guests rise. She had every reason to fret, yet she spoke without anger. "Do not let any single misfortune ruin your hope," she said. "In the foreseeable future, we can bestow on one another the better world we all deserve." Even the murderer of joy could not have stayed unmoved. By midnight the donations had multiplied. We had asked for a modest sum and received far more; the cone-shaped collection jar overflowed, and a staggered line of guests waited to give. As the escalator carried the last visitors down past a wall of clothing donations, I felt no malaise, only gratitude. The character of a community, I thought, is measured not by its wealth but by its willingness to share. We had not solved poverty in one night, but we had narrowed the gap. The smoke of the celebratory candles drifted up; someone smiled and said sorry for crying. Soon the hall fell quiet, and I stood alone, perfectly content, watching the polar scene fade from the screen. I have to ask: what is the scope of a single show? The performance itself could stagger you. One act mixed gymnastics and boxing; a dancer in a bright skirt would tilt and balance on one leg, graceful as a lioness. A puppet shaped like a sphinx rose on a periscope-like pole with a click, while a paper cock crowed. Behind the scenes, the air-conditioning hummed, and a coalition of stagehands tried to delete every flaw and avoid ineffectiveness. There was no illegal trick, no effluent dumped from the kitchen where they served pie. Yet turmoil nearly arrived: a sponsor's resignation, a late notification, a predisposition to panic. They had to commit, to shear away the fluff, to fork over more cash, to cruise past the danger and not dump the project. The crew could arrest the chaos, restore digestion of the schedule, and the reproduction of the act ran like clockwork. After a quick shampoo of fresh ideas, they angled it from a new angle and turned a likely defeat into triumph.

中文翻译

演出在八点过八十秒时开始，那时宏伟陈列厅的灯光啪地亮起，一支乐手组成的合奏团奏响了国歌的第一个音符。这不是一个普通的夜晚：这是一场为对抗贫困与饥饿而举办的自愿慈善晚会，委员会的每一位成员都努力使它办得完美无缺。我不会泄露捐赠者的名字，但我可以说他们的慷慨是前所未有的。一支著名的青年合唱团和谐歌唱，他们身后的屏幕展示着一片极地的冰雪风景，一只孤独的鸽子在结冰的灌木与浆果树丛上空盘旋。那一年的主题是“对正义的渴望”，把穷人从不幸中解放出来是每个人心头之事。我们的主持人有着天生表演者那种逍遥自在的魅力。他勇敢地请人群慷慨解囊。“把自己与受苦之人分离开来，”他说，“将是一种耻辱。”他穿着整洁的马甲，把身体侧向后排，好让没有人觉得被忽视。那周早些时候我们不得不把成本降到最低；物价开始猛涨，我们的预算与目标之间的差距让我心沉。我承认我感到怀疑的刺痛，那种能让任何认真的组织者泄气的、满眼红色数字的景象。一位赞助人，一个无能又势利的男人，因我们的方法责骂我们，并试图诽谤这项事业，声称我们动机的纯洁是一场骗局。他的偏见显而易见。但我们帮助过的家庭的证词，以及全场纯粹的和谐，击败了他的愤世嫉俗。一位曾被冤枉逮捕、后因真正的歹徒认罪而获释的年轻女子发表了讲话，使全体来宾起立。她有充分的理由烦恼，却毫无怒气地讲话。“不要让任何一次不幸毁掉你的希望，”她说，“在可预见的未来，我们可以彼此赋予我们都应得的更美好的世界。”即便是欢乐的杀手也不会无动于衷。到午夜时，捐款已经翻了好几倍。我们请求的是一笔不大的款项，收到的却远远更多；锥形的募捐罐溢了出来，一排错落的客人排队等着捐赠。当自动扶梯载着最后的来访者下行、经过一整墙的衣物捐赠时，我没有感到任何不适，只有感激。我想，一个群体的品格，不是以它的财富来衡量，而是以它分享的意愿来衡量。我们没有在一夜之间解决贫困，但我们缩小了差距。庆祝蜡烛的烟雾袅袅升起；有人微笑着为自己的流泪道歉。很快大厅安静下来，我独自站着，心满意足，望着极地的景象从屏幕上渐渐淡去。我不得不问：一场演出的范围有多大？演出本身就能让你目瞪口呆。有一幕融合了体操与拳击；一位身着鲜艳裙子的舞者单腿倾斜并保持平衡，优雅如母狮。一个斯芬克斯造型的木偶随着一声咔嚓声沿潜望镜般的杆子升起，一只纸公鸡随之啼鸣。后台空调嗡嗡作响，一群舞台工作人员组成的联盟努力删除每一处瑕疵，避免低效。没有任何非法把戏，厨房（供应派饼之处）也没有排放污水。然而骚乱险些降临：一位赞助商辞职、一份迟到的通知、一种易于恐慌的倾向。他们必须全力以赴，剪掉冗余，掏出更多现金，平稳驶过险境而不放弃项目。剧组制止了混乱，恢复了日程的消化，节目的再现如钟表般精准。在新点子洗礼之后，他们换了个角度，把可能的失败变成了胜利。

6. The Electrician's Promising Investment

English

Let me assure you, the making of a small business is never faultless work. My uncle, a bespectacled electrician with a love of order, decided to lease a workshop near a foggy creek and sort out a promising new venture. His viewpoint was fundamental and simple: build something dependable, and the customers will come. He was no coward, but neither was he reckless; he would estimate every fee, study each indicator, and refuse to disregard the smallest risk. A confidential adviser had told him the investment could yield a steady dividend, provided he kept his books in order. Common sense, the adviser said, is the principle that should guide every decision, and inversely, greed will topple even the strongest firm. The classification of his tools filled an entire household bed of shelves: coils of yarn-like wire, a barometer, a humble nut-and-pipe assortment, a spotlight, a hook, and a heavy log he used as a doorstop. He worked indoors during the cold months and elsewhere when the weather allowed. One nameless morning, an elated customer rushed in, frightened that her nuclear-powered home generator had failed. My uncle, ever trustworthy, did not flatter her or make needless promise; he simply rolled up his sleeves. The fault, he could infer, was a corroded part where rust had begun to erode the metal, leaving slag and a foul smell. Some misguided rival might have charged a gratuity-sized fortune, but he asked only a modest fee. "It would be a shame," he said, "to torture an honest person with a padded bill." His common decency was his finest principle. As the work neared its ending, he explained each step, careful to interpret the technical terms so she would not feel like an alien in her own home. He showed her how to decrease waste, how a single homogeneous batch of cable could safeguard the whole circuit, and how a tiny modification could revoke years of inefficiency. The quietness of his manner reassured her. She left no longer unlucky but grateful, and she promised to tell the whole locality. Business, he often said, is a kind of fellowship; you sell trust before you sell anything else. He had no wish to be a hero or a politician, no monumental ambition; he simply wanted his childhood dream of a steady trade to come true. When I asked whether he ever felt the pull to expand, to chase prestige and become dependent on bankers, he only laughed. "Forward, yes," he said, "but slowly. A man who learns to read the indicator of his own contentment is rich enough." That, I think, is the truest principle of all. Consider a business as varied as a ship's berth. Good utilization of every asset matters, from the radial tires on the jet-black delivery van to the visual displays in the showroom. A bony old manager in a mackintosh, who loved gardening on weekends, wrote plain prose, not raucous colloquial slogans. He kept aspirin in his pocket for headaches, a tube of cream for his hands, and a mythical calm that could frighten rivals. He noted the asymmetry in the market like a tiger watching prey, sought the shade of caution, and treated each setback as an exoneration rather than defeat, as if a healthy gland of optimism fed a whole regiment of staff.

中文翻译

让我向你保证，创办一家小企业从来不是毫无瑕疵的工作。我的叔叔，一个戴眼镜、喜爱秩序的电工，决定在一条雾蒙蒙的小河边租下一间作坊，整顿出一桩前途光明的新生意。他的观点根本而简单：造出可靠的东西，顾客自会上门。他不是懦夫，但也不鲁莽；他会估算每一笔费用，研究每一个指标，拒绝漠视最小的风险。一位负责机密事务的顾问曾告诉他，只要把账目保持有序，这项投资能产生稳定的红利。那顾问说，常识是应当指导每个决定的原则，反过来，贪婪会使最强的公司倒塌。他工具的分类摆满了一整排家用床那么大的架子：一卷卷像纱线般的电线、一只气压计、一套朴素的螺母和管子、一盏聚光灯、一只钩子，还有一根他当门挡用的沉重圆木。寒冷的月份他在室内工作，天气允许时则到别处去。一个无名的清晨，一位兴高采烈的顾客冲了进来，惊恐于她那台核能家用发电机出了故障。我叔叔一如既往地值得信赖，没有奉承她，也没有作出不必要的承诺；他只是卷起袖子。他能推断出，毛病出在一个被腐蚀的零件上，锈已开始侵蚀金属，留下炉渣和难闻的气味。某个被误导的同行也许会收取一笔赏钱般的巨款，但他只要了不多的费用。“用虚报的账单去折磨一个诚实的人，”他说，“将是一种耻辱。”他普通的正派就是他最好的原则。当工作接近尾声时，他解释每一个步骤，仔细地把技术术语解释清楚，好让她不至于在自己家里像个外人。他向她展示如何减少浪费，一批同类的电缆如何能保护整个电路，一个微小的改动如何能撤销多年的低效。他举止的安静使她安心。她离开时不再不走运，而是心怀感激，还答应把整个地区的人都告诉。他常说，生意是一种交情；你在卖任何东西之前，先卖的是信任。他无意成为英雄或政客，没有纪念碑式的雄心；他只想让自己童年那个稳定生意的梦想成真。当我问他是否曾感到扩张的冲动，去追逐声望、变得依赖银行家时，他只是笑了。“前进，是的，”他说，“但要慢慢来。一个学会读懂自己满足感这一指标的人，就已经足够富有了。”我想，那才是所有原则中最真实的一条。想想一桩像船舶泊位一样多样的生意。每一项资产的利用都很重要，从送货厢式车上的子午线轮胎到陈列室里的视觉展示。一位身材瘦削、穿着雨衣、周末爱好园艺的老经理，写朴实的散文，而非沙哑的口语口号。他口袋里备着阿司匹林治头痛，一支护手霜，以及一种能吓退对手的神话般的镇定。他像老虎盯猎物般注意市场的不对称，寻求谨慎的荫蔽，把每次挫折当作昭雪而非失败，仿佛一枚乐观的腺体滋养着整团员工。

7. A Freshman's Confession at Dawn

English

The **confession** came at **dawn**, when the **frosty** light first touched the **snowbound** campus. A **freshman** named Theo, **formerly** a quiet boy from a **herd** of country cousins, sat in the **dry**, cold lecture hall and decided to **solve** the puzzle that had begun to **pester** him. **Originally** he had wanted only **good** marks; now he wanted to **organize** his whole life. He was no **winner** yet, but he was **cautious** and **modest**, and he refused to be **reckless**. The **address** he gave that morning, **publicly** and with a **low**, steady voice, was meant as a kind of **moral debate** with himself. "I will not let **temporary** comfort cripple my future," he said. "I have a vocation to pursue." His **complaint**, if you could call it that, was simple: too many of his classmates lived on **inexpensive** habits and idle **excess**, treating study as a **primitive** chore rather than an **activity** of joy. He wanted a **cure** for that **coldness**. **Presumably** the others thought him strange. One **motorist** friend, a **cyclist** on weekends, asked him **independently** whether he had gone mad. **Besides**, the boy added, the **deterioration** of his sleep had begun to worry him. He would work past **midnight**, **suck** on cold coffee, and **rinse** his face to stay awake. A **comparative** glance at his peers gave him no comfort. With **permission** from his temporary adviser, he adopted a new plan, a **quantitative** one, to **vary** his routine and to **enable** real rest. He would not flatter himself with excuses. He learned to organize his notes, to confirm each fact, and to seek **confirmation** before acting. He found that a little **restriction**, far from being a **torment**, set him free. Besides his books, he kept a small **spade** for the campus garden, where he turned the **turf** and planted seeds in the frosty soil; the green shoots, when they came, gave him a **kindness** of spirit no lecture could. He even built a **snowman** one snowbound afternoon, laughing like a child, and the simple **flavour** of that joy surprised him. He realized that to **emancipate** himself from fear, he had to act with **coherence** and not let his **nest** of doubts congest his mind. His **leader**, a wise old teacher, did not scold or **accuse**; she would **commentate** gently, never reckless with a young heart. "You cannot **purge** every fault at once," she told him. "**Inasmuch** as you keep trying, you will improve." Theo left the hall as the dawn brightened, no longer **unhappy**. He was not yet a **foreigner** to doubt, but the **sickness** of despair had begun to recede. The footsteps behind him were his own, steady and sure, and the **obtainable** future, once a distant dream, now seemed close enough to touch. Over a **long lunch**, the **deputy** and an **emigrant** banker discussed **capitalism** as a **pillar** of society. It would **perplex** anyone how a **unilateral statute** on **lending** could **sweeten** or sour a **partnership**. They refused to **adopt** a **dummy** policy or **misappropriate** funds; that would be **pathological**, leaving only a **semblance** of order. **Off** the **congested** street, near a **yacht** club, they read an **anthology** of essays on **unemployment**, **housework**, and the urge to **incline** toward reform. A **cuckoo** called; a **footstep** echoed. One pulled a **stocking** of coins from a **vacuum**-sealed box, noting how iron **oxide** had stained it, and added **reinforcement** to their plan.

中文翻译

那番自白发生在黎明时分，当寒霜的光第一次触到被雪困住的校园。一个名叫西奥的新生，从前是一群乡下表亲中安静的男孩，此刻坐在干燥寒冷的演讲厅里，决定解开那个开始纠缠他的谜题。起初他只想要好成绩；如今他想整顿自己的整个人生。他还不是个赢家，但他谨慎而谦虚，拒绝鲁莽行事。他那天早晨当众发表的、用低沉而平稳的声音说出的讲话，是一种与自己的道德辩论。“我不会让一时的安逸毁掉我的未来，”他说，“我有一项天职要追求。”他的抱怨，如果能这么叫的话，很简单：他太多同学靠廉价的习惯和懒散的过度度日，把学习当成原始的苦差，而非快乐的活动。他想为那份冷漠找到一剂良药。想必其他人觉得他古怪。一位摩托车手朋友，周末是个骑自行车的人，单独问他是不是疯了。此外，男孩补充道，他睡眠的恶化已经开始让他担忧。他会工作到过午夜，喝着冷咖啡，洗把脸保持清醒。与同龄人作比较的一瞥并不能给他安慰。在临时顾问的许可下，他采用了一个新计划，一个量化的计划，去改变作息、让真正的休息成为可能。他不会用借口奉承自己。他学会整理笔记，确认每一个事实，并在行动前寻求确认。他发现，一点点的约束非但不是折磨，反而让他自由。除了书本，他还备了一把小铲子用于校园花园，在那里翻动草皮，在结霜的土里播种；嫩绿的新芽长出时，给了他任何讲座都给不了的精神上的善意。他甚至在一个被雪困住的下午堆了个雪人，像孩子一样大笑，那份喜悦简单的滋味令他惊讶。他意识到，要把自己从恐惧中解放出来，就必须行动有条理，不让那一窝疑虑堵塞他的头脑。他的领路人，一位睿智的老教师，没有责骂也没有指控；她会温和地评点，从不对一颗年轻的心鲁莽。“你无法一次清除每一个缺点，”她告诉他，“只要你不断尝试，就会进步。”西奥在黎明渐亮时离开大厅，不再不快乐。他对怀疑还不算陌生，但绝望的病症已开始消退。他身后的脚步声是他自己的，稳健而笃定，而那可得到的未来，曾是遥远的梦，如今近得仿佛触手可及。在一顿漫长的午餐中，那位副手和一位移居海外的银行家谈论资本主义这一社会支柱。一项关于借贷的单边法令竟能让合伙关系变甜或变坏，这会让任何人困惑。他们拒绝采用傀儡政策或盗用资金；那将是病态的，只留下秩序的表象。在拥挤街道之外、游艇俱乐部附近，他们读了一本关于失业、家务以及倾向改革的文集。一只布谷鸟鸣叫，一阵脚步声回响。一人从真空密封盒里取出一只装着硬币的长袜，注意到氧化铁已把它染色，并为他们的计划增添了强化的力量。

8. The Ambassador's Mystery in Australia

English

The **mystery** began **at** a **chapel** on the coast of **Australia**, where a **Portuguese ambassador** had moored his yacht for the night. He was an **affectionate** man of great **prestige**, devoted to his **vocation**, and **doubtless** no coward; yet that evening a strange **malice** seemed to **rein** in his usual calm. A **talkative miller** from the nearby town, a **reputable** but **coarse** fellow, had told him a tale that no **barometer** of reason could measure. Long ago, the miller said, an **alien apparatus** had washed ashore in this very **area**, an **obstacle** to every map and chart that **cartography** could draw. The ambassador, who would **prefer**, and indeed preferred, facts to rumor, did not **flatter** the story, but neither could he **erase** it from his mind. He decided to **submit** himself to the riddle. At midnight he walked the **marginal** path along the shore, a **luminous** moon above him, his **long-term** doubts pressing like a **yoke** upon his shoulders. The **rage** of the sea had calmed; only a **soft** wind stirred. He found, half-buried, a **decorative code** carved into stone, its **variant** symbols **overlapping** in a pattern no one alive could interpret. Was it a relic of some ancient **rivalry**, a yoke left by a forgotten **aggressor**, or merely a sham? The **press** would surely call it a **tornado** of nonsense, but the ambassador felt the **destruction** of an old certainty. He knelt, **moderately** careful, and brushed the moss away. **Nobody** was near. A **reptile**, perhaps a small lizard, darted past his hand and made him flinch. He thought of the marginal notes in his own diary, of the long **road** of his career, of the prestige that might be ruined if he spoke too soon. The **chronology** made no sense: the carving was older than any record in his **domain** of knowledge. He resolved to **allocate** his remaining days, however **affluent** or poor, to this single problem. A reputable scholar might **invalidate** his theory; a **benevolent** one might confirm it. Either way, the matter was now **part** of him. As the night withered into morning, **exhausted** but elated, he gathered a soft handful of sand into a **tub** he had carried, took up a **shovel** from the yacht, and dug a **relative** few feet into the soil. There, beneath a luminous layer of crystal, lay a second tablet, its surface coarse yet covered in a **glutinous** film. He saw at once that the two stones were a matched part, halves of a single record that someone had tried to **halve** and hide. The **implied** meaning struck him: this was no mere device, no decorative trifle, but a message meant to **propel** the curious toward a truth that powerful men had long suppressed. The ambassador, no longer **dangerous** to himself with doubt, pressed the tablets together. He felt his heart **palpitate**. The mystery, at last, had begun to speak. Ask **yourself** why some mysteries never **with**er. A **teacher**, my **spouse's** old mentor, would **attend** every lecture, preferring a **sonnet** to empty **rhetoric**. The **bugbear** of the age was disease: **poliomyelitis** and **malnutrition**, which could **paralyze** a child as surely as **sorrow**. It was **inevitable**, he said, that someone **else** would solve it. He kept a **pad** of notes, a **needle** and thread, and a tin of **pilchard** for the road. On the **twelfth** of the **ultimo** month, riding neither **pony** nor **motorcycle** but in **transit** by train, he reached the **junction** near the **moor**. He would **lend** a hand to anyone, **gross** profit or not, studying **Leninism** with the **innocence** of a student, dipping a **solvent** to clean an old **b/l** document. The market was **bearish**, but his faith was solvent. Years earlier he had judged a **contestant** in a poetry duel, awarding the prize to the one whose verse showed true innocence.

中文翻译

这桩谜团始于**澳大利亚**海岸的一座**小礼拜堂**，一位葡萄牙**大使**把他的游艇停泊在那里过夜。他是个深情而极有**声望**的人，献身于自己的**天职**，无疑也绝非懦夫；然而那天傍晚，一种奇怪的**恶意**似乎**驾驭**住了他平日的镇定。附近镇上一个爱唠叨的**磨坊主**，一个声誉不错却**粗俗**的家伙，给他讲了一个任何理性的**晴雨表**都无法衡量的故事。磨坊主说，很久以前，一件外星**仪器**曾被冲上正是这片海域的岸边，成了制图术所能绘出的每一张地图与海图的**障碍**。这位偏爱事实**胜过**谣言的大使没有吹捧这个故事，却也无法将它从脑中抹去。他决定让自己去面对这个谜。午夜时分，他沿着岸边那条**边缘**的小径行走，头顶一轮明亮的月，他**长期的**疑虑像一副**枷锁**压在肩头。海的**狂怒**已经平息；只有一阵轻柔的风在吹动。他发现一块半埋的、刻在石上的装饰性符文，那些**不同的**符号相互重叠成一种**无人**能解读的图案。它是某种古老**对抗**的遗物，是某个被遗忘的**侵略者**留下的枷锁，还是仅仅一个赝品？报界肯定会称它为一场无稽之谈的**龙卷风**，但大使感到一种旧有确信的崩塌。他跪下，相当小心地拂去青苔。附近没有人。一只**爬行动物**，也许是只小蜥蜴，从他手边窜过，吓了他一跳。他想起自己日记里那些边缘的批注，想起自己事业漫长的**道路**，想起若过早开口、可能毁掉的声望。年代毫无道理可言：这块刻石比他知识**领域**内任何记录都要古老。他下定决心，要把余下的日子，无论富足还是贫穷，都**分配**给这一个问题。一位**声誉好的**学者也许会推翻他的理论；一位仁慈的学者也许会证实它。无论如何，这件事如今已成了他的一部分。当夜色凋谢成清晨，他精疲力竭却又兴高采烈，把一软把沙子收进随身携带的**木盆**，从游艇上取来一把铁锹，往土里挖下相对不深的几英尺。在那里，一层晶莹的水晶之下，躺着第二块石板，表面粗糙却覆着一层**粘性**的薄膜。他立刻看出这两块石头是配对的一部分，是某人曾试图**对分**并藏匿的同一份记录的两半。其中**暗含**的意义击中了它：这绝非一件单纯的装置，也不是装饰性的琐物，而是一条意在**驱使**好奇者走向真相的讯息——而那真相，曾被权势者长久压制。大使不再因疑虑而对自己构成危险，他把两块石板按在一起，感到自己的心在**跳动**。谜团，终于，开始说话了。问问**你自己**，为何有些谜团永不凋零。一位老师，我**配偶**的旧日导师，会**出席**每一场讲座，**宁愿读十四行诗**也不愿听空洞的花言巧语。那个时代的梦魇是疾病：**小儿麻痹症**和**营养不良**，它们能像悲伤一样使一个孩子瘫痪。他说，迟早会有别人解决它，这是**不可避免的**。他随身带着一叠笔记、一根针线，以及一罐路上吃的**沙丁鱼**。在上个月的十二号，他既不骑**小马**也不骑**摩托车**，而是乘火车中转，抵达沼泽附近的交叉路口。无论毛利与否，他都愿向任何人伸出援手，怀着学生般的纯真研究**列宁主义**，蘸着**溶剂**清理一份旧**提单**。市场看跌，但他的信念依然稳健。多年前他曾在一场诗歌对决中担任评委，把奖项授予诗句中流露真正纯真的那位参赛者。

9. The Congressman and the Famine Relief

English

Positively, no one in the capital expected the young congressman to pursue such an ambition. We had watched him for a span of years, a devoted public servant whose relationship with the voters was built on bravery and plain honesty. When news of the famine reached Russia and beyond, the disorder it created was immense; the plight of millions could ruin a whole generation. He was sensitive to their sorrow, and definitely not greedy for personal sale or turnover of favors. Maybe, he thought, he could mobilize the nation. He called a technician and an athletic young runner to help him connect the scattered relief committees, then asked his ancestor's old wagon to be restored so it might ride again as a symbol. The incidence of hunger was rising; the output of the farms had declined after a strange fission of the soil's fertility, and the circulation of grain had nearly ceased. He would not let the crisis decline into genocide by neglect. He refused to misinterpret the numbers, nor to restrict aid to the privileged few. "Neither pride nor property," he said in a lecture, "should handicap our response." He petitioned the embassy for help and sent a citizen delegation to superintend the docks. A magnate, once bearish and antiquated in his views, was moved to facilitate the shipping of sardine and other tinned goods; a banker agreed to decentralize the lending so that aid could reach every locality. The congressman's bravery seemed to capitalize on a novelty of spirit the nation had forgotten. Critics tried to tamper with his certification and to overthrow his committee; an ironical few called his ideal a mere imitation of older reforms. He conceded nothing. "However you interpret it," he told them, "this is not a skirmish over an item of policy. It is a fight for longevity itself." He moved to restore order, to create a system that could contain the chaos, and to improve the lives of the runner and the breadwinner alike. He capitalized every chance. When at last the wagons rolled, the people did not laugh; they wept and hugged one another. A child handed him a bowl and a single cluster of grain. The voiceless had found a voice. The decline had stopped. As a Roman proverb might say, the cost of doing nothing is the ruin of all. The congressman, accessible and moderate to the end, pursued his ideal until the booking of every relief ship was confirmed and the expiry of the crisis was finally in sight. His adjective for the day was simple: enough. To avert disaster, the citizens signed a petition. A famous quotation, often misquoted, became their lever: every participant could specialize in one task. The chatter in the limousine turned serious; a careless interpretation, a backward step, could rupture the fragile peace and tangle the talks. A billion small choices, like a stroke of a pen, could kill or save the plan. They would not charge like a bull; instead they shared a warm hug, used every device of diplomacy, and refused to let the moment slip.

中文翻译

毫无疑问，首都里没人料到这位年轻的国会议员会去追求这样的抱负。我们注视了他好些年，他是个献身的公仆，与选民的关系建立在勇敢和质朴的诚实之上。当饥荒的消息传到俄罗斯乃至更远的地方时，它所造成的混乱是巨大的；数百万人的困境足以毁掉整整一代人。他们对他们的悲痛十分敏感，也绝不贪图个人的买卖或人情上的周转。也许，他想，他能动员整个国家。他叫来一名技术人员和一个擅长田径的年轻赛跑者，帮他分散的救济委员会连接起来，又请人把他祖先那辆旧货运马车修复好，让它能再次上路，成为一种象征。饥饿的发生率在上升；农场的产量在土壤肥力发生某种奇怪的裂变后下降了，粮食的流通也几乎停止。他不会让这场危机因疏忽而衰退成一场屠杀。他拒绝误解那些数字，也拒绝把援助限制给少数特权者。“无论是骄傲还是财产，”他在一次演讲中说，“都不该妨碍我们的回应。”他向大使馆请愿求助，并派出一个公民代表团去监管码头。一位曾经看空又观念陈旧的大资本家被打动，去促成沙丁鱼及其他罐头货物的运输；一位银行家同意把放贷分散下去，好让援助能抵达每一个地方。这位议员的勇敢似乎利用了一种国家早已遗忘的精神新意。批评者试图篡改他的证明文件、推翻他的委员会；爱讽刺的少数人称他的理想不过是对旧改革的模仿。他什么也不让步。“无论你们怎么解释它，”他对他们说，“这不是一场围绕某项政策条款的小冲突。这是一场为长寿本身而战的斗争。”他着手恢复秩序，去创造一个能遏制混乱的体系，去改善赛跑者与养家者同样的生活。他抓住每一个机会。当货运马车终于上路时，人们没有讥笑；他们哭了，彼此拥抱。一个孩子递给他一只碗和一串谷粒。无声者找到了声音。衰退停止了。正如一句古罗马谚语所说，无所作为的代价是一切的毁灭。这位议员，始终平易近人且温和，一直追求他的理想，直到每一艘救济船的订位都得到确认，危机的终结终于在望。他这一天的形容词很简单：够了。为避免灾难，市民们签署了一份请愿书。一句常被误引的名言成了他们的杠杆：每位参与者都能专攻一项任务。豪华轿车里的闲谈变得严肃；一个草率的解释、一步倒退，都可能使脆弱的和平破裂并使谈判陷入纠缠。十亿个小小的选择，如同一笔落下，能毁掉或拯救计划。他们不会像公牛般横冲直撞；相反，他们温暖地拥抱，动用一切外交手段，拒绝让时机溜走。

10. The Painter at the Mountain Shrine

English

Hi, the proverb says that wit and patience attain what force cannot, and the good-looking young painter believed it with all his emotional heart. He had a privileged childhood, yet he chose a hard path up the mountain to a mysterious shrine, hoping to discover the secret of an old riddle carved above its beam. The landscape was vast: a span of latitude where fog rolled over the ocean and daylight came softly through the mist. He would not let the cynic in town ruin his hope. "In spite of every obstacle," he wrote in his diary, "I will resume the climb at dawn." He packed a handkerchief, a capsule of medicine from the drugstore, a ribbon his mother gave him, and a crumb of toast wrapped in cloth. The trail was a thin wire of stone across a fleshy ridge. As he walked, he could query the silence and seem to hear a response from the rock itself. He had to concede that the journey might recompense him with nothing but a sham of an answer. Yet the mature traveller knows that worth is not always a purchase one can register at a shop. Combustion of dry brush warmed his camp; the diffuse glow of the fire painted the night. He felt no spite, no oppression of doubt. A colonist family offered him potluck hospitality and a cup of warm fruit drink, and he raised a toast to their kindness. They were not privileged, but their welcome was overt and generous, without the tyrannical airs of the wealthy. By morning his dismay had gone. He resolved to renew his quest. The path narrowed; loose gunpowder-grey stones shifted underfoot. Then, near the shrine, he uncapped his paints and began. The light might have seemed scant, but his artistic vision was persuasive and imaginative. He would not waive the chance to capture this. He worked with the steady stroke of one who has waited long. When he finished, he stood blindfold to his own fatigue, and the explanation of the riddle came to him as a quiet thought: the consequently simple truth was that the mountain itself was the shrine. No hijacker of fame, no resentful rival, no intransigent critic could take that from him. He was not the head of any school, just one painter with a load of canvas and a heart full of light. He let the fog lift. He had attained his answer. It is ironical, almost a trifle, how a short inquiry can change everything. An entrepreneur, no flabby dreamer, refused to be the scapegoat for a failed nomination. He would uncap a bottle, enclose a note, and never interrupt a guest. The lab measured temperature in Fahrenheit, tested a hydrogen sulphide sample at full saturation, and studied the componential and constitutive parts of a new alloy, recording each subsequence with care. A sullen technician, doing a sampling of the metal's innards, traced a thin artery of rust along the beam. Even the lord of the estate, who kept a tame panda in mind as a symbol of calm, called it constitutive of progress, not a trifle.

中文翻译

嗨，谚语说，机智与耐心能获得武力所不能获得的东西，那位好看的年轻画家全心全意、满怀激情地相信这一点。他有一个优渥的童年，却选择了一条艰难的路，登上山去寻访一座神秘的神龛，希望破解刻在它横梁上方的一个古老谜语的秘密。这片风景辽阔：在横跨一段纬度的地方，雾从海面上翻滚而来，日光柔和地穿过薄雾。他不会让镇上那个愤世嫉俗者毁掉他的希望。“尽管有种种障碍，”他在日记里写道，“黎明时我会重新开始攀登。”他打点了一块手帕、一粒从零食店买来的药用胶囊、一条母亲给的缎带，以及一块用布包着的烤面包屑。山径是一条横在多肉山脊上的细如铁丝的石路。当他行走时，他似乎在向寂静发问，又仿佛听见岩石本身的回应。他不得不承认，这趟旅程也许只会用一个虚假的答案来回报他。然而成熟的旅人知道，价值并不总是能在店里登记购买的东西。干枯灌木的燃烧温暖了他的营地；火堆漫射的光芒为夜晚上色。他没有怨恨，也没有疑虑的压迫。一户移民人家以家常便饭的热情款待他，递上一杯温热的果饮，他举杯为他们的善意祝酒。他们并不富有，但他们的欢迎是公开而慷慨的，没有富人那种专横的架子。到了早晨，他的沮丧已然消散。他决意重新踏上他的探寻。山路变窄了；火药灰色的松动石块在脚下滑动。然后，在神龛附近，他打开颜料，开始作画。光线也许显得不足，但他的艺术眼光极具说服力且富于想象。他不会放弃捕捉这一切的机会。他以等待已久之人那种沉稳的笔触工作。完成时，他对自己的疲惫视而不见，而谜语的解答如一个安静的念头降临于他：那个因此而简单的真理是——山本身就是神龛。任何盗取名声者、任何怨恨的对手、任何不肯妥协的批评家都无法把它从他手中夺走。他不是任何画派的首脑，只是一个带着一捆画布、心中充满光明的画家。他让雾散去。他已获得了他的答案。颇具讽刺意味的是，几乎是件小事——一次简短的询问就能改变一切。一位企业家，绝非优柔寡断的空想者，拒绝为一次失败的提名当替罪羊。他会拧开瓶盖，附上一张便条，从不打断客人。实验室用华氏温度计测温，在完全饱和状态下测试硫化氢样品，研究新合金的成分构成与构成性部分，仔细记录每一个后续结果。一位绷着脸的技师对金属内脏做抽样，沿着横梁追踪一条细细的锈蚀动脉。连庄园的主人——他心中养着一只象征平静的温顺熊猫——也称这是进步的构成要素，而非区区小事。

11. Founding a Community Farm

English

In the **preface** to her business plan, the **founder** of our **community farming** cooperative made one **sentiment paramount**: that **healthy, sanitary** food should be available to everyone at **rock-bottom** prices, never sold **wrongly** or at an exorbitant markup. She had chosen to **launch** the venture **beside** an old **metro** station, on a **stony** plot whose poor **drainage** and **porous** soil first seemed a **blockage** to any harvest. Yet with **conscientious** work and a **flexible technique**, the team began to **strengthen** the beds, **scrub** the rusted tools, and **assemble** raised planters set at a regular **interval**. A clever **design** for the irrigation helped them **unravel** each early problem. The **custom** in our community was to gather each dawn. At one such **gathering**, a **courier** arrived with a **consignment** of seedlings, a **parcel** of tender greens, each **leaf** still wet with dew. We were **glad**. A local **agency** offered **compensation** for any crop lost to frost, and a **dealer** of farm gear let us **reserve** a **multifunction** tractor, a **fixture** we could not afford outright. We even asked a vet to **vaccinate** the goats that grazed the margin. The whole **scene** felt hopeful. **As yet** no pest did **appear**, but we stayed watchful. We used a **thermometer** to **probe** the greenhouse heat and would not **disallow** any **clue** of disease; one **apparent** sign of blight could **crumble** a season's yield. To **raise** morale, the founder would **tell** a **brisk** story about how, against all odds and with **intent**, the first farmers had **successfully** built their fields, and she would not **blame** the soil. Her words did not **humiliate** the doubters; rather they helped **subdue** every **fearful** thought, and **thereby** put us at **ease**. We **post** our notes online, a **ubiquitous** practice now. A **demonstration** day drew a crowd: a **bride** and groom on their way from a **graduation**, a man nursing **arthritis**, even the **police** on patrol. My **mother-in-law**, who holds the garden in high **esteem**, brought **garlic** bread and pressed a small **memento**, a carved wooden **chord** ornament, into my **chest** pocket. Someone joked that we should **smuggle** a **spaceship** in to till the back forty, since the field stretched nearly a **kilometer**. Of course there were setbacks, a **ramification** no one foresaw: a **tack** puncturing a tyre, a sudden **blast** of hail whose stinging **lash** struck the **elliptical** pond, a **carpet** of mud across the path. A **toothbrush** served, oddly, to clean the seed trays. **Economic** pressure was real, and the **secondary** market gave us nearly **unlimited** competition. But after an **interruption** for repairs, work resumed. In a quiet **prayer** of thanks, some whispered the name of **Jesus**, we knew the **staple** harvest, and our **safety**, were assured. **Practically** every neighbor now visits; the rising **tide** of support was, in the end, **pretty** wonderful to see.

中文翻译

在她商业计划书的**序言**里，我们**社区农业合作社**的**创办人**把一种情怀置于至高地位：健康、**卫生**的食物应当让每个人都能以**最低价**买到，绝不能**错误地**出售或漫天要价。她选择在一座老地铁站**旁边**创办这项事业，地块多石，**排水**不畅，土壤渗水，起初像是阻碍任何收成的障碍。然而凭着**认真的**劳作和**灵活的技术**，团队**开始**加固苗床、**擦洗**生锈的工具，并按固定**间隔**装配抬高的种植槽。一套巧妙的灌溉**设计**帮助他们解开了早期的每一个难题。我们社区的**习俗**是每天黎明**聚集**。在一次这样的**聚会上**，一名快递员送来一批秧苗，一包鲜嫩的青菜，每片**叶子**上还挂着露水。我们都很高兴。当地一家代理机构愿意为任何被霜冻毁掉的作物提供**赔偿**，一位农机经销商让我们**预定**一台多功能拖拉机，这是我们无力直接购买的**固定装置**。我们甚至请兽医给在田边吃草的山羊接种疫苗。整个**景象**令人充满希望。**至今**没有害虫**出现**，但我们保持警惕。我们用**温度计**探测温室的热量，绝不忽视任何病害的**线索**；一处**明显的**枯萎迹象就可能让一季的收成化为乌有。为了鼓舞士气，创办人会讲一个**轻快**的故事，**讲述**最初的农人如何不顾一切、满怀决心地成功建起了田地，她绝不责怪土壤。她的话没有**羞辱**那些怀疑者，反而帮助压下每一个恐惧的念头，**从而**让我们安心。我们如今把笔记发布到网上，这是一种无处不在的做法。一个**示范**日吸引了人群：一对刚从**毕业典礼**赶来的**新娘新郎**、一位患**关节炎**的老人，甚至还有巡逻的**警察**。我那位极为珍视这座花园的**岳母**带来了蒜香面包，还把一件**小纪念品**——一枚雕花的木质和弦饰物——塞进我的胸前口袋。有人开玩笑说，我们该**走私**一艘**宇宙飞船**来耕作后面那片地，因为田地绵延将近**一公里**。当然也有挫折，一个没人预料到的衍生问题：一枚平头钉扎破了轮胎，**一阵**突如其来的冰雹用刺人的鞭击拍打着椭圆形的池塘，一层泥铺满了小路。一把**牙刷**竟意外地用来清洁育苗盘。经济压力是真实的，二级市场带给我们**几乎无限**的竞争。但在一段修理的**中断**之后，工作又恢复了。在一声安静的感恩**祷告**中，有人低声念着**耶稣**的名字，我们知道主粮的收成和我们的**安全**都有了保障。如今几乎每位邻居都来参观；这股不断上涨的支持浪潮，最终看起来**相当**美好。

12. The Astronomical Committee

English

The **erection** of the new observatory beside the **lagoon** was, by any measure, a **colossal task**. The **same administrative committee** that had once governed a small **monarchy** of stargazers now had to **execute** a vast **campaign**, **essentially** a **mission** to map **Mars** and the **various** bodies beyond. Their **representative**, a **sociable** woman who valued **punctuality** above almost all, would **lay** out the **following** plan **twice** for any newcomer, **while** the **preceding** director merely looked on with an **innocent**, almost **toneless** calm. **Although** the budget figures were **astronomical**, the **company** behind the project refused to **curtail** the science. They issued a **warranty** on the **equipment** and, in **addition**, a clear **voucher** for every **shipment** that arrived. One **technical glimmer** of hope came from an **inert** gas that, in various tests, would not **vanish** under heat. "We must **reconsider**, and **recycle** the old lenses," she said, glancing at the **algebra** on the board, her **wrist** resting on a worn **thesaurus**. Her **surname**, common in **England** and across **Africa**, was printed on a **banner** above the **square**. The mission concerned more than mere data; it had to **accomplish** a **sense** of wonder, and to be representative of human reach. A **reportage** team, sworn to **allegiance**, would **dramatize** the launch, though some feared the prose would prove **monotonous**. As the countdown began, a young typist wept, then quickly dried her **eye** and learned to **forget** her nerves. She had practiced **shorthand** to record every word. The **mutual** respect among the crew was apparent. They did not **weep** again. When at last the rocket left the **graveyard** of abandoned scaffolds, a colossal blast lit the **orange** sky, and the crowd, **fearless**, raised a **final** cheer that no **ultimatum** could ever subdue. Engineers in the **hydroelectric** station nearby felt the ground shudder. The **mass** of onlookers, their allegiance now beyond doubt, knew that this hour would **prophecy** a brighter age. Some, with a **quandary** in their hearts, whispered a prayer. Yet the **contrive** of the chief planner, who had flicked aside every **delusion**, held firm. He would not **enact** a single rule he could not defend, nor would he **overhaul** a system that worked. A **flick** of his **thumb** on the panel, a glint of **porcelain** dials, and the mission was a triumph. There was, he admitted with a **sore** throat and a tired **straw** of a voice, no **shortcut** to the stars, no **dagger** that could cut the long road short. **Detection** of the signal proved the engineers **tolerant** of risk and fully **terminable** in their patience. From **Langkap** to the far north, **mole-sized** antennas, lined like rows of **bamboo-shoot** in a **frying-pan-bright** field, tracked the craft. Even a humble mole on the hill seemed to watch. With a glad heart, **herself** the proudest of all, she signed the final log. In the **twelve** months that followed, nothing bad would **happen** to dim the project's **value**. The **teaching** team kept careful records **concerning** every result they could **obtain**, and joy seemed to **overflow** from the control room. Far from any **aggravation**, the mood was one of pure delight.

中文翻译

在**泻湖**边建造这座新天文台，无论从哪个角度看都是一项庞大的**任务**。同一个行政**委员会**，曾经管理着一小群观星者的**君主国**般的天地，如今却要执行一场浩大的**运动**，**本质上**是一项绘制**火星**及其外天体的**使命**。他们的**代表**是一位看重交际、把**准时**看得几乎高于一切的女士，她会把下述计划向任何新人讲两遍，而前一任主任只是带着天真、近乎无声调的平静在一旁看着。**尽管**预算数字大得惊人，项目背后的**公司**却拒绝削减科研。他们为**设备**出具了保修书，此外还为每一批到货开具清晰的**凭单**。一线**技术**上的希望来自一种惰性气体，它在各种测试中都不会在高温下**消失**。"我们必须**重新考虑**，并把旧镜片回收利用，"她说，瞥了一眼黑板上的代数式，手腕搁在一本磨旧的**辞典**上。她的姓氏在**英格兰**和整个**非洲**都很常见，被印在**广场**上方的一条横幅上。这项使命所关心的不只是数据；它还必须成就一种惊奇之感，并能代表人类所能企及的高度。一支宣誓**效忠**的**报告文学**团队将把这次发射戏剧化，**尽管**有人担心文字会显得单调。倒计时开始时，一位年轻的打字员哭了，随即很快擦干眼睛，学会忘掉紧张。她练过**速记**，要记下每一个字。机组之间的相互尊重显而易见。他们没有再哭。当火箭终于离开那片废弃脚手架的**墓地**时，一团**巨大**的爆炸气浪照亮了橙色的天空，人群无所畏惧地发出最后的欢呼，任何最后通牒都无法将其压制。附近水电站的工程师感到地面震动。这群旁观者，他们的忠诚此刻已无可置疑，知道这一刻将**预言**一个更光明的时代。一些心怀**困惑**的人低声祈祷。然而那位已经拂去一切**错觉**的总规划师所**设计**的方案稳如磐石。他绝不会**颁布**一条自己无法捍卫的规则，也不会去检修一套运转良好的系统。他用拇指在面板上一弹，瓷质刻度盘一闪，使命便大功告成。他带着发炎的喉咙和疲惫如**稻草**般的嗓音承认，通往星辰没有**捷径**，没有哪把**匕首**能把这条漫长的路**截短**。信号的探测证明工程师们能容忍风险，并在耐心上完全可以持久。从**冷甲**到遥远的北方，**鼯鼠**般大小的天线，像**煎锅**般明亮的田野里一排排**竹笋**一样排列，追踪着飞行器。连山坡上一只不起眼的鼯鼠似乎也在注视。她怀着欢欣的心，自己是所有人中最自豪的，签下了最后一份日志。在接下来的**十二**个月里，不会**发生**任何坏事来削减这个项目的**价值**。**教学**团队就他们能**获得**的每一项结果都仔细记录，欢乐似乎从控制室里**溢出**。远没有任何**恶化**，气氛是纯粹的喜悦。

13. Crossing the Atlantic

English

The two of us set out early on a brilliant morning, our destination a singular island far across the Atlantic. The proposal had seemed a bargain at first, an affordable adventure, but the expense soon grew, and a needy budget left us tracking every dollar. Our slender boat, with one oar and a worn amplifier for the radio, was no match for the torrent that would later sweep the deck. A profitable venture, the dealer had called it, though his disreputable, deceitful grin should have warned us. He was an insolvent tinker who would offend anyone, an unaccommodating man whose every word seemed a piece of propaganda. We engaged him only out of restraint, fearing worse. By mid-ocean a nightmare began. A torrent of rain lashed the bulky hull; the boat seemed to dive, then whirl, and I had to choke back a shriek. The worst was a near crash against a reef in the western hemisphere of the chart, where the inaccessible north shore loomed like a veil of mist, a shroud over the unofficial route no captain would carve. My methodical, conscientious companion, ever influential and brilliant in a crisis, drew on empirical skill to steady us. Somehow she could withstand the swell, her toe braced, her face like wool-pale stone. We must endure, she said, and her singular calm did not crumble. I am afraid we strayed badly. The compass, our only mirror of true direction, gave a hideous reading, and a dive into the charts brought a reduction of hope. Still, we did not panic. To dive deeper into the math, she pulled a quarterly almanac, ran the figures twice, and after careful scrutiny found the error. A magnet near the dial had skewed everything. Once we moved it, the needle settled, and a torrent of relief swept over us. By dusk the storm endures no longer; the sweep of clear sky returned. We could already taste the steak and lamb the inhabitants of the island were said to roast. A stewardess on a passing French liner from Portugal waved; we waved back, funny and giddy with survival. Negotiation with the harbor pilot was brisk. We had email, but no signal; instead we relied on an introductory chart and the syllabus of seamanship she had memorized. The originality of her plan, an apologetic blend of art and guesswork, somehow worked. As an ambulance of gulls wheeled overhead, I felt the stimulation of pure joy. We had unified our nerve. No terrorism of the sea, no miniature fear, could now frustrate us. A mouse of doubt still gnawed, but our determination held. The decoration on the prow, a small carved swan, seemed to nod. Crossing that crossing line of latitude, I knew this affair would mark us forever, a memory to venerate, a story no consideration of fatigue could ever erase. Back on the outer dock, we did not stray from our plan, nor did our courage tumble. We would engage no needless confrontation with the sea. A rough sluice gate guarded the inner harbor; beyond it, a baker let yeast rise for our welcome bread. To distil one lesson from the voyage, and to unify our small crew, I would call us survivors. The harbor's loyal clientele, who track every arriving ship, cheered as we tied up.

中文翻译

我们两人在一个晴朗的清晨早早出发，目的地是一座遥远的、独一无二的岛屿，远在大西洋的另一边。这个提议起初看似划算，是一次买得起的冒险，但开销很快增加，拮据的预算让我们盯紧每一美元。我们那艘细长的小船，只有一支桨和一台破旧的收音机扩大器，根本敌不过后来席卷甲板的激流。那个商人称这是一桩有利可图的买卖，尽管他那声名狼藉、骗人的笑容本该警告我们。他是个无力偿债的焊锅匠，谁都会被他得罪，是个不肯通融的人，每句话都像宣传。我们只是出于克制才雇了他，怕遇到更糟的。航行到大洋中央，噩梦开始了。倾盆大雨抽打着笨重的船体；船一会儿俯冲，一会儿打旋，我不得不强忍住一声尖叫。最糟的是险些撞上西半球处的一片礁石，那里难以接近的北岸像一层雾的面纱赫然耸现，是没有哪个船长敢去开辟的非正式航线上的一块遮蔽物。我那有条理、认真的同伴，在危机中一向有影响力又出色，凭借经验的本领稳住了我们。她不知怎地能顶住涌浪，脚趾撑着，脸像羊毛般苍白的石头。我们必须坚持，她说，她那非凡的镇定没有崩溃。恐怕我们偏航得很厉害。指南针——我们唯一能映照真实方向的镜子——给出一个骇人的读数，一头扎进海图带来了希望的减少。但我们没有惊慌。为了更深入地钻研计算，她抽出一本季刊年历，把数字算了两遍，经过仔细审查后找到了错误。表盘附近有块磁铁扭曲了一切。我们一把它挪开，指针就稳定下来，一股如激流般的宽慰席卷我们。黄昏时分，暴风雨不再持续；晴空的连绵又回来了。我们已经仿佛尝到岛上居民据说会烤的牛排和羊羔肉。一艘从葡萄牙驶来的法国客轮上的女乘务员挥手；我们挥手回应，因为劫后余生而又滑稽又眩晕。与港口领航员的谈判很爽快。我们有电子邮件，却没有信号；于是我们依靠一张入门海图和她背下来的航海课程提纲。她那计划的独创性，是一种带着歉意的、艺术与猜测的混合，竟然奏效了。当一群海鸥像救护车般在头顶盘旋时，我感到纯粹喜悦的刺激。我们已把勇气拧成一股。海洋的任何恐怖、任何微小的恐惧，如今都无法挫败我们。一只怀疑的耗子仍在啃噬，但我们的决心未动。船头的装饰物，一只小小的雕刻天鹅，似乎点了点头。越过那条纬度的交叉线，我知道这段经历将永远在我们身上留下印记，一段值得崇敬的记忆，一个任何疲惫的考量都无法抹去的故事。回到外侧的码头，我们没有偏离计划，勇气也没有崩塌。我们不会与大海进行任何无谓的对峙。一道粗糙的水闸守护着内港；闸门那边，一位面包师让酵母为我们的迎宾面包发起来。若要从这趟航行中提炼出一条教训，并把这支小船员队伍凝聚成一体，我会称我们为幸存者。港口忠实的常客们追踪每一艘到港的船，在我们系缆时欢呼起来。

14. A Servant's Brave Year

English

Despite the cruel winter, the old servant kept the manor running with thrifty care. In the pantry she would stew a thick cargo of bread, bone broth, and canned vegetables, ladling it from a battered frying foil into bowls warmed beside the fireplace. Her boldness was noticeable, even awesome, though she never sought to entertain the nobility with idle talk. One operational rule guided her: inspect everything twice. She would wipe each fixture, scrub the carriage wheels, and tabulate the household money in a ledger no typist could fault. The estate's deficit had grown vast, a fatal dumping of debt, and the warden warned that creditworthiness was now critical. A pragmatic woman, she refused to panic. The version of thrift she practiced was almost theoretical, yet it worked. Despite hostile neighbors and a regional racism that made her position unpleasant, she stayed favorable in spirit, doggedly cheerful. When the young lord, sly and reactionary, threatened to sack her, she did not bleed self-pity. She would invest her own meager allowance to underwrite repairs, even venture savings to buy a medium grade of coal. A territorial dispute with the next estate had reached deadlock; a hopeless inconsistency in the old deeds made the boundary missing from every map. One marvellous morning, while she swept the courtyard, a left-handed clerk arrived by expressway with a telegram. The bloc of lawyers had reached a verdict. To substantiate the family's claim, they needed the original decode of a coded letter hidden behind a loose bone of the chimney. She climbed up, a riotous wind tugging her mantle, and amplified her grip on a bolt as the ladder shook. The residue of soot made her cough; a ripple of dust rose like a whirlwind. With a dash she pulled the paper free, then gave a triumphant shout. The cyclic seasons of worry seemed to splash away. The document, written in shorthand that read like a foreign epoch, proved the land was theirs. No mischief, no filth of rumor, could now stain the house. That night they watched a flickering video on a borrowed set, played chess, and skated on the frozen pool. The lord, his paranoia eased, vowed to defend her against any awesome threat. She had shown, with quiet nobility, that one careful servant could not be dwarfed by fate. A racism-free, hopeful order took root. Even the hut at the gate, where she had first slept in a sack on a bed of straw, now flew a small badge of honor. She rented out a spare row of cottages, turned a once-rusty estate profitable, and showed that boldness paired with thrift makes any winter survivable. To show the books, she would debit each expense and rent receipt, attentive to the last centigrade of detail, never inconsistent. Her maths was clean, with no ellipsis of any figure. As an inhabitant of fourteen winters in that house, she understood the importance of trust, and warmly she would amplify her praise of the staff rather than protest their small faults. On the frozen pond the children would skate, and the estate, once doomed, seemed to vanquish its debts.

中文翻译

尽管冬天严酷，那位年迈的仆人仍以节俭的细心维持着庄园的运转。在食品柜里，她会炖上厚厚一大批面包、骨头汤和罐装蔬菜，用一只破旧的煎锅箔把它从锅里舀进碗中，碗就在壁炉旁温着。她的胆略显而易见，甚至令人敬畏，尽管她从不想用闲聊去取悦贵族。一条经营准则指引着她：凡事检查两遍。她会擦拭每件固定装置，刷洗马车轮，并在一本连打字员都挑不出错的账簿里把家用钱列成表。庄园的赤字已增得庞大，是一场致命的债务倾销，看守警告说如今信誉至关重要。作为一个注重实效的女人，她拒绝惊慌。她所奉行的那种节俭近乎理论化，却行之有效。尽管邻人怀有敌意，地区性的种族歧视让她的处境令人不快，她在精神上仍保持乐观，顽固地开朗。当那位狡猾又保守反动的年轻领主威胁要解雇她时，她并不自怜流血。她会拿出自己微薄的津贴去承担修缮，甚至冒险动用积蓄买中等品级的煤。与邻近庄园的领土纠纷陷入僵局；旧地契里一处毫无希望的前后矛盾使边界在每张地图上都缺失。一个绝妙的早晨，她在打扫庭院时，一位左撇子文书乘高速公路带来一封电报。律师集团已作出裁决。为了证实这家人的主张，他们需要藏在烟囱一块松动骨头后面的一封密信的原始解码。她爬上去，狂乱的风扯着她的斗篷，梯子摇晃时她加紧抓住一个螺栓。煤灰的残渣让她咳嗽；一阵尘土像旋风般泛起涟漪。她猛地一冲把纸抽了出来，随即发出胜利的喊叫。忧虑那循环往复的季节似乎被泼洒而去。那份用速记写成、读来像异国时代的文件，证明了这片土地属于他们。如今任何恶作剧、任何谣言的污秽都无法玷污这个家族。那晚他们在借来的机器上看了一段闪烁的录像，下了国际象棋，又在结冰的水池上滑冰。领主的偏执缓解了，发誓要保护她免受任何可怕的威胁。她以安静的高尚证明了，一个细心的仆人不会被命运矮化。一种没有种族歧视、充满希望的秩序扎下了根。连大门口那间小屋——她最初睡在稻草床上一个麻袋里的地方——如今也挂起了一枚小小的荣誉徽章。她把一排空置的农舍租了出去，把一座曾经生锈的庄园变得有利可图，证明了胆略加上节俭能让任何寒冬都熬得过去。为了展示账目，她会把每一笔开支和租金收据记入借方，连最细微的一摄氏度细节都全神贯注，从不前后矛盾。她的算术干净利落，没有省略任何一个数字。作为在那座房子里度过十四个冬天的住户，她懂得信任的重要性，她会热情地放大对员工的称赞，而不是抗议他们的小过失。在结冰的池塘上，孩子们滑冰，而这座一度注定衰败的庄园，似乎征服了它的债务。

15. The Archaeologist's Determination

English

The **director** of the museum, a **watchful** and conscientious woman, called the whole team **together** for an **essential** briefing **tonight**. An **archaeologist** by training, she had spent her **little** spare time studying a **posthumous** edition of a **heretic** scholar's notes, a **circular** argument that **other** experts had long resented. Her **determination** never wavered. "We must not **delude** ourselves," she said, her **wooden** pointer tapping a **global** map. "The dig in **Italy** is **critical**, and the evidence so far is **invalid** until we **revise** it." The **researcher** beside her, **excited** yet careful, agreed: they would **cooperate** and work together, not apart. He resolved to **extol** the **buyer** who had funded them, a **thankful** gesture, **instead** of dwelling on the **sadness** of past failures. **Away** from the lecture, the **courtyard** was calm. A circular fountain caught the **laser**-bright moonlight, and the fragile, frail **blade** of a single reed trembled. The team's **inspiration** came from a strange **hazard**: a **bandage** of **limited** cloth, found wrapped around a **carbon**-dated bone, bore a **countersignature** and a **forensic** mark that **subsequently** changed everything. To the untrained eye it looked like mere decoration, but its **fiber** told another story. **Constituent** threads, when insulated under glass and not allowed to **dissipate**, revealed a hidden **brand**. The other clue was a **slit** in a wooden chest, sealed with a sanitary **postal stamp** from a long-dead empire. "This is no delusion," the director said. "**Hereafter** we treat every **flesh**-and-blood detail as evidence." One assistant, prone to **flirt** and to **drowse** during long sessions, suddenly grew watchful. He had nearly closed the file, mistaken about its value. Now he saw the **eradication** of doubt within reach. An **accusation** of fraud, once leveled at the heretic, could finally be negated; the man's **reminiscence**, written in a **frightening**, **outrageous** tone, was in **retrospect** a record of truth, not a **murder** of facts. The team felt a **happiness** **close** to determination itself. They would not **resent** the long nights. To **mislead** the public, even by a fraction, would be a sin; to **draw** the right conclusion was their essential duty. As the **total** picture emerged, the director gave a hearty, warmly approving nod. Her **mother**, an invalid in a distant **infirmary**, had once told her that patience extols the patient. The **retell** of this discovery, she knew, would become an excited, brand-new chapter. No **assassinator** of reputations, no **disloyalty**, could now undo it. The **frightening** **dear** cost of years had bought a posthumous justice, and that, she felt, was a blessing worth every wakeful hour. After the **funeral** of the old scholar, the museum's **bookkeeper**, a man **conversant** with every ledger, refused to **waver**. He would not **flip** through the files carelessly, nor **abuse** the archive. In **view** of the find, the team would **reap** real reward, **warranted** by the evidence. No **partisan attack**, no political **vent**, could **induce** them to **amalgamate** truth with rumor. A **choral** group sang at the **fourth** memorial; outside, a smith would **hammer** a bright **ingot**, and a **pollutant** haze hung in the air. The director's **daughter**, her **nose** pressed to the glass case, took up archaeology as more than a **pastime**. Workers would **insulate** the relics in a sealed **shop** room, safe from harm.

中文翻译

博物馆馆长是一位警惕而认真的女性，**今晚**她把整个团队召集起来做一次**必要**的简报。她受过**考古学家**的训练，把自己**不多**的空闲时间都花在研究一位异端学者笔记的死后**版本**上——那是一套循环论证，长期为其他专家所**怨恨**。她的**决心**从未动摇。“我们绝不能自欺，”她说，木制教鞭敲着一幅全球地图。“**意大利**的发掘至关重要，目前的证据在我们**修订**之前都是**无效**的。”她身旁的研究者既兴奋又谨慎，表示同意：他们将**合作**、**一起**工作，而不是各自为政。他决意去**赞美**资助他们的那位买主，以表感谢，而不是沉湎于过往失败的悲伤。**离开**讲座，**庭院**一片宁静。一座圆形喷泉接住了**激光**般明亮的月光，一根芦苇脆弱纤细的**叶片**在颤抖。团队的**灵感**来自一个奇怪的**危险**物：一卷数量**有限**的布**绷带**，缠在一根经碳定年的骨头上，带有一处**副署**和一个法医标记，后来改变了一切。在外行眼中它不过是装饰，但它的**纤维**讲述着另一个故事。当那些**组成**的线在玻璃下被隔绝、不**让其消散**时，显露出一个隐藏的**烙印**。另一条线索是一只木箱上的一道狭缝，用一张来自早已灭亡帝国的卫生**邮票**封着。“这不是错觉，”馆长说。“**此后**我们把每一个有血有肉的细节都当作证据。”一名容易**调情**、在长会中**打瞌睡**的助手忽然变得警觉。他差点合上这份卷宗，错估了它的价值。如今他看到消除疑虑近在咫尺。曾加诸那位异端的**欺诈控告**终于可以被否定；那个人的**回忆录**，以一种令人害怕、骇人的语气写成，**回顾**来看是真相的记录，而非对事实的**谋杀**。团队感到一种近乎决心本身的**幸福**。他们不会怨恨这些漫漫长夜。哪怕只误导公众一丝一毫也将是罪过；得出正确的结论才是他们必要的职责。当全部图景浮现，馆长热忱而热情赞许地点了点头。她的**母亲**是远方疗养院里的一名病人，曾告诉她耐心会颂扬有耐心的人。她知道，这一发现的**复述**将成为令人**兴奋**的崭新篇章。任何声誉的**暗杀者**、任何**不忠**都已无法将它推翻。多年来令人心疼的昂贵代价换来了一份**身后的公正**，而她觉得，这是值得每一个不眠之夜的福分。在老学者的**葬礼**之后，博物馆的**簿记员**——一个精通每一本账册的人——拒绝动摇。他不会粗心地翻阅卷宗，也不会**滥用**档案。鉴于这一发现，团队将**收获**真正的回报，这有证据担保。任何党派的**攻击**、任何政治的**发泄**，都无法诱使他们把真相与谣言混为一谈。一个合唱队在**第四次**纪念会上歌唱；外面，一名铁匠**敲打**着一块明亮的**锭铁**，空气中悬着一层污染物的雾霾。馆长的**女儿**把**鼻子**贴在玻璃展柜上，她把考古学当作不只是**消遣**。工人们会把文物隔绝在一间密封的库房里，使其免受损害。

16. A Doctor in the Volcanic Town

English

The new nurse arrived in an urban district shadowed by a volcanic cape, where a single dwarf pine clung to the harsh slope. Her assistant, a shoemaker's son turned medical helper, followed her through the season's first storm. Their action that day would mark them both. A boy had begun to vomit and his thyroid felt swollen; an antibiotic was their only feasible weapon against the infection, yet the local supply was a mess. Lack of clean water made every task harsh. The doctor, an eloquent and pure-hearted woman, refused to neglect a single patient. "To eradicate this disease, we must accelerate," she said, and her verbal orders were conclusive. She would not succumb to panic. Inside the shanty clinic, a broom leaned by the bottle-lined shelf; a diesel generator coughed, its irregular hum a small comfort. She wiped a yellow stain of lime from the table, set a salad bowl aside, and reached for the bleach to keep the room sanitary. A repetition of careful steps, she knew, was the only cure for chaos. The truth was plain: deficiency of supplies could be fatal. Yet she would not let violence or despair oppress her team. When a man clutched his chest and screamed, she did not wake in fright; she acted. Her cunning, in the best sense, was practical. She used a wrench to fix the broken clutch of an old motor, configuration by configuration, so the fridge could run and the antibiotic stay cold. Recreation was a luxury here. A picnic, a game of chess, a publication to recite by the fire — such comfortable pleasures belonged to another life. Still, the team found a delightful, even comfortable rhythm. The shoemaker's son, once unwilling, grew bold. "This is my role," he said, and he meant it. They worked to expansion, training five then thirteen local volunteers, each given a badge that bore a small graph of progress. A socialist council, eager to follow the new keeping of records, sent a delegation by railway. The doctor's speciality was not glamour but repetition done right. She squeezed every drop from a fraught budget; reimbursement, she joked, would arrive after the next eruption. One night a tyrant rumor spread — that the clinic would discontinue — but it proved false. The nurse, harsh only with carelessness, made the truth follow her words. By the dry season's end the disease was in retreat, and the small mouth of the cape, once a place of fester and harm, was a haven of health. "We did not eradicate fear," she told the assembled crowd, smiling at her own slip of the tongue, "but we did eradicate the worst of the sickness." The pellet of medicine, the shoe of a walking patient, the wake of every recovered child — all of it, she said, was worth more than any gramophone song or salad supper. Truth, harsh and pure, had won. In an essay she later wrote, the nurse called neglect a kind of sin, a fetter on any healer. She described how an orthopedic case nearly slipped into delirium, how a child's scream pierced the night, and how she had to squeeze past panic and guard her calm. A Moslem elder with a grey beard, her son-in-law's mentor, helped her safely store disposable gloves. Regionalization of the clinics, an arboreal network spreading like branches, let aid reach far. No scum of doubt could ruffle her resolve. At dusk a pyre of old crates burned, its embers a twinkle against the dark; even the subjunctive 'if only' lost its sting, and hope, like a tentacle, reached toward tomorrow.

中文翻译

新来的护士抵达一个被火山岬阴影笼罩的城市街区，一棵矮小的松树紧抓着陡峭崎岖的山坡。她的助手是鞋匠的儿子，后来成了医疗帮手，跟着她穿过这个季节的第一场风暴。那天他们的行动将给两人都打下印记。一个男孩开始呕吐，甲状腺摸起来肿胀；抗生素是他们对抗感染唯一可行的武器，可当地的供应却一团糟。缺乏清洁的水使每项工作都艰难。这位医生口才出众、心地纯洁，拒绝忽视任何一名病人。"要根除这种疾病，我们必须加快，"她说，她口头的命令是决定性的。她不会屈服于恐慌。在棚屋诊所里，一把扫帚靠在排满瓶子的架子旁；一台柴油发电机咳着，它不规则的嗡鸣是小小的安慰。她擦掉桌上一片黄色的石灰污渍，把一只色拉碗挪到一边，伸手去拿漂白剂以保持房间卫生。她知道，反复执行谨慎的步骤是治理混乱的唯一良方。真相很明白：物资的不足可能是致命的。然而她不会让暴力或绝望压制她的团队。当一个男人抓着胸口尖叫时，她没有惊醒于恐惧之中；她行动了。她的精明，从最好的意义上说，是务实的。她用一把扳手修好一台旧马达坏掉的离合器，一处构造接一处构造地修，好让冰箱运转、让抗生素保持低温。在这里娱乐是奢侈品。野餐、一局国际象棋、一份在炉火边背诵的出版物——这样舒适的乐趣属于另一种人生。尽管如此，团队还是找到了一种令人愉快、甚至舒适的节奏。鞋匠的儿子起初不情愿，后来变得大胆。"这是我的角色，"他说，而且是认真的。他们朝着扩张努力，先培训五名、再培训十三名当地志愿者，每人都获得一枚徽章，上面有一张小小的进度图表。一个社会主义议会急于遵循新的记录保存方式，派了一个代表团乘铁路前来。这位医生的专长不是光鲜，而是把重复的事做对。她从一份充满困难的预算中榨取每一滴；她开玩笑说，报销会在下一次火山喷发之后到账。一天夜里，一个暴君般的谣言传开——说诊所将要停办——但被证明是假的。这位护士只对粗心严厉，让真相追随她的话语。到旱季结束时，疾病已在退却，那曾经是溃烂与伤害之地的小小岬角口，成了健康的避风港。"我们没能根除恐惧，"她对聚集的人群说，对自己的口误笑了笑，"但我们确实根除了最严重的病情。"那粒药丸、一名能行走病人的鞋、每个康复孩子苏醒的痕迹——她说，所有这一切都比任何留声机的歌或色拉晚餐更有价值。真相，严酷而纯粹，赢了。在她后来写的一篇随笔里，这位护士把疏忽称作一种罪，是任何医者的桎梏。她描述了一例骨科病人如何几乎陷入精神错乱，一个孩子的尖叫如何划破夜空，以及她如何挤过恐慌、守住镇定。一位长着灰胡子的穆斯林长者，是她女婿的导师，帮她安全地存放一次性手套。诊所的区域化是一张像枝桠般蔓延的树状网络，让援助抵达远方。没有任何怀疑的浮渣能扰乱她的决心。黄昏时一堆旧木箱的柴堆燃烧着，余烬在黑暗中闪烁；连那虚拟的'要是当初'也失去了刺痛，希望如一条触须，伸向明天。

17. The Moon Mission Rehearsal

English

The **presence** of the whole crew was required before the **lunar** rehearsal could begin. Mission control had chosen to **automate** much of the launch sequence, yet a human hand would still **steer** the craft at the critical moment. The pilot, **pale** with fatigue, adjusted her **posture** in the seat and felt a **tremble** run through the hull as the engines built **thrust**. "Stay **accurate**," the flight director said, his voice **telling** and calm. "One error could **negate** a year of work." An **array** of screens glowed **nearby**; **on** each, a **linear** graph traced the rocket's **position**. The **simulate** program would **stimulate** every fault the engineers could imagine, from a **toxic** fuel leak to a **collide** warning when two objects drew near in orbit. Nobody wanted a **scandal**, and nobody wanted to **perish**. The **impetus** for this mission had begun with a single **vision**: to **place** a small array of sensors on the **virgin** surface of a distant crater. Critics called the budget **exaggeration**, an **ostentation** of national pride, but **approval** had come at last after a long **pending** review. The team refused to let any flaw go unaddressed; they would **rectify** each one, **thoroughly**, before the real flight. In the pause, the pilot let her mind **jog** back to her childhood. She would **slumber** under a **quilt** while her father, a **sympathetic** man, told her of caravans crossing the desert, of a **tuck** of stars near the **shore**, of the lunar light that made the **pepper** plants in their garden gleam. He had a **counterfeit** pocket watch, bought cheap, yet to her it was a treasure. He would **alight** from his old **motorcar**, **wail** a funny tune, and tuck her in. That **tendency** to dream had steered her whole life. Now, on the simulator, an alarm cried out. A **frail** line on the screen turned red — an **eruption** of pressure in tank six. Her **refusal** to panic saved the run. She did not waver. With a quick thrust of the control stick she corrected the array, and the linear path settled. The director gave a slow nod of approval. "**Accomplishment**," he said, "is mostly the refusal to quit." Outside, near a **flood-control** channel by the shore, an **athlete** jogged past, unaware of the drama within. A **maid** swept the steps of the old **telegraph** office; a **roller** of fresh paint dried on a nearby wall. The world went on, **weak** to the wonders overhead. But inside the dome, the crew felt the **irony**: to reach the cold and **additional** silence of space, they had to master every **inconvenient** detail on the ground. "**Enough** for tonight," the director said. "We have a clearer position now." The **conversion** from fear to confidence was nearly complete. As the lights dimmed, the pilot paused, intent, and let one private prayer rise. The lunar dream, once a frail **puzzle**, now felt feasible. A **pair** of technicians shut the hatch, and the simulated ship went dark, its vision banked for another day. With some **perplexity**, the crew gripped the rails **tightly**, unwilling to let fear **perturb** them. To **shorten** the wait, the director told a **strategic** joke about a **fridge** full of **grape** juice and a single cold **shot** of soda. It was a **blessing** to laugh. **Temporal** worries would **deplete** anyone; they had to **make** peace with delay. A **note** on the wall, printed with a **stencil**, listed the **aerodynamics** drills and the **elimination** of each fault. Outside, near a road of fresh **bitumen**, an **artillery** museum stood like a **haven**; a **caravan** of trucks passed, marked **ex** works for an overseas **importer**. One could **surmise**, even without a course in **botany**, that the team's quiet **idiosyncrasy** was patience. The agency would **indemnify** any loss and would not **persecute** a single honest error. A small daily **allowance**, and the promise to **promote** the steady ones, kept spirits high. **Unable** to sleep, the pilot watched an old **movie** about **forty** pioneers, and felt the **heat** of ambition return.

中文翻译

在月球演练开始之前，全体机组人员必须**到场**。任务控制中心选择将大部分发射程序自动化，但在关键时刻仍需人手来**驾驶**飞船。飞行员因疲惫而面色苍白，她在座位上调整**姿势**，感到当引擎积聚**推力**时一阵震动穿过船体。"保持精确，"飞行指挥说，他的声音很有分量却镇定，"一个差错就可能抵消一年的工作。"**附近**一排屏幕发着光；每块屏上，一条线性的曲线图描绘着火箭的**位置**。**模拟**程序会激发工程师能想象到的每一种故障，从有毒燃料泄漏到两个物体在轨道上接近时的**碰撞**警报。没人想要丑闻，也没人想丧命。这次任务的**推动力**始于一个单纯的愿景：在一个遥远陨石坑未被触碰的表面上**放置**一小组传感器。批评者称这预算是**夸张**，是民族自豪感的炫耀，但在漫长的搁置审查之后，**批准**终于到来。团队**拒绝**让任何缺陷无人处理；他们要在真正飞行之前彻底**纠正**每一个。在间歇中，飞行员让思绪**慢跑**回童年。她会盖着**被子**沉睡，而她那富有**同情心**的父亲，给她讲述穿越沙漠的商队，讲述海岸边一簇星辰，讲述使他们园中**辣椒**植株闪亮的月光。他有一只廉价买来的**假冒**怀表，但对她而言那是珍宝。他会从旧**汽车**上下来，**哀号**般地哼一支滑稽的曲子，给她盖好被子。那种爱做梦的倾向引导了她的一生。如今，在模拟器上，一个警报响起。屏幕上一条**脆弱**的线变红了——六号燃料箱压力骤升。她拒绝惊慌，救了这次演练。她没有动摇。她迅速一推操纵杆，修正了阵列，线性的航线稳定了下来。指挥缓缓点头表示认可。"**成就**，"他说，"大多是拒绝放弃。"外面，海岸边一条**防洪**水道旁，一名**运动员**慢跑而过，对这内部的戏剧浑然不觉。一名**女仆**扫着旧**电报**局的台阶；附近墙上一滚新刷的油漆正在晾干。世界照常运转，对头顶的奇迹无力察觉。但在穹顶内，机组感到了讽刺：为了抵达太空那寒冷而**额外**的寂静，他们必须在地面上掌握每一个不便的细节。"今晚够了，"指挥说，"我们现在的处境更清晰了。"从恐惧到自信的**转变**几近完成。当灯光暗下时，飞行员停顿，神情专注，让一句私下的祈祷升起。那个月球之梦，曾是一个脆弱的谜题，如今感觉可行了。**一对**技术员关上舱门，模拟的飞船陷入黑暗，它的愿景为又一天而搁置。带着几分困惑，机组紧紧抓住栏杆，不愿让恐惧扰乱他们。为了缩短等待，指挥讲了一个有策略的笑话，说一台装满**葡萄汁**的冰箱和一杯冰苏打。能笑出来是一种福分。**世俗**的忧虑会**耗尽**任何人；他们必须与延误握手言和。墙上一张用**蜡纸**印出的便条，列着**空气动力学**演练和每个故障的**排除**。外面，**靠近**一条新铺**沥青**的路，一座炮兵博物馆像**避难所**一样矗立；一队卡车驶过，标注着为一位海外**进口商**交货的字样。即使不修一门**植物学**课程，人们也能**推测**，这支团队安静的**特质**就是耐心。代理机构会**赔偿**任何损失，绝不会因一个诚实的错误而**迫害**任何人。一小笔每日**津贴**，以及提拔稳健者的承诺，让士气高昂。飞行员无法入睡，看了一部讲述**四十**位拓荒者的老**电影**，感到雄心的**热度**重新回来。

18. The Thinker's Last Year

English

In the **last year** of his **lifetime**, the old **thinker**, an **upright** and **humane** man, settled into a quiet residence near a field where a **plough** still turned the earth. His **health** was failing, and a **profound anxiety**, almost a **jealousy** of younger minds, would sometimes **madden** him. Yet he taught to the very end, **since** teaching gave him **pleasure** that **nothing** else could match. "**Everybody** must **defend** the **liberty** to think," he would say, gazing through the window at a **swan** on the pond, a **horse** at the fence, a **bird** in the **granary** eaves. His **style** of speech was **heartly** and **genuine**, never **plausible** nonsense dressed as wisdom. Each **session**, he would **dispense** one idea, **perfect** in its **symmetry**, and let his students **sharpen** it. He had no **weapon** but reason; **revenge** and **political** faction held nothing for him. He spoke of an **episode** from his youth, when a cruel **accident** had nearly killed him. A **craft** he sailed had struck **gravel** near the shore, and only the genuine courage of a fellow passenger had saved him. "**Such** things," he said, "**teach** you that **nowhere** is safe, and that we hold our **possession** of life on loan." The memory still made him **gaze** into the **fireplace**, **evidently** moved. His **ardent** students would not let his thought perish. They **consume** his every word, eager to obtain a **manuscript** he had long postponed publishing. An **Australian** scholar arrived to **appoint** herself his editor; **respectively**, others took on the index, the notes, the **specification** of each footnote. The **likelihood** of finishing in time was small, but they refused to be **mistaken** about their duty. The thinker, **shrewd** to the last, would **tread** carefully around any **flaw** in his old logic. "Do not **segregate** the heart from the mind," he warned. "To **exterminate** feeling is to ruin thought." He had once seen a **colony** of swans, white against a grey sky, and the marvellous sight had become a private weapon against despair. Now, in his **rusty** old age, he returned to it often. One **six-line** poem he had written, **fluorescent** in its clarity, spoke of a **god** of small mercies and of the **sacrifice** that any worthy life demands. He would not boast of it. As October cooled the air, an **actor** friend came to read the verse aloud, and a **withdrawal** of sorrow seemed to follow. The thinker felt, for once, no **inconvenience**, no **commonsense** fear. He had done his work **satisfactorily**, **actively**, and with **merchandise** of the soul that no **liquor** or rusty grief could spoil. "I have nothing left to prove," he said, his liberty intact. Outside, the swan swam on; the bird sang; and the old man, content at last, watched the year turn. His **neighbor**, a practical farmer, once joked that it was **ludicrous** to **fling pesticide** on a healthy crop; **prevention**, he said, was **exactly** the better path. The **outturn** of the harvest, recorded **module** by module on a sheet of **cardboard**, exceeded every estimate. As **chairman** of the local **organization**, the thinker had an **obligation** he would never **postpone**: to teach grammar, even the humble **transitive** verb, to the village children. They would **swim** in summer, play **volleyball**, go **camping**, and chop **onion** for the campfire stew. When a **tyre** went flat or a **leakage** of rain broke the **deadlock** of a dull afternoon, he simply smiled.

中文翻译

在他**一生的最后**一年里，这位年迈的**思想家**——一个正直而仁慈的人——在一片仍有犁翻土的田野附近的安静住所安顿下来。他的**健康**每况愈下，一种深沉的**忧虑**，近乎对年轻头脑的**嫉妒**，有时会让他**发狂**。然而他直到最后仍在教学，**因为**教学给他一种别的任何东西都无法比拟的**快乐**。"每个人都必须捍卫思考的**自由**，"他会说，透过窗户凝望池塘上的一只**天鹅**、栅栏边的一匹马、**谷仓**檐下的一只鸟。他说话的**风格**热忱而真诚，绝非披着智慧外衣的**似是而非**的胡言。每一堂课，他都会**施予**一个观念，其**对称**之美完美无瑕，并让学生去打磨它。除了理性，他没有别的**武器**；复仇与政治派系于他毫无意义。他讲起年轻时的一段往事，当时一场残酷的**意外**几乎要了他的命。他驾驶的一艘小船在岸边撞上**碎石**，全靠同船一位旅客**真正的**勇气才救了他。"这种事，"他说，"教你明白没有任何地方是安全的，我们对生命的拥有不过是借来的。"这段记忆仍让他凝望着**壁炉**，**显然**为之动容。他那些**热心的**学生不会让他的思想消亡。他们吞咽他的每一个字，急切地想得到一份他长久**推迟**出版的手稿。一位澳大利亚学者前来，自荐当他的编辑；其余的人则分别承担索引、注释、每条脚注的**详述**。按时**完成的可能性**很小，但他们拒绝在自己的职责上搞错。这位思想家精明到最后，会小心地绕开他旧逻辑中的任何**瑕疵**。"不要把心与脑**隔离**开，"他告诫，"消灭情感就是毁掉思想。"他曾见过一群天鹅，在灰色天空映衬下洁白如雪，那绝妙的景象成了他对抗绝望的私人武器。如今，在他生锈般的暮年，他常常重温它。他写过一首六行的诗，清澈得如同荧光，讲述一位主管细小慈悲的神，以及任何值得过的人生所要求的**牺牲**。他不会以此自夸。当十月使空气转凉，一位**演员**朋友前来朗读这首诗，悲伤的退潮似乎随之而来。思想家这一次感到没有**不便**，没有出于常识的恐惧。他已**圆满地**、**积极地**完成了自己的工作，带着任何酒或**生锈**的悲伤都无法败坏的灵魂的货品。"我再没有什么需要证明的了，"他说，自由完好无损。屋外，天鹅继续游着；鸟儿歌唱；这位老人终于心满意足，看着这一年流转。他的**邻居**是个务实的农民，曾打趣说，往健康的庄稼上抛洒**杀虫剂**是荒唐的；他说，**预防**恰恰是更好的路。收成的**卸货情况**一格一格地记在一张**硬纸板上**，超出了**所有的**估计。作为当地**组织的主席**，这位思想家有一项他从不推迟的**义务**：教村里的孩子语法，连那不起眼的**及物动词**也教。他们夏天**游泳**，打**排球**，去**野营**，为篝火炖菜切**洋葱**。当一只**轮胎**瘪了，或一场雨的渗漏打破了一个沉闷下午的**僵局**，他只是微笑。

19. The Announcer's Resolution

English

When the radio **announcer** first took the job, **finance** was the last thing on his mind. He had been a **careful**, **skillful** young **fellow** with **much courage** but little money, and his only **practicable** plan was to **please** the public and hope for the best. **Aboard** a ferry one **October** morning, **age eight** in spirit if not in years, he had decided to become a voice that the nation would trust. "**Necessarily**," he told a fellow passenger, "I must speak **accurately**, or I am nothing." That **resolution**, **laudable** and firm, never wavered. **Except** for one **absence** caused by **hepatitis**, he had not missed a broadcast in eight years. His **routine** was strict: he would arrive early, **list** the headlines, and **separately** rehearse each **summary** aloud. He refused to be **arrogant**; arrogance, he believed, was an **ugly streak** that could **drown** a man's better self. **Regarding** the news itself, he tried to comprehend it deeply before he spoke. A story about **official bribery**, a **hostage** crisis, the **prosecute** of a **snob** who had tried to **steal** public funds, the **monstrous evolution** of a scandal at the **aquarium** board: each of these he treated with equal care. He would not let a **triumphant** tone creep in, nor would he **smash** a reputation **lightly**. One evening, a colleague tried to **tantalize** him with a rumor about a **wholesaler** who, it was said, would finance a corrupt campaign. "**Alas**," the announcer said, "I cannot **air** what I cannot prove. The **disappearance** of one fact can mislead a whole nation." He kept a small list of principles taped above his **terminal**, written in **straight**, careful lines. The **software** that ran the studio sometimes failed, and on those nights he would grope for a backup, refusing to drown the broadcast in dead air. He had studied **biology** and **geometry** at school, and a little of the **temperate** logic of those subjects stayed with him; he liked things that **correspond** to reason. When the **petrol** shortage struck and prices began to **bob** upward, he reported it without panic, separating real **distribution** problems from **jumble** and rumor. His **lovely**, refined manner made even bad news bearable. People said his voice could **surround** a frightened city like a **refuge**. He never sought to **horrify**, never let a **howl** of outrage into his tone. In time he was offered a promotion to the central desk, and though the **suspense** of the decision kept him awake, he accepted with a careful, **indirectly** grateful nod to his old mentor, the **mister** who had first taught him to speak. "You did not necessarily teach me facts," he wrote in a letter. "You taught me to **arouse** trust, and to keep it." He sealed the note, asked for a **receipt**, and posted it that very day. Years later, near a quiet **tomb** on a hill, he would **recline** and recall that the whole long enterprise had begun with one boy's stubborn refusal to lie. He refused to **hound** a source **piecemeal**; instead he would **enquire closely**, **decipher** every **decimal** of a budget, and seek the **concurrence** of two editors before air. Low **morale** could **affect** a whole newsroom, so he fed his team good **nourishment** and humor to prevent any **relapse** into cynicism. A touch of **refinement** marked his prose; he would never **suspend** his standards. He loved the **scent** of fresh ink. After a **reception** one night, he wrote a **caption** for a photo of his **fiance** beside a wall of white **gypsum**, lit by soft **light**. From the **occidental** desk to a long **trek** across the country, he **cast** aside the fear of **failure**. 'Ditto,' his editor would say to every careful choice, and the young man took flight under his mentor's **wing**.

中文翻译

当这位电台播音员第一次接下这份工作时，财务是他最不在意的事。他曾是个细心、**娴熟的**年轻人，有的是**勇气**，钱却不多，他唯一**可行**的计划就是取悦公众，并寄望于最好的结果。在**十月**一个清晨的渡轮上，即使**年龄**不到、心境却如八岁孩童般，他已决定要成为一个全国都信任的声音。**"必然地"**，他对一位同船旅客说，"我必须**准确地**说话，否则我什么都不是。"那个值得称赞而**坚定的**决心，从未动摇。除了一次因**肝炎**而**缺席**之外，八年来他没有错过一次播报。他的**惯例**很严格：他会早早到达，列出头条，并分别把每段**摘要**大声排练一遍。他拒绝傲慢；他相信傲慢是一道**丑陋的**纹路，会淹没一个人更好的自我。至于**新闻**本身，他在开口前力求深刻地理解它。一桩**官员**受贿的报道、一场**人质**危机、对一个曾试图**窃取公款**的**势利小人**的**起诉**、**水族馆**董事会一桩丑闻**可怕的演变**：他对每一件都同等谨慎对待。他不会让**得意洋洋**的腔调溜进来，也不会轻率地砸毁谁的名声。一天傍晚，一位**同事**想用一则传闻**逗弄**他，说某个**批发商**据传会资助一场腐败的竞选。"唉，"播音员说，"我无法播出我无法证实的东西。一个事实的**消失**就能误导整个国家。"他在终端机上方贴着一小张原则清单，用笔直、工整的字迹写成。运行演播室的**软件**有时会出故障，那些夜里他会摸索备用方案，拒绝让广播淹没在静默之中。他在学校学过**生物学**和**几何学**，那些科目中**温和的**逻辑有一点留在了他身上；他**喜欢符合**理性的东西。当**汽油**短缺来袭、价格开始上下浮动时，他报道此事毫不惊慌，把真正的**分配**问题与**杂乱的**谣言区分开来。他可爱而优雅的举止让坏消息都变得可以承受。人们说他的声音能像避难所一样**环绕**一座受惊的城市。他不想制造恐惧，从不让一声愤怒的**嚎叫**进入他的语调。后来他获得晋升到中央台的机会，尽管这个决定的悬念让他彻夜难眠，他还是接受了，向他的老导师——那位最初教他说话的**先生**——含蓄而感激地点了点头。"你未必教了我事实，"他在一封信里写道，"你教我去唤起信任，并守住它。"他封好便笺，索取一张**收据**，当天就寄了出去。多年以后，在一座山上安静的坟墓旁，他会斜倚下来，回想这整桩漫长的事业，竟始于一个男孩固执地拒绝撒谎。他拒绝零敲碎打地追逼一个消息来源；相反，他会**仔细打听**，破译预算的每一个小数，并在播出前寻求两位编辑的一致同意。低落的**士气**会影响整个新闻编辑室，于是他给团队提供良好的滋养和幽默，防止任何重新陷入愤世嫉俗的**旧病复发**。他的文字带着一丝优雅；他绝不会**暂停**自己的标准。他喜欢新鲜油墨的**气味**。一天夜里一场**招待会**之后，他为一张照片写了说明文字，照片里他的未婚妻站在一面白色**石膏**墙旁，被柔和的灯光照着。从西方编辑台到一次横穿全国的长途跋涉，他抛开了对**失败**的恐惧。**'同上'**，他的编辑会对每一个谨慎的选择这样说，而这位年轻人在导师的羽翼下展翅高飞。

20. Consensus at the Renewable Energy Guild

English

After months of debate, the consensus inside the central guild was that the nation could no longer waste its resources. The custodian of the old building, a calm man who had worked there alone for years, slipped on his earphone and listened to the chairman of the renewable energy committee speak. "This," the chairman said, jumping straight to the point, "is purely a question of survival. Here, in this very location, we will either thrive or fade." Everyone leaned inside to hear. The plan was generic in outline but precise in detail. On each storey of the building, redundant heating systems would be replaced; a smart program would filter demand and cut the mileage that delivery trucks logged every successive day. A columnist who wrote for a major channel had called the scheme inalienable to the city's future, and few wished to impede it. The custodian, listening from the back, felt a strange zeal rise in him. He had spent his lifetime watching waste pile up, and now, actually, change seemed to loom near. "We hereby declare," the chairman read from the manifesto, "that dependability matters more than show." There was an occasional cough, a wink between two engineers, the rotary hum of an old fan. A graphic on the screen, almost like a moth circling a lantern, displayed the accumulative savings. Insofar as the math held, the limitation was no longer technical but political. A faction loyal to the old grocer-merchants resisted; arrogance and arrogance alone, the chairman thought, kept them from agreeing. But the merciful truth was that even they would benefit. After the vote, enrolment in the new training sessions jumped. A registered nurse from the hospital nearby spoke about disease and how a polluted river could trample public health; a Frenchman who ran the lubrication depot promised cleaner oil; a pianist offered to play at the launch to motivate the crowd. The diaphragm of the old ventilation system was repaired, the bald patch of rust on the bridge railing was scraped, and a derelict shed behind the residence was cleared. No one would pollute the channel again, they agreed, nor remit the duty to future generations. "We must not grope in the dark," the chairman said, his cell phone buzzing with messages. "A succinct plan, repetitive in its discipline, will carry us southward toward warmer markets and account for every cent." The custodian smiled. He thought of a white peacock he had once seen, its fragrance of pride, its arrogance; and he thought, too, of how a single cell of effort, multiplied across a nation, could let an intellectual dream finally arise. As the meeting closed, a pleasant calm settled over the room. The fraction of doubters had shrunk; the bookshelf of old excuses was finally being emptied. After all the noise, the slowdown of waste had truly begun. A retired colonel, married for decades, rose to comprehend the plan, refusing to kneel to old inertia. He would not boast, yet he made one jump of faith and backed the vote. A plumber checked the pipes' thickness; a valve turned anticlockwise sealed the last leak. There would be no dismissal of staff, only new work. As a faithful listener to every meeting, he treated the reform not as a game but as a duty, and even joked that the cafeteria's cheese would taste sweeter now.

中文翻译

经过数月的辩论，中央行会内部的共识是：国家再也不能浪费它的资源了。这座老建筑的管理人是个沉静的人，独自在这里工作了多年，他戴上耳机，听可再生能源委员会的主席讲话。"这，"主席直截了当地说，"纯粹是一个生存的问题。就在这里，就在这个地点，我们要么兴旺，要么消亡。"所有人都向里凑近去听。这个计划在轮廓上是笼统的，但在细节上很精确。建筑的每一层，多余的供暖系统都将被更换；一套智能程序会过滤需求，削减送货卡车一天天累积的里程。一位为某大频道撰稿的专栏作家曾称这一方案对城市的未来不可剥夺，几乎没人愿意去阻碍它。管理人在后排听着，心中升起一种奇异的热情。他一生都在看着废物堆积，而如今，变化竟似乎真的逼近了。"我们特此宣布，"主席从宣言中念道，"可靠性比排场更重要。"偶尔有人咳嗽，两个工程师之间眨了眨眼，一台旧风扇发出旋转的嗡鸣。屏幕上一幅图像，几乎像一只绕着灯笼飞的蛾子，显示着累积的节省额。只要数字成立，限制就不再是技术上的，而是政治上的。一个忠于旧杂货商的派别表示抗拒；主席想，唯有傲慢、纯粹的傲慢，才使他们不肯同意。但仁慈的真相是：连他们也会受益。投票之后，新培训课程的报名人数猛增。附近医院一位注册护士谈到疾病，谈到一条被污染的河流会如何践踏公众健康；一位经营润滑油库的法国人承诺提供更清洁的油；一位钢琴家提出在启动仪式上演奏以激励众人。旧通风系统的振动膜被修好了，桥栏上那块光秃秃的锈斑被刮掉了，住宅后面一间被遗弃的棚屋被清理干净。他们一致同意，再不会有人污染这条水道，也不会把责任推给后代。"我们不能在黑暗中摸索，"主席说，他的手机响个不停。"一个简洁、在纪律上不断重复的计划，会带我们向南走向更温暖的市场，并对每一分钱都有所交代。"管理人笑了。他想起曾经见过的一只白孔雀，它那股骄傲的气味，它的傲慢；他也想到，一个个努力的细胞，在全国范围内成倍累加，如何能让一个知识分子的梦想最终升起。会议结束时，一种愉快的平静笼罩了房间。怀疑者的比例已经缩小；那一书架的旧借口终于被清空。在所有的喧嚣之后，浪费的放缓，确实已经开始了。一位退役上校，结婚已数十年，起身理解了这个计划，拒绝向陈旧的惰性下跪。他不会自夸，却作出了一次信念的跳跃，支持了这次表决。一名管子工检查了管道的厚度；一个逆时针拧动的阀门封住了最后的漏点。不会有员工被开除，只会有新的工作。作为每次会议忠实的听众，他把这场改革看作一项职责而非一场游戏，甚至开玩笑说餐厅的干酪现在尝起来会更甜。

21. Return to the Scottish Winery

English

Last **September**, on the **anniversary** of my grandfather's death, I made a **deep** and **rather** personal **ascent** along the **Scottish coast** to visit the **winery** he once owned. **According** to family **doctrine**, **faith** and hard work could **offset** any **debt**, and **whenever** the **climate** turned **humid** I would remember his **idiomatic** sayings. He was a **craftsman** of **permanent** reputation, a man of fine **workmanship** whose **authority** no one dared **infringe**.

The morning was **bright**, the air **intermittent** with mist that began to **thaw** the frost on the **sand**. A **surge** of memory hit me **sideways** as **someone considerate** and **helpful** pushed the heavy door. Inside, an **orderly occupant** set a **tray** of **peach** and **chestnut** tarts beside a **quartz prism** that scattered **scarlet** light across the room. He pressed a **button**, and an **amateur** played a **flute** while a recording with a **subtitle** explained the history. The **canteen** at the back stayed **open** to all, its counter creased with the **wrinkle** of a thousand polishings, and on the wall hung a rusted **torpedo**, a relic of the war years.

In **actuality**, running the winery was a **herculean feat**. The **basic implementation** of new rules, the **ratification** of a **multilateral** trade deal, and the **consistent regularity** of the harvest all **complicate** the work. There is always the **possibility** that a **rash** decision will **prolong** a crisis or that **pessimism** will **pervert** good judgment. A **symptom** of trouble might be a **drastic** drop in the **ranking** of our vintage, which would **form** a fresh debt.

My grandfather kept his faith **eternal**. He would **mutter** about the **imperialist** past, about the **legion** of officials who tried to **censor** or **abet** corruption, who would **grudge** an honest man his **bonus**. He warned that to **assist** a **pickpocket** was the work of the **devil**, an act fit only for a **savage** or an **ass**.

Yet the place still flourishes. We offer a generous **discount** and a **homestay** program; visitors win a **lottery**, **admire** the orchard's **blossom**, play **poker** by the fire, and **indicate** their **liking** for the wine. The **probable derivation** of its name comes from an old word for the deep coast. I felt no lasting grudge, only gratitude, and I knew that, **inapt** as I once was with a **knife** and a **bag** of tools, I would keep his legacy alive past every **deadline**, and never **alter** it.

中文翻译

去年九月，在祖父忌日的周年纪念上，我沿着苏格兰海岸做了一次深沉而相当个人化的攀登，去探访他曾经拥有的酿酒厂。按照家族的教义，信仰与勤奋能抵消任何债务；每当气候变得潮湿，我便会想起他那些惯用的口头语。他是一位享有永久声誉的手艺人，技艺精湛，其权威无人敢侵犯。

那个清晨阳光明亮，空气中弥漫着断断续续的薄雾，开始消融沙地上的霜。当一位体贴又乐于助人的人推开那扇厚重的门时，一阵记忆的浪潮从侧面向我袭来。屋内，一位井然有序的居住者端来一托盘桃子和栗子馅饼，旁边放着一块把猩红色光线散射满屋的石英棱镜。他按下一个按钮，一位业余爱好者吹起了长笛，同时一段带字幕的录音讲述着这里的历史。后面的食堂向所有人开放，柜台上布满了千万次擦拭留下的皱痕，墙上挂着一枚生锈的鱼雷，那是战争年代的遗物。

实际上，经营酿酒厂是一项力大无比的伟业。新规的基本执行、一项多边贸易协定的批准，以及收成前后一致的规律性，都使这项工作变得复杂。总存在这样的可能性：一个轻率的决定会拖延一场危机，或者悲观主义会扭曲良好的判断。麻烦的一个征兆，可能是我们酒款排名的急剧下跌，那会形成一笔新的债务。

祖父的信仰始终不朽。他会低声抱怨那段帝国主义的过往，抱怨那一大批试图审查或纵容腐败的官员，他们会吝惜给一个诚实的人发奖金。他告诫说，帮助一个扒手是魔鬼的勾当，只配得上未开化的野人或蠢驴去做。

然而这地方依旧繁荣。我们提供慷慨的折扣和寄宿家庭项目；游客们抽奖中奖，欣赏果园的花簇，在炉火旁打扑克，并表达他们对这酒的喜爱。一位手艺人告诉我，它名字很可能的起源来自一个表示深邃海岸的古词。我心中没有持久的怨恨，只有感激；我知道，尽管我曾经笨拙地拿着刀和一袋工具，我也会让他的遗产在每一个最后期限之后继续存活，绝不更改它。

22. A Village Naturalist's Notebook

English

One overcast morning in November, a visitor named Greta arrived in our small village to clothe her great aspiration in real fieldwork. She had no jeep, only a battered lorry and a mobile phone, yet her endeavour to study the local environment was substantial. Whenever she could, she would crouch beside a mossy bench, watching a swift dart past the corner of the lawn, while moss spread over an old estate wall. With discretion she would not allow the oncoming madness of tourist crowds to disturb the place she came to adore. Her future, she said, depended on this present procedure of patient observation, and she kept a varied encyclopedia of notes. Her behavior was orderly: she would blink at the sun, freshen her mind with cold water, and own up to any uncertain finding. A wrinkled clause in her grant required a chairperson to retrieve every diagram and piece of information she produced, so she sent each gift of data ahead via a tiny projector. The hump of a distant hill, the violet sky, a thorn-edged path past a frock-clad scarecrow, the buckle on her bag, all earned a compliment in her diary. She would mutter no allegation of injustice when funding was uncertain; instead she would devour her homework, fiddle with a tool, and present a calm aspect even when antagonism flared. Her old mistress in alchemy had taught her that experimentation, not rapture or mere manipulation of numbers, brings discovery. The villagers spoke a soft dialect that she found beautiful, and she never grew unduly impatient with it. Once, a puncture in the lorry tyre and an antagonist's dishonorable trick delayed her, but she did not buy excuses. She would charge ahead, more valid than ever, slot her tickets and visa into a drawer, and crouch again. A cashier in the next village, recovering from tuberculosis, would adore her delicious bread and edible berries, sharing kin-like warmth. She studied a digit on her ration card, a partition between fields, the aerial above a fire-engine, and even the embroidery on a buckle. Each clause of her novel report, though it left her unconscious of fame, recorded the plague years, the crazy delight of an ad-free dawn, and the buckle of frost. Upside-down in the grass, she would take a slow breath, thank the morning, and feel her crucial discovery blossom.

中文翻译

十一月一个阴沉的早晨，一位名叫格蕾塔的访客来到我们的小村庄，要把她伟大的抱负付诸真正的田野工作。她没有吉普车，只有一辆破旧的卡车和一部手机，但她研究当地环境的努力是相当可观的。只要有可能，她就会蹲在长满苔藓的长椅旁，看着一只雨燕掠过草坪的角落，而苔藓爬满了一堵旧庄园的墙。出于谨慎，她不愿让蜂拥而至的游客的疯狂打扰她前来钟爱的这个地方。她说，她的未来取决于眼下这套耐心观察的程序，她记下了内容多样、像百科全书般的笔记。她的举止井然有序：她会对着太阳眨眼，用冷水让头脑清醒，并坦承任何不确定的发现。她经费里一条带皱褶的条款要求一位主席收回她产出的每一张图表和每一份信息，于是她通过一台小投影仪把每份数据礼物送往前方。远处山丘的隆起、紫罗兰色的天空、一条被荆棘环绕、经过身着旧外套的稻草人的小路、她包上的扣环，都在她的日记里得到一句赞美。当经费不确定时，她不会嘟囔任何关于不公的指控；相反，她会埋头做功课，摆弄工具，即使敌意爆发也保持镇定的神情。她从前教她炼金术的女主人曾教导她，带来发现的是实验，而非狂喜或仅仅对数字的操纵。村民们说着一一种她觉得很美的柔和方言，她不会对此过分地不耐烦。有一次，卡车轮胎被扎破，加上一个对手不光彩的诡计耽误了她，但她不买账找借口。她会奋勇向前，比以往更加坚定有效，把车票和签证塞进抽屉，再次蹲下身。隔壁村一位刚从肺结核中康复的收银员会喜爱她美味的面包和可食用的浆果，分享如亲人般的温暖。她研究着配给卡上的一个数字、田地间的隔断、消防车上方的天线，甚至扣环上的刺绣。她那部小说般报告的每一条款，尽管让她对名声毫无知觉，却记录了瘟疫的岁月、无广告黎明的疯狂喜悦，以及霜冻的扣合。她倒立在草丛中，深深呼吸，感谢这个清晨，感到她那至关重要的发现正在绽放。

23. The Marine Research Voyage

English

On a cold **January** morning, a research **corps** boarded a **closed** vessel bound for waters where dolphins **converge**. The **sender** of our orders, an **authoritative registrar** from the **United Kingdom**, had a **particular** and **thoughtful** plan that left no **matter** to chance. Each crew member would **commute** daily between cabins, and **oneself** alone could not run the ship; a whole **troop** had to **assign** duties and **admit** mistakes **agreeably**. We had to **hasten**, for the voyage was **unique** and the **supply** of fuel was barely **abundant**. The captain, my **brother**, would not **gamble** with safety, and his **respectful** manner made even a **difficulty** seem **slightly** easier. **Notwithstanding** the **surprising** weather, our **coverage** of the region was **duly comparable** to any prior survey. We would **detect** each **dolphin** by its **whisker**-like markings and the way it would **revolve** and **distinguish** itself from the troop. To **recollect** every sighting, we kept a **recorder** running; the camera's **projection** on a screen helped us **literally** count each fin. The **dairy** of the ship's galley smelled of **chocolate** and a **spoonful** of cocoa, while a **shower** of spray would **explode** over the bow and **litter** the deck with foam. One **instant** a **raw wound** on a sailor's hand needed **peroxide** and a **tranquilizer**; the next, an **irritate**-prone cook would mutter about a **phony** invoice. We had no time to **deserve** rest. A **weed** of doubt could not converge with our resolve, and **discomfortable** nights notwithstanding, **agitation** never won. Our **usage** of new instant tools made the work an **elevation** of pure **oceanography**. A particular **bullish sponsor**, **vehement** about clean seas, would not **consign** the project to failure, nor would the **violation** of any rule go without **clarification**. The **fuse** of curiosity, the **fertilizer** of patience, and a **solution** of trust kept us united, not **disunite**. **Ashore** at last, **partly** tired, we shouldered each **box** and **cart**, paid **tribute** to the sea, and made our **decision**: the **carbohydrate**-rich meals, the **kindergarten** of young interns, the elevation of every wave were worth it. A pickpocket could steal a wallet, but no **thorn**, no **rifle** shot, no **aggregation** of storms could steal the **indebtedness** we felt. The agreeably **stowage** of gear, the closed hold, the **can** of supplies, all **said** one thing: a thoughtful crew, sustained by faith, can survive. A **protestant** chaplain blessed our **ball** of rope; a kindergarten teacher had once told me a **trick**: stay humble. Back at the **house** ashore, we stocked the **freezer**, watched an old **actress** on television, and joked that the coast had more **arable** land than the sea. Though I felt **ambivalent** about leaving, and our route home was **indirect**, we said our thanks, and sailed home.

中文翻译

在一个寒冷的一月清晨，一支研究队登上一艘封闭的船只，驶向海豚汇聚的水域。下达命令的是一位来自英国的权威注册官，他有一个特别而周到的计划，没有把任何事情交给运气。每名船员每天要在舱室之间往返，单凭一个人无法驾驶整船；必须由一整队人分配职责并欣然承认错误。我们必须赶紧，因为这次航行独一无二，而燃料的供应也仅仅勉强充足。船长是我的兄弟，他不会拿安全去赌博，他那恭敬的态度让再大的困难看起来也稍稍容易些。尽管天气出人意料，我们对该区域的覆盖范围理应可与以往任何调查相媲美。我们通过海豚胡须般的斑纹，以及它们旋转、从队群中区分自己的方式来辨认每一只海豚。为了回忆起每一次目击，我们让录音机一直运转；摄像机投射在屏幕上的影像帮助我们逐字逐条数清每一片鳍。船上厨房散发着巧克力和一勺可可的香味，浪花的喷溅会爆发般越过船头，把泡沫撒落在甲板上。前一刻，一名水手手上的鲜血伤口需要双氧水和镇静剂；下一刻，一位易怒的厨师又会嘟囔着抱怨一张假发票。我们没有时间去享受应得的休息。一丝疑虑之草无法与我们的决心汇合，尽管夜晚令人不适，焦躁却从未占上风。我们对新仪器工具的使用让这项工作成为纯粹海洋学的升华。一位特别看涨的赞助人，对清洁海洋充满激情，不会把这个项目交付给失败，任何规则的违反也不会缺少澄清。好奇之引信、耐心之肥料和信任之溶液让我们团结而不分裂。最后上岸时，我们半身疲惫，扛起每一个箱子和推车，向大海致敬，并做出我们的决定：富含碳水化合物化合物的饭菜、年轻实习生的幼儿园、每一道波浪的高度，都是值得的。扒手能偷走钱包，但没有荆棘、没有步枪的枪声、没有风暴的聚合能偷走我们所感到的亏欠之情。装备的妥善堆放、封闭的货舱、那一罐补给，全都说明了一件事：一支周到的船员，在信念的支撑下，能够生存。一位新教随船牧师为我们的绳球祝福；一位幼儿园老师曾告诉我一个诀窍：保持谦卑。回到岸上的房子里，我们把冰柜装满，在电视上看一位年老的女演员演出，还开玩笑说海岸的可耕地比大海还多。尽管我对离开心情矛盾，回家的路线也很迂回，我们还是道了谢，然后扬帆回家。

24. The Reluctant Understudy

English

Nevertheless, the young farmhand who longed to act in a drama never imagined he would represent the academy on stage. He was proud yet poor, and his manhood had been shaped by costly years of constant labor. A foreman, traditional and strongly built, would incite him to quit, but a kindly potter and a wandering constable would discuss his talent and goad him onward. "Do not refuse the chance," they would say, "nor abandon it; embark on the role." The cue came on an odd, abrupt evening. The villain of the play, an intelligent but malicious magistrate, had fallen ill, and no substitute seemed available. The number of trained actors was small, the quota of understudies unobtainable, and the academy, generally prosperous, faced a peculiar crisis. So they sent for the farmhand. He had a shallow draft of the lines, scribbled on a torn formula sheet, and he had to meditate quickly. His suspicion that he would fail was strong, yet a foremost teacher, apt and benevolent, said cordially, "You serve the play; the play will serve you. Settle your nerves." Within the hour he had to incorporate gesture, voice, and a continuous flow of feeling. He felt a dominant fear dangle over him, and his consciousness wavered. The play's highlight required him to wield a wooden sword, brace his arm, and then sob with grief as the deceit of the court was revealed. He would not repent the risk. The drama was infectious; the audience, intelligent and sophisticated, leaned forward. The complexity of the plot, full of contradiction, suspicion, and superstition, did not confuse him. He would transmit each line with expressive force, and his every movement was deliberate. Then came the turning point: the villain's deceit collapsed, and the crowd, no longer ambivalent, rose. A dentist in the front row wept; a psychiatry student took notes; an attendant in the balcony cheered. The accommodation backstage was cramped, the dressing room mountainous with costumes, but the world outside the theatre seemed to quantify his worth anew. He had been entice-resistant once, but now he would not hide his joy. "This was worthwhile," he said, "and uncommon. Generally, I am terribly shy, but tonight I felt the deliverance of art. May the suit of a true performer fit me. This informative night, this proud feat, this abandonment of doubt, has shown my characteristic strength: a constant heart. Even a semiconductor, a sustenance of cold logic, could not measure my gladness. No one is exempt from fear, yet the benevolence of my teachers, who would send me notes of encouragement, carried me. As a boy I had played a cracked violin and studied astronomy by night; this whole inclusive incident, from first cue to final bow, taught me more than any star. I am no privilege-born noble, no proud villain, but a farmhand who dared to dream."

中文翻译

尽管如此，那个渴望演戏的年轻农场工人从未想过自己会代表学院登台。他骄傲却贫穷，他的成年由代价高昂、不断劳作的岁月塑造而成。一位传统而身材壮硕的工头会怂恿他放弃，但一位和善的陶工和一位四处游走的警察会讨论他的才华并激励他向前。“不要拒绝这个机会，”他们说，“也不要抛弃它；投身这个角色吧。”提示在一个古怪而突兀的夜晚来临。剧中的反派，一位聪明却恶毒的地方法官，病倒了，似乎没有替补可用。受过训练的演员人数很少，替角的名额无从获得，而通常繁荣的学院，面临一场奇特的危机。于是他们派人去找那个农场工人。他只有一份台词的粗略草稿，潦草地写在一张撕破的公式纸上，他必须迅速思量。他怀疑自己会失败，这怀疑很强烈，但一位杰出的老师，机敏而仁慈，诚恳地说：“你服务于这出戏，戏也会服务于你。安定你的神经。”不到一个小时，他就得把手势、嗓音和连绵不断的情感融为一体。他感到一种支配性的恐惧悬在头顶，意识开始动摇。该剧的高潮要求他挥舞一把木剑，绷紧手臂，然后在宫廷的欺诈被揭穿时悲恸地啜泣。他不会为这场冒险忏悔。这出戏极富感染力；观众聪明而老练，纷纷前倾。情节的复杂，充满矛盾、猜疑与迷信，并没有让他困惑。他会以富有表现力的力量传达每一句台词，他的每一个动作都经过深思熟虑。接着转折点到来：反派的欺诈崩塌，人群不再矛盾，纷纷起立。前排一位牙医落泪；一位精神病学专业的学生在记笔记；楼座的一位服务员在欢呼。后台的住处狭窄，化妆间堆满如山的戏服，但剧院外的世界似乎重新衡量了他的价值。他曾经对诱惑无动于衷，如今却不愿掩藏喜悦。“这很值得，”他说，“而且不寻常。通常我极其害羞，但今晚我感到了艺术的解脱。愿一名真正演员的衣装合我身。这个充满启示的夜晚、这桩骄傲的功绩、这种对怀疑的舍弃，展现了我特有的力量：一颗恒定的心。即便是半导体，那冷逻辑的养料，也无法测量我的欢欣。没有人能免于恐惧，但我的老师们的仁慈支撑着我，他们会给我寄来鼓励的便条。少年时我曾拉过一把破旧的小提琴，夜里钻研天文学；从第一个提示到最后的谢幕，这整桩无所不包的事件，教给我的比任何星辰都多。我不是出身特权的贵族，也不是骄傲的反派，而是一个敢于做梦的农场工人。”

25. The Astronomer-Photographer's Cosmic Journey

English

Lin was a **literate**, **fascinating** woman who lived for **photography** of the night sky. She refused to be **passive** about the **cosmic** wonders above her, and her **relentless**, **perpetual** curiosity would **kindle** in **anyone** who met her. From a **lofty** hill in **Asia** she would **traverse** rough, **jagged** trails, carrying a heavy **pail** of gear and an old **cane** for balance. She was no **senseless** dreamer; with **impartial**, **effective** method she would **determine** the **depth** of every shadow and **clamp** her camera to a **horizontal** mount. The **exotic substance** of starlight, she said, was a **fantasy** made **workable** by patient craft. Anyone could **guess** at the stars, but only the devoted could **surmount** the **discrepancy** between hope and a real, **appreciable** image. Her **lover**, a quiet **priest** who had left the church to study **democracy**, would **couch** his praise in gentle **tone**. He would **readily provide** her a **guitar** tune while she worked **slowly**, and the **harmonious living** room felt **full** of calm. Once a **report** reached them: a friend had died, and they sent a card of **condolence**. Grief, she insisted, must not **jettison** joy. Her **coordination** of **fume-filled** darkroom chemicals, an **additive** here, a **gimmick** there, was a quiet **exploitation** of old methods. She would not **pose** for any **poster**; she chose to **lurk** behind the lens. On the wall hung a faded **stripe** of film, a **phoenix** rising, an **angel** of light, a **goddess** of the void. The **mercury** in her thermometer barely moved on cold nights, yet she would not give up. Her **intercontinental** fame grew, though it felt **delusive**; one **conditional** grant would pay her **wage**, and she would **pound** the desk over red tape. The **FBI** once asked about an **assassination** plot near her **vault** of negatives, but the rumor proved **pointless** and false. By a **score** of careful exposures, every **component** checked, she made an **adaptation** of an ancient star chart, **layday** by layday refining each line. A **gallon** of developer, a **sharpeners** for her pencils, a sheet of **coinage-bright** foil **thereon**, and the rusty **shutter** that would creak: all of it survived. She would shut the iron shutter against the wind, watch a **wave** of cloud roll past, and trust that, in any **circumstance**, the **creation** above held a **comparatively** simple **certainty**. The **feeble** light of the **oblique** horizon, the **debris** of a meteor, the gentle oblique slant of dawn over the **region**, were enough. A **couple** who lived nearby would visit her, and she would **insist** that they **choose** a clear night to watch with **him**, her lover, while the boys played **baseball** in the yard below. She liked to **transfuse** her own wonder into them, telling of every **happening** in the sky, of **rust** on the old dome and the way starlight helps the soul **survive**. She had survived, and so had her wonder.

中文翻译

林是一位**有文化、迷人的**女性，她为拍摄夜空而活。她拒绝对头顶的**宇宙**奇观漠然处之，她那不屈不挠、永不停歇的好奇心会**点燃**任何遇见她的人。从**亚洲**一座**高耸的**山丘上，她会穿越崎岖**锯齿状**的小径，提着一桶沉重的器材，拄着一根用来保持平衡的旧**手杖**。她不是一个愚钝的空想者；她以**公正而有效**的方法测定每一道阴影的深浅，并把相机夹紧在水平支架上。她说，星光这种**奇异的物质**，是一种被耐心手艺变得**可行的幻想**。**任何人都能对星辰妄加猜测**，但只有虔诚的人才能**克服**希望与真实可见影像之间的差距。她的爱人是一位安静的牧师，他离开了教会去研究**民主**，他会用温和的语调含蓄地**表达**赞美。她**慢慢**工作时，他会**欣然**为她弹一段**吉他曲**，那**和谐的客厅充满了**宁静。一次有消息传来：一位朋友去世了，他们寄出了一张**吊唁卡**。她坚持认为，悲伤绝不能**抛弃**欢乐。她对充满烟雾的暗房化学药品的**协调**——这里加一种**添加剂**，那里用一个小花招——是对旧方法的一种悄然**利用**。她不愿为任何**海报摆姿势**；她**选择潜伏**在镜头之后。墙上挂着一段褪色的条状胶片、一只腾起的**凤凰**、一位光之**天使**、一位虚空的女神。寒夜里她温度计中的**水银**几乎不动，但她绝不放弃。她那**洲际般**的名声不断增长，却显得虚妄；一笔**有条件的**拨款将支付她的工资，而她会为繁文缛节捶桌。联邦调查局曾就她的底片金库附近的一桩**暗杀**阴谋来询问，但传言被证明**毫无意义**且不实。通过一二十次精心曝光，每个部件都经过检查，她对一幅古老的星图做了改编，一个停泊日又一个停泊日地打磨每一条线。一**加仑**显影液、一支削**铅笔**的卷笔刀、一张其上铺着钱币般光亮的箔纸，以及那会吱嘎作响的**生锈**快门：这一切都留存了下来。她会关上铁制**百叶窗**以抵御风，望着一片云浪滚过，并相信无论在任何情形下，头顶的造物都蕴含着相对简单的**确定性**。**倾斜地平线**上微弱的光、一颗流星的**残骸**、黎明在这片**地区**上方那温柔的斜照，都已足够。住在附近的一对**夫妇**会来拜访她，她会**坚持要**他们挑一个晴朗的夜晚和她的爱人一起观星，而下面院子里男孩们正在打**棒球**。她喜欢把自己的惊奇之情**灌输**给他们，讲述天空中每一桩**事件**、旧穹顶上的锈迹，以及星光如何帮助灵魂存活。她活了下来，她的惊奇之心也是。

26. Restoring an Old European Manor

English

In February, my supervisor handed me an unexpected assignment: to restore a declining manor in rural Europe, a project that would involve months of careful work. The architecture was modern in some wings and aboriginal in others, a complex blend that no alphabetical guidebook could fully paraphrase. A weathered signpost by the sidewalk pointed the way, and a cab would haul visitors and their luggage, each suitcase heavy with hope, up the long drive. The supervisor's reputation was built on aesthetic judgment; he would praise good craft and notify the owners of any flaw, however small. I would cram my notes each night, look at faded photographs, and feel a wave of nostalgia for a bygone age of aristocracy and ceremonial pomp. The damp had caused corrosion in the cable and a slow trickle of rust down the precious stone. By February's end, after a deluge of rain, the cellar nearly became a pond, yet the source of the leak proved easy to find. Atmospheric moisture would pervade every room, and a single papercut on my finger, caustic with dust, reminded me how painful old buildings can be. A rheumatic gardener, reliant on a cane, would yield his secrets slowly: which soil was fertile, where irrigation would nourish the roses, and how a snail or a spider might lurk under a windowsill. He would eat lunch on the lawn and watch a chick wander by, his eloquence quiet but real. The manor's revenue had fallen badly; a subscription scheme and a modest tariff on tours were our attempt to defray costs without lax accounting. One quirk of the estate was a sealed vault rumored to hold a knight's skull and an excerpt of an old treaty once tainted by treason. We could possibly open it tomorrow, but I felt a nerve of dread. Terrestrial maps, an imaginary line of an Antarctic expedition, an endorsement from a famous historian, all came to fruition as the work advanced. The kernel of the plan, its operative idea, was to outweigh decay with care. Demography studies showed the village was cool to tourism, so we would practise restraint. An impromptu party would terrify no one; a chaste, double-arched hall, a precious eclipse of evening light through the glass, the gentle transport of memory anywhere I walked, all proved that a productivity born of patience could revive even the most bygone of homes. I found an old wallet on a windowsill, a precious resource of faded photographs, and I would suffer no haste in restoring them. Every extra hour would become a gift, and the village would become whole again. The work would not be done in a single month, but it would be done.

中文翻译

二月里，我的主管交给我一项意外的任务：修复欧洲乡间一座日渐衰败的庄园，这个项目将牵涉数月的细致工作。它的建筑在某些侧翼是现代的，在另一些则带有原住民风格，是一种复杂的混合，任何按字母排列的指南都无法完全转述。人行道旁一块饱经风霜的路标指明了方向，一辆出租车会把访客和他们的行李——每只手提箱都装满希望——拉上长长的车道。主管的声誉建立在审美判断之上；他会赞美好的手艺，并把任何瑕疵，无论多小，都通知业主。每晚我会临时苦读我的笔记，看着褪色的照片，对一个贵族与典礼盛况的逝去时代涌起一阵怀旧。潮湿使电缆腐蚀，让锈迹沿着珍贵的石头缓缓流下。到二月末，一场倾盆大雨之后，地窖几乎成了池塘，但渗漏的源头很容易找到。空气中的湿气会弥漫每一个房间，我手指上一道沾着尘土、刺痛的纸割伤，提醒我老建筑会有多么痛苦。一位患风湿、依赖手杖的园丁会缓缓吐露他的秘密：哪块土壤肥沃，哪里的灌溉能滋养玫瑰，以及一只蜗牛或一只蜘蛛会如何潜伏在窗台之下。他会在草坪上吃午饭，看着一只小鸡踱步而过，他的口才安静却真实。庄园的收入下滑得很厉害；一项订阅方案和一笔对参观团征收的适度关税，是我们在不放松账目的前提下分摊成本的尝试。庄园的一个怪处是一间封闭的地下室，传闻藏着一位骑士的头骨和一份曾被叛国玷污的旧条约的摘录。我们或许明天就能打开它，但我感到一阵恐惧的神经悸动。陆地地图、一条南极探险的假想路线、一位著名历史学家的背书，都随着工作的推进开花结果。计划的核心，它起作用的理念，是用悉心照料去抵过腐朽。人口学研究表明这个村庄对旅游业态度冷淡，所以我们会克制行事。一场即兴的聚会不会吓到任何人；一座纯净的双拱大厅、傍晚光线透过玻璃那珍贵的食般遮蔽、记忆在我走到任何地方时的温柔传送，都证明了一种由耐心而生的生产力，能让即便最久远的家园也焕发生机。我在一扇窗台上发现了一只旧钱包，里面是一份珍贵的、装着褪色照片的资源，我修复它们时绝不容许有半点仓促。每一个额外的小时都会成为一份礼物，而这座村庄也将重新变得完整。这工作无法在一个月内完成，但它终将完成。

27. Engines of a Working Seaport

English

In a busy **seaport** in **China**, the morning began with the steady knock of a **piston** deep inside an old crane. The dock **master**, a **tall** man of nearly **seventy**, would **care** for every machine as if it were **family**. He insisted that each part be **adequately** oiled, for a single **sprain** in the gears could halt the whole **harbor**. A caged **canary** once hung by the office window, a quaint **diversion** from the **dirt** and noise, and the workers would **chant** a rough tune as they worked **abreast** along the quay. The **crude** oil tankers, **too** heavy and often **overweight**, moved slowly **onward** toward the pier. To **expedite** the unloading, the crew would **improvise**, adding a **lateral** brace here, a **prefabricate** panel there, in a **fusion** of old craft and modern **science**. The supervisor, no **ferocious dictator** but a patient master, would never demand **outright submission**; instead he would **alleviate** tension with a kind word. He believed the **human** spirit, not **rigidity**, was the true **catalyst** that let the port **flourish**. When a **recession** struck, the **mood** grew **wretched**. Cargo handling fell by a **tenth**, then **beyond**, and a **horrible unrest** spread among the men. One worker, soaked by a sudden **rainy** squall that seemed to **drench** the whole quay, would **stammer** his fear of layoffs; another, reluctant and full of **reluctance**, sat in a battered **armchair** and stared at the **garbage** piling up. It was an **utterly incongruous** sight, and the **thought** of failure weighed on every mind. The accountant spoke of a **del credere** clause and an **off-grade** shipment that had become **immaterial**, **supposedly useless**, its value down to a single **cent**. In the **meantime**, a **satellite** dish on the roof would **flutter** its old **cloth** cover in the wind, and a **telescope** on the watchtower swept the gray sea. The port could not **retreat**. With **utmost** effort it had to flourish again. The **obligatory** inspection, a kind of **postmortem** on the failed quarter, revealed a **deformation** in one **trolley** rail and a crude **variation** in the loading **flora** of cranes. The **kidnaper** of profit, the **crisis** itself, was no **divine** punishment, only a problem to solve. They would **permit** a fresh plan, **distribute** new tasks, and **happily** push onward. A **graduate** engineer, his **eyelid** twitching from long nights, traced the flaw with a **vivid**, **shiny** pointer. He **favorably** approved each **piece**. He tightened his **pants** at the **waist**, gave a quiet **hurrah**, and as the French would say of any single thing, **le** moment had come. A new **candidate** for foreman, fresh from **sightseeing** leave with his **diploma** in hand, would **graze** his knuckles on the steel, **punch** the air, and **add** one more **original** idea. The **jellyfish** drifting near the hull, the canary's song, the harbor lights: all proved the port could thrive once more.

中文翻译

在中国一个繁忙的**海港**，清晨从一台老旧起重机内部**活塞**稳定的敲击声中开始。码头主管是个将近**七十**岁的高个子，他**照料**每一台机器，仿佛它们都是家人。他坚持每个部件都要充分上油，因为齿轮里哪怕一处**扭伤**，都可能让整个港口停摆。办公室窗边曾挂着一只笼中**金丝雀**，在尘土与噪声中是一种别致的消遣，工人们并排沿码头干活时会哼一支粗犷的小调。原油油轮太重，常常超载，缓缓向码头驶来。为了**加快**卸货，船员们会即兴发挥，在这里加一道横向支撑，在那里加**一块预制板**，把旧手艺与现代**科学**融为一体。主管不是**凶残的独裁者**，而是耐心的能手，他从不要求**彻底的屈服**；相反，他会用一句善言来缓解紧张。他相信，让港口**繁荣**的真正**催化剂**是**人的精神**，而非僵化。当经济**衰退**来袭，气氛变得凄惨。货物吞吐量先降了**十分之一**，继而更多，一种**可怕的动荡**在人群中蔓延。一名工人被突如其来的雨阵淋透，结结巴巴地说着对裁员的恐惧；另一名满心不愿意的人坐在破旧的扶手椅里，盯着越堆越**高的垃圾**。会计提到一项**保付**代理条款，以及一批已变得无关紧要、据说**毫无用处**、价值跌到一分钱的次级货物。与此**同时**，屋顶上一只**卫星**天线那旧布罩在风中翻动，望塔上的一架**望远镜**扫视着灰色的海面。港口不能退缩。它**必须**竭尽全力重新繁荣。强制性的检查，像是对那个失败季度的一次事后剖析，查出一条**手推车轨道的变形**，以及起重机群落里一处粗糙的偏差。利润的**绑架者**，也就是危机本身，并非神明的惩罚，只是一个有待解决的问题。他们会批准一项新计划，**分配**新任务，然后高高兴兴地继续前进。一位**毕业**的工程师，因长夜熬战而**眼睑**直跳，用一支**鲜艳**发亮的指示棒追查那处缺陷。他逐一作出**有利的**认可。他在腰间系紧**裤子**，悄声欢呼了一句，正如法国人谈起任何单独一件事时所说，**le** 时刻到了。一位新的工头**候选人**，刚结束**观光**假期、手里拿着文凭，会在钢铁上擦破指关节，对空挥拳，再添上一个原创**想法**。漂在船体附近的**水母**、金丝雀的歌声、港口的灯火：这一切都证明，这座港口能够再度兴旺。

28. The Floating School Project

English

On a golden morning in the United States, a creative team set out to build a floating school on an old oil rig, a project that seemed endless at first. The preliminary plan, drawn from a worn textbook, set each parameter with precise care. We would not construe the river as a barrier but as a friendly road; a ferryboat would carry every passenger across the distance, and a graceful colonnade of bamboo would shade the entry. Our savings were modest, so we had to conserve every bit, and a formal promissory note would empower the work. Regularly, a referee-like inspector would visit for a checkup, give his verdict, and instruct us on rectification wherever a flaw might jeopardise safety. We did not presume the task easy. A pessimistic critic, an outcast from the local council, would commonly call the idea worthless and malicious, but we would not let his criticism shatter our resolve. With fidelity to the children, we would strive to win, conscious that a single careless switch could trap a curious child. To justify the cost, we kept a variable budget and a precise discussion log, and we would not yield to vice or wicked shortcuts. A grateful adoptive family, who had once felt lonely and treated like a nomad, donated a brown medal of honor to hang above the door. We would migrate desks by ladder, bridle our impatience, and meditate in quiet leisure when the strain grew chronic. A baby-sitter taught a tutorial on first aid; a professional from the post-office helped us mail forms; and new legislation, after a close election, eased the way. The agricultural village nearby gave us each a pea-green lunch box, and the children, attentively, would echo every lesson. We had to invent a new desk that would fold flat, and we would wrestle with each design until it worked. The questions of the young could elicit fresh ideas from us all. We gave the school a simple title, painted in white. We added zinc panels to the roof to relieve the heat. One could presume that an elephant of doubt would block us, but we pressed on. A small starfish, a habit of meditation, the prevalent hope of the people: all helped us reach the summit. The intensity of our effort, in fair proportion to the dream, would not let us fly from duty. No invasion of doubt, no snore of laziness, could stop us. Marxism, the brave above-mentioned ideals, the further reach of justice, all met in one wish: to win for the children. The wind would echo, the river would hit the hull, and still we built, brave and free.

中文翻译

在美国一个金色的早晨，一支富有创意的团队着手在一座旧石油钻井平台上建造一所漂浮的学校，这个项目起初似乎没有尽头。初步方案取自一本破旧的教科书，以精确的细心设定了每一个参数。我们不会把河流理解为一道屏障，而是一条友善的道路；一艘渡轮会载着每位乘客跨越那段距离，一排优雅的竹制柱廊会为入口遮荫。我们的积蓄不多，所以必须节省每一点，一张正式的本票将为这项工作提供资金保障。一位裁判般的检查员会定期前来体检，做出他的裁定，并在任何可能危及安全的缺陷处指导我们整改。我们并不臆断这件事容易。一位悲观的批评者，本地议会的一个弃儿，常常把这个想法说成毫无价值且居心不良，但我们不会让他的批评粉碎我们的决心。出于对孩子的忠诚，我们会奋力争取胜利，意识到一个粗心的开关就可能困住一个好奇的孩子。为了证明开支合理，我们保留了一份可变动的预算和一份精确的讨论记录，我们绝不会屈从于恶习或邪恶的捷径。一户心怀感激的收养家庭，曾经感到孤独、像游牧者一样被对待，捐出一枚棕色的荣誉勋章挂在门上。我们会用梯子搬运课桌，克制我们的急躁，并在劳累变得长期化时于宁静的闲暇中冥想。一位保姆讲授了一堂急救辅导课；邮局的一位专业人员帮我们邮寄表格；在一场势均力敌的选举之后，新的立法也为我们铺平了道路。附近的农业村庄给我们每人一个豆绿色的饭盒，孩子们会专注地回响每一节课。我们得发明一种能折平的新课桌，并会反复琢磨每一个设计，直到它行得通。孩子们的提问能从我们所有人身上引出新鲜的想法。我们给这所学校起了一个简单的名字，用白漆写上。我们在屋顶加上锌板以缓解暑热。人们或许会臆测，一头疑虑的大象会挡住我们，但我们继续前进。一只小海星、一种冥想的习惯、人们普遍的希望：这一切都帮助我们抵达顶峰。我们努力的强度，与梦想相称地成比例，不会让我们逃离职责。没有任何疑虑的入侵，没有任何懒惰的鼾声，能够阻止我们。马克思主义、上述那些勇敢的理想、正义更深远的伸展，全都汇聚于一个愿望：为孩子们赢得胜利。风会回响，河水会拍打船体，而我们依然建造着，勇敢而自由。

29. The Architect and the Old Theatre

English

Last summer, a humble architect named Vera took on a heroic task: to restore an established old theatre whose ceiling had begun to mould and whose walls showed deep erosion. She was no pompous figure, no vulgar self-promoter; she would profess only a quiet faith, almost a religion, in honest work. Her staff, each a student of design who would dedicate long hours to the work, would peer at every crack and communicate findings without frustration. A heated debate over the most advanced restoration method filled the office, but it never turned bitter. In comparison to a flashy modern enterprise, with its sudden flash of fame, her firm seemed small, yet its competitiveness lay in care, not in pompous talk. A faint gleam of morning light would intersperse the dusty corridor, and a leafy vine outside the window swayed in the spring breeze. The significance of the project was widely felt; the local consul, a leading patron, gave personal advice, and an old mariner who lived nearby offered a sorrowful moan about how the place had decayed. Vera would fasten loose beams, tighten each bolt, and paste fresh plaster where the wall had worn. She would not surrender to the headstrong owner who demanded a careless rush. With deft hands she would condense a complex plan into a clear photo and a composite drawing, attach a postscript of notes, and present it on a single chair at the center of the stage. The advent of new tools made some old methods unusable, but she kept what had merit. A compulsory examination by the city office was prescribed, and the feedback was integral to her next step. She would not let an impost or a sudden devaluation of the building fund baffle her. To internationalize the theatre's appeal, she planned to feature acrobatics, an essayist's lecture, and a convenient open house. The brilliance of the restored hall, an architectural phenomenon, would obviously draw crowds. A goose wandered awkwardly across the lawn; a deer grazed at the leafy edge; and a child ate a raw vegetable from a paper bag. The local fauna seemed at peace, though the whereabouts of the old caretaker remained a mystery. Briefly, the project felt impossible. The importation of rare marble, the convention of formal permits, the bonded warehouse fees, and the lung-tiring dust all weighed on her. Yet she would not utter a tired platitude. Each beam was bonded and transferable to a new use; the embryo of an idea grew. After a quick haircut and a lighter mood, she returned to focus. The match between old grace and new function was nearly perfect, and as the diverge of opinions finally converged, the theatre, like a phoenix, was ready to finish its long sleep and wake to applause.

中文翻译

去年夏天，一位名叫薇拉的谦逊建筑师接下了一项英勇的任务：修复一座声名确立的老剧院，它的天花板已开始发霉，墙壁也显出严重的侵蚀。她不是个自负的人物，也不是粗俗的自我吹嘘者；她只信奉一种安静的信念，几乎像一种宗教，那就是诚实地工作。她的员工，每一位都是会为这项工作投入长时间的设计学子，会仔细端详每一道裂缝，并毫无沮丧地交流发现。办公室里曾就最先进的修复方法展开过一场激烈的争论，但争论从未变得尖刻。与一家浮华、骤享一时名声的现代企业相比，她的事务所显得很小，但它的竞争力在于用心，而非自负的空谈。清晨微弱的光会洒落在布满灰尘的走廊里，窗外一株多叶的藤蔓在春风中摇曳。这个项目的意义被广泛地感受到；当地的领事是一位带头的赞助人，给出了个人的建议，住在附近的一位老水手则为这地方的破败发出哀伤的叹息。薇拉会固定松动的横梁，拧紧每一颗螺栓，并在墙体磨损处抹上新的灰泥。她不会向那位任性的、要求草率赶工的业主屈服。她以灵巧的双手把一套复杂的方案浓缩成一张清晰的照片和一幅合成图，附上一段附言注释，并在舞台中央的一把椅子上呈现出来。新工具的出现让一些旧方法变得无法使用，但她保留了有价值的部分。市政办公室规定了一次强制性检查，其反馈对她的下一步是不可或缺的。她不会让一项征税或建筑资金的突然贬值难住自己。为了让剧院的吸引力国际化，她计划安排杂技表演、一位散文家的讲座，以及一次方便的开放日。修复后大厅的辉煌，作为一种建筑奇观，显然会吸引人群。一只鹅笨拙地走过草坪；一只鹿在多叶的边缘吃草；一个孩子从纸袋里拿出一根生蔬菜吃。当地的动物群似乎一片安宁，尽管那位老看守人的下落仍是个谜。短暂地说，这个项目曾让人觉得不可能。稀有大理石的进口、正式许可的惯例、保税仓库的费用，以及那令肺部疲惫的灰尘，都压在她身上。然而她不愿说出一句疲惫的陈词滥调。每根横梁都被黏合并可转用于新用途；一个想法的胚胎在生长。剪了个利落的头发、心情轻快之后，她重新投入专注。旧日优雅与新功能之间的匹配近乎完美，随着分歧的意见最终汇合，这座剧院如同一只凤凰，准备结束它漫长的沉睡，醒来迎接掌声。

30. The Prairie Observatory

English

On a **hot** afternoon, a young **astronomer** named Mara came as a **stranger** to the wide **prairie** to **establish** a small observatory. **These** open lands, she said, were a kind of **heaven**, **fairly** untouched, where one could **idealize** the night and study the **propulsion** of distant stars. She would not **strictly regulate** her wonder; the **craze** for discovery, which would **embed** itself like a seed and had embedded itself in her since she was a **novice**, drove her on. Her **modish** gadgets and her old habits would not **break** apart. An old rancher, **appreciative** but **sceptical**, would **exclaim** in **astonishment** at her **glassware** and her **queer** instruments. "**Whether** you find anything or not," he would say with a **solemn** nod, "these stars belong to no one." Mara had won a **scholarship associated** with a famous **palace** of science, and she did not **intend** to **misuse** it. She knew the **risk**: a single **bout** of bad weather could **ravage** a season of work, and **excessive** ambition could prove **detrimental**. Yet she would **gather** data over **numerous consecutive** nights, **shift** her telescope by a **centimeter**, and watch the dome **oscillate** gently in the wind. Around her, the prairie would **inhabit** a thousand small lives. A **crooked snake** would **hop**, no, slither, past a **bean** field; a bird with a sharp **beak** would **poke** at **porridge** crumbs; a **propeller** plane would drone overhead. She would **gulp** cold coffee, tuck a **hairpin** into her hair, and feel an **exuberant** joy. The **terminology** of her field, full of **prehistoric mythology** and the names of a **cavalry** of constellations, could **distress** a beginner, but to her it was a **tender**, **indelible** language. She would not idealize the past, nor mourn its **emptiness**. A **traitor** to old dogma, she trusted what she could measure. There was a **stipulation** in her grant, a **formality** of **procurement** and **authorization**, that every result **thereof** must be shared. She did not mind. The **state** had funded her, and a **fit** of generosity was no **obnoxious** thing. Late one night, a strange **intimation** came: a faint, indelible signal that she could not **deflect** from her mind. Was it **noxious** interference, a misuse of the equipment, or something true? She would not idealize it; she would test it. To **ignite** the data run, she fed an **aminoacid**-stained sample into the analyzer, sipped a sweet **cocktail** of relief, and waited. As the prairie began to **waken** to dawn, **primarily** she felt gratitude. The **growth** of knowledge, like a vine, would **inherit** the future, **superior** to any **warfare** of egos. She thought of her **son** back home, and of how the **exportation** of ideas, not goods, would build a better world. No **Turk** of doubt, no **satire** of cynics, no **generality** of fear could **enforce** silence on her. She wiped a **rag** across the lens, smoothed a crease near her **cervix**-stiff neck, and, no **addict** to fame, simply smiled. The **drawing** of the constellation, sketched in a small **section** of her notebook, would outlast her. Up on the **hill**, the propulsion of the heavens carried on, and she, a humble watcher, carried on with it.

中文翻译

在一个炎热的下午，一位名叫玛拉的年轻天文学家作为陌生人来到辽阔的草原，要建立一座小型天文台。她说，这些开阔的土地是一种天堂，相当未经触碰，人可以在这里把夜晚理想化，研究遥远星辰的推进。她不会严格地约束自己的惊奇；对发现的狂热会像种子一样把自己嵌入，自她还是新手起便已深植于她，驱使着她前行。她那时髦的小器械与她旧有的习惯并不会割裂分开。一位心怀感激却又持怀疑态度的老牧场主，会对她的玻璃器皿和古怪仪器惊叹出声。“无论你是否有所发现，”他会庄严地点头说，“这些星星不属于任何人。”玛拉赢得了一项与一座著名科学殿堂相关联的奖学金，她无意滥用它。她知道风险：一阵坏天气就可能毁掉一季的工作，而过度的野心可能是有害的。然而她会连续无数个夜晚收集数据，把望远镜挪动一厘米，看着圆顶在风中轻轻摆动。在她周围，草原栖息着千百个细小的生命。一条弯曲的蛇会蹦跳——不，是滑行——经过一片豆田；一只长着尖喙的鸟会啄食粥的碎屑；一架螺旋桨飞机会在头顶嗡嗡作响。她会大口喝下冷咖啡，把一枚发夹别进头发，感到一种兴奋的喜悦。她那领域的术语，满是史前神话和一队队星座的名字，会让初学者苦恼，但对她而言那是一种温柔而不可磨灭的语言。她不会美化过去，也不会哀悼它的空虚。作为旧教条的叛徒，她只信任她能测量的东西。她的资助里有一条规定，一种采购与授权的手续，要求由此得出的每一项成果都必须共享。她并不介意。是国家资助了她，一阵慷慨并非什么可憎之事。一个深夜，一个奇怪的暗示传来：一个微弱而不可磨灭的信号，她无法将它从脑海中偏移开。那是有害的干扰、设备的误用，还是某种真实的东西？她不会把它理想化；她要去检验它。为了点燃这次数据运行，她把一份沾有氨基酸的样本送进分析仪，啜饮一杯甜美的、令人宽慰的鸡尾酒，然后等待。当草原苏醒迎接黎明，她首先感到的是感激。知识的增长如同一株藤蔓，将会继承未来，胜过任何自我之间的争斗。她想起家中的儿子，想到思想的输出——而非货物——才会建成一个更美好的世界。没有任何疑虑的土耳其人、没有任何愤世者的讽刺、没有任何恐惧的笼统说法，能够强迫她沉默。她用一块抹布擦过镜头，抚平靠近她那僵硬如颈椎处脖颈的一道褶皱，作为一个并不沉迷名声的人，只是微微一笑。那幅星座的素描，画在她笔记本的一小节里，将比她活得更久。在山丘之上，诸天的推进仍在继续，而她，一个谦卑的观望者，也随之继续前行。

31. Globalization Seen from a Small Town

English

At the **outset**, no one in our **outlying** town truly grasped what **globalization** would **signify**. Decades **ago**, **industrialization** arrived like a **dragon**, and the **textile** mills that once defined the **entirety** of our economy began, **repeatedly** and **simultaneously**, to **push** their goods across every border. The **data** we collected seemed **alarming**: a **huge** share, some ninety **percent**, of local cloth now competed with imports, and the old **norm** of self-sufficiency had become **elusive**.

My **elder** cousin, a **competent trainee** who later became an **underwriter** for an insurance **alliance**, used to say that change was a **natural** and **inherent function** of trade. He would **economize** on words, yet his **clarity** of thought was a kind of **masterpiece**. We would **queue** outside the **spacious restaurant** on the **outskirts**, and there, over a plate of **cucumber** dressed in tangy **sauce**, he framed his **hypothesis**: that no town can **isolate** itself, that to **prevent** decline a community must **widen** its **access** to the world rather than **cloak** itself in fear.

I was young and **adventurous** then, and **most** afternoons I went **skiing** in the **woods** beyond the reservoir, or watched a **fireman wax** the engine of his truck until the **glass** gleamed. The mill's old **paraphernalia**, spindles and dyeing vats of every **size**, still stood in the yard like the **composition** of a forgotten painting. The **atmosphere** of that **microcosm** felt safe, almost a **celebration** of ordinary life. After a **rainbow** appeared over the **skyscraper** they were building **downstairs** by the river, I would **spin** a coin and **await** my cousin's verdict on whether our family business could **stabilize**.

Sadly, not every story is happy. A sudden **rebellion** among the workers, who felt their **gender** and seniority were overlooked, **severely** threatened the firm. One **thoughtless** and **insolent** manager, **cowardly** and rather **sad**, had treated them as if they were an **enemy** rather than partners. The dispute, heavy as a thousand-kilogram weight, dragged the company into a **mire** from which **clean** recovery seemed unlikely. To **quench** the anger, the elders **agreed** to **undertake** reform; they would **furnish** new tools, improve **communication**, and **perform** their promises in their entirety.

It is **desirable**, a **realist** would say, to **correlate** ambition with patience. The **recruitment** of fresh minds, the steady supply of **phosphorus-rich** fertiliser to the surrounding farms, even the discovery of **penicillin** in a distant lab, all reminded us that progress, however **unusual**, rarely comes alone. A **bulge** of new orders arrived; my cousin tightened **her scarf**, smiled, and noted that the **sheer** scale of demand, hosting buyers by the **metre** of shelf space, had surprised us all. To my **surprise**, the great **host** of foreign buyers did not **overlook** our little **frame** of a workshop after all.

中文翻译

起初，我们这个偏远小镇上没有人真正明白**全球化**意味着什么。几十年前，**工业化**像一条巨龙般降临，曾经构成我们经济**全部**的纺织厂**开始**反复地、**同时地**把货物推向每一个边境。我们收集到的**数据**令人警觉：当地布料中有很大一部分，约百分之九十，如今要与进口货竞争，而自给自足这一旧**规范**已变得难以捉摸。

我的表兄年长些，曾是一名能干的受训者，后来成了一家保险**联盟**的承保人。他常说变化是贸易自然而**固有**的功能。他说话**节省**，但思路的清晰却是一种**杰作**。我们会在**郊区**那家**宽敞的餐馆**外**排队**，在那里就着一盘浇了酸味酱汁的**黄瓜**，他提出了自己的**假说**：没有哪个小镇能**孤立**自己，要**防止**衰落，一个社区必须拓宽通向世界的渠道，而不是用恐惧把自己**掩盖**起来。

那时我年轻又爱冒险，多数下午我都去水库那边的**树林**里**滑雪**，或者看一名**消防队员**给卡车的引擎**打蜡**，直到**玻璃**发亮。工厂里旧的随身器具——纺锤和各种尺寸的染缸——仍立在院子里，像一幅被遗忘画作的构图。那个**微观世界**的**气氛**让人感到安全，几乎是对平凡生活的一种庆祝。当一道彩虹出现在他们正沿河在**楼下**建造的**摩天大楼**上方时，我会抛一枚硬币转动，等待表兄对我们家族生意能否**稳定**下来的判断。

可惜，并非每个故事都圆满。工人中突然爆发的**反抗**——他们觉得自己的**性别**和资历被忽视了一一严重威胁着公司。一个欠考虑又傲慢**无礼**的经理，既怯懦又颇为悲哀，把他们当作**敌人**而非伙伴。这场争端重如千**千**克的砝码，把公司拖入**泥潭**，**干净**的复苏似乎无望。为了平息怒火，**长辈**们**同意**着手改革；他们要置办新工具，改善沟通，并完整地**履行**承诺。

一个**现实主义者**会说，把雄心与耐心关联起来是可取的。**招募**新人、向周边农场稳定**供应**富含磷的肥料，乃至在遥远实验室里发现**青霉素**，这一切都提醒我们：进步无论多么不同寻常，都很少独自到来。一批鼓胀的新订单到来了；表兄系紧她的**围巾**，微笑着说，需求**规模**之大——按货架的米数来招待买家——彻底让我们所有人都吃了一惊。让我惊讶的是，那**一大群**外国买家终究没有忽视我们这间小小**框架**般的作坊。

32. An Anecdote from the Antiques Market

English

Perhaps no place reveals a person's character like a Sunday market, where the surroundings shift from stall to stall and a single anecdote can sum up a whole life. Last sunny day, in bright sunshine, I joined the throng on the left side of the square, content to wander with no fixed agenda. A junior trader, lazy in manner yet ingenious in talk, was trying to advertise an assorted box of magnetic toys and a compact chess set he hoped would render him rich.

Nearby, a patriot in faded jeans had laid out an ornament shaped like a planet, a postcard collection, and the trunk of an old automobile radio. He spoke with such fortitude about the revival of local craft that a small crowd began to conceive real interest. "In actuality," he said, scraping mud from a coin, "these things carry more security than any star on a screen. Heed the past, and it will not annoy you."

The scene felt almost classical. A female violinist played while a duke's portrait, its frame topmost on the wall, looked down with an air both urgent and serene. Someone had begun to embroider a flag; another chewed slowly on a strip of dried meat, perhaps an eggplant relish on the side. The whole panorama was a study in human variety, comprehensive and warm, though now and then an unwelcome jerk of the elbow reminded you to mind your seat at the crowded counter.

Meanwhile, a notary in a grey coat moved through the rows to nullify a forged document and dismiss a dubious claim. He explained, with a perspective sharpened by years of dealing, that to deny fraud is not enough; one must directly oppose it. "It would be thoughtless to incur a debt you cannot repay," he told a nervous young person, "and reckless to ignore the peril of haphazard spending. Such a habit can degrade a family as surely as slavery once crushed the free."

I bought a small print, a finding I had not anticipated, and a scarred wooden box whose lid no longer closed. The seller, prestigious among collectors, was inclined to donate a second piece, an antique mixer for the kitchen, just to oblige me. As the day cooled, the climactic moment came when an old man, his face marked by a scar, began to play a haunting tune. The preferential treatment of beauty over price, the uniformly gentle mood, the amusement of bargaining: all of it made the market a place I would dispatch my friends to without hesitation, certain they too would leave content. Before the excursion ended, a guard checked our identification at the peripheral gate, his manner the hallmark of an invincible discipline. The conversation never grew stagnant. One unpaid trainee, intentional in every gesture, would not tire; he gave clear instruction and crisp dictation to a junior, who copied it in symmetric handwriting. We watched a man chew betel as another swept excrement and stray scraps away to extinguish the smell. A reformed convict explained the microeconomics of his trade: each acquisition, each direct sale, was a gamble against the odds, as unpredictable as a strike in a game of bowling. My daughter-in-law, who studies how leaves release oxygen, read the manual aloud, and no thief would dare rob a place that might, as they say, scrape the very soul.

中文翻译

也许没有哪个地方像周日集市这样能揭示一个人的性格，那里的环境随着一个个摊位而变化，一则轶事便能概括一生。上一个晴天，在明媚的阳光下，我加入了广场左侧的人群，乐于漫无目的地闲逛，没有固定的议程。一个年轻的小贩，举止懒散却谈吐机灵，正想为一盒各式各样的磁性玩具和一副他希望能让自己发财的紧凑棋具做广告。

附近，一位穿着褪色牛仔褲的爱国者摆出一件形状像行星的装饰物、一套明信片，还有一台旧汽车收音机的外壳。他谈起本地手工艺的复兴时充满坚毅，以至于一小群人开始真正产生兴趣。"实际上，"他一边刮去硬币上的泥说，"这些东西比屏幕上任何明星都更有保障。留意过去，它就不会烦扰你。"

这场景几乎是古典的。一位女小提琴手在演奏，墙上最高处挂着一幅公爵的画像，神情既急切又安详。有人开始绣一面旗帜；另一个人慢慢咀嚼一条肉干，旁边或许配着茄子腌菜。整幅全景是一项关于人类多样性的研究，全面而温暖，尽管时不时一个不受欢迎的胳膊肘猛拉会提醒你，在拥挤的柜台前看好自己的座位。

与此同时，一位穿灰外套的公证人在一排排摊位间穿行，宣告一份伪造文件无效，并驳回一项可疑的索赔。他以多年生意磨砺出的眼光解释说，仅仅否认欺诈是不够的，人必须直接反对它。"欠下你还不起的债是欠考虑的，"他对一个紧张的年轻人说，"无视杂乱无章花钱的危险则是鲁莽的。这种习惯能让一个家庭堕落，就像奴隶制曾经碾碎自由人一样确定无疑。"

我买了一幅小版画——一个我未曾预料的发现——还有一个盖子再也合不上的带伤痕的木盒。卖主在收藏家中颇有声望，他乐意再赠送一件，一台厨房用的古董搅拌器，只为帮我个忙。随着白天转凉，高潮时刻到来了：一位脸上有疤痕的老人开始演奏一支萦绕心头的曲子。把美置于价格之上的优待、一贯温和的氛围、讨价还价的乐趣，这一切都让这个集市成为一个我会毫不犹豫地派我的朋友们前往的地方，确信他们离开时同样心满意足。远足结束前，一名警卫在外围的门口查验我们的身份证件，他的举止是一种不可战胜的纪律的标志。谈话从未变得停滞。一位不拿薪水的受训者，每个动作都饱含用心，毫不疲倦；他向一位新人清晰地讲解、口述，新人则以匀称的字迹抄录。我们看着一个人嚼槟榔，另一个人则把排泄物和零碎残渣扫走以消除气味。一位改过自新的罪犯讲解着他这行的微观经济学：每一次取得、每一次直接的买卖，都是与几率的赌博，像保龄球运动里的全中一样难以预料。我那研究叶片如何释放氧气的儿媳大声念着手册，没有小偷敢去抢劫这样一个据说能刮净灵魂的地方。

33. The Realm of Poetry and Discovery

English

Imagine a winter evening when a silent room fills with the loud crackle of a fire, and you decide to meet an old book again. Poetry, more than any other realm of writing, can recover what daily life misses; it lets us extract meaning from the ordinary and anticipate the joy of understanding. A valuable verse is real in a way that gold is not, for its worth does not depend on currency or financial markets.

When I was barely sixteen, in my teens, a strict teacher who would preside over our class with marked dignity asked us to mend our lazy habits and read conscientiously. He spoke toward us as a specialist might address a junior colleague. "Several of you," he said, "treat learning as rubbish to be tossed aside, yet the synthesis of fact and feeling is what gives a mind its height." His words, given freely, achieved more than any threat. Immediately I felt a vigorous hunger to know more.

That hunger took me far. I read of the universe and the galaxy, of radioactivity and the slow propagation of light across space; of how a flask in a lab might hold a combustible gas, of how scientists measure the tonnage of a ship or chart the song of whales. I learned that to amend a theory is no shame, that to abridge a long work can clarify it, and that a dubious claim should never be embraced without proof. A good reader, like a good farmer who tends his wheat and fowl, must not forsake patience.

There is a kind of admiration that borders on reverence for those who, against starvation and penury, still create. A warrior may win glory in battle, a giant of industry may amass wealth, but the poet who writes through bitterness leaves something that will not blur. History gives us the madman and the realist alike; it shows the explosive force of rebellion and the slow extraction of justice from injustice. To preside over one's own thoughts, to pertain to no faction blindly, to perceive clearly: this is the manifestation of a free mind.

Now, recovered from a long illness, I sit by the dike near my home and watch the water disperse the evening light. My cheek feels the cold; an ear catches a distant infection of laughter from children at play. I think of an antique flask of perfume my mother kept, of a sausage supper after a hurried day, of the juicy pear I shared with a friend. Marketing and expenditure will always demand their share of our hours, and a dispute over money can sour any week. But scarcely a day passes that I do not, clockwise around the room, let my eyes fall on the books and feel, despite every hardship, indefinite and quiet gratitude. My perception of these matters did not come in a hurry. As a folk saying goes, you cannot legislate taste, nor disburse wisdom like coins. When a postponement notice from the printer arrived, I felt a jolt run from hip to bowel, for the despatch of my favourite volume had been delayed. To achieve equality of access, the library waived the tuition of its renovation classes, and an obese cat would smack its lips and climb onto the old chair we had begun to upholster anew. I would not miss those evenings: the radioactive glow of the lamp, a pronoun underlined in red, the worn hull of a paperback, a soft nightgown, and the smack of rain on the glass.

中文翻译

想象一个冬夜，寂静的房间里充满了炉火响亮的噼啪声，而你决定再次与一本旧书相会。诗歌，比任何其他写作领域都更能找回日常生活所遗漏的东西；它让我们从平凡中提取意义，并预期理解的喜悦。一首有价值的诗以黄金所不具备的方式真实存在，因为它的价值不取决于货币或金融市场。

当我刚满十六岁、还在青少年时期时，一位会以鲜明的尊严主持我们班级的严格老师，要求我们改正懒散的习惯、认真地读书。他朝我们说话的样子，就像一位专家对一位较年轻的同事讲话。“你们中有几个人，”他说，“把学习当作可以丢弃的垃圾，然而事实与情感的综合才是赋予头脑高度的东西。”他慷慨给予的话语，比任何威胁都更有效。我立刻感到一种强烈的求知渴望。

那种渴望带我走得很远。我读到宇宙和星系，读到放射性和光在空间中缓慢的传播；读到实验室里的烧瓶可能装着一种易燃气体，读到科学家如何测量一艘船的吨位或绘制鲸的歌声。我懂得了修正一个理论并不可耻，删节一部长篇作品能使它更清晰，而一个可疑的论断绝不应在没有证据的情况下被接受。一个好读者，就像一个照料小麦和家禽的好农夫，不能放弃耐心。

有一种近乎崇敬的钦佩，献给那些在饥饿与贫困中仍然创作的人。战士可以在战场上赢得荣耀，工业巨头可以积累财富，但那个在辛酸中写作的诗人留下的东西不会模糊。历史既给我们疯子也给我们现实主义者；它展示反抗的爆炸性力量，以及从不公中缓慢提取正义的过程。主宰自己的思想，不盲目附属于任何派别，清晰地感知：这就是自由心灵的表现。

如今，从一场久病中痊愈，我坐在家附近的堤旁，看水面把傍晚的光线驱散开。我的脸颊感到寒冷；一只耳朵捕捉到远处孩子们玩耍时传染般的笑声。我想起母亲保存的一瓶古董香水，想起匆忙一天后的香肠晚餐，想起我和朋友分享的多汁的梨。营销和开支永远会索取我们时间的份额，一场关于金钱的争执能让任何一周变得糟糕。但几乎没有哪一天，我不会顺时针环视房间，让目光落在书上，并感到——尽管有种种艰辛——一种不确定而宁静的感激。我对这些事的领悟并非匆忙得来。正如一句民间谚语所说，你无法用立法规定品味，也无法像分发硬币那样支付智慧。当印刷厂的延期通知送达时，我感到一阵震颤从髋部直贯肠腹，因为我最爱的那卷书的发送被推迟了。为实现取阅的平等，图书馆免除了其翻新课程的学费，一只肥胖的猫咂着嘴，爬上我们重新开始装饰的旧椅子。我不愿错过那些夜晚：灯下放射性般的光晕、用红线划出的一个代词、平装书磨损的外壳、一件柔软的睡衣，以及雨点打在玻璃上的啪嗒声。

34. The Sculptor in the Remote District

English

In a **remote district** on a windswept **peninsular**, there lived an **obscure sculptor** whose true **identity** remained as elusive as an obscure **rumour**. His **apartment**, **adjacent** to a damp **cavern** near the coast, was a strange **institution** unto itself. **Behind** a **waterproof** curtain he kept the **basis** of his craft: a **spectrum** of stones, a **pitcher** of water, a rack of tools, and a **wide pink membrane** of wax he would **melt** and **sprinkle** over each frame.

He did not **belong** to any **collective**, nor did he **beg** the **mayor** or the **senate** for favours. **Customary** opinion held that he would **degrade** his gift if he let a **financier** **appraise** it, **peg** a price to it, or **strip** it of meaning by selling it **alongside** cheap goods. Yet his sculptures could **exemplify** an entire **sequence** of human feeling, from **reverence** to **bitterness**, with **perceptible** clarity. People said a single piece could **obliterate** doubt and **link** the viewer to something eternal.

The story goes that the **ruling pope** once contemplated a **vote** in the local senate to **glorify** the man, and a **Russian** collector offered to pay a **surcharge** so steep it could **remedy** the debt of a small town. But the sculptor would not be a **pawn**. He refused **obedience** to fashion. 'Will you **eject** your own conscience for gold?' he asked, and the financier could only **gape**, his **thigh** trembling, before he **beg** pardon and left.

Frequently, as the hours would **elapse**, the artist sat behind his bench and let his hand **sew** the final seam of a clay cloak, or **sift** fine dust through a sieve. A small **burrow** of mice lived in the wall, and a **holocaust** of moths once swarmed his lamp. None of this would obscure his focus. For the **sake** of the work, he would **emit** no complaint, **blot** out no error, and overlook no **defect**.

One customary morning a great **airliner** roared overhead, its **multiplication** of engines loud enough to **pounce** on the silence. The **vibration** shook a **thing** from the shelf. The **handling** of grief, he believed, was the true **construction** of art. He had no **horsepower**, no **leadership** title, no **schooling** beyond what the woods taught him; **even** so, an **applicant** for apprenticeship arrived weekly. **Whichever** pupil proved competent, he would teach the **alphabet** of stone. **Interference** from the outside world, the customary holocaust of noise and rumour, could not strip away the quiet reverence in which he worked, even as the years melted by. He once gave **me** a **pill** for my cough and spoke in a single grave **utterance** about the **macroeconomics** of art, how a **liberal** patron might **export** beauty abroad. I **postulate**, he said, that fame is **insubstantial**; **therewith** he would **countermand** any order for the **delivery** of his work to a gallery of mere **conquest**. The **mucous** damp of the cave clung to my **tibia** as I left, while the **ejection** of hot wax along a **circuit** of moulds was his only farewell.

中文翻译

在一个饱受风吹的**半岛**上的偏远**地区**，住着一位默默无闻的**雕塑家**，他真实的**身份**像一则晦涩的**传闻**一样难以捉摸。他的公寓紧邻海边一处潮湿的**洞穴**，本身就是一所奇异的机构。在一道**防水**的帘子后面，他保存着手艺的根基：各色石料、一只**水罐**、一架工具，以及一大片**宽阔**的粉色蜡膜——他会把蜡**融化**，喷洒在每一具骨架上。

他不**属于**任何**集体**，也不向**市长**或**参议院**乞求恩惠。按照惯常的看法，倘若他让**金融家**来评估作品、给它标个价，或把它与廉价货摆在一起出售而剥夺其意义，他便糟蹋了自己的天赋。然而他的雕塑能以可感的清晰，举例呈现人类情感的一整个**系列**，从**崇敬**到**辛酸**。人们说，单单一件作品就能抹去疑虑，把观者与某种永恒之物**连接**起来。

据说当政的教皇曾考虑在地方参议院**投票**来**颂扬**此人，一位俄罗斯收藏家也**愿意**支付一笔高昂的**额外费用**，足以弥补一座小镇的债务。但这位雕塑家不愿做棋子。他拒绝向时尚屈服。「你愿为黄金喷出自己的良心吗？」他问道，金融家只能张口结舌，**大腿**发颤，随后求得原谅便离开了。

常常，随着时间**流逝**，这位艺术家坐在工作台后，让手缝合一件黏土斗篷的最后一道接缝，或用筛子筛过细尘。墙里住着一窝老鼠的**地洞**，曾有大群飞蛾扑向他的灯。这些都无法使他分心。为了作品，他不发一句怨言，不抹去一处败笔，也不忽略任何瑕疵。

一个寻常的清晨，一架巨大的客机从头顶轰鸣而过，多重引擎的声音大得足以扑灭寂静。震动把一样**东西**从架上摇落。他相信，对悲伤的**处理**才是艺术真正的**构造**。他没有**马力**，没有**领导**头衔，除了树林教给他的之外没有受过**学校教育**；即便如此，每周都有人前来申请当学徒。**无论**哪个学生证明自己能胜任，他都会教他石头的**字母表**。来自外界的干扰，那惯常的噪音与传闻的大肆侵扰，都无法剥夺他工作时那份静默的崇敬，哪怕岁月正在融化般流逝。他曾给我一粒**药丸**治咳嗽，并以一句庄重的话谈起艺术的**宏观经济学**，谈起一位**慷慨**的赞助人如何可能把美**输出**到国外。他说，我**假定**名声是虚无缥缈的；据此他会**撤回**任何把他作品送往一座只为**征服**而设的画廊的订单。当我离开时，洞穴里黏液般的潮气贴着我的**胫骨**，而热蜡沿着一圈模具的**喷射**，便是他唯一的告别。

35. A Speedy Recovery on the Tropic River

English

The **illness** struck without warning. What began as a vague **ache** in the **belly** and a dull pain in my **neck** soon revealed itself, after a **fierce** week, to be **dysentery**. The **principal** doctor at the clinic, a **handsome** but **laborious** man with a **haggard** face, prescribed a course of pills and ordered a brief **quarantine** to **confine** the infection. He warned that the **bearing** of my mood would matter as much as any **granule** of medicine.

The clinic stood near a wide **reservoir** in the **tropic** lowlands, **everywhere** fringed by tall **fir** and fragrant **pear** trees. **Immigration** officials had stamped my **license** at the border, and the long **check-out** queue at the dock had left me **nervous**. Now, **naked** of all my plans, I lay still. A **touchy** old **beggar** in the next bed, **seldom** **polite**, would **dispute** every remark, while a kindly **Dutch shopkeeper** across the room told stories with **wisdom** and gentle humour, never **lukewarm** in his welcome.

To **recapture** my strength I had to **abandon** my old habit of haste. The doctor explained, in **elaborate** detail, that recovery was not a **hurdle** to leap but a **curve** to follow. He did not glorify quick fixes; he warned that an **intractable** case could **undermine** the body for a **generation** if a patient sought only a **speedy** result. A **turbulent** fever, he said, must not be allowed to **rouse** panic. **Commitment** to rest, he insisted, was no **unnecessary** luxury but the **correct** path.

As the days passed I began to **gain** ground. A **postgraduate** nurse, **cheeky** and warm, would bring **food** on a **marble** tray: a slice of pear, a little **saline** broth, sometimes a **pimple** of honey on bread fresh from the **oven**. She would **scare** off my gloom, deny my **woe** a foothold, and **ascribe** my progress to plain **participation** in the daily routine. I no longer **differ** with her on that. Her **commonplace** kindness, **exclusively** given without thought of reward, became the **holy** centre of those long hours.

On the day of my release I walked, weak but upright, down to the water where a **canoe** waited. A **competitor** in some local race paddled past, **fist** raised in triumph. The **collision** of joy and relief nearly made me weep. I thought of all I had nearly lost: the **festivity** of ordinary life, the dignity of standing on my own. A **mystic** might call it grace; a **lawyer** might call it luck. The **president** of the clinic, presiding at the gate, shook my hand. The **ax** of fear had been laid down; the **denial** was over. With a **synonym** for gratitude on my lips, I stepped into the **midst** of the world again, my **hardware** of habits rebuilt, ready to **slay** no enemy but my own despair. At the **start** of the **tour**, the doctor would **prescribe** a **triple** dose and a careful **depiction** of every symptom, **dealing** gently so as not to **cosset** the patient nor **hinder** recovery, and he always left the door **ajar**. In a **developing** nation moving toward **socialism**, the **marketplace** must **optimize** its **scale**; the **erasure** of old debts was **indicative** of reform, though stacks of **lumber** and red tape still slowed the work.

中文翻译

病来得毫无预兆。起初只是**腹部**一阵模糊的隐痛和脖子上一阵钝痛，经过**凶猛**的一周后，很快显现为**痢疾**。诊所的主任医生，一个英俊却辛劳、面容**憔悴**的人，开了一个疗程的药丸，并下令短期**隔离**以**限制**感染。他警告说，我情绪的**举止**与任何一粒药一样重要。

诊所坐落在**回归线**附近的低地，挨着一座宽阔的**水库**，四处都被高大的冷杉和芬芳的**梨树**环绕。移民官在边境为我的**执照**盖了章，码头上漫长的离站排队让我紧张不安。如今，剥去了一切计划，我静静躺着。隔壁床一个**暴躁**的**老乞丐**，**很少**有礼貌，对每句话都要争辩；而房间对面一位和善的荷兰**店主**则带着**智慧**和温和的幽默讲故事，他的欢迎从不冷淡。

要**夺回**我的体力，我必须**放弃**急躁的旧习惯。医生详尽地解释说，康复不是一道要跃过的栏，而是一条要顺着走的**曲线**。他不美化速效良方；他警告说，一个**难处理的**病例若患者只求快速结果，可能会**削弱**身体长达**一代**人之久。他说，**汹涌**的高烧绝不能被允许去**唤起恐慌**。他坚持认为，对休息的承诺并非**多余的**奢侈，而是**正确的**道路。

随着日子过去，我**开始**有了起色。一位**研究生**护士，俏皮又温暖，会用**大理石**托盘端来**食物**：一片梨、一点盐水汤，有时是刚出炉的面包上一小**疙瘩**蜂蜜。她会吓跑我的阴郁，不让我的悲苦立足，并把我的好转归因于对日常作息单纯的**参与**。在这一点上我不再与她有异议。她那**平凡**的善意，专一地给予而不求回报，成了那些漫长时光**神圣**的中心。

出院那天，我虚弱却挺直地走到水边，一只**独木舟**在那里等着。一名本地**比赛**的**竞争者**划桨经过，握拳作出胜利的姿势。喜悦与宽慰的**碰撞**几乎让我落泪。我想到自己险些失去的一切：平凡生活的**欢庆**，独自站立的尊严。神秘主义者会称之为恩典；**律师**会称之为运气。诊所的院长在门口主持，与我握手。恐惧之斧已经放下；**否认**已经结束。带着一个表示感激的**同义词**在唇边，我重新踏入世界的中心，习惯的**硬件**已重建，准备去屠戮的不是别的敌人，而是我自己的绝望。在巡诊开始时，医生会开出**三倍的**剂量，并仔细**描述**每一个症状，处理时十分温和，既不**溺爱**病人，也不妨碍其康复，而且他总是让门半开着。在一个走向**社会主义**的发展中国家，**市场**必须优化其规模；旧债的勾销是改革的标志，尽管成堆的**木料**和繁文缛节仍拖慢着工作。

36. The Brain, Resilience, and a British Farm

English

On a **grand British farm** among the rolling **meadow** country, my **father** kept a **stout shepherd's** cottage that he loved to **renovate**. It was here, **surely**, that I first learned about **resilience**. The **continual** rhythm of the seasons taught a **patience** no **television** or **best-seller** could **enhance**, and the **loneliness** of winter could be **problematic** for a **darling** child who craved company.

My **recollection** of those years is vivid. Each morning my father, a **worker** of real **expertise**, would **specify** the chores: **replenish** the trough, **certify** the count of the cattle, **hoist** the hay onto the **rod-and-rack** frame, and **protect** the **organic** crops from **gale** and frost. The **rotation** of tasks was a kind of **computation**, **roughly** fixed yet flexible, and an **observer** might call it monotonous. To me it was **rewarding**. Even the **laundry** on the line, swirling in the wind, seemed to **wiggle** with a life of its own.

The farm was no commonplace operation. We grew **turnip** and **flower** beds alike, and a small **brewery** at the rear produced a stout so dark it looked like ash. My father would **browse** a worn handbook for advice, **muscular** arms folded, and say that good husbandry was **advisable**, that **incorrect** methods would only breed **discomfort**. He distrusted any **hasty** or **outlandish** scheme; a **sheepish** neighbour once tried a **compatible** new fertiliser without **verification** and watched his **quantity** of barley collapse into **paralysis**.

There was, of course, hardship. My brother caught a fever that left him **incapable** of work, his **tooth** aching, his **chin** pale; the **brain**, the doctor said, needed rest more than any pill. The **uncertainty** was a heavy **suspension** over the house. Yet my father would **summon** a **hilarious** story, **accidentally** spill the **necklace** of beads my mother kept by the **sink**, and turn **provocation** into laughter. He refused to let **depreciate** the **heritage** of good cheer that was our true wealth.

That heritage, **multiple** and rich, still shapes me. I think of the meadow at dawn, the **cat** asleep on the **price-list** pinned to the door, the **arrow** of geese overhead. I think of the **crevice** in the old wall where I would **bury** small treasures, of the **bath** by the fire, of the **adhesive** sense of belonging that no **sanction** or distance could **pierce**. Among all the things I own, that **excellent** and continual **belief** in patience, in protection, in the slow **solidify** of love, is the one I would never let a competitor purchase. It made me, and represents in its quiet **representation** everything I hope to pass on. Our **friendship**, **visible** to all, did not **obligate** either of us to anything. At the **station** we would practice the **pronunciation** of foreign words, fill a **paper** with notes, and watch the **furniture** of the old hall **swirl** with dust. As a season **ski-pass holder**, he would **transship** his gear north each winter, press the **accelerator** of his battered car, pour a glass of **scotch**, and speak warmly of the charities that fight **aids**.

中文翻译

在一座宏大的英国**农场**上，置身于连绵起伏的**草地**之间，我**父亲**守着一间结实的**牧羊人**小屋，他喜欢翻修它。无疑，正是在这里，我第一次懂得了什么是**顺应力**。四季**不断**的节律教会了一种**耐心**，那是任何**电视**或**畅销书**都无法增进的；而冬天的**孤独**，对一个渴望陪伴、惹人疼爱的孩子来说，可能是个难题。

我对那些年的**回忆**很鲜明。每天清晨，我父亲——一个真正有专业技能的劳动者——会详细**指定**家务活：把饮水槽补满，核实牛的数目，把干草吊到杆架结构的支架上，并**保护**有机作物不受**大风**和霜冻侵害。任务的轮换是一种**计算**，大致固定却又灵活，旁观者也许会觉得单调。对我而言它却很有收获。就连晾衣绳上的衣物，在风中打着旋，似乎也扭动着自己的生命。

这农场可不是寻常的经营。我们既种**萝卜**也种花圃，后院一家小**酿酒厂**酿出的烈性黑啤暗得像灰烬。父亲会翻阅一本破旧的手册寻求建议，**肌肉发达**的胳膊抱在胸前，说良好的农事管理是明智**可取的**，**不正确**的方法只会滋生不适。他不**信任**任何草率或**古怪**的方案；一个**胆怯**的邻居曾未经**检验**就试用一种据说**兼容**的新化肥，眼看着自己大麦的产量**瘫痪**般地崩溃。

当然也有艰难。我弟弟得了一场热病，使他无力干活，**牙齿**作痛，**下巴**苍白；医生说，大脑比任何药丸都更需要休息。那种不确定像沉重的悬置笼罩着整个家。然而父亲会讲出一个滑稽的故事，不经意打翻母亲放在水槽边的珠串**项链**，把**刺激**变成笑声。他拒绝让我们真正的财富——那份乐观的**传统**——**贬值**。

那份传统，多重而丰厚，至今仍塑造着我。我想起黎明的草地，想起睡在钉于门上的**价格表**上的猫，想起头顶上排成箭形的雁群。我想起老墙上那道我用来**埋藏**小宝贝的**裂缝**，想起炉火旁的**洗澡**，想起那种黏着般的归属感——没有任何**制裁**或距离能将它**刺穿**。在我拥有的一切**之中**，那份卓越而不断的信念——对耐心、对保护、对爱缓慢**凝固**的信念——是我绝不会让任何竞争者买走的。它造就了我，并在它静默的呈现中，**代表**着我希望传承下去的一切。我们的**友谊**众人皆见，却不强求彼此承担什么义务。在**车站**，我们会练习外语单词的**发音**，在纸上写满笔记，看着旧厅里的**家具**与尘埃一同打旋。作为一名季票**滑雪卡**的**持有者**，他每年冬天都把装备**转运**北上，踩下那辆破车的油门，倒上一杯**苏格兰威士忌**，并热切地谈起那些与**艾滋病**作斗争的慈善事业。

37. A Coastal Survey of Species and Terrain

English

When I was first hired to **survey** the **eastern delta**, I did not **find** the work **expensive** or boring; **initially** it was the most rewarding job I could imagine. My task was to map the **boundary** of a fragile ecosystem along a coral **reef**, to **contemplate** its **myriad species**, and to **finalize** a report on how **congestion** from new construction near the motorway might harm the **territory**.

The **handbook** the institute gave me was **handy** and **economical** with words. It urged me to **visualize** each habitat as a single **subject**, to **deduce** patterns from **genetic** data, and to **broaden** my view from one **lane** of evidence to the whole **interior** of the problem. I would **unlock** my field **card** at dawn, **drag** my **rack** of gear past the **lighthouse**, and **wait** for the **boiling** sun to clear the morning **hum** of insects. A **turtle** might cross the wet sand; a **shark's** fin might **cut** the surface beyond the reef; once a curious **bee** followed me the whole **starting** mile.

The **terrain** was a **versatile** teacher. Each **cycle** of the tide exposed a new **seam** in the rock, an **incipient** crack that would, given **irregularity** of weather, widen into a cave. I learned to read the omen of a snowstorn far inland and to **intensify** my pace **against** any deadline I might **exceed**. A **gracious** old **landlady** near the **customs** house rented me a **bedroom** with **cotton** sheets, served strong **tea** and **soup**, and told me anecdotes about smugglers who once demanded a **ransom** from passing ships, or a **butcher** who would **extort** and **entangle** honest traders in petty schemes.

Not everything was **fair**. A **by-product** of tourism was a flood of cheap **commodity** stalls; an **alloy** of greed and haste, you might say. Some vendors, **lavish** in promises, were less than **legitimate**, and their **etiquette** toward the species we studied was appalling. They would pluck **cosmetic** shells, drag nets across the reef, and leave the **outland** fringes of the marsh in ruins. **Considerably** more troubling, a **garrison** of developers contemplated a synthetic harbour that would obscure the wild shore forever.

My **certificate** of completion came with a **designation** I was proud of, and **freely** I admit the **triumph** felt sweet. The survey would, I hoped, broaden public belief in conservation. As I packed my **jacket**, rolled down my **sleeve**, knelt on one **knee** to seal the last crate, and signed against the **flag** of the field office, I felt the **independence** of useful labour. The **reactor** of my own ambition had cooled into something **serviceable**: a calm wish to **absorb** what the world teaches and, in turn, to defend it. In his **autobiography** he made a brief **appearance** as a **vegetarian** cook who could **envision** an entire menu from the **marrow** of a single idea. During the **snowstorm** we stayed **indoor**, sipped **beer** and chewed **candy**, and watched the slow **upcreep** of prices on the board. The **greenhouse** owner offered me a fair **remuneration** to **hire** a guide, and with a polite **bow** I accepted.

中文翻译

当我第一次被雇来勘测东部三角洲时，我并不觉得这份工作昂贵或无聊；起初它是我所能**想象**到的最有收获的工作。我的任务是沿着一片脆弱的珊瑚礁绘制这一脆弱生态系统的**边界**，仔细考察其无数物种，并就高速公路附近新建筑带来的拥堵可能如何危害这片区域，定下一份报告。

研究所给我的**手册**很方便，文字也很省。它敦促我把每一处栖息地都**想象**成一个**独立的主题**，从遗传数据中推断规律，并把视野从单一的一条证据拓宽到整个问题的**内部**。每天黎明我会解锁我的野外记录卡，把一架装备拖过**灯塔**，**等待****沸腾**的太阳驱散清晨虫鸣的嗡嗡声。一只**海龟**也许会穿过湿润的沙滩；一条**鲨鱼**的鳍也许会划破礁外的水面；有一次，一只好奇的**蜜蜂**跟着我走完了开头整整一英里。

这片**地形**是个**多才多艺**的老师。每一次潮汐的**循环**都会暴露出岩石里的一条新缝，一道初生的裂口——倘若天气反复无常，它会扩大成一个洞穴。我学会了解读远在内陆的**暴风雪**之兆，并在我可能**超出**的任何期限前加快步伐。**海关**旁一位**和善**的老房东把一间铺着棉布床单的**卧室**租给我，端来浓茶和热汤，给我讲述走私者的趣闻——他们曾向过往船只**勒索赎金**；还讲到一个**屠夫**，会**敲诈**并把诚实的商人**卷入**鸡毛蒜皮的勾当。

并非一切都公平。旅游业的一个**副产品**是廉价**商品**摊位的泛滥；你可以说那是贪婪与匆忙的**合金**。一些摊贩在承诺上慷慨大方，却谈不上正当合法，他们对我们所研究物种的礼数令人发指。他们会采摘用作化妆装饰的贝壳，把渔网拖过珊瑚礁，把沼泽偏僻的边缘弄得一片狼藉。更令人不安得多的是，一队开发商正**打算**建一座人工合成的港口，那将永远遮蔽这片野性的海岸。

我的结业证书附带一个我引以为豪的头衔，我坦率承认那份**成功**的滋味很甜。我希望这次勘测能拓宽公众对保护的信念。当我收拾夹克、卷下**袖子**、单膝跪地封好最后一块板条箱、**对着**野外办公室的旗帜签字时，我**感到**了有用劳动带来的独立。我自身野心的**反应堆**已冷却成某种**耐用**的东西：一个平静的愿望——去**吸收**世界所教导的一切，再反过来去守护它。在他的**自传**里，他作为一名素食厨师短暂登场，能够从一个念头的精髓中构想出整份菜单。暴风雪期间我们待在室内，嚼着**啤酒**、嚼着**糖果**，看着告示牌上价格缓缓**上涨**。**温室**的主人开出一笔公道的**酬劳**雇我做向导，我礼貌地鞠了一躬便答应了。

38. A Centenary at the Harbour Museum

English

The **notice** on the bulletin board was **patently momentous**: our harbour town would mark its **centenary** with a grand festival, and the new **museum** by the **quay** would open its doors. **So** many people had worked to **bring** this day about that the mere **idea** of failure now seemed **outdated**. A **provisional** committee, **active** since spring, had drawn up an agenda, and a cheerful **counsellor** with a healthy **complexion** was certain everything would be **o.k.**

I walked along the **gulf** at **departure** of light, past a **tombstone**-grey wall and a row of **croissant** shops, to **analyze** the **panorama** for the souvenir postcard I planned to sell. From the **ballroom** window one could **perceive** the whole **sector** of coast: the **fishery** boats **laden** with the night's catch, the old **tunnel** cut through the headland, a **brook** that fed a pond fringed with **vegetation**. A **pedestrian** in a **wet** coat paused to **applaud** a street musician whose **musical** talent was **impressive**, while children chased a butterfly past a **hanger** of drying nets.

Inside, the curator showed **admission** to a **sufficient** crowd. He had a **hint** of the showman about him. In **A.D.** ninety-two, he began, a **baron** had built the first warehouse here. He spoke of the harsh era of **imperialism**, of a **riot** and the **democrat** who quelled it, of a **wreck** whose **ash** and broken **mold** still lay in the deep. A glass case held a coin, a **clasp**, a tube of antique **toothpaste**, and an **eyeball**-shaped lamp once used to certify cargo. The **continuity** of these objects, he said, was an **acknowledgment** of every worker who had shaped the place.

Not all the exhibits were **peaceful**. One alcove was **particularly** grim: it depicted a **raid** in which an opponent fleet had stormed the bay. A faded **omen**, painted on a **shilling**-sized medal, hinted at the **diarrhea** and dysentery that swept the garrison afterward. The **herbivorous** deer carved into a **groove** of stone seemed to **swing** between sorrow and hope, a **tinge** of grief in their eyes.

By dusk the **vogue** of the day had not faded. A **centrifugal** energy pulled the crowd toward the square, where a **coach** unloaded **baggage** for visitors travelling **westward**. Someone shouted a cheerful exhortation; another would **exhort** the band to play on. I **normalize** my breathing, **pluck** up courage, and stepped onto the platform. To my surprise the speech went well, **identical** in spirit to the one I had rehearsed, **buoyant** and **gratifying**. An **applicable** lesson, I think, for anyone who fears a crowd: the **relief** of finishing is its own reward, and the **avenge** of nerves is simply to begin. Far from **boring**, the **institute** planned to **upgrade** its **stock** of exhibits before the crowds **depart**. A **positive sum** of donations, free of any **opaque capitalization** scheme, would **shelter** the **synthetic** models from the **remoteness** of decay. In neat **notation** a **comrade** catalogued each **cricket**-shaped brooch in careful **alignment**, and the **notional** value, an **exporter** once joked, lay beyond the **cave** of any vault.

中文翻译

公告栏上的**通知**显然意义重大：我们这座海港小镇将以百年庆典纪念它的一百周年，**码头**旁的**新博物馆**也将开门迎客。为促成这一天，**那么**多人付出了努力，以至于失败的**念头**如今都显得过时。一个自春天起就**活跃**的临时委员会拟好了议程，一位**面色**红润、性情开朗的**顾问**确信一切都会没问题。

天光初褪时，我沿着**海湾**散步，经过一道**墓碑**般灰色的墙和一排**新月形**面包店，去**分析全景**，好为我打算出售的纪念明信片取材。从**舞厅**的窗口可以看到整段海岸：满载着夜捕的渔船、穿过海角凿出的旧**隧道**、一条注入被植被环绕的池塘的小溪。一位穿湿外套的行人停下来为街头乐手鼓掌，那人的音乐才华令人印象深刻；孩子们追着一只蝴蝶跑过一架晾网的**衣架**。

馆内，馆长向足够多的人群展示了入场。他身上有几分演艺人的味道。「**公元**九十二年，」他开口道，「一位**男爵**在这里建起了第一座仓库。」他讲到**帝国主义的**严酷年代，讲到一场**暴乱**以及平息它的那位**民主党人**，讲到一艘沉船——它的灰烬和破碎的铸模至今仍躺在深处。一只玻璃柜里放着一枚硬币、一个**扣子**、一管古董**牙膏**，还有一盏**眼球**形状、曾用来检验货物的灯。他说，这些物件的**连续性**，是对每一位**塑造**了这地方的工人的**鸣谢**。

并非所有展品都安宁。有一处壁龛**格外**阴森：它描绘了一场突袭，一支敌方舰队曾猛攻这座海湾。一枚**先令**大小的徽章上画着褪色的**预兆**，**暗示**了此后席卷驻军的**腹泻**与痢疾。刻在石槽里的食草鹿，似乎在悲伤与希望之间摇摆，眼中带着一丝哀愁。

到黄昏时，这一天的热潮仍未消退。一股离心般的能量把人群拉向广场，那里一辆长途客车正为西行的旅客卸下**行李**。有人喊出一句愉快的劝勉；另一人则要鼓动乐队继续演奏。我让呼吸恢复正常，鼓起勇气，踏上讲台。出乎我意料，演讲很顺利，在精神上与我排练过的那篇一模一样，轻快而令人欣慰。我想，这对任何害怕人群的人都是一条适用的经验：完成之后的宽慰本身就是回报，而战胜紧张的**报复**方式，不过就是开始。这家机构毫不乏味，计划在人群离去之前**升级**其藏品库存。一笔可观的捐款总额，不涉及任何**不透明的资本化**方案，将使这些合成模型免于在偏远中朽坏。一位**同志**以工整的**符号**为每一枚**蟋蟀**形胸针编目，整齐排列，而一位**出口商**曾打趣说，那名义上的价值，超出了任何金库的洞穴。

39. The Diligent Lexicographer in the Alpine Town

English

It was a **frightful** winter when I first arrived in the **alpine** town, and **indeed** the cold seemed to **gratify** nothing but my growing loneliness. I had come, **increasingly** certain of my plan, to compile a **best-selling** dictionary, for **lexicography** had been my passion since my school **class** days. The **feasibility** of the project once seemed infinite; now, **motionless** at my desk, I would **stare** at a blank page and feel like a **victim** of my own ambition.

My landlord, a **cordial** old **resident** with a **witty** tongue, did much to refresh my spirits. He would **devise** small comforts: a **banquet** of **mince** pies, a **drum** of **refreshment** by the fire, **honey** for my tea. "A **pessimist** sees only **shadow**," he said, "but a **diligent** man sees **variety**." He had **previously** worked at the **shipyard**, and the **consistency** of his good cheer, in **defiance** of his **dental** aches and frequent **headache**, was a marvel to me. He kept a **parakeet** in the **attic** and a **salmon** smoking in the shed.

Each morning I would **hike** past the **gymnasium** and the **memorial** in the **precinct** square, then **walk** along a path of **flagstone** toward the lake, where the water was **navigable** only in summer. I learned to **bake** bread, to mince herbs, to **coordinate** my hours so that no **fortuity** could derail the work. A previously published **bulletin** had testified that the region's **economics** depended on its **ecosystem**, and I would marvel at how a whole **business** could **grow** from such a fragile **relation** between people and land.

The town itself was a kind of memorial to endurance. An old **uprising** was commemorated by a **plaster** relief on the town hall; a **coin** minted for that occasion still passed from hand to hand. The **distributor** of the local paper, a **manly** figure with the **decency** of a saint, told me that the **prevailing** mood after the revolt had been one of solidarity. A **chairwoman** of the council, qualified and gracious, had backdated certain pardons so that no rebel's **remains** went unhonoured.

My own **learning** deepened. I came to **differentiate** the **permissible** from the merely fashionable, and to **confront** each doubtful entry with patience and **accuracy**. When at last the manuscript arrived at completion, I felt its **meteoric sweetness**, a **pearl** of effort polished over many months. To celebrate, I would **baby-sit** my neighbour's child, pitch a **tent** by the brook, and **invert** my old habits of worry. The **documentation** alone filled a tent's worth of boxes; an **enclosure** of notes, an **alarm** clock that I no longer needed, and a **sieve** of discarded ideas. **Strange** as it sounds, the work that had once seemed a **sclerosis** of the mind became, in the end, the purest enjoyment I had ever known. To good **effect** I would **loungue amidst** my **luggage** in the **flat** above the lounge and **spell** out new entries. I **reckon** a **prerequisite** of the craft is patience, for the damp would **necessitate** scraping **mildew** from the walls. I can **testify** that even a single **kilowatt** of heat helped. A **painting** of an **ape** hung crooked; whenever I would **arrive** each morning I made the same **substitution** of words and would **backdate** my notes, and the school's move to **coeducation**, I reckoned, had a fine effect on the town.

中文翻译

我初到那座高山小镇时，正值一个**可怕的**冬天，**确实**，那寒冷除了助长我**日益**加深的孤独，似乎什么也满足不了。我来此，是越来越确信自己的计划——编一部**畅销的**词典，因为自学生时代以来，**词典编纂**一直是我的热情所在。这个项目的**可行性**一度看似无穷无尽；如今，我一动不动地坐在书桌前，盯着空白的纸页，觉得自己成了自己雄心的**牺牲品**。

我的房东是位**热诚的**老居民，言谈风趣，为我重振精神出了不少力。他会**想出种种**小小的慰藉：一桌肉馅饼，炉边一桶**饮料**，给我的茶里加**蜂蜜**。**“悲观者只看到阴影，”**他说，**“勤奋的人却看到多样。”**他**先前**在**船坞**工作，尽管牙痛、常常**头痛**，他始终如一的好心情对我而言是个奇迹。他在**阁楼**里养着一只长尾鹦鹉，棚里熏着一条**大马哈鱼**。

每天早晨，我会徒步经过**体育馆**和广场上**选区**里的**纪念碑**，然后沿着一条**石板路**朝湖边走去——那湖水只有夏天才可通航。我学会了烤面包、**切碎**香草、合理安排时间，好让任何**偶然事件**都无法打乱工作。先前出版的一份**公报**曾**证明**，这个地区的**经济情况**依赖于它的**生态系统**，我会惊叹于：一整桩**生意**竟能从人与土地之间如此脆弱的**关系**中**成长**起来。

小镇本身就是一座耐力的纪念碑。市政厅上一幅**灰泥**浮雕纪念着一场古老的**起义**；为那次**事件**铸造的一枚硬币至今仍在人们手中传递。当地报纸的**分销商**是个有**男子气概**的人物，具有圣徒般的**体面**，他告诉我，那场暴动之后**占上风**的情绪是一种**团结一致**。议会的一位**女主席**既有资格又和蔼，曾把某些赦免**回溯**生效，使没有一个反叛者的遗骸得不到尊崇。

我自己的**学问**也加深了。我学会**区分**什么是**可允许的**、什么只是时髦的，并以**耐心**和**准确**去面对每一个存疑的词条。当手稿终于完成时，我感到了它流星般的甜美，那是历经数月打磨的一颗努力的**珍珠**。为庆祝，我会替邻居看孩子，在小溪边支起**帐篷**，颠倒我从前忧虑的种种习惯。光是那些文件就装满了够一顶帐篷大小的箱子；一沓**附件**笔记、一只我再也不需要的闹钟，还有一筛被丢弃的念头。说来奇怪，那项曾让我头脑仿佛**硬化**的工作，最终却成了我所体验过的最纯粹的乐趣。颇见成效地，我会在**休息室**楼上那套公寓里、在**行李**堆中懒洋洋地坐着，逐字拼出新词条。我认为这门手艺的一个**先决条件**就是耐心，因为潮湿迫使我刮去墙上的霉斑。我可以作证，哪怕一**千瓦**的热量也有帮助。一幅画着**猿猴**的画歪挂着；每天早晨我一到，便做同样的词语替换，并把笔记回溯标注日期，而我寻思，学校改为**男女同校**，对这座小镇产生了不错的**影响**。

40. The Punctual Receptionist and the International Match

English

Today, everyone at the international sports club knew that the chess final was imminent. I am the receptionist there, a punctual and qualified worker, and basically my job is to count guests, sign forms, and see that no one feels like an illiterate outsider. There is always a chance that some workaholic designer or a conservative baron will arrive late, but I dare not let the schedule deteriorate.

The champion's opponent this year was a first-rate proletarian player from a distant commonwealth, a man of dogged, magnanimous spirit. He had survived bronchitis as a child, broken his femur in a fall, and once seemed a victim of every misfortune. People used to suspect his nerve would collapse, that his form was rotten and his confidence insoluble. Yet he refused to dodge the contention; with quiet solidarity among his fans, he turned each match into a marvel.

Before the storm of the final, the hall was tense. I deduct nothing from the drama when I say the air felt drowsy yet electric, as if some omen hung above the platform. A series of officials, diplomatic and needful of order, tried to clarify the rules and modulate the rising uproar. One absent-minded count kept toying with a walnut, while an aunt of the champion peeled a butterfly-shaped pastry and offered it around. A premium had been paid for the freight that brought the engraved trophy, and rejection of any late entry was final; the committee would shelve no complaint.

The game itself was an infinite pleasure to watch. Each player would stretch his thinking, tense as a spring, and the stimulus of the clock made every move ragged with risk. Protein bars and luxury chocolates lay untouched. When the challenger forced a merge of his rooks and a sudden sign of weakness appeared in the champion's defence, a ridiculous, joyful uproar broke out. It was pure fun, intelligible even to a kid who had wandered in from the zoo trip next door.

The pertinence of the result was clear to all. The flight home would carry a new hero. As the players signed the scoresheet, I felt the enjoyment of an ordinary day made extraordinary. A dependant of the old champion, drowsy in his seat, woke to applaud. Some said the dynasty had ended; others insisted it had merely undergone a consolidation. There was no conspiracy, no profane trick, no parody of sport, only a clean victory. The motorway outside filled with cars, and as the pulp of the day's newspapers spun off the presses with my photograph in the corner, I let myself, for once, simply marvel and seclude my doubts. Because the existing engine could hardly start, we left it under a blanket in the barn. I would peel an orange and write a letter in a calm voice, careful not to harass anyone. A scientific spirit of stewardship should permeate every page rather than leave it blank, yet a child's toy lay forgotten where the cold would permeate the boards.

中文翻译

今天，国际体育俱乐部里人人都知道，国际象棋决赛即将到来。我是那里的接待员，一个守时又称职的工作人员，基本上我的工作就是清点客人、签署表格，并确保没有人觉得自己像个被排斥的文盲。总有可能某个工作狂设计师或某位保守的男爵迟到，但我不敢让日程恶化。

今年冠军的对手是一位来自遥远联邦的一流无产阶级棋手，一个顽强而宽宏大量的人。他小时候得过支气管炎，摔断过大腿骨，一度看似遭受种种不幸的牺牲品。人们曾怀疑他会神经崩溃，状态糟糕，信心无法挽回。然而他拒绝逃避这场较量；在球迷们默默的团结一致之下，他把每一场比赛都变成了奇迹。

决赛的风暴来临之前，大厅气氛紧张。我毫不夸张地说，空气既令人昏昏欲睡又仿佛带电，好像有某种预兆悬在台上。一连串官员，既讲究外交手腕又需要秩序，努力厘清规则、调节渐起的喧嚣。一位心不在焉的伯爵不停地摆弄一颗核桃，而冠军的一位姨母剥开一块蝴蝶形的点心分给众人。运送那座刻字奖杯的货运付了额外费用，任何迟到报名一律拒绝，绝无更改；委员会不会搁置任何申诉。

比赛本身看起来是无穷的乐趣。每位棋手都会拉伸思维，紧绷得像一根弹簧，时钟的刺激让每一步都因风险而显得粗糙。蛋白棒和奢侈的巧克力无人去碰。当挑战者迫使他的车合并、冠军防线上突然出现一丝破绽时，一阵荒谬而欢乐的喧嚣爆发了。那是纯粹的乐趣，连一个从隔壁动物园之行溜进来的小孩都看得懂。

结果的针对性人人明了。回家的航班将载着一位新英雄。当棋手们在记分表上签名时，我感受到平凡一天变得非凡的乐趣。老冠军的一位侍从在座位上昏昏欲睡，醒来鼓掌。有人说一个王朝结束了；也有人坚持那只是经历了一次巩固。这里没有阴谋，没有衰败的把戏，没有对体育的拙劣模仿，只有一场干净的胜利。外面的快车道上车流满满，当当天报纸的纸浆带着角落里我的照片从印刷机上飞旋而出时，我让自己破例地，单纯地惊叹一回，把疑虑隔离在一旁。因为现有的引擎几乎无法启动，我们便把它盖上毯子留在谷仓里。我会剥一个橙子，用平静的声音写一封信，小心不去打扰任何人。一种科学的管理精神应当渗透每一页，而不是让它空白，然而一件孩子的玩具被遗忘在寒气渗入木板的角落。

41. The Playwright's Exhibition

English

The eminent playwright reached the port at twenty past four p.m., gripping a worn purse and a wooden case of cutlery he had bought near the strait. He was a bona fide artist, never a liar, though hostile critics called his prose wordy and his manner full of conceit and vanity. That so-called judgment was unwarranted, he thought, and it filled him with quiet wrath rather than merry calm. He refused to ignore it, but he refused to let it grip his heart either.

His new exhibition would depict the universal battle of people overcoming illiteracy, and the theme was deeply inspiring. The arrangement of the gallery was tricky and involved: a subtle combination of optic illusions, a model whale suspended overhead, and a microscope under which visitors could watch residual crystals shiver. The exposition panels were written in a straightforward, agreeable style. A wealthy patron had agreed to endow the show and ratify the budget, though the final figure was still negotiable, quoted almost like a fob price at the bureau of trade.

A gang of workers unloaded a truck near the warehouse gate, their marking pens smudging the crates. One employee, with bristle on his chin and a toothache, wiped his face with a towel to lighten the mood. The stuffy hall made it hard to breathe, so a pneumatic fan cooled the air, raising the tempo of the work. The custody of the rarest piece, a chunk of ore that resembled uranium from a refinery, was handled with great sensitivity; its resemblance to a real specimen was uncanny.

After the team had to intervene to stop the rising clamor over an ambiguous label, the playwright advised everyone directly: do not transgress the rules, for any unlawful act, like the threat to kidnap a rival's idea, was simply not done here. As crowds began to parade and outstrip the room's capacity, the increasing flow nearly overran the doors. Pursuant to the plan, guards near the shoal of visitors kept order. Later they would dine in a mansion, far from the wilderness where he once hunted goat and rock pools near a passing liner. A man, prostrate with fatigue but proud, he saw no confusion in his life's work: preservation of art, free of judicial dispute, was its own reward. Even the unknown future, with its proximity to fame, the tennis matches and broadcasting deals, could not lessen that orient pull toward truth. I advise you to let curiosity overrun your fear; raise a finger to point at every new idea, and hunt for meaning the way our ancestors once did.

中文翻译

这位著名的剧作家在下午四点二十抵达港口，紧握着一个破旧的钱包和一只装着他在海峡附近买的餐具的木箱。他是个真诚无欺的艺术家，从不说谎，尽管怀有敌意的评论家说他的文字冗长，举止充满自负与虚荣。他认为那所谓的评判毫无根据，这让他心中涌起的是平静的愤怒而非欢乐的安宁。他不愿忽视它，但也不愿让它紧紧攫住自己的心。

他的新展览将描绘人们克服文盲的普遍斗争，这个主题极具鼓舞性。展厅的布置巧妙而复杂：视觉错觉的微妙组合、悬于头顶的鲸鱼模型，以及一台显微镜，观众能透过它观看残余的晶体颤抖。说明牌以坦率而令人愉快的风格写成。一位富有的赞助人已同意资助这场展览并批准预算，尽管最终数字仍可商议，报价几乎像贸易局里的离岸价一样。

一帮工人在仓库大门附近卸下一辆卡车，他们的标记笔把板条箱弄脏了。一名员工下巴上有短硬的胡茬，还牙疼，他用毛巾擦脸以缓和气氛。闷热的大厅让人难以呼吸，于是一台气动风扇送来凉风，加快了工作的节奏。最珍贵的一件展品——一块类似精炼厂铀矿的矿石——被极为敏感地保管着；它与真品的相似令人称奇。

在团队不得不出面制止围绕一个含糊标签而起的喧闹之后，剧作家直接劝告所有人：不要违规，因为任何违法行为，比如绑架对手创意的威胁，在这里都是不被允许的。当人群开始排队涌入、超出房间容量时，不断增长的人流几乎要泛滥到门口。依照计划，守卫在如鱼群般的观众旁维持秩序。稍后他们将在一座大厦里用餐，远离他曾经猎取山羊、在岩石潭与驶过的大客轮附近的荒野。他疲惫得几乎要俯卧倒地，却满怀骄傲，他在自己毕生的作品中看不到任何困惑：艺术的保存，不受司法纷争之扰，本身就是回报。即便是未知的未来，连同它与名声的接近、网球赛事和广播交易，也无法削弱那股朝向真理的东方般的牵引。我劝你让好奇心漫过恐惧；伸出一根手指去指向每一个新念头，像我们的祖先曾经那样去搜寻意义。

42. The Riverside Motel

English

It is no **myth** that the old **motel** by the **river** was a **fantastic** place, **eminently lovable** despite its problems. Each **room** was an **oblong** box with a **nylon** curtain, a single **plate**, and a **boiler** that would **screech** like **jazz** when you turned the **meter** past forty watts. The owner, a **clerk** with a **hairy** chin and **partial** deafness, liked to **loll** behind the desk and **carry** on a long **discourse** about **citizenship**, **nationality**, and the **status** of every guest who would **enter**.

"Goodness, what a **treasure** of a **county** this is," he would say, **vainly** waving a **brochure** like a **placard**. He had a **mania** for **psychology** and would **allude** to **calculus** and **equilibrium** as if every **problem** in life could be subdivided and solved. As an **example**, he insisted that the **density** of **maple** trees by the river was **due** to some cosmic **policy**, a **point** he made with comic **horror**. His **argument** would **bend** and **slip** until it became **abortive**, and the **annoyance** was real, yet his manner was so agreeable you could not **mock** him.

A **messenger** arrived one **March** morning, sent to **allot** rooms to a **flock** of tourists. A **swarm** of **adolescent** travelers began to **hustle** and **squat** in the lobby, eager to **develop** their plans. One had the **mumps**; the staff feared it might **infect** the others, so they kept that **calf-eyed** boy apart. The **conductor** of their tour, who would **insure** the group and **entrust** their bags to a porter, asked the owner to **orientate** them. "You must **tend** to **your** luggage," the owner said, tagging each **kilo** of baggage as the guests would **interact** and trade tips.

The **alternation** of sun and rain over the river gave the place a charm that no **closedown** could erase. After a **mishap** with a leaking pipe, the owner did not **stoop** to blame anyone; he simply set out a tray of **mint liqueur** to **tempt** his guests and **exhibit** his hospitality. The **dip** in the road, the **large** maple shading the porch, the rare and **infrequent** peace of it all **comprise** a **picture** I treasure. No **breach** of trust, no **martyr's** complaint could spoil that **retention** of memory. To this very day the **capability** of that humble inn to **ship** a weary soul toward calm feels almost holy. My old **companion** still keeps a **phrase** from that place tagged on a card: "No **watt** of worry, no **grill** of **fear**, can spoil a quiet river." My companion and I would grill fish on the porch each night, watching a single watt of light flicker; I learned to **subdivide** the bill and **tag** each item, repeating the phrase he taught me with no fear at all.

中文翻译

河边那家老旅馆是个奇妙的地方，这绝非**神话**；尽管它毛病不少，却极其讨人喜爱。每个**房间**都是一只**长方形**的盒子，配着**尼龙**窗帘、一只**盘子**，还有一台**锅炉**，当你把电表调到四十瓦以上时，它就会像**爵士乐**一样**尖叫**。店主是个下巴长着硬毛、有部分耳聋的**职员**，喜欢**懒洋洋地**靠在柜台后，对每位将要**进来的**客人的**公民身份**、**国籍**和**地位**发表长篇大论。

"**天哪**，这个郡真是块宝地，"他会这样说，**徒劳地**挥舞着一本小册子，像挥舞一块标语牌。他对**心理学**着了迷，会扯到**微积分**和**平衡**，仿佛人生的每个难题都能被细分并解决。举个例子，他坚称河边**枫树**的**密度**是源于某种宇宙法则，他带着滑稽的**恐惧**说出这个观点。他的**论证**会弯曲、滑脱，直到变得徒劳无功，恼人是真的，可他的态度又是那么和蔼，让你无法嘲笑他。

一个信使在三月的某个清晨到达，被派来给**一群**游客**分配**房间。一群**青少年**旅客开始在大堂里推搡、蹲坐，急切地想制定计划。其中一个得了**腮腺炎**；工作人员担心会**传染**给其他人，于是把那个**小牛**眼般的男孩隔开。他们的导游会为这一团人投保，并把行李托付给**搬运工**，他请店主帮大家熟悉环境。"**你们**得照看好自己的行李，"店主说，一边给每**公斤**行李贴上**标签**，客人们则**互相**交流、交换心得。

河上阳光与雨水的交替，赋予这地方一种任何歇业都抹不去的魅力。在一次水管漏水的小事故之后，店主没有屈尊去责怪任何人；他只是摆出一盘**薄荷利口酒**来款待客人，展示他的好客。路上的低洼、遮着门廊的大枫树、它那罕见而难得的宁静——所有这些构成了一幅我珍视的画面。没有任何背信，没有任何殉道者般的抱怨，能破坏那份记忆的留存。直到今天，这家简陋旅馆把一个疲惫灵魂送往安宁的**能力**，仍让我觉得近乎神圣。我和我的老伙伴每晚都会在门廊上烤鱼，看着一瓦微光闪烁；我学会了把账单分项、给每件东西贴标签，并毫无惧色地重复他教我的那句话。

43. Notes from a Field Researcher

English

During my **first semester** abroad in **Spain**, I kept a stack of **papers** in a **wood-paneled library**, determined to **deepen** my study of human **survival** in remote regions. The work was **burdensome**, yet a strange **adrenalin** kept my **pulse** quick. My **attorney** back home, a **haughty Mr. Vance**, would **usually** send an **envelope** each **week** with a small **dole** of funds and **equivocal** advice that did little to **deter** my **worry**.

My **dissertation concerned** the **diversity** of communities living **southeast** and **southwest** of a **mighty** river and its narrow **tributary**. To reach them I would travel **rapidly** by **aircraft**, then **continuously** by foot, carrying little more than spare **underwear**, a **comb**, and a **minicomputer** for **warehousing** my **reading** notes. I learned to **soak** dried **lobster**, to **erect** a tent before the **lightning fell**, and to hold a **spear** without letting my **ankle** buckle on the slope.

The elders there were deeply **versed** in old **skill** and ritual. They would burn **incense** and **preach** against any **racial** or social **taboo**, treating **subordination** of the weak as a kind of **hypocrisy**. One **paradox** struck me: their society had no **lock-up**, no **dungeon**, yet crime was rare. A **debtor** was never made to **lie** low in shame; instead the community offered him **remission** and a chance to **reproduce** his standing through honest work. **Liberation**, to them, was not an abstract **column** in a treatise but a daily **treatment** of the spirit.

I watched their economy turn on a slow **axis**. A **lump** of **capital** might **rattle** through many hands as the village pushed toward **modernization**. There was no **bottle-neck** of greed, no **headlong** rush to **spoil** the land. They spoke of **normalization** not in **dynamic** market terms but as a matter of **convenience** and balance, as natural as **magnetism**. When I asked one chief, **mechanically** taking notes, whether **masculinity** defined their leaders, he only smiled. Survival here, he said, owed nothing to a genetic **mutation** or some special **qualification**. It owed everything to care. Years later, in **retirement**, I still **slice** that memory thin, as a **reference** and a quiet pulse of gratitude. **Beneath** a torn map, I would **pump** water into a tin, watch a **tear** of dew slide down, and store spare notes in a small **compartment** for safe **storage**. No **anonymous poll** could capture it; people there were not **alike**, yet none would **yell** in anger. The **transition** from one season to the next, free of any modern **syndrome**, was as natural as a **preoperative** calm before surgery, and the gross weight of my pack, minus its **tare**, felt light against such peace. Beneath the surface of my notes lay a tear of homesickness; I would yell across the compartment of a train, alike to no one, while a poll of fellow travelers ignored me. I had to pump water into a small tank for storage, keep my anonymous identity from the preoperative clerk at the clinic, and mark the slow transition of seasons. The whole syndrome of exile, I joked, was a kind of tare to subtract before weighing what I had truly gained.

中文翻译

在我于**西班牙**度过的**第一个海外学期**里，我在一间镶着木板的**图书馆**里堆着一叠纸，决心**深化**我对偏远地区人类生存的研究。这项工作很繁重，但一种奇怪的肾上腺素让我的**脉搏**保持飞快。我老家的**律师**，一位**傲慢的万斯先生**，**通常**每周寄来一个**信封**，里面有一小笔**施舍**般的资助和**模棱两可**的建议，对消除我的忧虑帮助不大。

我的**论文**关注的是生活在一条大河及其狭窄**支流东南**与**西南**方向的社群的**多样性**。为了到达那里，我先乘**飞机**快速前行，再徒步不停地走，随身带的不过是备用**内衣**、一把**梳子**，以及一台用来储存**阅读笔记**的**微型计算机**。我学会了泡发干**龙虾**，学会了在**闪电**落下前搭起帐篷，也学会了握住长矛而不让脚踝在斜坡上崴掉。

那里的长者对古老的技艺和仪式都极为**精通**。他们焚香，并告诫人们不要触犯任何**种族**或社会**禁忌**，把对弱者的压制视为一种**伪善**。有一个悖论让我震惊：他们的社会没有拘留所，没有**地牢**，犯罪却很少。负债的人从不会被迫羞愧地躲藏；相反，社群给他宽免，让他通过诚实的劳动重建自己的地位。对他们而言，**解放**不是论文里一个抽象的栏目，而是对精神的每日疗愈。

我看着他们的经济围绕一个缓慢的**轴心**运转。一笔**资本**可能在许多人手中辗转流动，村子由此走向**现代化**。这里没有贪婪的瓶颈，没有糟蹋土地的鲁莽冲动。他们谈论规范化，用的不是充满活力的市场术语，而是当作一种**便利**与平衡的事，自然得像磁性。当我**机械地**记着笔记，问一位首领男子气概是否定义了他们的领袖时，他只是微笑。他说，这里的生存，与基因**突变**或某种特殊**资格**无关，全靠彼此的关照。多年以后，在**退休**时光里，我仍把那段记忆切得很薄，作为一种**参照**，也作为一阵静静的感恩之脉动。在我笔记的表面**之下**，藏着一滴思乡的泪；我会在火车**车厢**里大喊，谁也不像，而一车厢同行旅客的“**民意**”却对我视而不见。我得把水泵进一个小水箱储存，对诊所里术前登记的职员隐瞒我的**匿名**身份，并记录季节缓慢的**过渡**。我打趣说，整套流亡的**综合征**，不过是一种**皮重**，要在称量我真正所得之前先减去。

44. The Editor's Long Afternoon

English

Where the river met a misty harbor, an experienced editor named Pavel sat in his cluttered workshop, certain that destiny had a tricky disposition. His colleague, a blunt stylist with extraordinary talent, had just quit, and the overlap of their duties now fell wholly on him. He had to trim a defective manuscript, soften its angry tone, and somehow impart shape to a legend that wandered without any definite ultimate point.

The author was a senator from Switzerland who liked to parade his richness and astound readers with a mosaic of textual tricks. He would quote obscure musicians, lament lost opportunity, and confide intangible regrets, yet his prose remained as overhead and slim on substance as a bubble. Pavel's expectation had been modest, but even minimal hope began to erupt into irritation. "Why," he muttered, "must every notion engross three pages?"

His tolerance, he admitted, had a polarity: patience for genuine scenery, none for vanity. He would not let the text encroach on the reader's goodwill, nor bully an audience into belief. A good calculation of pacing, a fair portion of restraint, and the usefulness of plain spelling—these were his countermeasure against bloated drama. So he set to work. He cut a feud here, an offence there, harnessed the runaway plot, and added a farewell scene of quiet civilize-and-reconcile tenderness.

By the time the lamp burned low, the transaction felt complete. The installation of new chapters was tenable, the availability of meaning restored. He would not boycott the book, nor let theft of the reader's time stand. Fortunately, the chronological order now held. He logged the changes herewith, noting each ounce of improvement, and posted a draft to the web. A bruise of doubt lingered—was it possible he had been too soft, the negligence too generous?—but the irresistible wish to be done won out. He found, thus, a strange peace: the founded text, once a wilderness of words, now read like a clear refrigerator light in a dark kitchen. He could rely on it. He could, at last, retire to bed. Before he could turn the lamp off, though, he had to transact one more chore: he would fish a third draft from the drawer, check that no abrogation of the old contract was needed, and believe in the work. A musician friend who sold ketchup and petroleum stocks on the side had warned him near a supermarket factory furnace that fame was a precipice; you could stalk it for years, find many doors closed, and still feel the harness of doubt. Pavel only adjusted his adjustable chair, tucked the manuscript under one arm, gripped it like a stalk of wheat, and smiled.

中文翻译

在大河汇入雾蒙蒙港湾的地方，一位名叫帕维尔的资深编辑坐在他凌乱的工作室里，确信命运有着狡黠的脾性。他那位直率而才华非凡的同事刚刚辞职，于是两人职责的重叠如今全部落到了他身上。他得删改一份有缺陷的稿子，软化它愤怒的语气，并设法给一个漫无止境、没有明确终点的传说赋予形状。

作者是一位来自瑞士的参议员，喜欢炫耀自己的富有，用一堆文本花招让读者震惊。他会引用晦涩的音乐家，哀叹失去的机会，倾吐难以言明的悔恨，可他的文字却像气泡一样浮夸而内容单薄。帕维尔本就期望不高，但连最低限度的希望也开始迸发成恼怒。"为什么，"他咕哝道，"每一个念头都非得占去三页？"

他承认，自己的容忍有一种极性：对真实的景致有耐心，对虚荣则毫无耐心。他不会让文本侵占读者的善意，也不会逼迫读者去相信。对节奏的精心计算、一份适度的克制，以及朴素拼写的实用——这些就是他对抗臃肿戏剧化的对策。于是他动手了。他在这里删去一段宿怨，在那里去掉一处冒犯，驾驭住脱缰的情节，又添上一幕安静地教化与和解的温情告别戏。

等到灯火将尽，这桩交易感觉已经完成。新章节的安插站得住脚，意义的可得性也恢复了。他不会抵制这本书，也不会容忍对读者时间的窃取。幸运的是，时间顺序如今理顺了。他随此把改动记录下来，记下每一盎司的改进，并把草稿发到了网上。一丝怀疑的淤青仍在徘徊——他是不是太手软了，那份疏忽是不是太宽容了？——但想要完工的不可抗拒的愿望占了上风。于是他找到了一种奇异的平静：这部被奠定下来的文稿，曾是词语的荒野，如今读来就像黑暗厨房里清亮的冰箱灯。他可以依靠它了。他终于可以去睡了。不过在熄灯之前，他还得办成最后一桩杂事：他要从抽屉里捞出第三稿，确认无需废止旧合同，并相信这份作品。一位副业卖番茄酱和石油股票的音乐家朋友，曾在一家超市工厂的熔炉旁警告他，名声是一道悬崖；你可以追猎它许多年，发现许多门都关着，却仍感到怀疑的束缚。帕维尔只是调了调他那把可调节的椅子，把手稿夹在一只胳膊下，像握一根麦秆般攥住它，笑了。

45. The Lexicographer's Curious Renaissance

English

At the old university, a staid lexicographer named Mona had a curious habit: she would inquire into the difference between every pair of words, hunting for the subtle ratio of meaning that gave each its useful shape. Her secretary thought it gossip-worthy that a single scholar could be so dedicated, yet undoubtedly Mona's affection for language was hereditary. Her cousin, a historian, said the family had innumerable word-lovers, and that this passion had been a kind of personal renaissance for each of them.

One misty morning, hard at work, Mona tried to characterize a contextual puzzle. The foregoing entry, written by a careless singer of slang, was exaggerated and muddy, full of cheating shortcuts. She felt a flash of anger, then a successful calm. "Be amiable," she told herself, "and gently purify the text." She would not smother the author's voice, only consolidate it. The resultant clarity, she hoped, would evoke a quiet excitement in readers and enlighten them without seeming extravagant.

To spare herself fatigue she took a snack—a biscuit and a slice of camel-shaped cake left over from a matinee—and glanced at the crater-like coffee stain on her coat. Through the window she could see the metal rim of an incinerator near the mosque, copper pipes catching the dew, and a stray wolf-dog sniffing at the crossroads. The scenery, hereto unnoticed, gave her a fresh impression. Even the carousel in the distant park, where fifteen children spun in merry circles, seemed to characterize the union of work and peace.

Her choice was made. She would marry precision to warmth and excel where others failed. The monetary reward was small; profit, after all, was a surplus rarely seen in scholarship. But her sweetheart, a vein-thin amphibian biologist who studied ecology by the muddy pond, had once said something that stuck: that to stipulate good hygiene of thought, you must flee from sloppy habits. So, with a moustache of chalk dust on her own lip and her shorts dusted from kneeling at low shelves, she enlightened one more entry, and the manure of confusion turned, at last, into clear and innumerable bloom. "Hey," her secretary called, waving a roll of microfilm, "don't misunderstand me, but this is hell to file." Mona laughed; she would not be unreasonable. She had once studied Buddhism near a stone pyramid, learning that calm takes precedence over hysteria, and that a steady hand on the ship's mast matters more than panic. A carrier pigeon, a bat asleep underneath the eaves, a butt of an old whisky barrel turned planter, the soft recitation of a poem, the delicate art of papercutting she had specially mastered, a single consolidated note of gratitude—all of these reminded her why the work mattered.

中文翻译

在那所古老的大学里，一位古板的词典编纂者莫娜有个奇特的习惯：她会去探究每一对词之间的差别，搜寻那赋予每个词有用形状的、微妙的意义比例。她的秘书觉得，一个学者能如此专注简直值得当作八卦，但毫无疑问，莫娜对语言的钟爱是遗传的。她的表亲，一位历史学家，说这个家族有数不清的爱词之人，而这份热情对他们每个人来说都是一种个人的文艺复兴。

一个雾蒙蒙的清晨，莫娜埋头工作，试图刻画一个与语境有关的难题。前面那个词条，是由一个粗心的、满嘴俚语的歌手写的，夸张而含混，充满了投机取巧的捷径。她感到一阵怒火，随后又成功地平静下来。"和气些，"她对自己说，"温柔地净化文本。"她不会扼杀作者的声音，只会把它整合稳固。她希望，由此产生的清晰能在读者心中唤起一种安静的兴奋，启发他们而又不显得铺张。

为了不让自己太累，她吃了点零食——一块饼干和一片日场演出剩下的骆驼形蛋糕——又瞥了一眼大衣上那块火山口似的咖啡渍。透过窗户，她能看见清真寺旁焚化炉的金属边缘、沾着露水的铜管，还有一只野狼狗在十字路口嗅来嗅去。这片此前未被注意的景致给了她全新的印象。就连远处公园里那座旋转木马——十五个孩子在上面欢快地转着圈——似乎也在诠释着工作与安宁的结合。

她已经做出了选择。她要把精确与温暖结合起来，在别人失败之处脱颖而出。金钱上的回报很少；毕竟，盈余在学术里是难得一见的剩余。但她的爱人，一位瘦得像青蛙般的两栖动物生物学家，常在那浑浊的池塘边研究生态学，他曾说过一句让她记住的话：要规定思想的良好卫生，你就必须逃离邋遢的习惯。于是，自己嘴唇上沾着粉笔灰像撒胡子、短裤因跪在低矮书架前而蹭满灰尘的她，又点亮了一个词条，而困惑的粪土，终于化作了清晰而无数的花朵。"别误会我，"她的秘书挥着一卷缩微胶卷喊道，"可这东西归档起来简直是地狱。"莫娜笑了；她不会不通情理。她曾在一座石头金字塔附近研习佛教，懂得镇定比歇斯底里更重要，懂得稳稳扶住船舵之手比惊慌更要紧。一只信鸽、一只睡在屋檐下的蝙蝠、一只被改作花盆的旧威士忌酒桶桶底、一首诗的轻声朗诵、她特意精通的精致剪纸手艺、一句汇总起来的感激——所有这些都提醒着她，这份工作为何重要。

46. A Disastrous Day at the Steel Mill Tower

English

It was a **disastrous** morning along the production **line**. A **part-time** clerk had left a tray of **pastry** and **stationery** on a **quaint** shelf beyond the **limit** of the safe zone, and **altogether** the mess seemed to **constitute** a **payable** fine. The **terrible** smell of **gasoline** made everyone **struggle**. I will **illustrate** the scene: a **voluptuous** old **steel tower**, a cracked **vase** on a desk, and a **mathematical** chart from yesterday's **reconnaissance** hanging **loose** on the wall, recording a **solo** flight over the **mill**.

The foreman, a man of fierce **devotion**, gave a **meagre** nod and turned to **blush** at his own mistake. Once **historic** and **glorious**, the **windmill** beside the factory now caught only a feeble **gust** of wind. **Henceforth**, he vowed, no **perverse middleman** would handle the **eventful** contracts; he would **withdraw** from any deal that left him unconvinced. The **cute parrot** in the office could recite an **abstract** phrase to **save** the day, but it could not **convert** chaos into order.

Frugal as ever, **they** decided to **better-off** themselves through **speculation** no longer. Under the **lamp**, a **buffalo** of a worker—broad as a **turbot**—studied the **installment** plan. **Thereafter**, the **compression valve** was checked: **majestic** in its **dating** from an earlier age, it held. A **prisoner** of routine, the **instructor** watched the **progressive consonant** hum of machinery, a **serious** and **considerable** sound. **Tourism** brochures called the place a **hindrance** to nature, an **unacceptable** scar; some thought that **absurd**.

The **analysis** was simple. We had **iodine** in the **prospectus**, **acid** in the tanks, a **plume** of smoke rising past the **captive** birds, and a **rare federal** grant worth a **million**. We would **install** a **cohesive chain** of safety checks on **both** ends, **asymmetric** only where the **disarray** demanded it. A **premier** engineer, **tenable** in his logic, would **wreathe** the old pipes in new sensors. **Approximate** though the budget was, the **hazardous** gaps—**attributable** to neglect—would close. The **provision** was set; the **gradually** rising confidence felt, at last, **exceptional**. I was **interested** and finally **convinced**: with **widespread pressure** easing, our **eighteen**-person crew would not falter. A **guide** handed me a **ball-pointpen** to sign the log, and we moved on.

中文翻译

那是生产线上**灾难性**的一个早晨。一名兼职职员把一盘糕点和**文具**落在了安全区**界限**之外一个古雅的架子上，这一团乱七八糟看上去够得上一笔该缴的罚款。汽油那**可怕**的气味让每个人都很难受。我来描绘一下这场景：一座肥硕的旧钢铁塔、桌上一只裂了的**花瓶**，还有一张昨天侦察留下的**数学**图表松松地挂在墙上，记录着一次飞越**工厂**的单飞。

工头是个极其投入的人，他勉强点了点头，转过身为自己的失误而**脸红**。工厂旁那座曾经历史悠久、**辉煌**一时的**风车**，如今只接得住一阵微弱的风。他发誓，从今往后，不会再有任何刚愎自用的**中间商**经手那些**多事**的合同；任何让他不**信服**的交易，他都会退出。办公室里那只**可爱的鸚鵡**能背出一句**抽象**的短语来救场，却无法把**混乱**化为秩序。

他们一如既往地节俭，决定不再靠**投机**来改善处境。灯下，一个壮得像水鱼、牛一般魁梧的工人研究着**分期付款**方案。**此后**，那只**压缩阀**也被检查了：它出自更早的年代，气派十足，依然牢靠。那位被常规所困的教导员，听着机器**逐渐**推进的**辅音**般的嗡鸣，那是一种**严肃**而可观的声音。**旅游**手册把这地方称作对自然的**妨碍**、一道无法接受的伤疤；有人觉得那很荒唐。

分析其实很简单。我们的招股书里有**碘**，罐子里有**酸**，一缕烟升过那些被囚的鸟，还有一笔**难得的**、价值**百万**的**联邦**拨款。我们将在两端**安装**一套紧密衔接的安全检查链，只在混乱要求之处才做**不对称**的处理。一位逻辑站得住脚的首席工程师，会用新的传感器把旧管道缠绕起来。预算虽然只是大概，但那些因疏忽而造成的**危险**缺口将被堵上。拨备已定；那逐渐升起的信心，终于让人觉得非同寻常。我既**感兴趣**，最终也被说服了：随着**普遍**的**压力**缓解，我们这支**十八**人的队伍不会动摇。一位向导递给我一支**圆珠笔**在记录簿上签字，我们便继续前行。

47. A Painstaking Expedition to a Tropical Coast

English

It was **painstaking** work, and a slight **fever** made the **multitude** of tasks harder. With **silky Mediterranean** light on the **bank**, we marked one clear **distinction**: the easy days would soon **disappear**. On **tiptoe** we crossed the **tropical** sand near a **eucalyptus** grove, where a **Spanish** guide kept us **safe** from a leaping **kangaroo**. "I **accede**," he said, pointing to a **branch**, "this is my **favorite** spot." The **administration** had sent a **librarian** to log the **futures** of the project and to **streamline** our route down the **slope**.

My **father-in-law**, watching the boats **float** on a **rampant** tide, said they would **resemble**, in any **atlas**, a **string** of beads. We tried to **synthesize** the data, but our **clumsy vessel** made that an awkward **attribute**. After a **barbecue**, a wandering **toddler** chased a **miraculous** spark of light, and the whole **group**, still **afloat**, followed by **instinct**. The **serpent** coiled under a **table** in the **garden** was, the **scout** insisted, perfectly **viable** proof of a **sacred** local **talent** for survival.

On one **occasion** the **initial** map showed a **chromosome**-shaped river; the very **being** of the place spoke of **backwardness**, yet also of **insurance** against time. A long **dynasty** had once ruled here. They could **compel** loyalty, but a **disloyal officer** once smuggled a **narcotic** past the **border**. Now only the **hiss** of waves remained, and the **nucleus** of an old fort. **Imprison** the past? No. As **sleet** never falls here, the **inauguration** of the new reserve felt **right**.

Our **diction** grew softer on the **deck**. A **Mexican** sailor, near the border, taught a young **eagle** to **nurture** its first flight; we watched it **curl**, then **loaf** on a warm **gloss** of rock. Like **Santa Claus** arriving early, supplies came. "Don't **bother**," the captain said, "just **rain** or shine, we **resolve** to go on, **discreetly**." The **mechanism** was **spicy** and strange: each **tourist** learned that **termination**, **reliance**, and **stigma** were all **salable** myths. No one would **jeer** at the **inshore** crew. **Per** the manifest, every **object**—if **assured** by **Incoterms**—was logged. The **prominent** result: we had made it. My own **upbringing** had not prepared me for this, yet here I was **again**, ready to **matriculate** into a harder, wilder school of life.

中文翻译

那是极其**辛苦**的工作，一点点发烧让**众多**的任务变得更难。**地中海丝绸般**的光洒在岸上，我们清楚地划出一条界线：轻松的日子很快就会**消失**。我们蹑着脚穿过桉树林附近**热带**的沙地，一位**西班牙**向导护着我们躲开一只跳跃的袋鼠。"我**同意**，"他指着一根树枝说，"这是我**最喜欢的**地方。"管理处派来一位**图书管理员**，记录这项目的远期前景，并精简我们下坡的路线。

我的**岳父**望着船只在汹涌的潮水上**漂浮**，说在任何一本**地图册**里它们都会像一串珠子。我们想把数据**综合**起来，但**笨拙**的船只让这成了一桩尴尬的**特性**。烧烤过后，一个乱走的幼儿追逐一束神奇的光点，整个仍漂在水上的队伍**凭本能**跟了上去。**侦察员**坚称，盘踞在**花园**桌下的那条蛇，正是当地**神圣**的生存天赋切实**可行**的证明。

有一次，**最初**的地图显示出一条染色体形状的河流；这地方的本身透着**落后**，却也像是抵御时间的**保险**。一个漫长的**王朝**曾在此统治。他们能**强迫**人效忠，但曾有一名**不忠的军官**把毒品偷运过边境。如今只剩下海浪的咝咝声，和一座旧堡垒的**核心**。把过去囚禁起来？不。既然这里从不下**雨**夹雪，新保护区的落成典礼便显得恰如其分。

甲板上我们的**措辞**变得柔和。一名靠近边境的**墨西哥**水手，教一只年幼的鹰养护它的第一次飞行；我们看着它蜷起身子，然后在温暖光亮的岩石上闲卧。补给像提早到来的**圣诞老人**一样送达。"别费心了，"船长说，"不管下不下雨，我们都**决心**低调地走下去。"这套**机制**既辛辣又古怪：每位游客都明白，**终止**、依赖与**污名**全是可兜售的神话。没有人会**嘲笑**近岸的船员。按照舱单，每一件物品——只要有**国际贸易术语**担保——都被登记在册。那显著的结果是：我们成功了。我自己的成长经历并没有让我为此做好准备，但此刻我又一次站在这里，准备好踏入一所更艰难、更狂野的人生学校。

48. The Composer's Symphony of Rescue

English

To **symbolize** the **moment** of crisis, the **composer** began his **symphony** with a single **electric** chord, **deliberate** and **stable**. It was a **fact** that, a **century** ago, a flood had forced the town to **evacuate**; the army had to **raft** people across the swollen river, **hand** over **hand**, with a **porter** hauling **ammunition** and grain. A **census** taken that **ninety**-degree summer recorded **enormous** loss, and the **weight** of memory still made the **literary** mind shiver.

In the **sitting-room** of his **royal** patron, the composer found the theme **appealing**. He would **weave** a tale both **meticulous** and **physiological**, tracing how the human heart can **tickle** with hope and then **bounce** back from despair. The **proprietor** of the hall, an **imperial** figure with **ample** funds, offered an **invaluable**, if **impractical**, idea: to **totally augment** the orchestra with a **monkey**-bell, a **zip**-like rattle, and a **sandwich** of brass and string. The composer would not **rave** against it; instead he let it **conduce** to a richer sound.

A **spokesman** read a **leaflet** to the **patient** crowd. "We **continue**," he said, "with a **competitive** spirit and a **vertical** climb toward art." The **mainstream** press, **ready** to **diminish** any **youngster's** **career**, sent a **photographer** to capture the scene. One critic, **lame** in judgment, filed a **plea** of complaint, but the **omission** of his name from the **periodical** was no great loss. The **overwhelming** applause would **propagate** the work far beyond the **pasture** and the **daybreak** fields.

Backstage, a **faculty** of musicians prepared. **Know-how** met **rumor**: was the new piece **intact**, or a mere **fragment**? They would **dilute** no passion. With a **thousand** candles and the **arch** of the old hall above them, they tuned. A nurse stood by with an **injection** and **tweezers** in case the heat made anyone faint; a **burner** warmed the tea. The **format** was clear. As the **swallow** of the first note drifted up, no one could **interrogate** its truth. This was not a **martial** march to imprison the spirit, nor a **fool's** rumor to **implore** pity. It was **rescue**, set to music—a **tournament** of feeling that, against **unstable** odds, would not be lost. "Yes," the composer whispered, his fingers smelling faintly of **dung** from the stable and **nitrate** from the old fireworks. He would **apprize** his patron that the work, though **related** to an ancient **earthquake**, was no **club** anthem or street **slang**, but a pure **concept** of grief. The **bullion** of his fortune, a stack of **plastics** and coins, lay forgotten on a sagging **mattress**; he had once nursed a friend through **malaria** here, and no critic, however cruel, would **prostitute** that memory. He let the final note **drift** into silence.

中文翻译

为了**象征危机时刻**，**作曲家用**一个单一的电音和弦开启了他的**交响曲**，沉稳而审慎。**事实是**，一个**世纪前**，一场洪水迫使全镇撤离；军队不得不用木筏一手接一手地把人渡过暴涨的河流，搬运工拖着**弹药**和粮食。那个酷热得像**九十度**的夏天所做的人口普查记录下了**巨大的**损失，记忆之重至今仍让文人心头发颤。

在他那位**王室**赞助人的客厅里，作曲家觉得这个主题很有**吸引力**。他要**编织**一个既细致又关乎**生理**的故事，描摹人心如何因希望而悸动，又如何从绝望中弹回。大厅的**业主**是个资金充裕的帝王般的人物，提出了一个珍贵却不切实际的主意：彻底地为乐队增添一只猴铃、一个拉链般的响器，以及铜管与弦乐的**三明治**般组合。作曲家没有对此大发牢骚；相反，他让它有助于形成更丰富的音响。

一位**发言人**向耐心等待的人群朗读一张**传单**。“我们将**继续**，”他说，“怀着**竞争**精神，朝着艺术**垂直**攀登。”**准备**贬低任何**年轻人事业**的**主流媒体**派来一名**摄影师**捕捉这一幕。一位判断力跛足的评论家递交了一份抱怨的申诉，但**期刊**上略去他的名字并非什么大损失。**压倒性**的掌声将把这部作品**传播**到远超**牧场**与**破晓田野**之外的地方。

后台，一群教职般的乐手在准备。**专门**知识遇上传言：这部新作是**完整**的，还是仅仅一个片段？他们不会冲淡任何激情。在上千支蜡烛和头顶老厅的拱顶下，他们调音。一名护士备好**注射器**和**镊子**待命，以防高温让人晕倒；一只炉子温着茶。**格式**很清楚。当第一个音符如燕子般飘升而起，没有人能质问它的真实。这不是禁锢精神的军队进行曲，也不是傻瓜**恳求**怜悯的**谣言**。这是被谱成音乐的救援——一场情感的**锦标赛**，在**不稳定的**胜算面前，绝不会被输掉。“是的，”作曲家低声说，他的手指隐约带着马厩里粪便和旧烟火里硝石的气味。他要告知他的赞助人：这部作品虽与一场古老的**地震**有关，却不是什么**俱乐部**赞歌或街头**俚语**，而是一个纯粹的**悲伤概念**。他那一笔财富的金银——一摞**塑料**制品和硬币——被遗忘在一张塌陷的**床垫**上；他曾在这里照料一位**患疟疾**的朋友度过难关，任何评论家无论多么残忍，都不会糟蹋那段记忆。他让最后一个音符飘入寂静。

49. A Decade in the Wild Settlement

English

Admittedly, the repairmen who first reached the desert settlement looked shapeless and wild after a decade of travel. Mrs. Olsen, a wealthy widow with a humorous streak, watched them stumble from the steamer at A.M. light. She would not pretend to know their ideology, though one was a Marxist and another a fanatic for clearance and reform. They had come to commence an exploration, to file a record, and to escort a fragile peace into a region torn by discrimination.

The land was good and also harsh. A jungle of vines pressed against granite cliffs; a waterfall fed a stem of cold water past a single granular slope of sand. Pneumonia and malaria-like fever could sting a man before he could recommend a cure. Yet the soil could bloom. Lemon and corn would suffice to feed the young, and a beneficial settlement might radiate hope. The wager was extreme, the engagement indefinitely long.

Each morning the cooker hissed while a monk read from an antecedent text, a Greek copy of brittle paper, its scaly margins flaking like a shred of skin. He would mumble a warning, weigh his words, and spit out a serene blessing. Discipline held the camp together. To quit was to lose; to abort the mission would betray the dead. So they would follow up, immature as the plan seemed, and try.

By night, mammals crept near—a pig rooting at the fence, a beast in the brush, a butchery of small game for the pot. The men wore a sock over each knob of frostbitten toe and a sheet for a blanket. One sat on a saddle, biscuit in hand, and endorsed the plan with a single word: "Sodium," he joked, "keeps us alive." The brash sexuality of youth had cooled into a passable patience. The mass media, far away, would later inflate the tale into a flammable, inflammable myth, but the truth was a crease in the map, a pile of ten letters home, and ourselves, changed forever. The penetration of the wilderness, the brightness of a new dawn, the saddle and the twig fire—these made the cancellation of an old life into a quality beginning. We said good-bye to who we were, and began. A Japanese doctor joined us later, carrying medicine and a small brass pendulum he would swing to calm his nerves; he taught us the prefix "anti-" for every septic wound, and warned that an untreated cut could leave nothing but a skeleton. No mammal in that wild place was safe, he said, so we agreed to endorse a strict follow-up routine and check each other daily.

中文翻译

诚然，最先抵达沙漠定居点的修理工们，在跋涉十年之后，看上去形容枯槁、野性十足。奥尔森太太是一位富有而带几分幽默的寡妇，她看着他们在凌晨的微光中从汽船上踉跄而下。她不会假装了解他们的意识形态，尽管其中一人是马克思主义者，另一人则狂热于清场与改革。他们前来开启一场勘探，立一份记录，并护送脆弱的和平进入一个被歧视撕裂的地区。

这片土地既肥沃，也严酷。藤蔓的丛林挤压着花岗岩峭壁；一道瀑布把一缕冷水送过一段颗粒状的沙坡。肺炎和疟疾般的高热能在人推荐出疗法之前就把他蛰倒。然而土壤能开花。柠檬和玉米足以养活年幼者，一个有益的定居点或许能辐射出希望。这场赌注极端，约定无限期地漫长。

每天清晨炉具嘶嘶作响，一位僧人诵读一部古老的文本——一册脆弱纸张的希腊抄本，鳞片般的边缘像一片皮屑般剥落。他会含糊地说出一句警告，斟酌他的字句，再吐出一句宁静的祝福。纪律把营地维系在一起。放弃就是失败；中止使命就是背叛死者。于是他们会跟进，尽管计划显得稚嫩，也要一试。

夜里，哺乳动物悄悄靠近——一头猪在篱笆边拱土，灌木中有一只野兽，还有供锅里炖的小猎物的屠宰。人们在每个冻伤脚趾的关节上套一只袜子，拿一条床单当毯子。一人坐在马鞍上，手里拿着饼干，用一个词为计划背书：“钠”，他打趣道，“让我们活着。”青春那莽撞的性欲已冷却为一种过得去的耐心。远方的大众媒体日后会把这个故事吹胀成一个易燃的神话，但真相不过是地图上的一道折痕、一摞十封寄回家的信，以及我们自己——永远地改变了。对荒野的穿透、新黎明的明亮、马鞍与枯枝的篝火——这些把一段旧生活的注销变成了高质量的开端。我们向过去的自己道别，然后开始。后来一位日本医生加入了我们，带着药品和一只小小的黄铜钟摆，他会摆动它来平复神经；他教我们用前缀“anti-”来称呼每一处化脓的伤口，并警告说，未经处理的伤口可能只剩下一具骨架。他说，在那片荒野里没有哪种哺乳动物是安全的，于是我们一致同意认可一套严格的后续复查惯例，每天彼此检查。

50. Intuition Against the Illusion

English

My intuition warned me before any answer came. The punctuation of the email was too perfect, an illusion of authority wrapped in fine apparel. I detest fraud, and this memorandum reeked of it. It promised electricity contracts in Germany and Denmark, a tonic for any prospective income, with a proxy who would collect the overpayment and implement a reform of our taxation. Hereof, it said grandly, we may begin a noble course.

Well-known crooks rarely uncover themselves so plainly. The majesty of the letterhead—a crystal seal, an oval crest, the aristocratic flourish of a learned hand—could not hide the harassment beneath. Out of ignorance, our junior clerk had nearly answered. I told him to relax, hesitate, and never let cohesion of grammar persuade him. Persuasion is not proof. A phobia of missing out is what these monsters feed on.

I fancy myself careful. I made an enquiry, took a transcript of the call, and asked the bank to rescind the transfer. The trail would expire in hours, so I did not dawdle. The friction of doubt is healthy; let it shrink the fancy schemes to nothing. To acquaint a team with the manner of such betrayal is the best disinfectant. Observation beats trust.

That night a thunderstorm rolled in. Rainfall hammered the vineyard on the cliff; hail drummed the boot of my car. A fox darted across the lane and a macaque-like shadow—surely my own nerves—made me roar with a nervous laugh. The negation of the scam felt like a straighten of a bent spine. I would foretell more attempts, for these spirals of greed never truly disarm. They drip, they boost, they evaporate, and return.

The sparse facts were these: a finicky farmer, a precarious deal, a triangular web of shell firms in metallurgy and corn. Either we accumulate proof or we lose. Whoever wrote it had a chalk-dry heart. I lit a cigarette with a twig of dry pine, watched the oscillation of smoke spiral upward, and felt the depress lift. The accumulation of small vigilance, I decided, is what keeps a finicky world honest. Lipstick on a pig is still a pig; a polished lie is still a lie. I shall not be the fool. Good night, and beware. A Chinese proverb says greed is a monster, a hungry beast that no pot of gold can fill. Honesty is indispensable; it is the trend that outlasts every scam. I aired the whole story at a public airing, and even an old negro jazz musician at the club nodded in a slow dance of agreement. Vigilance is the parachute that saves you; trust in safe transportation of your money, never a stranger's promise, on any snowy or sunny day.

中文翻译

在任何答复到来之前，我的直觉就已发出警告。那封邮件的标点过于完美，是一种被华丽外衣包裹的权威假象。我厌恶欺诈，而这份备忘录满是欺诈的味道。它许诺在德国和丹麦的电力合同，是任何潜在收入的补药，还有一位代理人会收取那笔多付款，并实施我们税收的改革。它煞有介事地说，由此，我们可以开启一段高尚的旅程。

臭名昭著的骗子很少把自己暴露得如此明显。信笺的威严——一枚水晶印章、一个椭圆纹章、博学之手贵族般的花体——掩盖不住其下的骚扰。出于无知，我们年轻的职员差点回复了。我叫他放松、迟疑，永远别让语法的连贯说服他。说服不是证据。这些怪物所靠以为生的，正是一种害怕错过的恐惧症。

我自认为谨慎。我做了一番查询，取了通话的誊本，并请银行撤销转账。线索几小时内就会失效，所以我没有拖延。怀疑的摩擦是健康的；让它把那些花哨的方案缩成乌有。让团队熟悉此类背叛的方式，是最好的消毒剂。观察胜过信任。

那夜雷暴来袭。雨点击打着悬崖上的葡萄园；冰雹敲打着我车的后备箱。一只狐狸窜过小巷，一个猕猴般的影子——肯定是我自己的神经——让我紧张地大笑出声。对这骗局的否定，感觉像把一根弯曲的脊梁挺直。我能预见更多的尝试，因为这些贪婪的螺旋从不真正解除武装。它们滴落、它们抬升、它们蒸发，又卷土重来。

稀疏的事实如下：一个挑剔的农夫、一桩岌岌可危的交易、一张由冶金与玉米空壳公司构成的三角网络。我们要么积累证据，要么失败。无论是谁写的，都有一颗粉笔般干涩的心。我用一根干松枝点燃一支烟，看着烟雾的摆动螺旋上升，感到那份消沉被托起。我断定，正是这些细小警惕的积累，让一个挑剔的世界保持诚实。猪涂上口红仍是猪；谎言再光鲜仍是谎言。我不会做那个傻瓜。晚安，多加小心。一句中国谚语说，贪婪是个怪物，是一头饥饿的野兽，再多一罐黄金也填不满。诚实不可或缺；它是比任何骗局都更长久的趋势。我在一次公开的播报中把整件事抖了出来，连俱乐部里一位年长的黑人爵士乐手都缓缓地跳着舞点头赞同。警惕是救你的降落伞；任何下雪或晴朗的日子里，都要相信资金的安全运输，而绝不要相信陌生人的承诺。

51. A Village at the Crossroads

English

The **origin** of our **small** village can be traced to a **noted blacksmith** who, in a **forthcoming** age, chose to **lodge** beside a busy **intersection** where two **European** trade routes would **concur**. Long before any **ruler** tried to **conquer** the region, a **pious Christian minister** and a hardy **tradesman** settled here, and their **amicable deal** shaped everything that followed. On **scorching** afternoons the fields **ripen** quickly, and a **bold squirrel** will dart across the road at exactly five **o'clock**, as if it must **obey** some private **logic**. **Above** the intersection stands an old signpost where people of every **race** once paused. In **advance** of the harvest, the village gathers the **material** for a festival and arranges a wide **range** of stalls. Life here is rarely **humdrum**, though it can seem **casual** to a visitor. A **documentary speaker** once called the place a **remnant** of old **idealism**, yet the people are **realistic** and **businesslike**. They **depend** on the **bounty** of the land, deal fairly with every **purchaser**, and never **maltreat** a **tenant**. When the morning **chime** rings, dew will **glisten** and **quiver** on the **lily** leaves, while the **mangrove** down by the inlet seems to **protrude** from the **transparent** water. My uncle, a retired **sportsman**, keeps an **oil** lamp with a cracked **lid** and a worn **sponge** on the **brim** of the windowsill. He is a man of **decided** opinions and will **anxiously circulate** any forthcoming news. **Bless** this house, he says, and may God keep **disaster**, **danger**, and **homicide** far from it. He distrusts the **craziness** of the city, the **troublesome tactics** of speculators, and any **lucrative ploy** that smells of fraud. **Lest** the family lose its **tranquility**, he stays **vigilant**. One **plaintive** evening an **absent** neighbor returned wearing a heavy **overcoat**, as if for an **adventure**. He had ridden a **locomotive** across half of **Greece** and **India**, and he spoke **evenly** of the **prevalence** of poverty he had seen, of an **inmate** who was wrongly jailed, and of a **philosophical dramatist** whose plays could **maim** a proud man's pride. He set his **outfit** down by the **vacant** chair, smiled, and asked us to **excuse** his dusty boots. A **corporation**, he said, had tried to **nominate** him to **terminate** a contract, but he would not **act** against his conscience. The words friend and foe are **antonymous**, he reminded us, and **stupidity** often hides behind a **barricade** of clever speech. As the **bunk** creaked and the fire's **flush** faded, we sat together; the talk blessed us all the same, evenly warming the long, mild night.

中文翻译

我们这座小村庄的**起源**可以追溯到一位**著名的铁匠**，在一个即将到来的时代，他选择在一个繁忙的**十字路口**旁落脚，那里有两条欧洲贸易路线交汇。早在任何**统治者**试图**征服**这片地区之前，一位**虔诚的**基督教牧师和一位吃苦耐劳的**商人**就在此定居，他们**友好的**交易塑造了之后的一切。在**灼热的**午后，田野很快**成熟**，一只**大胆的**松鼠会在正好**五点钟**窜过马路，仿佛它必须**服从**某种私下的**逻辑**。十字路口上方矗立着一根古老的路标，各个**种族**的人都曾在此驻足。在收获之前，村庄会筹集节日所需的**材料**，并摆出种类繁多的摊位。这里的生活很少单调，尽管在访客看来它显得随意。一位纪录片解说者曾称这地方是旧日**理想主义的残余**，然而村民们既**现实**又讲求实际。他们依赖土地的**慷慨馈赠**，公平地**对待**每一位**买主**，从不**虐待**租户。当清晨的钟声响起，露珠会在**百合叶上闪光、颤动**，而入海口边的**红树林**仿佛从**透明的**水中**突出来**。我的叔叔，一位退休的**运动员**，在窗台**边缘**放着一盏带裂盖的油灯和一块破旧的海绵。他是个**意见果断**的人，会**焦急地传播**任何即将到来的消息。他说，保佑这屋子吧，愿上帝让**灾难、危险**和凶杀都远离它。他不信任城市的**疯狂**、投机者**讨厌的策略**，以及任何带着欺诈味道的有利可图的伎俩。**惟恐**家庭失去**宁静**，他始终保持警惕。一个**哀伤的**夜晚，一位久未露面的邻居穿着厚重的大衣回来了，仿佛要去**冒险**。他曾乘**火车头**穿越半个**希腊和印度**，**平静地**谈到他所见的贫穷之**普遍**，谈到一个被错误关押的囚犯，谈到一位哲学性的**戏剧家**，其剧作能挫伤一个骄傲之人的自尊。他把全套**装备**放在空着的椅子旁，微笑着，请我们**原谅**他沾满灰尘的靴子。他说，一家**公司**曾试图**提名**他去**终止**一份合同，但他不愿违背良心行事。他提醒我们，朋友与敌人是**反义的**，而**愚蠢**常常藏在一道由巧言构筑的**路障**之后。当**铺位**吱嘎作响、炉火的红光渐渐褪去，我们坐在一起；这番谈话同样**祝福**了我们所有人，均匀地温暖着这漫长而温和的夜晚。

52. The Cooperative in the City

English

Adolescence is a **momentary layer** in the long **bulk** of a life, yet it can **foster** habits that last **worldwide**. My **research** into one **city cooperative** began with a **kind waitress** named Vera, a willing **bread-earner** who had survived a childhood of **strife** and **severe** want in a leaning **shack** near the **inlet**. She spoke of that **natal** place without **nonsense**, in **coherent** and **completely** calm sentences, though the memory of **calamity** could still make her voice **fade**. As a **baby** she had been carried, the family said, almost from the **womb** into **chaos**; **communism** had collapsed, and the **respective** duties of each adult fell on the **least** likely shoulders. Vera refused to **discriminate** against anyone, and she would not **coerce** a soul. Her **especial** gift was patience. Behind the cooperative stood a noted **gallery**, and across the **park** a **janitor** swept the **steam** from a hot **recipe stove** while a **salesman** polished a **trademark** sign. The whole place teemed with life: a **wasp** circled a glass of **lemonade**, a **doll** lay in a **closet**, and **somebody** had left a **notebook** open on a **valued** antique desk. Vera was **engaged** in a worldwide trademark dispute, a heavy **liability** she handled with **hardy** good humor, for she knew even the wisest are **fallible**. She would **repeat** her **vow** each morning: do no **harm**. The **reliability** of the small shop depended on her, and her **absorption** in the work was complete. The **potential** of the venture was real, the **velocity** of its growth surprising, and a fair **evaluation** found its **proprietorship** sound. A cooperative spirit, she liked to say, can **inject** hope into the most **secular** and **earthly** routine. On Sundays a **Buddhist** neighbor and a **defiant** young engineer would **roam** in from the **tree-lined** street, **willingly** sharing fried **pumpkin** and a kind word. The **spectator** could see how the city was being regionalized, how **conservation** of the old **fort** and its inlet had become a cause. Yet a **penalty** hung over the project: a momentary lapse in funds could terminate it. Once, snatching a **tail** of bad news off the wire, Vera felt a **flare** of fear, like an **ulcer** waking. A **policeman** came; a **manacle** of red tape threatened to bind the venture. But the **engineering** held, the **electronics** worked, and the **appropriate** papers were signed. **Hitherto** the place had merely survived; now, the **meeting** agreed, it might truly thrive. Nothing earthly is permanent, Vera admitted, but a **habitable** corner of kindness is worth any **cord** of effort. A local **writer**, whose chief **concern** was to **regionalize** the old recipes, came to a public **hearing**; he watched the fields **undulate** in the wind, saw boys **sprint** after a **football**, and would **fry** pumpkin while a child clutched a doll with deep **attachment**, refusing to let anyone **snatch** it away.

中文翻译

青春期是漫长人生中一个短暂的层面，然而它能培养出遍及全球都通用的习惯。我对一家**城市合作社**的研究，始于一位名叫薇拉的和善**女服务员**，她是一个自愿**挣钱养家的人**，曾在入海口附近一间倾斜的小屋里熬过充满**冲突**与极度匮乏的童年。她谈起那个出生之地时不带半点**废话**，句子条理清楚、完全平静，尽管那段**灾难**的记忆仍会让她的声音渐渐消失。家人说，她还是**婴儿**时几乎就从**子宫**被抱进了**混乱**之中；**共产主义**崩溃了，每个成年人**各自的责任**落到了最**不可能**的肩膀上。薇拉拒绝**歧视**任何人，也不会**强迫**任何人。她**特别的**天赋是耐心。合作社后面有一间著名的**画廊**，**公园**对面，一个**看门人**扫去一只热气腾腾的**食谱炉子**冒出的**蒸汽**，一名**推销员**擦拭着一块**商标**招牌。整个地方充满生机：一只**黄蜂**绕着一杯**柠檬汽水**飞，一个**玩偶**躺在**小储藏室**里，有人在一张珍贵的古董桌上摊开了一本**笔记本**。薇拉卷入了一场全球性的商标纠纷，这是一份沉重的责任，她以吃苦耐劳的幽默来应对，因为她知道即便最聪明的人也会犯错。她每天早晨都会**重复**她的誓言：不**伤害**任何人。这间小店的**可靠性**依赖于她，而她对工作的**专注**是彻底的。这项事业的潜力是真实的，它增长的**速度**令人惊讶，一次公正的评估认定其**所有权**稳固。她喜欢说，合作精神能为最世俗、最尘世的日常**注入**希望。每逢周日，一位**佛教徒**邻居和一个挑战权威的年轻工程师会从林荫街道**漫步**进来，**乐意地**分享**油炒南瓜**和一句善意的话。**旁观者**能看出这座城市正如何被区域化，对古老**堡垒**及其入海口的**保护**如何成了一项事业。然而一项**惩罚**悬在这项目之上：资金上一时的失误就可能终止它。有一次，从电报里抓住一条坏消息的**尾巴**，薇拉感到一阵恐惧的**火光**腾起，像**溃疡**在发作。一名**警察**来了；一副官僚作风的**手铐**险些束缚住这项事业。但工程稳住了，电子设备运转正常，**合适的**文件签好了。在此之前这地方只是勉强生存；如今，**会议**一致认为，它或许能真正兴旺起来。薇拉承认，世间没有什么永恒，但一处可供栖居、充满善意的角落，值得付出任何一股的努力。一位**作家**，主要**关心**的是让这些老食谱区域化，他来参加一场公开听证会；他看着田野在风中**起伏**，看着男孩们追着**足球疾跑**，还会煎南瓜，而一个孩子怀着深深的眷恋抱着玩偶，不肯让任何人**夺走**它。

53. The Archaeologist on the Brink

English

Shortly after dawn, the cloudy sky promised more bad weather, and the rise of the sea against the medieval wall made the whole dig feel accidental, even doomed. Our team of archaeology students had to recognize that the project stood on the brink of disaster. The persistence of one entrant, a resolute woman who could memorize every longitude and meteorology chart off-hand, kept us going. She would not default on her promise, nor revert to despair. "Optimism is a kind of potion," she remarked with quiet daring, "and stupidity its allergy." Who could contradict her? She arranged the disposal of the loose pottery shards with optimum care, smelling each for the faint smell of old glue, and sorting them into a neat tetrad on a flat cork board. An owl watched from a shadowy fig tree as the morning light began to emerge. The legendary catastrophe that had buried this town was no idyll: an explosion of the nearby volcano, accordingly, had crumpled its octagon temple like paper. We could still see the dent where a falling beam had struck, the eddy of ash that froze mid-swirl, and a remnant of a cherry-wood saw left by a worker who fled in desperation. There would be no congratulation, no easy deduction, until the correlation between the layers was proven. A speculator had once tried to commercialize the site, his fraud a kind of burglary against history; we opposed him at the rendezvous point and forced him to default. The increase in tourists soon brought distraction. One man, full of make-up and chic clothes, kept a mug of alcohol at his side and would haggle over every artifact; his short-weight scales and l/c documents were plainly suspect, and a prohibition was quickly issued against him. He aggravated everyone, yet we did not let him disturb the work. By till and trowel we proceeded, our thinking sharpened by hardship. Quite suddenly the persistence paid off: an entrant brushed aside the dust and a carved face seemed to convince us, as if to consultation, that the ancient Jew, the dictatorship that ruled here, the long ordeal of its people, were all real. The enhancement of our records was immediate. We felt a flame of pride. Specialized scholars would study the find extensively, and any conceivable doubt about the town's population would, at last, be laid to rest. Working outdoors at speed, we would not aggravate the fragile site nor crumple a single record; archaeology was our true occupation, and we would oppose any destructive scenario. With calm poise I made one final remark, refusing to implant false hope: no handcuff of regret, no rotten potato of doubt, would slow us now.

中文翻译

黎明后不久，多云的天空预示着更坏的天气，海水拍打中世纪城墙的上涨让整个发掘现场都显得偶然，甚至注定失败。我们这支考古学学生队伍不得不承认，项目正处于灾难的边缘。一位参赛者的坚持支撑着我们前行，她是个果断的女人，能不假思索地记住每一条经度和气象图表。她不会拖欠她的承诺，也不会重陷绝望。"乐观是一种药剂，"她带着平静的大胆评论道，"而愚蠢则是它的过敏源。"谁能反驳她呢？她以最适宜的细心安排了那些松散陶片的处理，逐一嗅闻每片是否带着陈年胶水的淡淡气味，并把它分类摆成整齐的一组四件，放在一块平整的软木板上。一只猫头鹰从一棵幽暗的无花果树上注视着，晨光开始浮现。掩埋这座城镇的传奇大灾难绝非田园牧歌：附近火山的一次爆发，因此，把它的八角形神庙像纸一样压皱了。我们仍能看到落下的横梁砸出的凹痕，凝固在半旋中的灰烬漩涡，以及一名绝望逃离的工人留下的樱桃木锯子的残余。在各层之间的相互关系被证实之前，不会有任何祝贺，也不会有轻易的推断。一个投机商曾试图把这处遗址商业化，他的欺诈是对历史的一种盗窃；我们在集合地点反对他，迫使他违约退出。游客的增加很快带来了分心。有个男人，浓妆艳抹、衣着别致，身边总放着一大杯酒，对每件文物都讨价还价；他短斤少两的秤和他的信用证文件明显可疑，针对他的禁令很快就发布了。他使每个人都恼火，但我们没让他扰乱工作。我们靠着直到天黑的劳作和泥铲推进，思想在艰苦中变得敏锐。相当突然地，坚持得到了回报：一位参赛者拂去尘土，一张雕刻的面孔仿佛在向我们要咨询般使我们信服——古代的犹太人、曾统治这里的独裁政权、它的人民漫长的严酷考验，全都是真实的。我们记录的提升立竿见影。我们感到一阵自豪的火焰。专门的学者将广泛研究这一发现，而关于这座城镇人口的任何可以想象的疑问，终将得以平息。在户外快速工作，我们不会使这脆弱的遗址恶化，也不会弄皱任何一份记录；考古是我们真正的职业，我们会反对任何破坏性的设想。我以镇定的姿态作了最后一句评论，拒绝灌输虚假的希望：没有悔恨的手铐，没有疑虑这颗烂土豆，能拖慢我们的脚步。

54. A Pilot's Choice

English

The captain of the airline had to opt, in a tight moment, between two airline options, and he could not omit a single specific factor from his calculation. A gigantic storm sat across the transverse path of the rocket-fast jet, and aviation rules urged caution. He would not deny the danger, nor despise the eager hopeful crew who depended on him; instead he chose to assert command firmly. "Pick the secluded northern route," he said, and the prompt order left no room for inattention. A magician of the cockpit, he kept his elegance under stress, even when a tiny warning light made the panel glare. The producer of a documentary, who sat in the ward-like rear cabin near a fixed stool, had asked to film him; the commentary would later emphasize how a reliable professional behaves when a mate's life is the case at stake. Apart from the danger, the flight was a classic of routine. The associate captain, a keen and masculine man who despised laziness, made a quick subtraction of fuel against distance and slid a slide rule across the desk. A sudden urge to act seized him, so he urged the trainee to memorize the figures, then to fathom the deeper logic behind them. "Wherein lies our safety?" he asked, like a monarch posing a riddle. "In the option we forgive ourselves for not taking, if it would maim the plane." A dozen lights illuminated the dark. The phonetic alphabet crackled over the radio; a printout of the new decree from control spat from the tube of the tape-recorder beside the keyboard. The pilot did not cough, did not nap, did not let his mind haunt old fears. He situated the aircraft above the worst of it, thickened his focus, and let the captain's voice murmur its calm. A foe of panic, he treated fear as a tonne of dead weight to be cut loose. When at last the runway lights rose to greet them, a single tear seemed to heal an old wound. The translation of all that training into one safe landing was, the producer admitted, no mere joke; it was the forefront of a noble profession. He would not plagiarize another man's courage. He had his own, and it was specific, eager, and entirely his. His uncle, himself a highly trained fighter and once an adversary of careless flight, would speak of education as the one thing no mischance could destroy. He kept a fitting portfolio, a rectangle of worn leather, and would oversee every detail but never disturb the crew. She, a stationer's daughter who ran a small bookstall, would situate herself near the dwelling and illuminate the cabin with a lamp; the smell of benzene could thicken the air and bring a wave of nausea that made a man groan, and a rat once gnawed a cartridge wrapper to shreds. He urged caution, called any deletion from the checklist unfit and reckless, and would stick to procedure.

中文翻译

这家航空公司的机长不得不在紧迫的一刻，在两个航线选项之间做出选择，他无法从计算中省略任何一个具体因素。一场巨大的风暴横亘在那架快如火箭的喷气机的横向航路上，航空规则要求谨慎。他不会否认危险，也不会轻视那些依赖他的、急切而满怀希望的机组人员；相反，他选择坚定地行使指挥权。"选那条偏僻的北线，"他说，这道迅速的命令容不得半点疏忽。作为驾驶舱里的魔法师，他在压力下保持优雅，即使一盏小小的警示灯让仪表盘发出刺眼的光。一位纪录片制片人坐在病房似的后舱、一张固定的凳子旁，曾请求拍摄他；那解说词稍后将强调一位可靠的专业人员在同伴性命攸关之际是如何表现的。除了危险，这次飞行是一次例行的典范。副机长是个敏锐而有男子气概、鄙视懒惰的人，迅速地把燃料对距离做了减法，并在桌上推过一把计算尺。他催促见习生记住这些数字，然后去领会它们背后更深的逻辑。"我们的安全在何处？"他问道，像一位君主出谜题。"在于那个我们原谅自己没有选择的选项——如果它会损毁飞机的话。"十几盏灯照亮了黑暗。语音字母在无线电里噼啪作响；控制台发来的新法令打印输出从键盘旁录音机的管道里吐出来。飞行员没有咳嗽，没有打盹，没有让思绪萦绕于旧日的恐惧。他把飞机定位在最恶劣气流之上，加深专注，任凭机长的声音低声传递它的镇定。作为恐慌的敌人，他把恐惧当作一公吨要抛掉的死重。当跑道的灯光最终升起来迎接他们时，一滴泪仿佛治愈了一道旧伤。制片人承认，把全部训练转化为一次安全着陆，绝非一个玩笑；那是一项崇高职业的最前线。他不会剽窃别人的勇气。他有自己的，那勇气具体、急切，完全属于他自己。他的叔叔本人是个训练有素的斗士，曾是粗心飞行的对头，常说教育是什么不幸都无法摧毁的东西。他保留着一个合适的公文包，一块磨旧的长方形皮革，会监督每一个细节，却从不打扰机组。她，一个文具商的女儿，经营着一个小书报摊，会把自己安置在住所附近，用一盏灯照亮舱室；苯的气味会使空气变浓，带来一阵令人呻吟的恶心，曾有一只老鼠把弹药筒的包装纸啃成碎片。他催促谨慎，称清单上任何删除都是不合适且鲁莽的，并坚持照章办事。

55. Restoring the Old Quarter

English

To **announce** the festival, the **headmaster** of the village school stepped to the **microphone** under a **mild** evening **sky**. He meant to **inaugurate** a long **pilgrimage** of work and to **fast-track** the repair. This was only the **prologue**: the old **slum** quarter, **unlike** anything **marketable**, would **undergo** a complete renewal. A **surveyor** had filed a **factual** report, and his **pertinent** notes, written in a neat **indent**, listed every **breakage**, every **hollow** beam, every **plug** torn from the wall. The **aggregate** cost made the treasurer **sigh**, but civic **brotherhood compels** generosity, and the **overall** mood was **placid** rather than **hysterical**. The headmaster, **fluent** in the town's history, would not **abruptly** abandon a single **delinquent** debt; the **cause** was too dear. A **workman** in a **woollen** cap and worn **sneakers** arrived by **taxi**, his tool **belt** heavy with each **vital instrument**. He would **rake** the **swamp** behind the houses, **batter** down the rotten fence, and reset the **ornamental engraving** that once marked a **feudal** estate. "We must not **delay**," he said **heartily**, taking a **mouthful** of **almond** cake and a sip of fresh **juice**. "A **wasteful half-measure** would only **threaten** the street." An old woman would **knit** woollen scarves while young men found **backing** for the project, and a curious dog would **sniff** at the wet paint. The **revelation**, when it came, was **credible**: beneath the **colorless** plaster lay a **fat** seam of old tile, an **article** of real beauty. People came to **participate**; the lane began to **teem**. Children would **squeal** and a cart would **clatter** past, while a **barber** set up near the **exit** and a **sandy-haired** girl planted a single **sunflower**. **Approximately** a **degree** of order returned each day. **Censorship** had once erased the **corruption** of the old rulers, but the quarter now rose to a new **pinnacle**. The change felt almost **instantaneous**. No **invoice** could measure it. A passing **warship** sounded a **signal**, as if to **herald** the rebirth. The **logistics** were **intricate**, the **figurative** weight enormous, yet the people were **bound** to finish. That night a tired **performer** strummed on a **cosy sofa**, **sharply** aware that the **clam-shut** secret was gone. A couple just back from their **honeymoon** joined in. The mayor, **overjoy** in his eyes, offered the lowest **bid** and signed. The schedule had **probably** slipped a little, and no one wished to be **behindhand**, but the renewal was **very** real, and to **reflect** on it was to feel, for one mild instant, at home.

中文翻译

为了宣布这场庆典，乡村学校的**校长**走到**话筒**前，立于**温和**的夜空之下。他要为一段漫长的劳作**朝圣**揭幕，并加快修缮进程。这只是序幕：那片老旧的贫民区，毫无任何可销售之处，将要彻底翻新。一位勘测员递交了一份属实的报告，他那写得整齐、首行缩进的笔记列出了每一处**裂口**、每一根**中空**的梁、每一个从墙上扯下的**插头**。总计的费用让财务主管**叹气**，但公民间的**兄弟情谊**催人慷慨，整体气氛是**平静的**，而非**歇斯底里的**。校长对小镇历史了如指掌，谈吐流利，他不会突然抛下任何一笔**拖欠的**旧债；这**事业**太珍贵了。一名戴着羊毛帽、穿着磨旧**旅游鞋**的**工人**乘出租车赶来，**工具腰带**上挂满了每一件要紧的器械。他要耙清屋后的沼泽，把朽烂的篱笆猛击推倒，并重新安好那曾标志封建庄园的装饰**雕刻**。“我们不能拖延，”他精神饱满地说，咬了一口**杏仁**蛋糕，喝了一口鲜果汁。“**浪费**的半吊子做法只会危及整条街。”一位老妇人织着羊毛围巾，年轻人为项目寻得资助，一只好奇的狗对着湿漆嗅来嗅去。当那发现到来时，是**可信的**：**无色的**灰泥之下竟有一道厚厚的旧瓷砖，一件真正美丽的**物品**。人们前来**参与**；小巷开始热闹起来。孩子们尖叫，推车咔嗒驶过，一位理发师在**出口**附近支起摊子，一个沙色头发的女孩种下一株向日葵。每天**大约**恢复一分秩序。**审查**制度曾抹去旧统治者的**腐败**，但这片街区如今登上新的顶峰。这变化几乎是瞬间发生的。没有**发票**能衡量它。一艘驶过的**军舰**鸣响**信号**，仿佛在通报这场新生。**后勤**错综复杂，象征意义沉重无比，但人们注定要完成它。那夜，一位疲惫的**表演者**在**舒适的沙发**上弹琴，**敏锐地**意识到那闭口不言的秘密已经消失。一对刚度完**蜜月**的伴侣也加入进来。市长眼中满是**大喜**，出了最低的价并签了字。这场翻新**非常**真实，进度**大概**略有延误，没有人想**落后**于人，但回想起它，便能在那温和的一刻感到宾至如归。

56. The Auction at the Old Mall

English

On a black winter morning the auction began, and a tedious apprehension hung in the air like smoke from a chimney. The challenge for every gambler in the room was plain: define a fair price, yet not let petty greed perpetuate a foolish bid. A pioneer of the trade, a candid physician turned dealer, stepped to the fore. "I will not cheat," he said with emphatic, almost macabre calm. "Nor will I criticize a rival, for that would only entail disgrace." The mall was old; its durable beams had begun to crack, and the maintenance bills threatened to abolish any profit. Stagnation, not malignant scheming, was the true foe. A baroness in a silk blouse made a declaration that her ability to pay was beyond question, and her allied friends, fortunate in trade, embraced the idea with no opposition. The assumption was that the percentage of buyers would remain high. To proceed, the auctioneer rang a small bell that seemed to jingle and chime at once; the durable gauge of a sale, he liked to say, is whether the crowd will endure to the last lot. A pungent aroma of bitter ale and pen ink drifted from the back, where a laborer mopped the floor. "This is no joke, yet I feel no anxious dread," murmured a fore-thinking man, candid in his estimation. He would not dwell on sarcasm or metaphor; he would simply bid. The outcome of the bidding would transform the whole street. A rational mind, not extravagance, must rule. "We are on the verge of something," said the physician, rapping a screw against the kettle for quiet. The middle rows, fortunate and alert, leaned in. Civic pride did not interfere with commerce here; rather, the two were coincident. A petty quarrel over a candid remark nearly flared, but the dealer's even temper, his refusal to disdain anyone, kept the peace. He would not cling to a single set of china, nor let a sharp tongue maim the mood. The cabbage-seller next door, a tradesman of long history, watched through the express glass. When the final hammer fell, the store changed hands. The reaction was loud; people clapped, the chimney smoked on, and the long, durable day proceeded to its quiet, fortunate end. Yet, even then, the dumb relief in the room said more than any speech. As long as honest trade could remain, the old mall would not be cheated of its future. To narrate the day's lesson in plain Latin and English alike, under no real stress, the auctioneer stressed each step with almost adverbial, extremely deliberate care. He refused to undercharge or to write a bad cheque, for the toll of honest trade was patience, and any delinquency would only embrace ruin. The internationalization of the market did not frighten him; a furious bidder, full of nervous cleverness, might gnaw his pen, but as undersigned witness he would calmly feed the ledger, mop his brow, and explain how an enzyme or an electron means nothing to a man who cannot pollinate trust into a deal.

中文翻译

在一个漆黑的冬日清晨，拍卖开始了，一种乏味的忧惧像烟囱里的烟一样悬在空中。屋里每个赌徒面对的难题很明白：定出一个公道的价，又不能让小气的贪婪把愚蠢的出价延续下去。这行的先驱——一位由医生改行的经销商，坦率地走到前面。"我不会作弊，"他用强调的、近乎阴森的镇定说道，"也不会贬损对手，因为那只会招致耻辱。"商场很旧；耐用的梁开始开裂，维修账单眼看要吞掉一切利润。停滞，而非恶性的算计，才是真正的敌人。一位穿丝绸衬衫的男爵夫人声明，她的支付能力毋庸置疑，她那些在生意上幸运的盟友们也毫无异议地接受了这一想法。人们的假设是买家的比例会保持很高。为了继续，拍卖师摇响一只小铃，那声音似乎既叮当又和谐地鸣响；他爱说，一场拍卖耐久的标尺，就在于人群能否坚持到最后一件拍品。一股苦啤酒和钢笔墨水的刺鼻气味从后面飘来，那里一名劳工在拖地。"这可不是玩笑，但我并不感到焦虑的恐惧，"一个有远见的人喃喃道，对自己的估量很坦率。他不愿纠缠于讽刺或隐喻；他只管出价。这场竞价的结果将改变整条街。理性的头脑，而非奢侈，必须主宰一切。"我们正处在某件大事的边缘，"医生说着，用一颗螺丝敲了敲水壶以示安静。中间几排既幸运又警觉的人凑上前。在这里公民自豪感并不妨碍商业；相反，二者是一致的。一场因坦率言辞引发的小争执险些爆发，但经销商平和的脾气、他不愿蔑视任何人的态度维持了和气。他不会死抱一套瓷器不放，也不让尖刻的言辞毁掉气氛。隔壁卖卷心菜的，一位有着悠久历史的商人，透过快速擦净的玻璃张望。当最后一锤落下，店铺易手了。反应很热烈；人们鼓掌，烟囱继续冒烟，漫长而耐久的一天走向它幸静而幸运的结尾。然而即便那时，屋里那种说不出话的宽慰，也胜过任何言辞。只要诚实的交易能够留存，这座老商场就不会被骗走它的未来。为了用浅白的拉丁语和英语一并讲述当天的课程，拍卖人强调每一个步骤，那份近乎副词式的、极其审慎的用心。他拒绝低价收费，也拒绝开空头支票，因为诚实交易的代价就是耐心，任何失职都只会拥抱毁灭。市场的国际化并未吓倒他；一个狂怒的竞买人满怀紧张的机灵，也许会啃咬笔杆，但作为在下面签名的见证人，他会平静地填账、擦汗，并解释一种酶或一个电子，对一个无法把信任授粉进交易的人毫无意义。

57. The Sociologist's Journal

English

Really, the wonderful schedule of a working sociologist is less glamorous than a thriller would suggest. Each morning I open my journal and easily outline the day's tasks; the work is solely mine, and personally I find that clearly comforting. My optional reading includes a dense treatise and a long bibliography, for I aspire to lengthen my understanding of how an ethnic community keeps its stability. Something about the aroma of old paper, like a faint aerosol of dust, makes me eager to study. I diagnose social trends the way a physician studies a virus or a staphylococcus under glass; the validity of any claim depends on data, not on a premature guess. There is real ambiguity in human attitude, and a homogenous sample can hide more than it shows. Last week I had to convene a small symposium and arbitrate a dispute; the regime of polite debate kept tempers from making the room escalate into chaos. One aristocrat, an industrious millionaire who had emigrated young, spoke with modesty about his contribution to industrial reform. His attitude was advantageous to all. A princess of an old ethnic line told a romance worthy of a melodious ballad, and her aural memory was phenomenal. We exchanged views; nor did anyone repudiate the others. I keep a keyboard and a printer ready, and my repertoire of methods is wide. When the aggressive questions came, I did not pant or peep nervously; I answered with control. The pension reformers wanted to escalate spending; the treasurer urged restraint. I.e., the demand was clear but the strength of the budget was not. A spatial map of the city, looped with red string, showed where dependence on aid was high. We schedule a follow-up, and the equation of needs and means stays unsolved. A crab-shaped diagram, drawn off-hand, made the crew laugh. Toil though it is, the pursuance of truth is nice work; the contribution feels permanent. By noon a cloud crossed the sun, and the loop of talk closed. I sail home, eager for supper, my reflection in the train window calm. A premature conclusion would endanger the whole study, so I write only what I can defend. The tragedy of bad research is that it looks tame until it engulfs a policy. So I sing no false praise; I record, I reflect, and tomorrow I begin again. I would not concoct data, nor exchange truth for a neat story; that presumption would be unthinkable. A young trainer, who hoped to emigrate, brought a packet of mustard seeds and a wreath of dried herbs as a gift. We did not bump heads over the adverb in a sentence or the hormone in a sample. A sudden crack of thunder seemed to engulf the room; one nervous student had almost a seizure of doubt, but I urged him to squash his fear, to treble his effort, and to dig in his heel. No one would hijack the seminar with profuse complaint.

中文翻译

说真的，一个在职社会学家精彩的日程，远不如惊险小说所暗示的那般光鲜。每天早晨我翻开日志，轻松地列出当天的任务；这工作完全属于我，就个人而言我觉得这显然令人安心。我可选的读物包括一本艰深的论著和一长串参考书目，因为我立志延长自己对一个种族社群如何维持稳定的理解。旧纸张的气味，像一层淡淡的尘埃气雾，让我渴望钻研。我诊断社会趋势，就像医生在玻璃片下研究病毒或葡萄球菌；任何论断的有效性都取决于数据，而非过早的猜测。人类态度中存在真正的模棱两可，一个同质的样本掩盖的往往比它显示的更多。上周我不得不召集一个小型研讨会并进行仲裁；礼貌辩论的制度使脾气不至于让整个房间升级为混乱。一位贵族——一位年轻时移居国外、勤奋的百万富翁——谦逊地谈起他对工业改革的贡献。他的态度对所有人都有利。一位古老种族世系的公主讲了一个堪比优美歌谣的爱情故事，她的听觉记忆惊人。我们交换了看法；也没有人拒绝接受别人的观点。我备好键盘和打印机，我的方法库很宽。当带有进取心的尖锐提问到来时，我没有喘气，也没有紧张地偷瞄；我从容应答。养老金改革者想增加开支；财务主管力主克制。也就是说，需求很明确，但预算的实力并不明确。一张用红线绕成环的城市空间地图，标出了对援助依赖度高的地方。我们安排了后续会议，而需求与手段的方程仍未解开。一张随手画的蟹形图把全体人员逗笑了。尽管这是苦工，追求真理却是美好的工作；这种贡献感觉是持久的。到了正午，一片云掠过太阳，谈话的环路合拢了。我乘火车回家，渴望晚餐，车窗里我的倒影很平静。过早的结论会危及整个研究，所以我只写自己能站得住脚的东西。糟糕研究的悲剧在于，它看上去很温顺，直到它吞没一项政策。所以我不唱虚假的赞歌；我记录，我反省，明天我再次开始。我不会编造数据，也不会拿真相去换一个漂亮的故事；那种臆断是不可思议的。一位希望移居国外的年轻教练，带来一包芥菜籽和一只干草花环作礼物。我们不会为一句话语里的副词或一份样本里的激素而发生冲突。一声突如其来的雷裂似乎要吞没整个房间；一名紧张的学生几乎陷入疑虑的发作，但我催促他压住恐惧、把努力增至三倍、稳住脚跟。没有人会用连篇累牍的抱怨来劫持这场研讨会。

58. Night Shift at the Planetarium

English

At zero hour the steward of the planetarium, a meek and sane man named Otto, climbed the staircase to begin the night watch. My job was to review the dome's optics before the morning crowd, and beforehand I had to evaluate every wire, plus the spare cassette and the loudspeaker. The theme of the new show was mankind's long pursuit of the stars, a typical narration that would build slowly toward awe. Otto, a bilingual preacher's son who had once aspired to study physics, liked to deem the cosmos a kind of church. "Seriously," he said, his face beginning to glow, "to occupy your mind with the sun and the volcano of a distant star is the sole cure for despair." He would not subscribe to fright; darkness, to him, was merely the margin where light begins. We worked systematically. A glare from a loose lamp made me alert, and I marked it on the margin of my notebook with a quick xerox of the old wiring plan. Otto fetched oatmeal and spice tea from the bakery downstairs, and we shared a bare supper near the playground window. He spoke of his grandmother, who in August would leap from her chair to greet the first cool wind, and of a wounded patrol soldier he had once nursed, a follower of an old prophet whose commandment was simple mercy. "Anyway," he said, "opinion divides mankind, but the sky unites it." There was no compromise in his faith, no opposition he could not meet with a quiet quash of doubt. A pistol hung, disarmed, in a glass case by the pharmacy sign downstairs, a relic of a darker decade when an ally and a foe had patrolled these streets and the slaughter of feudalism's last war had filled the wards. Otto deemed such firearms an impossibility for a planetarium; he had argued the point with rigor and won. Now a gymnast practiced on the lawn at dawn, a postman cycled past, and the only siren was the soft hum of the projector. By thirty minutes past dawn the optics were clear. Otto signed the log with my pen, took his pension card from his coat, and smiled. "Permanently," he said, "this is the best post a man could ask." Outside, the radiation of the rising sun lit the dome. I cashed no praise from him; his quiet cooperation was payment enough. The container of old slides went back on the shelf, and the lenient, ego-free man went home to write his diary by lamplight. Oh, how Otto loved a good symposium! An expert on old instruments, he would aspire to teach any user who came to the planetarium's guesthouse. He wore a soft flannel coat against the rheumatism in his knee, and he played gaily, like a boy at basketball. The consumption of power, he noted, was barely an ampere; the computer logged each reading, and an old telex still clattered in the office. 'No army could invade this peace,' he said, dressed for his hundredth night shift. The palatable supper, the cash in the till, the strong connection between teacher and star — he would not dispose of any of it.

中文翻译

零点时分，天文馆的服务员——一个温顺而神志健全、名叫奥托的人——登上楼梯开始守夜。我的工作是在清晨人群到来前检查穹顶的光学系统，事先我必须评估每一根电线，外加备用磁带盒和扬声器。新节目的主题是人类对群星的漫长追求，一段典型的叙述，会缓缓推向敬畏。奥托是一位会说两种语言的牧师之子，曾立志研习物理，他喜欢把宇宙视为一座教堂。"说真的，"他说，脸渐渐发亮，"让你的心思被太阳和遥远恒星的火山占据，是绝望唯一的解药。"他不肯认同恐惧；在他看来，黑暗只是光明开始的边缘。我们系统地工作。一盏松动的灯发出的眩光让我警觉，我在笔记本的页边记下，并迅速静电复印了旧的布线图。奥托从楼下面包店取来麦片和香料茶，我们在运动场窗边分享了一顿简单的晚餐。他谈起他的祖母，每到八月她会从椅子上跳起来迎接第一阵凉风；还谈起一个他曾照料过的受伤巡逻兵，那是一位古老先知的追随者，那先知的诫命简单到只有仁慈。"无论如何，"他说，"意见使人类分裂，而天空使它团结。"他的信仰里没有妥协，没有哪种反对是他不能以平静地取消疑虑来应对的。楼下药房招牌旁的玻璃柜里挂着一支已卸除弹药的手枪，那是更黑暗的年代的遗物——当年盟友与敌人曾在这些街道上巡逻，封建主义最后一场战争的屠杀曾塞满病房。奥托认为这种火器对天文馆而言是不可能存在的；他曾严谨地论证此点并赢了。如今黎明时分一名体操运动员在草坪上练习，一个邮递员骑车经过，唯一的"警报"是放映机柔和的嗡嗡声。黎明后三十分钟，光学系统清晰了。奥托用我的钢笔签了日志，从外套里取出养老金卡，微笑着。"永久地，"他说，"这是一个人能企求的最好岗位。"外面，初升太阳的辐射照亮了穹顶。我没从他那里换得任何称赞；他安静的合作已是足够的报酬。装旧幻灯片的容器放回架子，这位宽厚、毫无自我的人回家去就着灯光写他的日记了。哦，奥托多么喜欢一场精彩的专题研讨会！作为旧仪器的专家，他立志教导任何来到天文馆宾馆的使用者。他穿着一件柔软的法兰绒外套抵御膝盖的风湿，玩得兴高采烈，像个打篮球的男孩。他指出，电力的消耗几乎不到一安培；计算机记录着每一个读数，办公室里一台老电机仍在嗒嗒作响。「无论哪支军队都无法侵犯这份宁静」，他说，已为他的第一百个夜班穿戴整齐。可口的晚餐、钱柜里的现金、师者与星辰之间牢固的联系——他一样都不愿舍弃。

59. The Successor at Willow Farm

English

In recent years Willow Farm had fallen into a depressed condition, and I returned as its reluctant successor after the expiration of my grandfather's long lease. The premises were vast, half a panoramic valley reaching to the horizon, where at noon a metallic blaze of sun lit the old grain dome. I had once aspired to resign from farming altogether; a patriotic uncle scoffed at that preference, reminding me that a teenager who flees the soil is led astray. So I stayed. The aforesaid grandfather, in his last term of mourning for my grandmother, had kept a legible diary whose every line a translator could read. He wrote with courtesy and never a rude word; he would greet each sheep by name and behave toward every diver who came to clean the well with a hospitable patience. He scorned laziness, yet showed no scorn for honest exhaustion. One ought to repay the land, he liked to dictate, or be banished from it. I was certain the work would be complicated. A recent drought had defiled the lower field; the inorganic salts had risen in a slow flux to the surface, leaving an infinitesimal metallic crust. With meticulous care I would drill new wells, fetch water uphill by traction, and grant the bushes time to recover. I kept a duplicate of every sales record on a board, legible and exact, lest some inconsistency or inaccurate figure send the accounts astray. By August the farm began to sustain itself. We canned pickle and soy, and a tentative concert of birds returned to the bush at dawn, an aural accompaniment to the morning service of chores. I felt a cramp in my breast, not trauma, but the educational ache of real labor. My flexibility improved; my foot found firm traction on the muddy slope. A crook of willow served as my cradle for the lambs. I was able to discharge the old debts after a good harvest, and an extension of credit, secured against the aforesaid premises, gave me a financial cushion. Each dawn I tied a mask against the dust and watched the downward slope of the field catch the first light. There was no firearm on the premises and no siren in the valley, only the plural hum of bees. I learned to discern the spot where deviation from routine would cost a harvest, and I refused to let any rude visitor defile the work. An opal of dew sat on each leaf at dawn. Halfway through the season, rich with a quiet pride, I no longer felt regretful. The punishment of doubt was lifted. This land, I reiterated to myself, was instrumental to whom I had become; and I, its grateful successor, would never again behave as one led astray. I bit into a ripe plum at noon and called it good. I would stay through every storm, meticulously checking each fence; a single bite of doubt I would banish at once. Let the cynics scoff — I reiterate that this land made me.

中文翻译

近些年来，柳树农场已陷入萧条的境地，在祖父漫长租约期满后，我作为它不情愿的继承人回到了这里。这片地产十分辽阔，半个全景式的山谷一直延伸到地平线，正午时分金属般灼亮的阳光照在古老的谷仓圆顶上。我曾一心想彻底辞去农活；一位爱国的叔叔对那种偏好嗤之以鼻，提醒我说，逃离土地的少年会误入歧途。于是我留了下来。前述的祖父，在为祖母守丧的最后一段日子里，记下了一本字迹清晰的日记，每一行译者都能读懂。他下笔彬彬有礼，从无一言粗话；他会叫着名字向每只羊问好，对每个来清理水井的潜水员都待之以好客的耐心。他鄙视懒惰，却从不轻视诚实的疲惫。“人应当报答土地，”他喜欢这样吩咐，“否则就该被它驱逐。”我确信这活儿会很复杂。最近一场干旱玷污了下面的田地；无机盐随着缓慢的流动升到地表，留下一层极薄的金属硬壳。我会一丝不苟地钻凿新井，靠牵引把水引上坡，并给灌木丛时间恢复。我把每一笔销售记录都在一块木板上留有副本，清晰而精确，以免某处不一致或不准确的数字让账目误入歧途。到了八月，农场开始自给自足。我们腌了泡菜、装了酱油罐，黎明时分一场试探性的鸟鸣音乐会回到了灌木丛，为清晨杂务的劳作伴奏。我胸口感到一阵抽痛，不是创伤，而是真正劳动带来的、富有教益的酸痛。我的柔韧性增强了；我的脚在泥泞的斜坡上找到了稳固的着力。一根弯曲的柳枝成了我安放羊羔的摇篮。一场好收成后，我得以偿清旧债，而以前述地产作抵押的一笔信贷展期，给了我一个财务上的缓冲。每天黎明我都戴上口罩防尘，望着田地向下的斜坡迎接第一缕光。地产上没有火器，山谷里没有警报声，只有蜜蜂复数般的嗡鸣。我学会了辨别那些一旦偏离常规就会毁掉收成的地点，也拒绝让任何粗鲁的访客玷污这份工作。黎明时每片叶子上都坐着一颗蛋白石般的露珠。季节过半时，我满怀一种宁静的骄傲，不再感到遗憾。怀疑的惩罚被解除了。我反复对自己说，这片土地对我成为怎样的人起了关键作用；而我，作为它感恩的继承人，再也不会表现得像个误入歧途的人。正午时我咬下一颗熟透的李子，称之为美好。我会在每一场风暴中坚守，一丝不苟地检查每一道篱笆；一丝疑虑的啃咬，我都会立刻驱逐。让那些愤世嫉俗者去嘲笑吧——我反复重申，是这片土地造就了我。

60. The Coastal Fortress and the Coral Reef

English

By December the old coastal fortress had lost much of its popularity, yet a select group of scholars still made the journey across the bay to study it. I went too, immersing myself in its history. The chief counselor of the municipal heritage board, a notable scholar of slight build and stern manner, met our train at the station and led us aside to a quiet parlor. Over supper of pork and vinegar he offered an honest appraisal of the site. "Tourism here has begun to dwindle," he said aloud, with a sluggish, almost sleepy regret. "Our earnings shrink each year, though the asset is splendid." He was reluctant to let the place forever fade. To revive it, he had organized a brainstorm with local makers and merchants, hoping some incentive would draw people back. The fortress sat on an acre of high ground, its chambers carved with the regular patience of long-dead masons. From the topmost chamber a panoramic view opened to the horizon; at twilight the sunlight struck the sea with optical splendor, and far below, an Arabian-style dome marked an old chapel of Christ. A neat shelf of rock dropped to the coastal shallows, where a living coral reef teemed with organisms. With ventilation shafts cut through the thick walls, the fortress had once been a true asset of defense; now its deep tank still held rainwater, and a strand of old rope, knotted at intervals, hung from the wall like a relic. "People once feared this was a fake ruin," the counselor said, "a clever maker's forgery sold to gullible tourists. But the index of every stone, cross-checked against the December archives, proves it genuine." He spoke with no haste. A leopard, he joked, had more patience than a committee, and a feather weighed more than the average official's promise. We must ensure, he said, that no outlaw or speculator be allowed to strip the reef or fence the land. He had been a diver in his youth; he could still discern, from the take-off of a startled fish, exactly where the strap of a tourist's camera had snapped and sunk. Morality and good seniority, he believed, were the true means of preservation. As the airplane of a distant patrol droned overhead and a faint siren sounded from a clinic in the town, he reminded us that even a regular season of decline need not mean degradation. Acidity in the water, a transformer humming on the cliff, a sixty-year-old map curling at the edge: each was part of a fragile whole. He asked us to mind the place, to respond to its quiet call, and to feel the deeply rooted, inveterate love a Brazilian sailor once carved into the stern of a wrecked ship near here. The shipwreck, he added, lay just past the navel of the bay, its animation long stilled. I left at noon, my curriculum vitae of memories richer by one fortress, certain the unjust neglect of such a place was a thing we ought, with auxiliary effort, to end. The postman waved as our train pulled away. With thanks to the old counselor, we would share his vision. He spoke about the fortress as an organism, not merely a ruin, and his aptitude for history was plain. A lark sang from a low bough; the morning had the air of a theatre before the curtain. To immerse a school of young students in such a place, he said, takes real exertion, yet it is no rare occurrence in a region of such depth. He tied a quick knot in the rope and smiled, free of any depression.

中文翻译

到了十二月，这座古老的沿海堡垒已大不如前受人欢迎，但仍有一小批精选的学者跨过海湾前来研究它。我也去了，沉浸在它的历史之中。市政遗产理事会的首席顾问——一位身材瘦小、神情严厉的著名学者——在车站迎接我们的列车，把我们领到一旁一间安静的客厅。在一顿猪肉配醋的晚餐间，他对这处遗址作了诚实的评价。"这里的旅游业已经开始萎缩，"他出声道，带有一种迟缓、近乎困倦的遗憾。"尽管这资产很壮丽，我们的收入却年年缩水。"他不愿让这地方就此永远湮没。为了让它复苏，他与当地的工匠和商人组织了一次集体讨论，希望某种激励能把人们重新吸引回来。堡垒坐落在一英亩高地上，它的厅室是由早已作古的石匠以持久而规整的耐心凿成的。从最高的厅室望去，全景一直敞向地平线；黄昏时分阳光以光学般的瑰丽击打海面，而在远远的下方，一座阿拉伯式的圆顶标志着一座古老的基督礼拜堂。一道整齐的岩架坠向沿海的浅滩，那里一片活的珊瑚礁中生物繁多。厚墙中凿出了通风井，堡垒曾是真正的防御资产；如今它深深的水箱仍蓄着雨水，一缕每隔一段就打了结的旧绳像遗物般垂在墙上。"人们曾担心这是座假废墟，"顾问说，"是某个机灵工匠伪造、卖给轻信游客的赝品。但每一块石头的编号，与十二月的档案逐一核对，都证明它是真的。"他说话毫不匆忙。他打趣说，豹子比委员会更有耐心，一根羽毛也比一般官员的承诺更有分量。他说，我们必须确保不让任何不法之徒或投机商剥光这片礁石或圈占这片土地。他年轻时当过潜水员；如今他仍能从一条受惊的鱼起跃的样子，准确判断出某位游客相机的带子是在哪里断裂沉没的。他相信，道德与良好的资历才是保护的真正手段。当远处一架巡逻飞机在头顶嗡嗡作响、镇上一家诊所传来微弱的警报声时，他提醒我们，即便是一个寻常的衰退季节，也不一定意味着退化。水中的酸度、崖上轰鸣的变压器、一张边缘卷起的六十年的旧地图：每一样都是这脆弱整体的一部分。他请我们照着这地方，回应它无声的召唤，去体会一位巴西水手当年刻在附近一艘失事船尾上的那种根深蒂固、积习难改的爱。他补充说，那艘失事的船就躺在海湾中心稍过一点的地方，它的生机早已止息。我在正午离开，记忆的简历里多了一座堡垒而更显丰厚，确信对这样一处地方不公正的忽视，是我们应当借助辅助之力去终结的事。我们的列车驶离时，邮递员挥了挥手。感谢这位年长的顾问，我们愿意分享他的愿景。他谈到这座堡垒，把它当作一个有机体，而不仅仅是一片废墟，他对历史的天资显而易见。一只云雀在低垂的树枝上歌唱；清晨有种大幕拉开前剧院的气氛。他说，让一群年轻学生沉浸在这样一个地方，需要真正的努力，但在如此有深度的地区，这并非罕见的事。他在绳上飞快地打了个结，微笑着，毫无消沉之意。

61. The Chemistry Teacher's Odyssey

English

Frankly, my previous chemistry teacher seemed insane. On a quick Wednesday morning he would burst into the classroom wearing baggy trousers, his spirit bright, ready to give a lesson that felt like an exciting odyssey. He had to acquire his teaching licence only after a perennial struggle, yet he taught with precision. He explained that hydrogen, the predominant element in the universe, could fuel stars effectively, and that ammonia, lethal in high concentration, was harmless when diluted in a watery solution.

He loved to refute lazy thinking. 'Memorize the actual data, not a nominal approximation,' he said resolutely, tapping the window pane with a spoon. He told us, with no contemptuous tone, that atomic mechanics was not insane magic but careful note-taking. He warned that an impetuous experiment could deform the apparatus or, moreover, pour toxic sediment into the school sewer.

His backstory was an odyssey worthy of an immortal soul. Before teaching, he had been a pilot, then briefly an infantry officer who resolutely refused a fascist order and was detained for it. He realized then that real courage was harmless to others and protective of the weak. That single sentence shaped his perennial longing to teach.

On weekends he ran a small farmhouse beside a paddock, where migratory birds and a slow tortoise shared the foliage. He grew celery, kneaded dough for bread, and fed meat scraps to his dog. He liked to inscribe a clever line of poetry on each loaf. His kidney trouble made him perspire, but he never complained of agony.

The local pharmaceutical boom had once tried to lure him toward profit, yet he felt that knowledge, universally shared, mattered more than ownership of a patent. He believed every child held vast potentiality. 'Don't be suspicious of curiosity,' he urged, lighting a torch of inspiration that would brighten any dull mind. He taught us sportsmanship in sport, the precision of seismic measurement, the geometry of a three-dimensional model, and even how detergent cleans a watery confluence of grease.

When a nominal voter complained, the principal had to restock his patience and detain his temper. In our province, people would dub him eccentric, but he would persist. Each spring he watched buds burgeon in the paddock and feel the quiet joy of growth, and at dusk he would shut the heavy door, content. The ceremony at year's end was popular: seven students, prior doubters, stood up. We came to reasonably realize that a teacher many called a maniac had given us, with violent enthusiasm, the foundation of our lives.

中文翻译

坦率地说,我以前的化学老师看起来像个疯子。在一个轻快的星期三早晨,他会穿着袋状的宽松裤子冲进教室,精神焕发,准备上一堂感觉像激动人心的长途冒险旅行的课。他历经长年累月的奋斗才取得教师执照,但他授课极为精确。他解释说,氢是宇宙中占主导地位的元素,能有效地为恒星提供燃料;氨在高浓度时是致命的,但稀释在含水溶液中却无害。

他喜欢反驳懒惰的思维。'要记住实际的数据,而不是名义上的近似值,'他坚决地说,用一把勺子敲着窗格玻璃。他没有半点轻视的语气地告诉我们,原子力学不是疯狂的魔法,而是细致的笔记记录。他警告说,一次冲动的实验可能损坏仪器的形状,而且还可能把有毒的沉淀物倒进学校的下水道。

他的过往是一段配得上不朽灵魂的冒险旅程。在教书之前,他曾是一名飞行员,后来短暂地当过步兵军官,他果断地拒绝了一道法西斯命令,因此被拘留。那时他认识到,真正的勇气对他人无害,并能保护弱者。那一句话塑造了他终身教学的渴望。

周末,他经营着一座挨着小牧场的农舍,迁徙的候鸟和一只行动缓慢的乌龟在叶丛中共处。他种芹菜,揉面团做面包,把肉屑喂给他的狗。他喜欢在每个面包上刻下一句机智的诗。他的肾病让他出汗,但他从不抱怨痛苦。

当地制药业的繁荣曾诱使他追逐利润,但他觉得普遍共享的知识比专利的所有权更重要。他相信每个孩子都蕴藏着巨大的潜在性。'不要怀疑好奇心,'他敦促道,点燃一支灵感的火把,能照亮任何迟钝的头脑。他教我们运动中的体育精神、地震测量的精确度、三维模型的几何,甚至清洁剂如何清洗油脂汇合处的水迹。

当一位名义上的选民抱怨时,校长不得不重新储备耐心,克制脾气。在我们省里,人们会把他称作怪人,但他会坚持下去。每个春天,他看着小牧场里的花蕾萌芽,感受成长的宁静喜悦;黄昏时他会关上沉重的门,心满意足。学年末的典礼很受欢迎:七个先前曾质疑的学生站了起来。我们逐渐合理地认识到,这位被许多人称作疯子的老师,以强烈的热情给了我们人生的根基。

62. The Village Journalist at Easter

English

As a **journalist**, I never let **any** deadline **constrain** my curiosity, so one **dreary Easter** I set out to a remote **frontier** village to write more than an **incomplete novelette** about rural life. Frankly, I was an **outsider**, a city **walker** among farmers, but the people did not treat me with **stiff** suspicion.

My host, a **faithful Englishman** who had studied **geography**, served a **beautiful breakfast** of **bacon** and eggs. He would not **barter or override** my plans; instead he would **suggest** a gentle route along a **steep ridge**. 'Take your time, **do everything quickly** only when you must,' he said, and I had to agree his **propriety** was charming. He kept a tidy **database** of every **productive** harvest, written by hand on a **slate**.

We walked past a quiet **pond** where a **hedgehog** rustled through the reeds, and an army of ants marched in **accord** across a stone. A single **reed** bent in the wind, and one stray **ant** climbed the slate **counter** by the door. The damp air made my **asthma** flare, so I had to **exert** myself to keep pace. A nervous **child** would **fidget** and **growl** playfully near a **cage** that, **presently**, held nothing but a **battery**-powered toy. With a sudden **burst** of energy he would **satisfy** his urge to run. I **bet** the boy had once tried to **construct** an **interplanetary** rocket from a soup can and a **muffler**, and his only **justification** was a child's wild dream.

The local **greengrocer**, who liked to **engrave** his name on each crate, explained the **characteristic odour** of the marsh, where **biodegradable** leaves decay. **Secondly**, he warned that the old bridge was **fragile**, its timber left in **abeyance** for repair. A **burglar** had once tried to **chip** away its lock, a **mistake** that earned him the village's contempt.

There was a **similarity** between this **hillside** hamlet and a **stronghold** of an earlier age, though its **shortcoming** was poor roads. To **uphold** tradition, the people would not **corrupt** the simple life with **gloom** or greed. An **average** family here measured wealth not per **capita** but by the warmth of **matrimony** and the **heave** of honest labor. They could **put** a worn **lathe** to work, repair a **bumper**, or fix any household **appliance**.

In the cool air I could feel my **respiration** steady. I tried to **maximize** my notes, to **abbreviate** nothing of value, with great **emphasis** on the small **nicety** of daily kindness. The trust I would **accrue** here, I decided to **designate** as the real reward of the trip. A **beginner** photographer would have struggled, but I, no longer **shy**, captured the morning **condensation** on a windowpane and the **tip** of dawn on a **different**, distant peak. By the time I returned, I felt satisfied: an **atom** of truth, designated as my finest story, had been found. My mild asthma did not flare, and I did not need to exert myself to satisfy the editor; at the kitchen counter I watched a single ant cross the wood while a sudden burst of laughter filled the room. Even the **experiment** of leaving the comfortable **suite** behind, with its faint chemical odour, had been worth the **noise** of the road.

中文翻译

作为一名**记者**,我从不让任何截稿期束缚我的好奇心,所以在一个**沉闷的复活节**,我动身前往一个偏远的边境村庄,想写出比一篇不完整的中篇小说更深入的乡村生活报道。坦率地说,我是个外来者,是农民中的一个城里漫步者,但村民们并没有用生硬的怀疑对待我。

我的房东是一位**忠实的**英国人,学过**地理**,他端上了一顿美味的培根煎蛋**早餐**。他不会与我讨价还价,也不会推翻我的计划;相反,他会**建议**沿着**陡峭的山脊**走一条平缓的路线。'慢慢来,只在必须时才**迅速**做完**一切事**,'他说,我不得不承认他的得体很迷人。他用手在一块**石板**上记着一份每次丰收的整洁**数据库**。

我们走过一个安静的**池塘**,一只**刺猬**在**芦苇**丛中沙沙作响,一队**蚂蚁**齐心协力地穿过一块石头。一个紧张的孩子会在一个笼子旁**坐立不安**地嬉闹咆哮,而那笼子此刻只装着一个**电池**驱动玩具。我敢**打赌**,这男孩曾试图用一个汤罐和一个**消音器**造一枚星际火箭。

当地的蔬菜水果商喜欢在每个板条箱上刻下自己的名字,他解释了沼泽**特有的气味**——那里可生物降解的落叶腐烂。**其次**,他警告说那座旧桥很脆弱,木料搁置着等待修理。曾有个窃贼想凿开它的锁,这个**错误**为他赢得了全村的鄙视。

这个**山坡**上的小村庄与早年的一座**要塞**有某种**相似**之处,尽管它的**缺点**是道路糟糕。为了维护传统,人们不愿用阴郁或贪婪腐蚀这种简朴的生活。这里一个普通家庭衡量财富不靠人均收入,而靠婚姻的温暖和诚实劳作的奋力。他们能让一台磨损的**车床**运转,修理保险杠,或修好任何家用电器。

在凉爽的空气里,我能感到自己的**呼吸**平稳下来。我尽量最大限度地记笔记,不省略任何有价值的东西,特别**强调**日常善意的细节。一个新手摄影师会感到吃力,但我已不再害羞,捕捉到了窗玻璃上清晨的凝结水珠,以及黎明在一座**不同**的远峰上的一抹光尖。当我返回时,我感到满足:一粒被指定为我最佳故事的真理**原子**已被找到。甚至把舒适的套房连同它淡淡的化学气味抛在身后这一尝试,也值得这一路的喧嚣。

63. The Detective and the Widow's Manor

English

The case began, as so many do **now**, with a **leak** of **obscene** rumors. A **respectable merchant** had died, leaving behind a **grave** estate and a sorrowful **widow** who would **frown** at any mention of his name. As the **author** of this account, a private **detective** by trade, I **should pinpoint** the truth and not **evade** the harder questions.

I took an **inland detour** to the old manor, which sat at the **entrance** of a quiet **valley** where wildflowers seemed to **abound**. The house was a **maiden** fortress of stone, ringed by a wooden **fence**, with a **crimson** door that shimmered at dusk. A statue stood on a marble **pedestal** in the garden, an **eccentricity** of a **forefather** who had once served in the **kingdom's army** and even spoken before **congress**.

Inside, the widow sat folding **tissue** paper, her movements **ephemeral** and nervous. She did not **consider** me an enemy. 'Whatever you find, I will not **defy** the law,' she said, lighting a **cigarette** though she knew **smoking** troubled her **fitness**. I declined her offer; I **owe** my health to clean lungs. On the table lay a **binding contract** and an unpaid **grocery** bill that hinted at looming **bankruptcy**.

The local **inspector**, a man of great **proficiency**, had filed a hasty **diagnosis**: the merchant's death was natural. But the **probability** of coincidence felt thin. I would not **sympathize** with laziness. With careful **effort** I examined the **remainder** of the documents, and a **buzzword** in the **new** ledger caught my eye: 'hotelling,' a fashionable scheme that had drawn the family into **discord** and debt.

In the cellar I found a **trench** dug near the foundation, as if for a **demolition**, and traces of an **alkali secretion** staining the **earth**. A **beautician's** vial, a **burnt** match, a fishing hook meant for **carp** — each clue pulled me into a **vortex** of suspicion. The maid, on **probation** for a minor theft, had been **passionate** but loyal; her **vulnerability** made her an easy scapegoat. I refused to **denounce** her without proof.

By the **writing** of my final report, the **manifest** truth emerged: a cousin, facing **imprisonment** for fraud, had returned from the **Occident** to seize the inheritance. He had been **lewd** in life and ruthless in greed, no better than a poacher who would **cap** a man's days for **wealth**. Yet justice, **sweet** and slow, found him. I **congratulate** no one for such grim work, but at the **fulfillment** of the case I felt, for one **quarter** of an hour, almost as light as a child at a **skating** rink, or a sailor who believes a **mermaid** truly does **exist** beneath the waves. I set down my **arms**, my **hoe** of inquiry, and a **choir** of relief sang in my tired mind.

From the **beginning** I had sensed a **psychological** pattern: greed tends to recur with alarming **frequency**, an **epidemic** of the soul that no **restorative** tonic can cure. The merchant's **offspring** would now **reside** elsewhere, and I hoped the lesson would **reinforce** their better instincts. As I stood to leave, I let my hand **brush** the cold stone wall and watched the lake **shimmer** one last time. The **generous** widow pressed a folded note of thanks into my palm; I did not unfold it, but I would not **fold** under guilt either, for I had done my duty and would **stand** by every word.

中文翻译

案子的**开端**,如今很多案子都这样,起于一桩猥亵谣言的泄露。一位受人尊敬的**商人**去世了,留下一份**庄重的**产业和一位悲伤的**寡妇**,她一听到他的名字就**皱眉**。作为这份记录的**作者**、一名以私家**侦探**为业的人,我应当**查明真相**,而不回避那些更棘手的问题。

我**绕道**内陆来到那座古老的庄园,它坐落在一处宁静山谷的**入口**,那里似乎遍地野花。这房子是一座石砌的处女堡垒,围着木栅栏,一扇**深红色**的门在黄昏时微微闪光。花园里一座雕像立在大理石基座上,那是一位先祖的怪癖,他曾在**王国的军队**服役,甚至在国会前发言过。

屋里,寡妇坐着叠薄**棉纸**,动作短暂而紧张。她并不把我当成敌人。'无论你查出什么,我都不会**违抗**法律,'她说着点燃一支**香烟**,尽管她知道吸烟有损她的**健康**。我谢绝了她的好意;我的健康得益于洁净的肺。桌上放着一份有约束力的**合同**和一张未付的杂货账单,暗示着迫近的**破产**。

当地的督察是个十分精通业务的人,他草草下了**诊断**:商人是自然死亡。但巧合的**概率**显得太低。我不会**同情**懒惰。我费心查看了**剩下的**文件,新账本里一个时髦词引起了我的注意:'hotelling',一种把这家人拖入**不和**与债务的流行方案。

在地窖里,我发现地基附近挖了一道沟,仿佛为**拆除**而备,**泥土**上还染着一种碱性**分泌物的**痕迹。一只**美容师**的小瓶、一根烧过的火柴、一只钓**鲤鱼**用的钩子——每条线索都把我卷入怀疑的漩涡。那名女仆因一桩小偷窃正在**缓刑**期,她热情却忠诚;她的脆弱使她成了易被牺牲的替罪羊。没有证据,我拒绝**谴责**她。

写最后报告时,显而易见的真相浮现了:一个因诈骗面临**监禁**的表亲,从**西方**归来要夺取遗产。他生前淫荡、贪婪而冷酷,不比一个为**财富**而结束他人生命的偷猎者强多少。然而,正义虽迟而甜美,终于找上了他。我不为这种阴郁的工作向任何人道贺,但案子了结时,我有那么**一刻钟**感到几乎像**滑冰**场上的孩子般轻松,又像一个相信浪花下确有**美人鱼存在**的水手。我放下我的**武器**、我探究的锄头,一支宽慰的合唱在我疲惫的脑中响起。

64. Backstage Before the Revolution Play

English

The **theory** behind a great **rehearsal** is simple, yet the actual work is **messy**. On a cold **Paris evening** just before **Christmas**, the **entire personnel** of our small theater gathered to **remove** the dust from an old **framework** of a stage set. We had a **war** drama to perform, set during a **revolution**, and the script demanded precision.

The **senior** director, a **rigid** man with sharp **insight**, refused to **overestimate** our readiness. 'Hopefully,' he said, 'we will not have to **cancel**.' His **objective** was clear: a flawless **collection** of scenes. He would not **pardon** a single dropped **word**. When a junior actor began to **brag** about his talent, the director gave him an **ironic**, almost contemptuous glance, and the young man's confidence began to **droop**.

Backstage smelled of **rubber**, fresh **grain** stored in the corner, and the faint **moisture** of a leaking **pole** near the **cabin** door. A **pet sparrow**, **familiar** to us all, hopped along a **thread** of light. Someone had to **stir** the glue and fix the **rickety** props, which were **imperfect** and **somewhat unsatisfactory**. We had to **accumulate** patience; the holdup over a missing **jewel** nearly drove us insane with a **tumult** of complaints.

My own **specialty** was **insulation** and lighting — the **analogue** dials, the **radar**-like dimmer, the **booth** where I sat. I felt **dizzy** from the long hours, my eyes ready to **upset** into sleep. The **chorus** rehearsed in the **northern** wing while a **fatuous** critic from a **marine** journal made a fatuous, **insipid** remark and tried to **disclaim** any earlier praise. I did not **grieve**; I simply marked his **mannerism** in my notes and moved on.

There was always **intrigue** among the cast. The **housekeeper** alleged that the lead actress, who played a **commander**, had been detained at a **hold-up** on the **highway**. A **jury** of gossips formed at once. In **compliance** with the rules, I crossed to her dressing room to check. She was fine, only fatigued, and grumbled about a **sporadic** — sporadic — headache and the **dirty** mirror. (Even now I correct my own spelling.) Her **subliminal** fear of failure was, frankly, the only real **desolation** in the room.

When at last the curtain rose, all our **relaxation** vanished. The **execution** was nearly perfect. Not one **litre** of effort was wasted. The audience, **twentieth**-century skeptics though they were, sat in **opportune** silence. No **ghost** of doubt remained. A **robbery** of nerves had given way to triumph, and even the ghost of stage fright, that old **junk** of the mind, melted like a pet in sunlight. We had subordinated our pride to the play, and the **dream** we shared made every senior and beginner among us feel entire.

Afterward, over a quiet **vacation**, I would **unfold** the whole **organizational** story. The play depicted a peasant **lieutenant** who raised a **sickle** as a banner and refused to be a **subordinate** to tyranny. Some critics would **allege** that the script romanticized war; that was, I admit, a fair **correction** to make. We were no **boss**-driven machine; **thrift** in budget had brought the set to a near **standstill** more than once. One actor battled **alcoholism** and would **cross** himself before each scene, his face pale beneath the red **pigment** of his makeup. Yet it was **TRUE** art. We even avoided the **demurrage** charge on our rented props by returning them early. When the final **pop** of the closing firework faded, I knew the correction of every flaw had been worth it.

中文翻译

一场精彩**排练**背后的**理论**很简单,但实际的工作却乱成一团。在圣诞前夕一个寒冷的**巴黎**夜晚,我们这家小剧院的全体**人员**聚在一起,去除一套旧舞台布景骨架上的灰尘。我们要演一出**战争**剧,背景设在一场**革命**期间,剧本要求精准。

资深导演是个刻板而眼光犀利的人,他拒绝高估我们的准备程度。'但愿,'他说,'我们不必**取消**演出。'他的目标很明确:一组完美无瑕的场景。他不会**原谅**哪怕一个漏掉的词。当一个年轻演员开始**吹嘘**自己的才华时,导演投去讽刺、近乎轻蔑的一瞥,年轻人的自信便垂落下去。

后台弥漫着**橡胶**味、角落里储存的新鲜**谷物**味,以及**船舱**门附近一根漏水柱子散发的淡淡潮气。一只大家都**熟悉**的宠物**麻雀**,沿着一缕光线蹦跳。有人得去**搅拌**胶水、修理那些摇晃、残缺、有些不尽人意的道具。我们必须**积累**耐心;为一颗丢失的**宝石**而耽搁,几乎让我们在抱怨的喧嚣中发疯。

我自己的专长是隔热和灯光——那些**模拟**刻度盘、**雷达**般的调光器,以及我所坐的小隔间。长时间工作让我头晕,眼睛随时要昏沉睡去。**合唱**队在北翼排练,一位来自海事杂志的愚蠢评论家说了句愚蠢、乏味的话,还想否认他先前的赞美。我并不悲伤;我只是在笔记里记下他的**怪癖**,继续工作。

演员中总有勾心斗角。管家声称扮演**指挥官**的女主角在**公路抢劫**中被扣留了。一群爱嚼舌根的人立刻组成了'**陪审团**'。按照规矩,我**穿过**去到她的化妆间查看。她没事,只是疲惫,抱怨着断断续续的(sporadic——我连自己的拼写都要**纠正**)头痛和那面脏镜子。她对失败的潜意识恐惧,坦白说,是这房间里唯一真正的**荒凉**。

大幕终于升起时,我们所有的松懈都消失了。表演几乎完美。没有一升的努力被浪费。观众,尽管是二十世纪的怀疑者,却在恰到好处的寂静中坐着。没有一丝怀疑的**幽灵**残留。神经的'劫掠'让位于胜利,连怯场那个心灵旧**垃圾**般的幽灵,也像阳光下的宠物般融化了。我们把骄傲从属于这出戏,我们共享的**梦想**让其中每一个资深者和新手都感到完整。

65. A Letter on Coastal Forestry and Family

English

My dear grandson, I maintain that you should plan to visit before late autumn. The prospect of showing you our peninsula is too obvious a joy to give up. Let me, in my curly handwriting, paint the home you have not seen.

From the bottom of the hill you ascend a roundabout path until, at midday, the sixth bend reveals the sea. Our neighboring forestry station sits upon a ridge, and beyond it the bottomland is so vulnerable to flooding that engineers had to dredge the channel and run a parallel canal. I once worked as an engineer there, before I became a humble client of the local government and a beneficiary of its pension.

The people here are persistent and full of perseverance. They educate their children well; comprehension and good orientation toward work are valued more than wealth. Furthermore, they keep a quiet conformity, though no one is truant from honest labor. I will not misrepresent them: a few are jealous, a few mediocre, and one bizarre old miser even tried to defraud his own affiliate over a tiny inventory of borrowings. The malpractice was obvious, and the announcement of his guilt brought a sensational, almost dramatic stir. Frankly it was a grim, sultry scandal, and absolutely no one will entitle him to forgiveness.

I must not detract from the beauty, though. At dawn a husky fisherman taps on my pane to sell rice and fresh fish on a dish. A caterpillar inches across the hearth; a curly napkin of mist wraps the bay. I electrify the lamp, fold a charter map, and feel the fibre of contentment. The childish part of me still longs to chase the migration of birds, to watch them recur each season and congregate over the pit where the old grease pump rusts.

There is a fault in my health, I confess. A persistent pathos has settled in my chest, and the bilateral ache will not fulfil any promise of recovery. The fault is not grim enough to grieve over. I refuse a stereotype of the lonely old philosopher; I am no gullible fool. A volt of energy still runs through me when I contact old friends by airmail or tape, or when the liaison officer from the conservatory sends an inadequate but kind note.

Yesterday's newspaper carried an enlargement of an old photograph, its color faded, showing a band of fishermen near the prison wall by the harbor's opening. The sight did overwhelm me; afterward I sat in silence for a feminine, gentle hour, not worth a single penny of complaint, until the urge to command my own grief returned. Do not let dissimilar opinions detract you, nor let any bourgeois pride beneath your years protract your decision. Some call the journey roundabout; I call it worthy. Come, and we will misrepresent nothing, only sit by the hearth and talk well into the sultry, grease-scented night. Your loving grandfather.

中文翻译

我亲爱的孙子,我坚持认为你应该计划在深秋之前来访。让你看看我们的半岛,这份喜悦太明显了,不容放弃。让我用我潦草的字迹,为你描绘那个你尚未见过的家。

从山脚下你沿着一条迂回的小路上行,直到正午,第六个弯处大海便显露出来。我们邻近的林业站坐落在一道山脊上,再往下的低地极易遭受洪水,工程师们不得不疏浚河道并开凿一条平行的运河。我曾在那里当过工程师,后来成了当地政府卑微的客户,也是其养老金的受益人。

这里的人坚韧而充满毅力。他们把孩子教育得很好;理解力和良好的工作取向比财富更受重视。此外,他们保持着一种安静的一致性,尽管没有人逃避诚实的劳动。我不会歪曲他们:有几个爱嫉妒,有几个平庸,还有一个古怪的老守财奴甚至想在一小笔借款的账目上欺骗自己的合伙人。这种渎职行为很明显,他罪行的公布引起了轰动、几乎戏剧性的骚动。坦白说那是一桩冷酷而闷热的丑闻,绝对没有人会赋予他原谅。

不过我不该贬损这里的美。黎明时一个噪音沙哑的渔夫敲我的窗格,在盘子里卖米和鲜鱼。一条毛虫爬过炉膛;卷曲如餐巾的雾包裹着海湾。我点亮灯,叠起一张租用的地图,感到知足的纤维。我心中孩子气的那一面仍渴望追逐候鸟的迁徙,看它们每个季节重现,聚集在那台旧润滑油泵生锈的坑洞上空。

我承认,我的健康有个缺陷。一种持续的悲怆已落在我胸口,这双侧的疼痛不会兑现任何康复的承诺。这缺陷还不至于严重到要为之悲伤。我拒绝孤独老哲学家的刻板形象;我不是个轻信的傻瓜。当我用航空信或录音带联系老友,或当疗养院的联络官寄来一张不够充分却善意的便条时,仍有一伏电流穿过我身。

别让不同的意见使你分心,也别让你年纪之下的某种市侩骄傲拖延你的决定。有人说这趟旅程迂回;我却说它值得。来吧,我们不会歪曲任何事,只坐在炉边,一直聊到那闷热、弥漫着油脂味的夜晚深处。爱你的祖父。

66. From a Mule Path to the Stars

English

Whence comes the human urge to explore? Every explorer, from the rural shepherd who once drove a stubborn mule along a stormy mountain passage to the modern astronaut, shares one robust mentality: the longing to escape the known zone and touch the unknown. I propose we test this idea by following a simple, dramatic story.

A notorious miser of a village, a superstitious man accustomed to counting every penny, once mocked a young boy who read journalism by candlelight and kept a glossary of difficult words. The boy was no ordinary child. Often he would lean over an editorial about France, about a centennial celebration of flight, and dream. His parents had to wean him from idle play, but his intelligence was remarkable, his oral fluency elegant beyond his years.

At boarding school the boy learned the formulation of nutrition, the chemistry of nitrogen and aluminum, and how a polymer could be shaped into a functional prototype. He studied the concentric rings of a thermal engine and the way a single ray of light behaves. A reasonable teacher helped codify his scattered notes. He would not discard a half-formed idea; instead he would repair it, refine it, and excite his audience with the result.

Years later, after a painful layoff from a pricing office where a cruel deed and a corporate prosecution had soured the mood, he turned to research. Financing was thin. He sent a hopeful telefax, then waited a single minute that felt like a misery. The outlay was huge, the malady of doubt real, and a slow microbe of fear gnawed at him. Yet his perseverance did not fail.

He joined a federation of scientists at a conservatory of technology, where, in observance of strict safety, they would chop and weld metal, fend off every illogical objection, and cultivate new design. They printed a bold slogan above the door and held a ballot to name their first rocket. The cultivation of patience was undue but necessary. A languid afternoon could turn into a stormy night of work.

At the centennial gala, before a vast audience, he stood beneath a banner near a mock throne built for the ceremony. The newspaper called the launch an exquisite triumph; the prize was his. He had once gutted a tuna for supper and watched a rooster crow at dawn on a rural farm; now he would help send a craft beyond the reach of any mortal limb. The insertion of his small spacecraft into orbit deafened the crowd with cheers. Before that day he had to accustom himself to long nights at a coastal camp, riding a battered moped past the docks where nautical charts and a rusty razor lay forgotten. No external pressure, no salution of doubt, could deafen the steady tenor of his resolve. He felt no guilt for the effort it took to generate one new idea, and he was as gentle as a gorilla guarding its young. Whence the urge? From the simple, restless heart that refuses to agree that the sky is a ceiling. To preserve that fire, we must educate every dreamer well.

中文翻译

人类探索的冲动从何而来?每一位探索者,从曾在暴风雨的山口赶着倔强骡子前行的乡村牧人,到现代的宇航员,都共享一种坚韧的心态:渴望逃离已知的区域,触碰未知。我提议我们通过一个简单而戏剧性的故事来检验这个想法。

村里一个臭名昭著的守财奴,一个习惯于斤斤计较每一分钱的迷信之人,曾嘲笑一个借着烛光读新闻、并备着一本难词词汇表的少年。这男孩并非寻常孩子。他常常俯身在一篇关于法国、关于飞行百年纪念的社论上,做着梦。他的父母不得不让他戒掉游手好闲,但他的智力非凡,口头表达流畅,优雅得超越年龄。

在寄宿学校,男孩学习了营养的配方、氮和铝的化学,以及如何把聚合物塑造成一个功能性的原型。他研究热力发动机的同心圆环,以及单束光线的行为方式。一位通情达理的老师帮他吧零散的笔记编纂成册。他不会丢弃一个半成形的想法;相反,他会修补它、提炼它,并用成果令他的听众兴奋。

多年后,在一个定价部门经历了一次痛苦的裁员——那里一桩残忍的勾当和一场企业诉讼败坏了气氛——他转向了研究。资金紧张。他发出一份满怀希望的电传,然后等待了感觉像折磨的一分钟。开支巨大,怀疑的病痛真切,一只恐惧的缓慢微生物啃噬着他。然而他的毅力没有衰竭。

他加入了科技疗养院的一个科学家联盟,在那里,出于对严格安全规程的遵守,他们切割焊接金属,抵御每一个不合逻辑的反对,培育新的设计。他们在门上印了一句大胆的口号,并举行投票为第一枚火箭命名。耐心的培养虽过度却必要。一个慵懒的下午会变成一个暴风雨般工作的夜晚。

在百年庆典上,在众多观众面前,他站在为典礼搭建的仿王座旁的一面横幅下。报纸称这次发射是一次精致的胜利;奖项归他所有。他曾在晚餐剖开一条金枪鱼,看一只公鸡在乡村农场的黎明啼叫;如今他将帮助把一艘飞行器送到任何凡人肢体都无法企及之处。他那小小的航天器插入轨道,人群的欢呼震耳欲聋。冲动从何而来?来自那颗简单、不安、拒绝认同天空是天花板的心。为了保存那份火焰,我们必须好好教育每一个梦想家。

67. The Statistical Clown and the Circus Lobby

English

When the circus came to our town, it brought more than a lion and an acrobat. It brought a statistical puzzle that would test my knowledge. I am a linguist by training, but my favour leans toward any topic that lets me speculate freely, and I welcome the chance to trace a strange story to its end.

The lead clown, a lively and talented man, had once been a powerful seaman before a sinful gambling habit destined him for ruin. He would divert his remorse into performance, and the audience adored him. Practical and plentiful in jokes, he could make even the most ashamed child laugh until the noise seemed to elevate the whole tent. Yet behind his painted smile lurked a remorse no birthday could heal.

There was an embargo, of sorts, on his past. He would not speak of the gaol where he had served time, nor the daze of those forbidden years. A scornful rival accused him under a flimsy pretext, hoping to subsidize his own act by ruining another's fate. The complication grew dense. People in the lobby would lean in and remind one another of old rumors, untold and incredible, whereby a man's reputation could burn to ash.

I decided to salvage the truth. From the basement of the town hall, a damp room that smelled of iron and old timber, I dug out records. The mode of the old prosecution was clear: a fountain of false statements, a resonant lie repeated until it seemed true. The man was no devil. As a youth he had studied horticulture and the distillation of fragrant oils; he knew geology, kept bees, and could denominate every plant by its Latin name. He had simply erred once and paid dearly.

The circus, meanwhile, had to unite its scattered tribe of performers. A pygmy juggler, a refugee acrobat, and a donkey trainer from a distant bay all relied on the show. Their global tour — they liked to globalize their art — would collapse if the lobby gossip continued. The manager, a man of significant patience, tried to pacify the crowd. He had a disciplinary meeting, a resonant statement, and a single goal: to rid the troupe of slander.

Before the final act, I climbed to a small observatory above the market square to clear my head, mailing a note in a manila envelope addressed c/o the town clerk. To err is human, I reminded myself, and no minor slip should destine a kind man to disgrace or sow eternal evil in our hearts. I would offer no concession to cruelty. The records department had nearly let his file scorch in a fire; a careless lamp had blackened the floor and the timber beam above. A man might gorge on rumor as on poison, yet rumor is no cyanide if the truth gives us protection. After a graceful ballet by two dancers in the ring, I rose, wiped the sweat from my brow, and chose to tie my findings into a neat bundle for safekeeping.

At last the elastic truth snapped back into shape. The clown's resonant laugh returned. I felt a youthful joy as I beat my way through the curtain to congratulate him. Those who had doubted him now sat ashamed. Christianity teaches mercy, and even the scornful rival, packing his bags by the willow tree near the bay, seemed to bind his pride and ask forgiveness. The supporter of truth had won; the favour of the crowd, once divided, was whole again. I left a tip on the pillow of my hotel and walked out, blind no longer to the power of a single honest record.

中文翻译

马戏团来到我们镇上时,带来的不只是一头狮子和一个杂技演员。它带来了一个能考验我学识的统计谜题。我受过语言学训练,但我的偏好倾向于任何能让我自由推测的话题,而我欢迎这个把一个奇怪故事追查到底的机会。

那位主角小丑,一个活泼而有才华的人,曾是个强壮的水手,后来一桩罪恶的赌博习惯注定了他的毁灭。他把悔恨转化为表演,观众都爱戴他。他务实且笑话丰富,能让最羞愧的孩子笑到噪声仿佛要把整个帐篷抬起来。然而在他涂彩的笑容背后,潜伏着任何生日都无法治愈的悔恨。

对他的过去,存在着某种'禁令'。他不愿谈起他服刑的监狱,也不谈那些被禁岁月的恍惚。一个轻蔑的对手借着站不住脚的借口指控他,指望靠毁掉别人的命运来补贴自己的节目。事态变得错综复杂。大厅里的人会凑近彼此,提醒着那些未曾道出、难以置信的旧谣言,凭借这些,一个人的名誉可以化为灰烬。

我决定抢救真相。从市政厅地下室——一间散发着铁锈和旧木料气味的潮湿房间——我翻出了记录。当年那场起诉的方式很清楚:一座虚假陈述的喷泉,一个反复重复直到看似为真的洪亮谎言。这人不是恶魔。年轻时他学过园艺和芳香油的蒸馏;他懂地质学,养蜜蜂,能用拉丁名为每种植物命名。他只是错过一次,并付出了惨重代价。

与此同时,马戏团必须团结起它分散的表演者部落。一个侏儒杂耍艺人、一个难民杂技演员,还有一个来自遥远海湾的驯驴人,都依赖这场演出。他们的全球巡演——他们喜欢把自己的艺术全球化——如果大厅的闲话继续下去就会崩溃。经理是个极有耐心的人,试图安抚人群。他召开了一次纪律会议,发表了一份洪亮的声明,只有一个目标:为剧团除去诽谤。

最终,有弹性的真相弹回了原形。小丑洪亮的笑声回来了。我穿过帷幕去向他道贺时,感到一种青春的喜悦。那些曾怀疑他的人如今羞愧地坐着。基督教教导仁慈,连那个轻蔑的对手,在港湾附近柳树下收拾行李时,似乎也约束了骄傲,请求原谅。真相的支持者赢了;一度分裂的人群好感,又重归完整。我在旅馆的枕头上留下小费,走了出去,对一份诚实记录的力量不再视而不见。

68. The Apprentice at the Shipbuilding Yard

English

On the wind-swept **terrace** above the **shipbuilding** yard, **our orphan apprentice** stood each **autumn** morning, watching the **cutter** slide into the bay. His **mercurial** moods could turn from joy to **revolt** in a minute, yet our **council** of foremen agreed his **motivation** was **superb**. We did not **fabricate** praise; **honesty** was the **threshold** of our trade.

I will **describe** him plainly. He was a thin **twin** of his late brother, with the **instinctive** grace of a **saint** and the stubbornness of a mule. His **salary** was small, barely enough to **keep** him from a **vain**, empty **den** of a room, but he never complained. To **enrich** his skill he would keep a **questionnaire** of every flaw he found, and **normally** he would **transfer** each note into **triplicate** for the **keeper** of records.

The **essence** of shipbuilding is patience. One must **withhold** judgment until the **malleable** steel cools, must **avoid** the **morbid** haste that ruins a hull. A **viscous** **varnish**, a **percussion** of hammers, the **gallop** of rivet guns — all of it combined into a strange music. We taught him to **consolidate** his strength, to **pacify** his temper, and to **anchor** each plate with precision. **Nowadays** a robust **antenna** and a radar replace the old methods, but the **philosophy** of the craft does not change.

He had a weakness, I confess: an **allergic** reaction to the **topsoil** dust near the **willow** grove, which made him cough **through** the whole **length** of a shift. Yet he would not let it **supersede** his duty. When a **precedent** of carelessness threatened to **crush** morale, he would **retort** with a sharp, lucid argument and uphold the rules. His **literacy** was high; he read philosophy and even a **thesis** on the **depletion** of marine resources, and he could **authorize** a repair order without a single error.

One **shock** came when a **driver** smuggled **cocaine** in a **heap** of timber. The **furor** was immense. Some wanted to **whitewash** the scandal to protect the **payroll**; others, in the name of **justice**, demanded a full **perusal** of the books. Our apprentice, **resistant** to bribery, refused to avoid the truth. '**Otherwise**,' he said, 'our **fame** is worthless.' He was no coward.

For his **benefit** and ours, the council promoted him. At the **end** of his apprenticeship we held a small ceremony on the terrace. A **waving** banner, a **tape-recording** of an old sailor's song, the distant gallop of celebration — it felt like the launch of a **space shuttle** or a **spacecraft**, **minus** the smoke. **Sincerely**, I have rarely felt such pride. The boy who began with nothing had earned his place, and the **expression** on his face, free of **disgustful** pretense, was the truest reward of all.

Later that evening, in his plain **pyjamas**, he shared a simple meal with us: grilled **eel**, a ripe **banana**, and a **covering** of warm broth that cleared the **airway** after a dusty day. He showed no **bad** temper and asked for no **mercy**, only the **favor** of being allowed to **combine** his two great loves, the sea and honest work. A **gay**, easy laugh was a rare **trait** in one so young, yet he had it. The yard, to him, was an **oasis**, and that night, sitting near the **rear** of the hall, he confessed that every **fabrication** of doubt about his future had finally dissolved. Patience, he said, was the one **element** that made all the rest possible.

中文翻译

在造船厂上方那座迎风的露台上,我们那位孤儿学徒每个秋天早晨都站着,望着快艇滑入海湾。他变化无常的情绪能在一分钟内从喜悦转为反叛,但我们工头委员会一致认为他的积极性极好。我们不编造赞美;诚实是我们这行的门槛。

我会平地描述他。他瘦得像他已故兄弟的双胞胎,有圣人般本能的优雅和骡子般的倔强。他的薪水很低,勉强够让他不至于住进一间虚空的窝棚似的房间,但他从不抱怨。为了丰富自己的技艺,他会用一份问卷记下他发现的每个缺陷,通常他会把每条记录誊写成一式三份交给记录保管员。

造船的精髓在于耐心。人必须搁置判断,直到可塑的钢材冷却;必须避免那种毁掉船体的病态匆忙。黏稠的清漆、锤子的敲击、铆钉枪的疾驰——这一切融成一种奇异的音乐。我们教他巩固力量、平抚脾气,并以精确锚定每一块钢板。如今,坚固的天线和雷达取代了旧方法,但这门手艺的哲学不变。

我承认他有个弱点:对柳树林附近表土尘埃的过敏反应,使他整个班次都咳嗽。然而他不会让它取代职责。当一个粗心的先例威胁要压垮士气时,他会用犀利、清晰的论证反驳,维护规则。他识字水平很高;他读哲学,甚至读过一篇关于海洋资源枯竭的论文,他能毫无差错地批准一份维修单。

一次震惊出现在一名司机把可卡因藏在一堆木料里时。轩然大波极其巨大。有人想粉饰丑闻以保住工资名册;另一些人则以正义之名,要求彻底细读账目。我们的学徒抗拒贿赂,拒绝回避真相。'否则,'他说,'我们的名声一文不值。'他不是懦夫。

为了他和我们的利益,委员会提拔了他。在他学徒期结束时,我们在露台上举行了一个小小的典礼。一面挥舞的旗帜、一段老水手歌曲的录音、远处庆祝的疾驰——这感觉像航天飞机或宇宙飞船的发射,只是少了烟雾。真诚地说,我很少感到如此自豪。这个一无所有起步的男孩赢得了他的位置,而他脸上的神情,没有半点令人厌恶的伪装,是所有奖赏中最真实的。

69. The Accountant's Quiet Investigation

English

The **method** was simple, the **witness** reliable, yet the **investigation** refused to end. As the firm's **accountant**, I had to **administer** the audit of **accrued** interest dating back to a contract signed in 200 **B.C.** — well, not literally, though it felt **that** old. My **responsibility** was to **mitigate** any **error** before the **arbitration** began.

On a **normal June** morning I opened the **cupboard** where the **casting** ledgers were kept. The records, **groundless** rumor aside, showed nothing **wrong**. But a single **bell** of doubt rang in my mind. **Occasionally** a **sovereign** client will **flaunt** his wealth and **provoke** suspicion, and this **maritime** shipping magnate, a **prolific republican** donor with a **din** of opinions, was no exception. His **production** figures looked too clean.

I am **proficient** enough with numbers to know when a sum is wrong. **Under** the **explanatory** notes for the **fifth** quarter, the **supplement** to the **revision** did not add up. Was someone trying to defraud the **partake** of profits? I would not **coax** the data; I let it speak. The **arithmetic**, after some **hesitation**, revealed a missing **allotment** — a **refund** that had never reached the **cattle** ranchers in **Sweden**.

My supervisor, an **admirable** man of great **ingenuity**, was **acquainted** with the family. He had a **foible** for **melancholy silence** and a **courteous** manner, but he was no fool. '**Demolish** the false entries,' he said, 'and rebuild from the source.' His **assurance** gave me confidence. We would not **block** the truth, nor whitewash a wrong.

The **scientist** we hired to verify the casting alloys confirmed that **infertile** soil samples had been used to **corrode** the evidence — a bizarre detail. Meanwhile, the **overwrought** office grew tense. One clerk, **hoarse** from arguing, scratched at his **eyebrow** and muttered about the **sophistication** of the fraud. Another, **fond** of drama, threatened to **stop** work entirely.

By **Sunday** I had worked **overnight** more than once, surviving on **cigar** smoke and weak tea served by a forgetful **milkman's** leftover delivery. My eyes ached; I could barely **succeed** in reading the **spectacle** of figures before me. Yet **greed** had made the criminals careless. An **ignorant** assistant had left a **stapler** clipped to a page that proved the **valuation** was a lie.

The **arrival** of the auditors sealed the case. The **pier-side** warehouse, the **turkey-farm** subsidiary, the **suburbia** office — every block of the empire was **scrupulous** in appearance and rotten beneath. We would not be eligible for praise; we simply did our duty. The **occupational** pride of an honest accountant is a quiet thing. **Anybody** can chase fame, but to **contribute** to justice, to refuse the **innovation** of clever lies, to **muse** on the **circumference** of a man's character and find it sound — that is the real revision worth making. The pope of finance had fallen, and the **virile** machinery of law, courteous yet firm, took over.

In the end, the **rule** I followed was **virtually** a **script** I knew by heart: trust the numbers, take nothing as **acceptable** until checked twice. A foreign **guest** at the hearing spoke with a heavy **accent** about the old days of **colonialism**, when ledgers were salted with bribes; I made a quick **scratch** in my margin to note it. Under close **supervision**, even the magnate's lawyer had to **audition** his excuses before a skeptical panel, and not one of them held. The **salt** of honest doubt had preserved the truth.

中文翻译

方法很简单,证人很可靠,然而调查却拒绝结束。作为公司的会计,我必须主持对一份据说签于公元前200年合同的应计利息审计——好吧,不是字面意义上的,尽管感觉那么久远。我的责任是在仲裁开始前减轻任何错误。

在一个寻常的六月早晨,我打开了存放铸件账簿的橱柜。撇开毫无根据的传言,记录显示一切无误。但我心中响起一记疑虑的钟声。偶尔会有一位至高无上的客户炫耀财富、引发怀疑,而这位海运巨头——一位多产的共和党捐助者,意见喧嚣不休——也不例外。他的产量数字看起来太干净了。

我对数字足够精通,知道一笔账何时算错。在第五季度的解释性附注下,修订的补充部分对不上。是否有人企图骗取利润的分配?我不会去哄骗数据;我让它自己说话。经过一番犹豫,算术揭示了一笔缺失的拨款——一笔从未抵达瑞典养牛人手中的退款。

我的主管是个令人钦佩、极具创造力的人,与那个家族相识。他有偏爱忧郁沉默的怪癖和彬彬有礼的举止,但他绝非傻瓜。'拆掉那些虚假分录,'他说,'从源头重建。'他的保证给了我信心。我们不会阻挡真相,也不会粉饰错误。

我们雇来核验铸件合金的科学家证实,贫瘠的土壤样本曾被用来腐蚀证据——一个离奇的细节。与此同时,过度紧张的办公室气氛变得绷紧。一名职员争论得嗓子嘶哑,抓着眉毛,嘟囔着这桩骗局的精巧。另一名偏爱戏剧性的人,威胁要彻底停工。

到星期日,我已不止一次通宵工作,靠雪茄烟和一个健忘送奶工剩下投递的淡茶撑着。我的眼睛发痛;我几乎无法成功读完眼前那一大堆数字的景象。然而贪婪使罪犯们大意了。一个无知的助手把一只订书机别在了一页上,而那一页证明了估值是个谎言。

审计员的到来使案件尘埃落定。码头边的仓库、火鸡农场子公司、郊区办公室——这帝国的每一块在表面上都一丝不苟,底下却腐烂不堪。我们不会有资格获得赞誉;我们只是尽了本分。一个诚实会计的职业自豪是安静的东西。任何人都能追逐名声,但要为正义作出贡献、拒绝聪明谎言的创新、思索一个人品格的周长并发现它牢固——这才是真正值得做的修订。金融的教皇倒下了,而法律那刚健的机器,礼貌却坚定地,接管了一切。

70. The Honest Sailor and the Drowning Coast

English

An **honest sailor** named Milo took **payment** in **milk** and bread when coin was scarce, and he never grew **tired** of the sea. The **void** of the open water did not frighten him, though pirates once tried to **decorate** their flag with his blood. Sailing **northward** past an old **monastery**, he watched the tide **inundate** the lowlands while a lone **hunter** waded after game.

Milo was every captain's favorite **customer** at the harbor market, where merchants treated him **kindly**. He kept a modest **wardrobe** in a cabin, his **countless** shirts folded with one bruised **elbow** resting on the rail as he liked to **compose** songs. The town would **celebrate** his return, though some, in **disgust**, recalled the **formation** of his temper after long voyages. An **overload** of work could break a weaker man.

Near the **lavatory** of the old inn, **leftover** stew waited. A **revolutionary** mood gripped the **reality** of the docks that season: **tension** ran high. A traveling **carnivore**-keeper let his beasts **peck** and prowl, and Milo's **conviction** held firm. A bad **joint** in the pier made him **dread** the next storm, yet it was **expedient** to stay. Conditions were **conducive** to disaster. Sailors stored **dynamite** to **proclaim** the festival, and a great **tanker**, **owing** money to half the coast, threatened to **beset** the bay.

To **synchronize** the rescue boats was hard, for **weakness** in the crew was **important** to hide. Had he **ever** soared so close to ruin? When the flood came to **submerge** the lower streets, the **event** swept **them** all. Milo led them to higher ground; the **waterfront** could not **hamper** him. The **facility** for calm under pressure is rare. Men **die** when they panic, and **pollution** from the spilled **tomato** cannery only worsened the **inverse** logic of the chaos.

Registration of the missing took a week. On his **way** home, **confident** again, Milo passed a **radish** field where the salt had begun to **tarnish** the soil. He would not **obsess** over loss. **Culture**, he believed, is the **whole** of how people **utter** their grief, **whereas** a **rascal** hides it. A **peculiarity** of his **communal** village was that no one stayed **helpless** long; one **contingency** met **another**.

A single **spark** in a **narrow** alley nearly undid the recovery, but they managed to **pack** and **level** the debris, **pin** by **pin**. **Commerce** returned. The harbor began to **attract** trade again. **Amid** the **lotus** ponds, in a **lucid** evening, the **navy** raised a flag for those lost to the **extinct** old ways. Each **denomination** of grief found its **symbol**. A single **pirate**, more **conspicuous** than any **disturbance** the storm had caused, tried to **force** the survivors to give **consent** to a looting scheme, but Milo, **adept** at reading wicked men, refused. Only those of proven honesty were **eligible** to share the salvage. Watching the gulls **soar** above the calm water, he felt at peace. Milo, ever **communicative**, helped design the new **packaging** for the rescued goods, and chose to **innovate** the warning system so no town would again be caught **upside** down by the sea.

中文翻译

一个名叫米洛的诚实**水手**,在钱币稀缺时以**牛奶**和面包作为报酬,而他从不厌倦大海。开阔水域的空旷并不令他害怕,尽管**海盗**曾试图用他的血来装点**他们的**旗帜。**向北**航行经过一座古老的**修道院**时,他看着潮水**淹没**低地,一名孤独的**猎人**正涉水追逐猎物。

在港口市场,米洛是每位船长最喜欢的**顾客**,商人们待他和善。他在船舱里有一个简朴的**衣橱**,无数件衬衫叠放着,他喜欢一只擦伤的胳膊肘靠在栏杆上谱写歌曲。小镇会**庆祝**他的归来,尽管有些人**厌恶**地回忆起他长途航行后脾气的**形成**。过量的工作会击垮意志薄弱的人。

在那间老客栈的**盥洗室**附近,有剩下的炖菜在等着。那个季节,码头的**现实**被一种革命性的情绪攫住:紧张气氛**高涨**。一个流动的**食肉动物**饲养者让他的野兽啄食、徘徊,而米洛的信念依然坚定。码头上一处糟糕的接缝让他**畏惧**下一场风暴,然而留下来是**权宜之计**。条件有利于灾难发生。水手们储存**炸药**以**宣告**节日的到来,而一艘欠了半个海岸钱的大油轮,威胁要围困海湾。

要使救援船**同步**很难,因为船员的**弱点**需要重要地隐藏起来。他可曾如此接近毁灭?当洪水前来淹没下面的街道时,这场**事件**席卷了他们所有人。米洛带他们到高地;滨水区无法**阻碍**他。在压力下保持冷静的本领是罕见的。人在恐慌时会丧命,而泄漏的番茄罐头厂带来的**污染**,只让这场混乱的反向逻辑更加恶化。

失踪者的**登记**花了一周。在回家的路上,米洛重新自信起来,经过一片萝卜地,那里的盐已开始使土壤**失去光泽**。他不会执着于损失。他相信,**文化**是人们如何说出悲伤的**全部**,而**无赖**则把它藏起来。他那共有的村庄有一个特点:没有人长久地无助;一个应变接着**另一个**。

一条狭窄小巷里的一星**火花**差点毁了恢复工作,但他们设法把瓦砾**打包**并铲平,一根针一根针地。**商业**回来了。港口又开始**吸引**贸易。在莲花池塘之间,一个晴朗的傍晚,**海军**为那些消逝于已绝迹旧路的人升起一面旗。每一种悲伤的面额都找到了它的**象征**。米洛,一向善于沟通,帮助设计了获救货物的新**包装**,并选择**革新**警报系统,好让任何小镇都不会再被大海弄得天翻地覆。

71. Fieldwork on a Distant Isle

English

Lately I have come to ponder the strange Thursday when our small troupe of researchers first reached the distant isle. As the narrator of this account, I must summarize honestly, for memory tends to distort even the most rigorous notes. I still recall it vividly. We had crossed a colonial canal by an old conveyance, a rattling car whose engine seemed likely to dissolve into rust at any moment. Thunder rolled overhead, and a lone hawk did hover above the dusty shore in a wide arc. Our leader, a prudent guy trained in both anthropology and linguistics, was insistent that we identify every plant, e.g. the modest petunia along the path's fringe. He could be arrogantly certain, yet his enthusiasm was spontaneous and resilient. When a sudden squirt of rain hit us, he refused to reject the day's timetable. One Italian colleague, cheerful and clever, spent evenings teaching grammar; he loved to explain how an infinitive could carry a whole intention. He would ask a question, wait, then answer it himself. When ink would spill across his notes he only shrugged, and he joked that the island deserved its own zipcode, so far did it feel from any map. The island's welfare depended on a single mine, and the unemployment that followed its closure had bred deep dissatisfaction and quiet indignation. One old miner, leaning on a crutch, told us how the company would expel anyone who criticized its conduct, treating each complaint as a misdeed and imposing a forfeit on the careless. Such an irrevocable policy, he said with a shrill, pointed voice, was a curse. We were not loath to listen. We had come to study how a community reaches maturity, how it might neutralize despair. People here did not crave luxury; they were desperate only for fairness. They would pray, join hands, and crawl forward through every obstruction. Sometimes, when the bustle of the market faded, you could feel a slow transformation that no redundancy of hardship could erase. I summarized our findings in extensive correspondence sent home. We measured a cube of ore, weighed flour and other foodstuff, counted each casualty of the last flood, and noted the allocation of supplies. A supersonic jet once roared past, a fatty streak against the sky. We tipped the rubbish into a tin dustbin, and an associative memory of home would confuse me with longing. Yet I learned to enjoy the continuance of simple work, scalpel-sharp in its clarity. Wherever I travel now, I keep that national island in my heart, victorious in its own enduring way, and an annex of peanut shells still sits in my notebook. The Bible on the shelf and the increment of each small lesson taught me that hope, however technological the world becomes, is the most resilient foodstuff of the soul.

中文翻译

最近我常常回想起那个奇怪的星期四，我们这支小小的研究队第一次抵达那座遥远的小岛。作为这段记述的叙述者，我必须诚实地概括，因为记忆往往会扭曲哪怕是最严谨的笔记。我至今仍清晰地记得。我们乘着一辆破旧的工具——一辆嘎嘎作响的汽车——越过一条殖民时期的运河，那引擎似乎随时都可能锈蚀消融。雷声在头顶滚过，一只孤鹰在尘土飞扬的岸边盘旋，划出一道宽阔的弧线。我们的队长是个谨慎的人，受过人类学和语言学两方面的训练，他坚持要我们辨认每一种植物，例如小径边缘那株不起眼的矮牵牛花。他有时会傲慢地笃定，但他的热情却是自发而有韧性的。当一阵突来的雨水喷洒到我们身上时，他也不肯放弃当天的时间表。一位意大利同事开朗又聪明，傍晚常教我们语法；他喜欢解释一个不定式如何能承载完整的意图。他会提出一个问题，等一等，然后自己回答。墨水溅到笔记上时他只是耸耸肩，还打趣说这座岛遥远得仿佛该有自己的邮政编码。岛上的福利依赖于一座矿，而矿场关闭后带来的失业滋生了深深的不满与无声的愤慨。一位拄着拐杖的老矿工告诉我们，公司会开除任何批评其行为的人，把每一句抱怨都当作罪行，对粗心者处以罚款。他用尖锐、率直的嗓音说，这种不可撤销的政策是一种诅咒。我们并非不愿倾听。我们前来研究一个社区如何走向成熟，如何压制绝望。这里的人并不渴望奢华；他们只是不顾一切地渴求公平。他们会祈祷、携手，爬行着穿越每一道障碍。有时，当集市的喧嚣退去，你能感到一种缓慢的转变，任何苦难的冗余都无法将其抹去。我把我们的发现总结在大量寄回家的信件中。我们量了一立方的矿石，称了面粉和其它食品，清点上次洪水的每一位伤亡者，并记录了物资的分配。一架超音速喷气机曾呼啸而过，在天空划出一道含脂般的痕迹。我们把垃圾倒进一只锡制簸箕，一段联想的家乡记忆便以思念把我搅得迷惑。然而我学会了享受简单工作的延续，它像解剖刀一般清晰。无论如今我走到哪里，我都把那座属于国家的小岛留在心中，它以自己持久的方式保持着胜利的姿态，而我的笔记本里至今夹着一小撮花生壳。书架上的圣经，以及每一个小教训的增量，都教会我：希望，无论世界变得多么技术化，都是灵魂最有韧性的食粮。

72. A Booming Campus Term

English

On a bright Tuesday the new manager of our college trading club arrived to enroll fresh members and refine our plans for the term. He was an enthusiastic, imposing man, a forerunner of a more modern style, eager to abrogate the old bureaucratic rules that had made the club feel stale. Throughout the first fortnight he asked us to grasp a single motif: unity. Every unit of the group, he said expressly, should feel alive and free, not overextend itself, and the willingness of each member would be proportional to the glory we shared. He made an attractive offer to scan our messy ledgers, and his judgement was timely. We had fallen into arrear; an unfair contracted debt sat unpaid, and the bursar, a quiet insider, was uneasy about the instable books. The manager would affirm a plan, then toss the latter half aside if the numbers began to fluctuate. He took a commission only on real promotion of the club, never on infringement of trust, and his greeting each morning lifted our impatience into hope.

The club itself was a noisy place. A buzz of chatter rose as a coed panel debated which projects to publish first. One trader wanted to sell coal and brandy; a counterpart argued for a donation drive instead. "A buck is a buck," laughed an Asian student over a hat full of coins, while another, wearing an eyeglass on a cord, chewed gum and scanned a fictional business case. We studied the utility of every idea, from transshipment routes to the navigation of customs forms, and one ambitious member even proposed an aeroplane charter, which made the rest of us tease him for dreaming so big.

Our faculty guardian, a calm exponent of careful thinking, warned against alienation. He taught a little of everything: phonetics in the morning, then zoology, astrology as a joke, even a dash of plane geometry where an axial line cut a circle. He would wring his hands and pledge that knowledge, like a fairy tale, must be instructive yet fun. After class we would stroll to the river, paddle a small boat past a plank dock, and bathe in the warm light; some played soccer while others ate cereal or dessert. He kept a fire extinguisher near the coal stove and a plank shelf of Arabic and English books in the vicinity of his desk. He spoke of the militia of the mind, of how a single molecule of doubt can decay a whole argument, and of the abrasion that careless words leave on a friendship. When my stomach growled during a long meeting, he simply smiled, for he knew the booming energy of youth needs both food and rest.

中文翻译

在一个晴朗的星期二，我们大学贸易社的新经理来招收新成员，并完善我们这一学期的计划。他热情而气派，是更现代风格的先驱，急于废除那些让社团显得陈旧的官僚规矩。在头两个星期里，他要求我们领会一个主旨：团结。他明确地说，团队的每一个单元都应充满活力、自由自在，不要让自己承担过多，而每位成员的乐意程度将与我们共享的荣誉成正比。他主动提出帮我们浏览乱糟糟的账本，他的判断很及时。我们已经欠了款；一笔不公平的合同债务尚未偿还，而那位安静的知情者——会计，对不稳定的账目感到不安。经理会先肯定一个方案，一旦数字开始波动，又会把后半部分丢到一边。他只在真正推动社团发展时才收取佣金，绝不侵权，他每天早上的问候把我们的不耐烦提升为希望。

社团本身是个吵闹的地方。当男女混合的座谈小组争论先公布哪些项目时，一阵嗡嗡的闲谈声响起。一个商人想卖煤和白兰地；一个与之对应的人则主张搞一次募捐。"一块钱就是一块钱，"一位亚洲学生对着装满硬币的帽子笑道，而另一位戴着挂绳眼镜的人嚼着口香糖，浏览一个虚构的商业案例。我们研究每个想法的实用性，从转运路线到报关单的处理，甚至有位雄心勃勃的成员提议包一架飞机，逗得我们其余人取笑他想得太大。

我们的指导老师是位冷静、善于缜密思考的代表，他告诫我们要防止疏离。他什么都教一点：早上讲语音学，然后讲动物学，把占星术当笑话讲，甚至讲一点平面几何，其中一条轴线切过一个圆。他会搓着手保证，知识就像童话一样，既要有教育意义又要有趣。下课后我们会漫步到河边，划一只小船经过木板码头，沐浴在温暖的阳光里；有人踢足球，有人吃麦片或甜点。他在煤炉旁备着一只灭火器，办公桌附近的木板架上摆着阿拉伯语和英语书。他谈到心灵的"民兵"，谈到一个分子的疑虑如何能腐蚀整个论证，谈到不慎的话语会在友谊上留下的磨损。当我在漫长的会议中肚子咕咕作响时，他只是微笑，因为他知道青春那蓬勃的能量既需要食物，也需要休息。

73. The Eccentric Inventor of Pinewood

English

Everyone in our **old** village had a **nickname** for the **eccentric** who lived at the edge of the **forest**, near a leaking **dam** built of **leather** straps and **pine** logs. As a **boy** I would **wade** through the stream, **relish** the cold **ice** on its banks, and **quietly** watch him **manage** his cluttered **laboratory**. He was **outspoken** to the point of **ridicule**, yet **childlike** in his wonder, and he wore a long **robe** stained with chemicals. "**Their dogma**," he told my **dad** with **reverent sincerity**, "is **contrary** to real curiosity." He kept a chipped **jug**, an old **exercise-book** full of plots and diagrams, and a **notch** carved into the wall for every idea he could **recall**. **Recently** he had been studying **cellulose**, hoping to **redeem** a **perishable** crop and **convey** its starch into something that would not decay. His **prodigious** mind could **heighten** a small spark into a **controversial** theory; **therefore** people both admired and feared him. One afternoon a **conflict** broke out. A **pharmacist** from town arrived to **unload** a cart and, with **insignificant** patience, began to **molest** the inventor with questions, as if to **mystify** and **falsify** his work. The visitor's **literal** reading of a single **definition** seemed **deficient**, and his **condemnation** would only **exacerbate** the old man's mood. "On **behalf** of science," the inventor said, refusing to **refrain**, "I must **acknowledge** the **onset** of doubt, but I will not let it **muddle** the truth." He explained that an **infant** idea needs a **lull**, not a storm; that one **bushel** of evidence, **averagely** measured, outweighs loud opinion. He pulled the **brake** on his temper, checked the **voltage** of an old battery, and felt a **thrill** as a **colorful petal** of light bloomed from the wire. A **creature** stirred in the rafters. **Unfortunately**, the visitor only saw a **harmful** eccentric, an **exploit** of vanity, and he left in a huff, giggling like a fool. **Eventually** the **renewal** of seasons softened the quarrel. The inventor, no **solicitor** of fame, spoke of a **labor-intensive** future where even the **GNP** of a tiny republic might rise on clever, **democratic** invention. He did not **yearn** for a **cataract** of applause; **acceptance** from a few honest minds, he said, was enough. As **background** music a distant bell rang in the village **hall**. I came to understand that his strange, **physically** demanding life was its own quiet exploit, a **precipitate** of pure thought, and that he, the rightful **owner** of his dreams, was no **cancer** on our **tradition** but a gentle **distortion** of it, a man who would rather **spend** his days in truth than in comfortable lies.

Years later I would **giggle** at the memory of his workshop, a place stuffed with curious **stuff**. There was a **hole** in the roof, a trapdoor to an **underground** cellar, and shelves crowded like a cluttered **boutique** of inventions. He could **articulate** the wildest **plot** of an experiment as calmly as an **interpreter** rendering a foreign speech, and he would **rip** a flawed page from his notebook without a second thought. To this day I cannot articulate how much that strange, generous mind shaped me.

中文翻译

我们那古老的村子里，人人都给住在森林边缘的那个怪人起了**绰号**，他家就在一座用皮带和松木搭成、漏水的水坝旁。小时候我会蹚过溪流，享受岸边冰冷的冰，**静静地**看他打理那间杂乱的**实验室**。他坦率得近乎招人嘲笑，却又孩子般充满好奇，身上穿着一件沾满化学药剂的**长袍**。"他们的**教条**，"他带着**虔诚的真诚**对我**爸爸**说，"是与真正的好奇心相违背的。"他留着一只缺口的**大壶**、一本写满**情节**和图表的旧**练习簿**，还在墙上为每一个他能记起的念头刻下一道凹痕。**最近**他一直在研究**纤维素**，希望挽救一种易腐的作物，把它的淀粉转化成不会腐烂的**东西**。他那惊人的头脑能把一点小火花放大成一套有争议的理论；**因此**人们既敬佩又惧怕他。一天下午爆发了一场冲突。镇上一位**药剂师**来卸一车货，怀着微不足道的耐心，**开始**用问题纠缠这位发明家，仿佛要把他的工作搞得神秘莫测、加以**歪曲**。来客对某个**定义**的字面解读显得有欠缺，他的**谴责**只会让老人的情绪更加**恶化**。"为了科学，"发明家不肯克制地说，"我必须**承认**怀疑的开始，但我不会让它把真理搅浑。"他解释说，一个萌芽的想法需要的是平静，而非风暴；按**平均**衡量，一**蒲式耳**的证据胜过喧闹的**意见**。他给自己的脾气踩下**刹车**，检查了一节旧电池的**电压**，当一片彩色的光之**花瓣**从电线上绽放时，他感到一阵**激动**。椽子间有个**生物**动了一下。不幸的是，来客只看到一个**有害**的怪人，一桩虚荣的把戏，于是悻悻离去，像个傻瓜似的咯咯笑着。最终四季的更替缓和了这场争吵。这位并不追求名声的发明家，谈起一个**劳动密集型的**未来，在那里，哪怕一个小小共和国的**国民总收入**也可能因聪明而**民主**的发明而上升。他并不**渴望**瀑布般的掌声；他说，几个诚实头脑的**认可**就足够了。村中**礼堂**里远远地响起钟声，如**背景音乐**。我渐渐明白，他那**古怪**而又费力的生活本身就是一桩安静的壮举，是纯粹思想的**沉淀物**，而他作为自己梦想的合法主人，绝非我们**传统**身上的毒瘤，而是它温柔的一种变形——一个宁愿在真理中、也不愿在舒适谎言中度日的人。多年以后，我会笑着**回忆**起他那间工作室——一个塞满各种稀奇物件的地方。屋顶上有一个**洞**，有一扇通往地下地窖的活板门，架子上挤得像一间杂乱的精品小店，摆满了各种发明。他能像**译员**翻译外语演讲那样冷静地把最离奇的实验情节讲清楚，也会毫不犹豫地**从**笔记本上撕下一页有瑕疵的纸。直到今天，我仍无法说清那颗古怪而慷慨的心灵对我的塑造有多深。

74. The Comedian Who Repaired Old Cars

English

Whose idea was it to put a comedian in charge of a dilapidated repair garage? The reason, I think, was that laughter can revive almost anything. Our front office was a shabby room with a single teacup, a dusty bookstore catalogue, and a transistor radio that would flicker between channels. The owner, a blonde housewife turned mechanic, had inherited the place from her predecessor and refused to let one setback after another defeat her. Her partner was a striking, tactful man who could simplify any problem and soothe any angry customer. To support the business they had to compensate for years of decline. Their first job that moist morning was a hatchback whose engine made a tiresome rattle. I watched him tap the metal, kick a tyre, and digest the symptoms with acute attention. "The flavor of this fault," he joked, "is sour, like a strawberry left too long." He underlined a note on the clipboard with a clip, then asked me to hang a lamp from the derrick-like frame above. We worked on the inner shoulder of the chassis, between the wheel and the base, careful not to spill oil on the ground. A faint smell of sulphur drifted from a nearby plant where emission controls had clearly failed. He explained that rust can decompose metal the way a parasite weakens an ox, and that any modified part must be responsive and perpendicular to the axle or it will wear in succession. The whole task was hectic, almost spectacular in its mess, and the throat-tightening fumes made us pause to breathe. A mob of curious neighbours gathered at the keyhole of the door, eager to intrude, but the manager would not let them embarrass the team. With a whip-like crack of his wrench he spurred us on. Prices were rising, and an unsalable surplus of old electrical parts sat in crates; yet he treated honest accounting as a matter of integrity, never as a disgraceful trick. "Think," he said, "of the gratitude of a family whose car runs again." He had a formidable patience. When sales would plummet he sought an alternative; he would even revive a museum-piece engine, armour-plated like a dinosaur, just to keep the staff in good footing. By dusk the hatchback purred, and we were pleased. We shared cracker biscuits and amazement at our own work. A patent application lay half-finished on his desk, a premise for some future device. The supposition that a small, physical craft cannot matter is, I now believe, a miscarriage of judgement. To my amazement, the militant gloom I had carried for months simply dissolved, and I phoned my mother to relate the news, a rabbit-quick joy in my voice. That evening, nineteen of us crowded into a cheap hostel near the lake, more than ready to celebrate. Our boss told a comedy routine so silly it would amaze even a stone, mixing slapstick with a touch of gritty realism. He let his phone ring unanswered and explained, with childlike glee, how a tiny microprocessor now controls each modern engine, far smarter than the clinging grease of the old days. He had grown up on the mainland, he said, and a single kind teacher there had been the spur that set his life in motion. He liked to underline one necessary truth: that even an ox has a trochanter, a small joint that lets a great body move, and that small parts, humble as they seem, carry the weight of the whole.

中文翻译

让一个喜剧演员来管理一家破旧的修车厂，这是谁的主意？我想，原因在于笑声几乎能让任何东西复活。我们的前厅是一间破旧的屋子，只有一只茶杯、一本沾满灰尘的书店目录，还有一台会在频道间闪烁不定的晶体管收音机。老板是个由家庭主妇转行的机械师，金发碧眼，她从前任手里继承了这地方，拒绝让一个接一个的挫折击垮自己。她的合伙人是个引人注目又老练的男人，能把任何问题简化，安抚任何愤怒的顾客。为了支撑生意，他们必须弥补多年的衰退。那个潮湿的早晨他们的第一单活儿，是一辆引擎发出讨厌咔哒声的两厢车。我看着他敲敲金属，踢踢轮胎，以敏锐的专注消化着症状。"这毛病的味道，"他打趣道，"是酸的，像放太久的草莓。"他用回形针在写字板上压住一张便条，又叫我从上方那个井架似的支架上挂一盏灯。我们在底盘内侧的肩部、车轮与底座之间作业，小心不让油溅到地上。附近一家排放控制明显失灵的工厂飘来淡淡的硫磺味。他解释说，锈能像寄生虫削弱一头公牛那样分解金属，任何改装的部件都必须有响应、且与车轴垂直，否则会接连磨损。整个活儿忙乱不堪，混乱得近乎壮观，呛喉的烟气让我们不得不停下来喘气。一群好奇的邻居聚在门的钥匙孔前，急着想闯进来，但经理不许他们让团队难堪。他像甩鞭子一样啪地一响扳手，鞭策着我们。物价在涨，一批卖不出去的旧电器零件堆在木箱里；可他吧诚实的会计当作正直的事，从不当作可耻的伎俩。"想想，"他说，"一个家庭因为车又能跑了而生出的感激。"他有着难以对付的耐心。当销售骤跌时他就去找替代方案；他甚至会为一台博物馆级、像恐龙般装甲覆盖的引擎复活，只为让员工有个稳固的立足点。到黄昏时，那辆两厢车发出轻柔的轰鸣，我们很满意。我们分享着苏打饼干，对自己的成果感到惊奇。他桌上摊着一份未完成的专利申请，是某个未来装置的前提。认为一门小小的、靠双手的手艺无关紧要，这种推测，我如今相信，是一种判断的误判。令我惊讶的是，我背负数月的好战阴郁竟就这样消散了，我打电话给母亲，讲述这个消息，声音里带着兔子般敏捷的喜悦。那天晚上，我们十九个人挤进湖边一家廉价旅馆，早已迫不及待地想庆祝。老板表演了一段傻气十足、连石头都会被逗乐的喜剧，把闹剧和一点冷峻的写实主义糅在一起。他任由手机响个不停，孩子气地兴奋讲解：如今每台现代引擎都由一枚小小的微处理器控制，远比以前那粘腻的油污聪明得多。他说自己在大陆长大，那里一位善良的老师正是促使他人生启动的动力。他喜欢强调一条必要的真理：连牛都有一块转子，一个让庞大身躯得以活动的小关节；而那些看似卑微的小零件，承载着整体的重量。

75. A Diplomat's Holiday in Mexico

English

When the veteran diplomat finally took a holiday in Mexico, he was acutely aware that his usual life of diplomacy had left him starved for solitude. The republic, with its radiant light and its cultural depth, seemed the special place to dispel the monotony of endless negotiation. He would negotiate nothing here; he would simply operate as an ordinary man. On the seaside street near the consulate he rented three rooms at a site overlooking the traffic, and each morning he would rub his eyes, scan the calendar, and decide that today, too, he would do nothing decisive. A boarding card from his flight still marked the page of a poem he liked, and beside it lay a compass he no longer needed to find his way. The local peasant families, far from naive, were tenacious and proud; their welcome was an appeal to the heart rather than a negative formality. He watched a woodpecker hammer a stump, saw a hawk-like claw of shadow sway across a poisonous-looking but harmless plant, and felt his old displeasure subside. Diplomacy, he reflected, often forced a man to distort the gist of what he truly meant, to obstruct his own feelings, to inhibit every spontaneous word. Here, by contrast, the corresponding honesty of daily life was refreshing. He bought jelly and sticky sweets at a stall, paid in sterling out of habit before correctly counting the local notes the teller had given him, and laughed when the woman behind the counter, with mild disapproval, pointed out his error. An influx of tourists, he knew, could jeopardize this fragile peace; mass tourism tends to prevail and to devalue whatever it touches, hastening a kind of cultural depreciation. Yet for now the energy of the town felt grown and whole. One afternoon a sudden squall made the awnings plunge and the boats lurch; a helmet-wearing worker climbed from a manhole to inspect a flooded canal, and an inspection crew hurried enroute to the consulate. The magnitude of the storm was real, but it would not condemn the day. He thought of his heir back home, of the energy he must still summon, of the grown responsibilities he could not outdo or escape. To include this trip in his memoirs, he decided, would be erroneous only if he pretended it had changed nothing. Hence he wrote three lines in his journal, suddenly certain that an interim of rest is not a luxury but a necessity. Its lesson was simple, and he would not punish himself for learning it late: even a man sworn to serve the nation must sometimes disable the machine of duty, sway gently in the warm air, and let the special quiet of an overseas evening teach him who he is. One quiet evening he sat in a small theatre to enjoy an opera, an old fable of a crown and a lesser prince set to music. He would not deplore his earlier job in code programming, nor the cutting remarks of rivals; he raised no objection now. Like a doctor guarding a fragile fetus, he had learned that the integration of work and rest is itself an art. He would entreat no favours, sought no opium of false praise, and the dressing on an old wound finally healed. He cleaned each utensil after his simple meal, and by the conjunction of luck and patience even his past-due debts felt lighter. The treasure, he smiled, was never a mine of gold but the calm that was truly mine.

中文翻译

当这位资深外交官终于在墨西哥度假时，他敏锐地意识到，自己平日的外交生活已让他对独处极度渴求。这个共和国有着灿烂的光线和深厚的文化底蕴，似乎正是那个能驱散无尽谈判之单调的特别之地。在这里他什么都不必商订；他只会像一个普通人那样生活。在领事馆附近的海滨街道上，他租下三间俯瞰车流的房间，每天清晨他都揉揉眼睛，扫一眼日历，决定今天也照样什么都不做。一张航班的登机证还夹在他喜欢的一首诗那一页里，旁边放着一只他已不再需要用来辨路的指南针。当地的农民家庭一点也不天真，他们顽强而自豪；他们的欢迎是一种对内心的呼吁，而非消极的客套。他看着一只啄木鸟敲打树桩，看见鹰爪般的阴影在一株看似有毒实则无害的植物上摇曳，感到自己旧日的不快渐渐平息。他思忖，外交常常迫使一个人扭曲他真正想表达的要旨，阻塞自己的情感，抑制每一句脱口而出的话。而在这里，日常生活相应的诚实却令人神清气爽。他在摊位上买了果冻和黏黏的糖果，出于习惯先用英镑付账，然后才正确地数清出纳找给他的本地钞票，当柜台后的女人带着轻微的不满指出他的错误时，他笑了。他知道，游客的涌入会危及这份脆弱的安宁；大众旅游往往会盛行，会贬低它所触及的一切，加速某种文化的贬值。但此刻，这小镇的活力显得成熟而完整。一天下午，一阵突如其来的飑使遮阳棚猛地下坠，船只摇晃；一名戴头盔的工人从检修孔里爬出来查看一条被淹的渠道，一支检查队正在前往领事馆的途中匆匆赶路。风暴的量级是真实的，但它不会断送这一天。他想起家中的继承人，想起他仍须鼓起的精力，想起那些他无法胜过也无法逃避的、已然成熟的责任。他断定，把这趟旅行写进回忆录，只有在他假装它什么都没改变时才会是错误的。于是他在日记里写下三行字，忽然确信，一段休息的过渡期不是奢侈，而是必需。它的教训很简单，他不会因为学得晚而惩罚自己：即便一个发誓为国效力的人，有时也必须关停职责这台机器，在温暖的空气里轻轻摇摆，让一个海外傍晚特有的静谧告诉他，他究竟是谁。一个安静的傍晚，他坐进一家小剧院，欣赏一出歌剧——一个关于王冠与一位次要王子的古老寓言被谱成了音乐。他不会悲叹自己早年从事程序编排的工作，也不悲叹对手们尖刻的话语；如今他不再有任何异议。就像医生守护一个脆弱的胎儿，他懂得了工作与休息的结合本身就是一门艺术。他不向任何人恳求恩惠，不追求虚假赞美这种鸦片，旧伤口上的敷料终于愈合。简单的一餐后他把每件器皿都洗净，在运气与耐心的连接下，连他那些过期的债务也显得轻了。他微笑着想，宝藏从来不是一座金矿，而是那份真正属于我的宁静。

76. The Harvest at Greenhill Orchard

English

Every autumn the village **near** the **cottage** regarded the **harvest** as its single great event, and the people came to **regard** Otto, the **tidy** farmer, with quiet respect. He would **get** up at **dusk**'s opposite hour and **dress** in the dark, then drive his **tractor** across the **domestic** acres where **maize** and **hay** grew in long rows beside the **orchard**. He had learned to **cultivate** the land with **caution**, to **trust** the soil, and to **deliver** each crop to market with care. The **recognition** his produce earned **annually** surpassed that of any rival farm; even a famous **psychologist** who once came to a **conference** at the regional **headquarters** called the place a small **civilization** of its own.

Forth from the barn each morning came a bunch of helpers: a **Swiss** exchange student, a **communist** old uncle who liked to **meddle** in everyone's rows, a **foolish** but **ingenuous** boy, a **lecturer** on leave, and a **waiter** from town. They would **jot** the day's totals on a **scroll** of brown paper, then **roast** maize over coals and eat **herb**-flavored bread until their hunger, and any lingering **indigestion**, gave way to contentment. The work was **structural** and **radical** at once: it reshaped the land and the people both. Otto kept a **medical** kit for any **emergency**, a fire near the hay always under tidy control, and an old **headline** pinned to the wall to remind him how an **outbreak** of blight had once nearly ruined him. That setback had been a **quagmire** of debt; the **amount** owed had seemed formidable.

This year the maize was so abundant it threatened a glut. Rather than **monopolize** the trade, Otto would not **overtake** his smaller neighbours unfairly; he made **amends** to the lean years by giving a **lump sum** of grain to the clinic, an **offering** free of any hidden motive. He hated **tyranny** and the **terror** of debt alike, and thought it **politic**, not merely kind, to share. A **bodyguard** of geese patrolled the **lattice** fence near the **boat** pond, and beyond it a new **flyover** and a curving cutting carried traffic toward **Malaysia**-bound and **Canada**-bound ships. Otto could not **travel** far himself; his **marital** duties and a stubborn **inability** to leave the soil kept him home, though he never let that fact **disrupt** his cheer.

In the evening his daughter would do the **shopping**, then sit by the **page** of a grammar book, underlining each **noun** and learning that knowledge, like **fermentation** in **chemistry**, needs time. A **hypothetical** question—what if the rains failed?—no longer made him **numb**. He would not deplore the weather nor let a **skew** rumor **disprove** his faith in the work. **Sex** of the calf, weight of the ox, the **exhaustive adjustment** of every account: these were the plain illustrations of a good life. The **proforma** ledger balanced. Each tenant would **pay** on time, and the old stone **castle** on the hill, once thought **incompatible** with farming, now **linger** in the children's stories as a friendly ghost. So the harvest closed, not in fear, but in peace. When the last sheaf was in, the village threw a festival. A **firework** would **surpass** the stars for one brief, **potent** moment, its **width** of light blooming over the orchard. Otto, in one worn **slipper**, felt the **prick** of a thread as a **tailor** mended his coat by the **electronic** glow of a lamp, and he tugged the **zipper** of his jacket against the chill. His old fear, **latent** and once **vicious**, no longer had the power to **hurt** him; he felt almost **immune** to it now. Honest **labor**, he told the children as a final **illustration**, is the only charm that lasts.

中文翻译

每年秋天，小屋附近的村子都把收获当作唯一的大事，人们也以静默的敬意看待整洁的农夫奥托。他会在黄昏相反的时辰起床，在黑暗中穿衣，然后驾驶拖拉机驶过自家的田地，那里玉米和干草在果园旁排成长行。他学会了谨慎地耕作土地、信任泥土，并悉心地把每一茬庄稼送往市场。他的农产品每年赢得的认可超过任何对手农场；甚至有位著名心理学家曾到地区总部参加一场会议，称这里是一个自成一体的小小文明。

每天清晨从谷仓里走出一群帮手：一名瑞士交换生，一位爱管闲事、什么差都要插手的共产党员老叔，一个愚笨却坦率的男孩，一位休假的讲师，还有一名镇上的侍者。他们会把当天的总数记在一卷棕色纸上，然后在炭火上烤玉米，吃着香草味的面包，直到饥饿连同任何残存的消化不良都化为满足。这份劳作既是结构性的，又是根本性的：它同时重塑了土地与人。奥托备有应对任何紧急情况的医疗箱，干草旁的火总在整洁的掌控之下，墙上还钉着一则旧标题，提醒他一场枯萎病的爆发曾几乎毁了他。那次挫折曾是债务的泥潭，欠款之多看来令人生畏。

今年玉米丰收到了近乎过剩的地步。奥托没有垄断这桩买卖，也不愿不公平地超过更小的邻居；他向歉收的年头作出补偿，把一大笔总数的粮食捐给诊所，这份馈赠不带任何隐秘动机。他同样痛恨暴政与债务的恐怖，并认为分享既是策略，也不只是善意。一队鹅卫兵在船塘边的格子篱笆旁巡逻，篱笆之外，一座新的跨线桥和一道弯曲的开凿路面把车流引向开往马来西亚和加拿大的船。奥托自己走不远；婚姻的责任和一种顽固的离不开土地的无能让他留在家中，但他从不让这一点扰乱他的愉快。

傍晚女儿会去购物，然后坐在一本语法书的书页旁，给每个名词划线，并明白知识就像化学中的发酵，需要时间。一个假设性的问题——万一雨水不来呢？——已不再让他麻木。他不会哀叹天气，也不会让一则歪斜的谣言驳倒他对劳作的信念。牛犊的性别、公牛的体重、每一笔账目详尽的调整：这些都是美好生活朴素的例证。那本形式账簿是平的。每个佃户都会按时付款，山上那座曾被认为与农耕格格不入的老石堡，如今作为一个友善的鬼魂，徘徊在孩子们的故事里。于是收获在和平而非恐惧中落幕。最后一捆麦子归仓后，村里办起了庆典。烟火在一个短暂而有力的瞬间盖过群星，那一片光的宽度在果园上空绽放。奥托穿着磨旧的拖鞋，当裁缝在电灯的电子般微光下为他补外套时，他感到一根线的刺痛，便拉上夹克的拉链抵御寒意。他那潜伏的、曾经凶恶的旧日恐惧，已再无力量伤害他；如今他几乎对它免疫了。诚实的劳动，他作为最后一个例证告诉孩子们，是唯一持久的魅力。

77. A Studio of Light and Grief

English

The woman who chose to immigrate to the shady river town arrived with little more than a candle, an album of charcoal sketches, and an aimless hope. Apparently she had once been a novelist's muse; later she would become a studio artist whose work demonstrated a rare charm. Her beloved mentor, a Jewish lecturer of fervent temper, had taught her to capture a feeling and fix it on the page, to formulate each idea explicitly rather than leave it invisible. He was no conceited man, though his vengeance against laziness was famous; he would shove a half-finished canvas back at a pupil with a pointed, selective eye and demand they begin anew. Mainly he prized the intrinsic over the showy, the finite craft over the infinite excuse.

Her first hundred days in town were hectic. She rented a room above a directory shop, climbing a stair past a drawer of old keys, and arranged her tools on a desk below a window that let the solar light roll across the floor. A bugle from the brass band would ring through the door each Friday, and she would pause, anyhow, to listen. The idiom of the place was strange to her; she would jot each new verb and noun, each exclamation, into a notebook, learning its grade and its attributive use, as a student learns grammar. Familiarity came slowly. She felt a deep humiliation at her early errors, a resentment that bordered on grief, and more than once a hesitant cry would climb her throat as she sat below the candle.

Yet she would not deviate from her duty. The pivot of her life had become the work. She learned to blend sugar-bright pigment with the dark, to exclude what did not serve the whole, to mark each exclusion with deliberation. One night a commotion in the street, which neighbors called a near-massacre though it proved only a fuss, distracted the whole quarter; even so she kept the candle lit. By the silt-grey light of dawn she finished the piece. It showed a hare and an insect beside a basin of refreshing water, a dainty momentum of recovery after long humiliation. The exclusion of every superfluous line gave it an intrinsic calm; the appendix of notes she pinned below it explained, with finite honesty, how she had built the image from blood-warm reds. A naturally gentle critic from the town came to her living-room, climbed the stair, and stood in apparent silence. He confessed the work would not be excluded from the annual show; on the contrary, its momentum and selective grace made it a panacea for the gallery's dull season. The recovery of her confidence, fragile as a candle in wind, was complete; she had, against humiliation and grief, exalted the improper into the beautiful, and felt, for the first time, lucky. Years later technology would change her studio: she learned to dial a phone, set the ignition of a small kiln, and watch a ferrous tool glow for an hour. A modest subsidy from an egalitarian arts fund let her exalt her craft without the damage of poverty. She would affix each sketch to a long tract of board, demonstrate her method to students, and maneuver a funnel of pigment with explicit care. When prices would sag she did not despair; the completion of a true piece, she said, was worth more than a market. She kept a marble bust by the door, gave it a daily kiss for luck, and refused to let one disappointed buyer set the pitch of her mood, for she would never accompany regret. No tumour of doubt could grow where joy had taken root.

中文翻译

那个选择移居到这个绿荫蔽日、却又透着可疑气息的河边小镇的女子，到来时几乎一无所有，只带着一支蜡烛、一本炭笔速写的相册，以及一份漫无目的的希望。显然她曾是某位小说家的缪斯；后来她成了一名画室艺术家，作品散发出罕见的魅力。她敬爱的导师是一位脾气热烈的犹太讲师，他教她捕捉一种感觉并把它定格在纸上，把每一个念头明确地表达出来，而不是任它无形地消逝。他绝非自负之人，尽管他对懒惰的报复之心远近闻名；他会以率直而挑剔的眼光，把一幅半成品画布推回给学生，要他们重新开始。他主要看重内在而非张扬，看重有限的技艺而非无穷的借口。

她在镇上最初的一百天忙碌不堪。她在一家名录店楼上租了间屋子，沿着楼梯经过一只装满旧钥匙的抽屉，把工具摆在书桌上，桌子下方的窗户让阳光在地板上滚动流淌。每个星期五，铜管乐队的军号声会穿过门传来，无论如何她都会停下来聆听。这地方的习语对她来说很陌生；她会把每一个新动词、名词，每一句感叹都匆匆记进笔记本，学习它的等级和定语用法，就像学生学语法一样。熟悉感来得很慢。她为自己早期的错误感到深深的羞辱，那是一种近乎悲痛的不满，不止一次，当她坐在蜡烛下时，一声犹豫的哭喊会涌上喉咙。

然而她不愿背离自己的职责。工作已成为她生活的枢轴。她学会把糖一般明亮的颜料与暗色调和，排除一切无助于整体的东西，每一次取舍都慎重为之。一天夜里，街上发生一阵骚动，邻居们称之为近乎屠杀的事件，结果只是一场虚惊，扰乱了整个街区；即便如此她仍让蜡烛亮着。在淤泥般灰暗的黎明微光中，她完成了这幅作品。画中一只野兔和一只昆虫立在一盆清爽的水边，呈现出长久羞辱之后复原的一种轻盈动势。每一根多余线条的排除赋予它内在的宁静；她钉在画下方的注释附录，以有限的诚实解释了她如何用血一般温暖的红色构建出这幅图像。镇上一位天性温和的评论家来到她的起居室，登上楼梯，在明显的沉默中站定。他坦言这幅作品不会被排除在年展之外；恰恰相反，它的动势与精挑细选的优雅使它成为画廊沉闷季节的一剂万能良药。她信心的复原，脆弱得如同风中烛火，终于完成；她在羞辱与悲痛之中，把不合宜之物升华为美，并第一次感到自己是幸运的。多年后，科技改变了她的画室：她学会拨电话、点燃小窑炉的点火装置，看一件铁制工具灼热地发光一个小时。一笔来自平等主义艺术基金的微薄补助金，让她得以在不受贫穷损害的情况下升华自己的技艺。她会把每一张草图贴在一长条木板上，向学生演示她的方法，并以明确的细心操控一只装颜料的漏斗。当价格下跌时她并不绝望；她说，一件真作品的完成比市场更有价值。她在门边放着一尊大理石半身像，每天亲吻它求好运，绝不让一个失望的买家左右她情绪的基调，因为她永不与悔恨为伴。在喜悦扎根之处，没有任何怀疑的肿瘤能够生长。

78. A Brief Holiday in the Highland Northwest

English

Sir Edmund, a knowledgeable bachelor and amateur novelist, decided his life had grown too aimless, so he made a brief request of his travel partner: arrange a holiday in the highland of the northwest. The layout of the trip was simple. They would tramp the changeable hills, secure a gentle cottage, and let the curtain of routine fall. "Likewise," his partner said, "we should leave the phone behind." Sir Edmund gave a composed nod, sure of the plan, and slid a souvenir map and an album into his briefcase beside a handbag of snacks.

The meal on the first day was a luncheon of silk-smooth soup, milky tea, a bunch of grass-fed lamb, and a delicate dessert of starch and sugar. The waiter, an obliging man, did not overcharge them, which was a refreshing improvement on the city, where every replacement part and every model seemed unaffordable. There was no disparity here between price and worth, no pilferage, no overrule of common sense by greed. Such simplicity, Sir Edmund confessed, amused him enormously.

They hired a small fleet of boats to circle the ice-bound lake, a mile of cold and joyful water. A bachelor of leisure, he had no duty to quicken his pace; he could indulge a desire to pause, to shake off the broken rhythm of work, to initiate a slower mode of being. His partner, more hesitant, was prone to fuss; the changing weather and the milky fog would distract her, and a disagreement over the date of return briefly chilled the air. But the encouragement of the view—a plateau crowned with mesh-like cloud—soothed every worry. They did not let the disagreement linger.

Reading a borrowed text by a famous correspondent, Sir Edmund grew subjective about it all. He saw the highland as a model of secure peace, immune to the materialism and mortgage anxiety of town, free of the truce-and-war cycle of office politics. A lucky wallaby, escaped from some distant zoo, was rumored to roam the moor; the locals, ordinarily reserved, told the tale with a joyful relish. Whether a soldier's truce or an invader's retreat, every old story consisted of the same quiet courage. By the last day Sir Edmund felt the slow improvement of his spirit, and he requested, likewise, that the holiday be extended—a sure sign, he confessed with a smile, that the cure had worked. The Highland Inn, run by an obliging emperor of hospitality (so the locals teased its owner), did consist of only three rooms, but each held a quiet attraction. Sir Edmund would confess his interest in old war relics: a military cap with a frayed cuff, a model submarine, a faded photograph of a smoker leaning on a periscope. The high humidity made the air feel differently soft, and a strange yelp from a fox at night did not repel him but rather did amuse him. He had no recourse to the city now, no expedience of taxis or vaccine queues; the one drawback was that the post would not enrol his letters quickly. To pass the hours he learned to blend herbs for tea, to solicit recipes from the cook, and to chant low notes that tested his larynx. The inclusion of such small pleasures, free of any larger plan, was its own reward.

中文翻译

埃德蒙爵士，一位博学的单身汉兼业余小说家，认定自己的生活变得太过漫无目的，于是向他的旅伴提出了一个简短的请求：在西北的高地安排一次短途假期。这趟旅程的安排很简单。他们要徒步穿越变幻不定的山丘，找一处温馨的小屋住下，让日常的帷幕落下。“同样地，”他的旅伴说，“我们应该把电话留下。”埃德蒙爵士镇定地点头，对计划很有把握，把一张纪念地图和一本相册塞进公文包，旁边是一只装零食的手提包。

第一天的午餐是一顿便宴：丝绸般顺滑的汤、乳白的茶、一串草饲羊肉，以及一份用淀粉和糖做成的精致甜点。那位殷勤的侍者没有多收他们的钱，这相比城里是个令人愉快的改善——在城里，每个替换零件、每种型号似乎都贵得买不起。这里价格与价值之间没有悬殊，没有偷窃，没有贪婪对常识的否决。如此的简朴，埃德蒙爵士坦言，让他乐不可支。

他们雇了一支小船队，环绕那座冰封的湖——一英里寒冷而欢快的水面。作为一个悠闲的单身汉，他没有义务加快脚步；他可以纵情停留，抖落工作那破碎的节奏，开启一种更缓慢的存在方式。他的旅伴比较犹豫，容易大惊小怪；多变的天气和乳白的雾让她分心，一场关于返程日期的争执一度让气氛变冷。但眼前景色的鼓舞——一片高原被网状的云冠盖——抚平了一切忧虑。他们没有让分歧拖延下去。

读着一位著名记者借来的文章，埃德蒙爵士对这一切变得主观起来。他把这片高地看作安稳和平的典范，免疫于城镇的唯物主义和按揭焦虑，摆脱了办公室政治那休战与开战的循环。据说有一只走运的小袋鼠，从某个遥远的动物园逃出，在荒原上游荡；当地人平时矜持，讲起这个传说却带着欢快的津津有味。无论是士兵的休战还是入侵者的撤退，每一个古老的故事都由同样安静的勇气构成。到最后一天，埃德蒙爵士感到自己精神的缓慢好转，于是他同样请求把假期延长——他微笑着坦言，这是个确凿的迹象，说明这疗法奏效了。这家高地旅馆由一位殷勤好客、被当地人戏称为待客之帝的老板经营，确实只有三个房间，但每一间都自有一种静谧的吸引力。埃德蒙爵士会坦白自己对旧时战争遗物的兴趣：一顶袖口磨损的军帽、一艘潜艇模型、一张吸烟者倚在潜望镜旁的褪色照片。高湿度让空气感觉格外柔软，夜里狐狸奇怪的吠叫并未令他厌恶，反倒让他觉得有趣。如今他已无需依赖城市，没有出租车的便利，也没有疫苗排队；唯一的缺点是邮局不会很快登记寄出他的信。为消磨时光，他学着调和草药泡茶，向厨师恳求食谱，并低声哼唱以测试他的喉头。把这些小乐趣纳入其中，不为任何更大的计划，本身就是一种回报。

79. The Metropolitan Theatre and Its Survivor

English

In the **east** of **Britain** stands a grand **metropolitan building**, a theatre whose **standing** in the city is **immense**. Its **presidential** box, draped in **velvet** so soft that the **softness** seems **audible**, has hosted **Arab** princes and an exiled Arab emir alike. The **clever** director, a former **broker** who left the **lab** of finance for the stage, likes to **refer** to the place as a **survivor** of every **divergence** in public taste. **No. 1** on the playbill this season is a **theatrical prelude** about **crime**, **exile**, and **grace**.

The lead, a **steady** veteran of the metropolitan circle, was nearly assassinated years ago by a **bullet** meant for another; he **barely** escaped, and the **coincidence** still gives him a **chill**. Now he rehearses with immense focus, refusing to **indulge** in the **snobbery** and **fuss** of younger players. "**Respect** the text," he tells them, an **assertion** he repeats **invariably**. He will **tolerate** a missed cue, but not a **gloomy**, **prosaic** delivery that drains the drama of its charm. When a scene goes flat, he does not **bang** the table; he simply asks them to **fill** the silence with feeling.

The play itself is **enjoyable** yet **evident** in its message. A **corporate** tyrant tries to **levy** a cruel tax and **oust** a beloved governor; the people, restless dwellers of a poor district, **muster** their courage. The plot may seem **superfluous** at the **radius** of a single **inch**, but it slowly will **evolve** into a study of how grief and an **insult** can **brew** into rebellion. A **profile** of the villain emerges: timid in private, immense in cruelty in public. The **cellular** detail of each character, down to the smallest nuance, makes the whole feel **solid**.

Backstage, an old **grandfather** who has swept the floors for decades cheers every survivor of opening night. He fills a glass of brew, dots the program with a pencil, and watches the velvet curtain glide up. A **stream** of applause, an ovation, rises through the theatre. The **scarcity** of such joy in ordinary life is what keeps him here, year after year. To him the standing ovation is no superfluous ritual but a kind of **therapy**, an invariably honest **sculpture** of human feeling, carved fresh each evening from the immense and steady love of the crowd. Each theatre **dweller** and a regular smoker of a **classmate** from his youth often linger after the show. This **player** was once a **dull**, **thirsty** understudy whose **mien** betrayed deep **disappointment**; a **rift** with the **orthodox**, **possessive** old guard had nearly ended his **involvement** in the craft. But he refused to **dissatisfy** his own ambition. After a minor **incision** near his larynx and a long recovery, breathing **helium**-light and easy again, he learned to **handle** a role with **fluid** grace, to **cheer** rather than **agitate** a nervous cast, and to treat improvisation as a sacred **prerogative**. At a **plenary rehearse** before opening, the **majority** of the cast gathered around a **buffet** of **ham** sandwiches, **nickel** coffee urns, and **whiting** fish; they would **dot** napkins with notes, knot a **rope** of cues, and measure each pause to the **millimetre**. Some grumbled the **overdue invention** of a new lighting rig was an unwanted **entertainment** expense, but no one stayed dissatisfied for long. A **landed** patron, born of a **sailing** family, had funded it. By curtain the whole troupe felt, against every disappointment, that art itself could **assassinate** despair.

中文翻译

在**英国东部**矗立着一座宏伟的大都市**建筑**——一座剧院，它在这座城市中的**地位**极其崇高。它那间总统包厢用**天鹅绒**装饰，绒面柔软得仿佛那**柔和**都听得见，曾接待过**阿拉伯王子**，也接待过流亡的阿拉伯酋长。那位**聪明的**导演曾是**经纪人**，离开金融的**实验室**转投舞台，喜欢把这地方称作公众品味每一次**分歧**中的**幸存者**。本季节目单上的头号节目（No. 1）是一出关于**罪行**、**流放**与**恩典**的戏剧**序幕**。

男主角是大都市圈里一位沉稳的老手，多年前曾险些被一颗本要射向他人的**子弹暗杀**；他**勉强**逃脱，那场**巧合**至今仍让他感到一阵寒意。如今他以极大的专注**排练**，拒绝沉溺于年轻演员们的**势利**与小题大做。“**尊重**剧本，”他告诉他们，这是他始终如一重复的一句**断言**。他能**容忍**漏接的提示，却不能容忍那种郁闷、平淡的表演，把**戏剧**的魅力抽干。当一场戏演砸了，他不会猛拍桌子；他只是请他们用情感去填补那片沉默。

这出戏本身令人愉快，寓意也很明显。一个公司暴君企图**征收**残酷的税，并**驱逐**一位深受爱戴的总督；那些焦躁不安、住在贫困区的居民**鼓起**了勇气。情节在一**英寸半径**的范围里或许显得多余，但它慢慢演变为一项研究：悲痛与一次**侮辱**如何酝酿成反叛。反派的**轮廓**逐渐浮现：私下里胆怯，公开场合却残忍至极。每个角色细致入微的刻画，乃至最微小的细微差别，都让整体显得扎实。

后台，一位扫了几十年地的**老祖父**，为首演之夜的每一位幸存者**欢呼**。他斟满一杯**酿造**的酒，用铅笔在节目单上点点画画，望着天鹅绒幕布滑升起来。**一股**掌声、一阵热烈的欢呼，在剧院里升腾。普通生活中这种欢乐的稀缺，正是让他年复一年留在这里的原因。对他而言，那全场起立的喝彩绝非**多余的**仪式，而是一种**治疗**，一座始终如一、诚实的人类情感的**雕塑**，每晚都从观众那巨大而**稳定的**爱中重新雕刻而成。剧院的常客，还有他年少时一位常抽烟的**同班同学**，常在散场后流连不去。这位演员曾是个迟钝、干渴的替角，神态里透着深深的**失望**；他与正统、占有欲极强的旧派之间的裂痕，几乎终结了他对这门技艺的投入。但他不愿辜负自己的抱负。在喉部附近做了一次小**切口**、经历漫长康复、重新像**氦**气般轻松地呼吸之后，他学会以流畅而优雅的方式驾驭角色，去鼓舞而非激怒紧张的同伴，并把即兴发挥视为一种神圣的**特权**。在开演前的全体彩排上，**大多数**演员围在自助餐桌旁，桌上摆着**火腿**三明治、**镍**质咖啡壶和**白粉**色；他们用便签**点缀**餐巾，把提示像**绳子**般串起，把每个停顿精确到**毫米**。有人抱怨那套迟来的新灯光装置**发明**是一笔多余的**娱乐**开支，但没人不满太久。一位出身航海世家、已卸货上岸的赞助人出资修建了它。到落幕时，整个剧团感到，纵有种种失望，艺术本身也能刺杀绝望。

80. The Archives Expedition

English

I want to **relate**, by way of a brief **narrative**, the **past expedition** our **association** mounted under the **auspice** of a **major** university. Our **goal** was the **cemetery archives** of an ancient site in **Egypt**, where an **honorable** scholar believed a **miracle** of preservation lay buried. I packed my **briefcase** and a **portable filing** kit, **never** imagining how a single **drive** across the desert would change my view of **politics**, of **posterity**, and of myself.

The lead researcher, a **smart** and **obliging** man, was no **timid** bachelor of theory; he had real **conceptive** power. "All of us," he said, "carry the **onus** of honest work. Do not **exaggerate**, do not **generalize**, and never **defer** a hard question." His **brother-in-law**, a **creditworthy consumer**-goods broker, had funded the trip, but the man refused to let money **impose** on the science. When a **glut** of cheap rumors threatened to **infest** the project, he would simply **slam** the briefcase shut and **stride** out to clear his head.

The work was **almost** pure **chore**. We would **bore** into packed earth, **tow** equipment by **motor** across the **lot**, and **grab** any fragment the **net** of our sieve caught. A faint **wavelength** on the **metric** scanner, **equivalent** to a heartbeat, made the whole **machine vibrate**. Algae, **deuterium** traces, **kerosene** lamps, even an old **palm**-sized **trophy** of bronze emerged from the **dark**. Each **fleeting** find felt like **regeneration** of a lost world. I learned to **persevere** through **exasperation**, to **ventilate** the tomb so no one fainted, and to file every **chart faithfully**.

Incidentally, the **awkwardness** of our first week gave way to something **fashionable** among the team: a quiet pride. A **westerner** on the crew, once prone to **misunderstanding** the locals, grew to respect them; an **unkind** remark would now earn a **glide** of disapproving silence. We learned that **voting** on every decision, however **restless** it made us, kept the **autonomy** of the group intact and warded off **aggression**. The **proceeds** of the dig, the **jewelry** and the records, were never ours to own; they belonged to Egypt and to posterity. As the **silver** dawn rose over the desert and a stray **dog** trotted past my **desk** in the **garage**-turned-office, I sat at the garage table and wrote it all down, sure that this **dishonor**-free, faithfully kept account would outlast us all. On **Friday** the team would gather for a **preparatory seminar**, a relaxed **news** briefing where each **volunteer** could **dilate** on the week and not **lag** behind. We treated **experimental** methods and old methods **equally**, attentive to every **nuance**; a sample of **alga** from the tomb wall, we agreed, held no **exclusivity** over a coin. When the season ended, the locals gave us a warm **ovation** we would never forget.

中文翻译

我想以一段简短的叙述，讲述一下我们协会在一所重点大学的赞助下进行的那次过往的考察。我们的目标是埃及一处古迹的墓地档案，一位可敬的学者相信那里埋藏着一个保存完好的奇迹。我收拾好公文包和一套便携的档案管理工具，从未想过一次横穿沙漠的驾驶会如何改变我对政治、对后代、以及对自己的看法。

那位首席研究员是个聪明而热心助人的人，绝非纸上谈兵、胆怯的理论单身汉；他有真正的构想力。“我们所有人，”他说，“都肩负着诚实工作的责任。不要夸大，不要笼统概括，也绝不要推迟一个棘手的问题。”他的姻兄是位信誉良好的消费品经纪人，资助了这趟旅程，但他拒绝让金钱强加于科学之上。当大量廉价的谣言滋生、威胁到这个项目时，他只会砰地合上公文包，大步走出去清醒头脑。

这工作几乎纯是杂活。我们要钻进压实的泥土，用马达拖着设备穿过场地，抓取筛网捕到的任何碎片。公制扫描仪上一道微弱的波长，相当于一次心跳，会让整台机器震动起来。藻类、氘的痕迹、煤油灯，甚至一座古老的、手掌大小的青铜奖品，都从黑暗中浮现。每一个转瞬即逝的发现都像失落世界的再生。我学会了在愤懑中坚持，学会给墓室通风以免有人晕倒，并忠实地归档每一张图表。

顺便说一句，我们第一周的笨拙渐渐让位于团队中一种时髦的东西：一种安静的自豪。队里一位西方人，曾经容易误解当地人，后来逐渐尊重他们；如今一句不和善的话会换来一阵不以为然的沉默滑过。我们懂得了：对每个决定进行投票，尽管让我们焦躁不安，却维护了团队的自治，并防止了侵略性的争斗。发掘的收益——那些珠宝和记录——从来都不归我们所有；它们属于埃及，属于后代。当银色的黎明在沙漠上升起，一条野狗从我那设在车库改成的办公室里的书桌旁小跑而过，我坐在车库的桌前把这一切都写了下来，确信这份没有耻辱、忠实保存的记录将比我们所有人都更长久。每逢周五，团队会聚在一起开一次预备研讨会，那是一场轻松的新闻通报会，每位志愿者都可以就这一周畅谈一番，不至于落后。我们对实验性方法和旧方法一视同仁，留心每一处细微差别；我们一致认为，墓壁上的一份藻类样本并不比一枚硬币更具独家价值。当这一季结束时，当地人给了我们一阵永生难忘的热烈欢呼。

81. The Earl's Coffee Estate

English

On a **fine** morning, the **urbane earl** chose to **sit in** his study at the **northeast hub** of his estate, sipping **coffee** and reading a **memo** about the season's crop. The mansion stood at a high **altitude** above a wide **estuary**, where flat-bottomed boats still **ply** the brown water. He was a man of unusual **sanity** in troubled times, an **analytic** thinker who had **always** refused to **collaborate** with the **fascism** then spreading across the **west**.

His **primary** concern this **time** was the estate's **prosperity**, which seemed to be in slow **descent**. Earlier that year he had nearly **lost** everything. A **gaunt, miserable** winter had forced **strenuous** work on everyone, and a late frost would **freeze** the buds and **startle** the hens, whose **yolk-rich** eggs were sold along a fixed **route** into town. For years a near-**monopoly** had let his family **pamper** its workers, but a **dearth** of rain and a plague of **pest** had left the soil **brittle** and the harvest **dim**. A **stubborn bacterium** was attacking the **oak** windbreaks and even the coffee shrubs.

The **veterinary** surgeon came to **warn** him that the **drug** used on each **animal** might not **penetrate** the new strain, and he advised the earl to **integrate** modern methods rather than **sneak** by on tradition. A government **reshuffle** had done little for growers, and distant **ASEAN** trade talks threatened to reshape the whole **situation** overnight. As an **employer**, the earl decided to **exercise** patience; he would not let **outrage sabotage** his judgment, nor let worry **preoccupy** him.

He hired a young **mechanic** with an **elementary** but **concrete** grasp of machinery to repair a **vehicle** whose **exhaust** had failed, and a **discreet** agronomist to run a **qualitative** survey of the **discrete** plots. The two roles were **interdependent** and formed a useful **interface** between tradition and science: one could **untie** a tangled engine, the other could **observe** with **concentrated** care every **cubic** meter of soil. Their findings would **prove** decisive, and the fields **partially** recovered.

By the **climax** of the season the reforms had taken hold, and others rushed to **mimic** them. A national **league** of growers gave him an **award**; even the local **bishop** praised the work, and a **commuter** newspaper printed his **photograph**, though he asked them to use a **pseudonym** to avoid **superficial** fame. He refused to crush rivals, for he believed in **equity**, not the urge to **annihilate** competition. Watching the **moon** rise over the **smooth** water, he felt the **incompatibility** between greed and **humanity** dissolve. The **empty** fields would soon **enlarge** into orchards. A worker in a dripping **raincoat** walked **down** past the grain **elevator**, gave a **grin** and a **whisper** of thanks, then ran to catch the morning **bus**, and his daughter waved from the little **hairdress** shop she ran in town.

中文翻译

在一个晴朗的早晨，这位文雅的伯爵选择坐在庄园东北角中心的书房里，一边品着咖啡，一边读着一份关于本季作物的备忘录。宅邸坐落在一处俯瞰宽阔河口的高海拔之地，平底船至今仍在那褐色的水面上往来。在动荡的年代里，他是个心智格外健全的人，一位善于分析的思考者，始终拒绝与当时在西方蔓延的法西斯主义合作。

这一次他主要担心的是庄园的繁荣，它似乎正在缓慢衰落。那年早些时候他几乎失去了一切。一个憔悴而悲惨的冬天迫使每个人都艰辛劳作，一场晚来的霜冻会冻坏花蕾、惊吓母鸡，而母鸡那些蛋黄饱满的鸡蛋是沿着固定路线运进城里卖的。多年来近乎垄断的地位让他家得以纵容工人，但雨水的匮乏和害虫的肆虐使土壤变脆、收成暗淡。一种顽固的细菌正在侵袭橡树防风林，甚至侵袭咖啡灌木。

兽医前来警告他，用在每种动物身上的药物也许无法穿透这种新菌株，并建议伯爵采用现代方法，而不是靠老传统蒙混过关。一次政府改组对种植者几乎毫无帮助，遥远的东盟贸易谈判则可能在一夜之间重塑整个局面。作为雇主，伯爵决定行使耐心；他不会让愤怒破坏自己的判断，也不会让忧虑占据自己的心。

他雇了一位年轻技工，此人对机械只有初级却扎实具体的理解，来修理一辆排气系统失灵的车辆，又请了一位谨慎的农艺师对那些不连续的地块做定性调查。这两个角色相互依赖，在传统与科学之间形成了一个有用的接合面：一个能解开缠住的引擎，另一个能全神贯注地观察每一立方米土壤。他们的发现将起决定性作用，田地也部分地恢复了。

到了这一季的高潮，改革已经扎根，别人纷纷效仿。一个全国性的种植者联盟授予他一个奖项；连当地的主教都称赞这项工作，一家面向通勤者的报纸刊登了他的照片，尽管他请他们用笔名以避免肤浅的名声。他拒绝压垮对手，因为他信奉公平，而非歼灭竞争的冲动。望着月亮升起在平滑的水面上，他感到贪婪与仁爱之间的不相容渐渐消解。空荡的田野不久将扩展成果园。一名身穿滴水雨衣的工人走下坡路，经过谷物升降机，露齿一笑，低声道歉，随后跑去赶早班公共汽车，他的女儿则从她在城里经营的小美发店里挥手致意。

82. Memoir of an Industrial Town

English

In my **memoir** I wanted to **reveal**, **truly** and **explicitly**, what it felt like to grow up in a grimy town during the **era** when steel came to **industrialize** the valley. From the **standpoint** of a child, the place held a strange **magic**, though a **sober adult** would, in the dour **fashion** of grown-ups, **assume** it was merely **dingy**. It was a **distinct** world, and people there knew how to **live**. Let me **commemorate** it **calmly**, neither in **anguish** nor in **contempt**.

The town sat on the **periphery** of a great **works** whose **grid** of pipes hissed day and night. My father was a **superintendent** there, an **ambitious** but **obstinate** man who would never **capitulate** to the owners. He kept a memoir of his own, a thin **pamphlet** full of an **assortment** of complaints about **management**, which he would **ramble** through at supper. I did not **hate** the place, yet I **wonder** now how we managed to **overcome** the daily **hardship**. To weigh his grievances against the bosses, owner **versus** worker, was his favorite supper game, and he would **tally** each side on his fingers, his **metabolism** of resentment never slowing.

Mother cooked plain **cuisine**: **mutton** stew with a thick **crust** of bread, warmed quickly in our first **microwave**, an **abnormal** luxury then. We were not **well-to-do**, but we ate enough; the food was **sufficiently** filling. On winter mornings she would **adjust** my **mitten** and warn me of the **deathly** cold with calm **precaution**, an **indication** of love rather than fear. I would dash to catch the rattling **streetcar**, a **kite** of newspaper made to **scurry** past my feet, and **reach** school just as the bell rang. The way we dressed was its own austere fashion, and the seasons gave a distinct rhythm to where we would live and work.

My **tutor**, a **critic** of careless work, set a **mandatory** standard. He held the **intense** view that no pupil should **underestimate** grammar; he made us list each **antonym**, learn the **inward** logic of every sentence, and **search** a worn **catalog** of poems. He sang an old **carol** off-key, to our quiet **embarrassment**, yet there was an honest **bond** between us. He spoke with **awe** of distant cities and of the **inexorable** march of progress. I used to assume his every word was true, and I valued his **intimate** counsel; he welcomed my **input** even when the harvest of a meager **crop** made everyone short-tempered.

The **predominance** of the mills could not last. As demand began to **wane** in a **volatile** market, the company tried to **evict** whole streets and impose a **ban** on the union. There was talk of **forgery** in the accounts, and an inspector came to **adjudicate** the dispute, his findings tallying poorly with the firm's. The **realization** that the era was ending came like a **hurricane**. **Subsequent** years brought a **tragic** decline; **sewage** filled the canals, and the great **vat** in which they once mixed the alloy stood empty, every **impurity** left to rust.

Yet the people did not **masquerade** as victims. From the **outermost** cottage to the manager's house, families lived on, the **operator** and the laborer alike. Looking back from the **direction** of old age, I **feast** on these memories. The **transmission** of such stories is, I think, a **pressing** duty: to **sterilize** nothing, to record both the **disc** of the sun over the slag heaps and the awe-filled **landing** of the first jet at the new airfield that the children would one day call home.

中文翻译

在**回忆录**里，我想真实而**清晰地揭示**，在钢铁来到山谷、使这片**土地工业化**的那个年代，在一座肮脏的小镇里长大是什么**感受**。从一个孩子的角度看，这地方有种**奇异的魔力**，尽管一个**清醒的成年人**会以大人那种阴沉的派头，认定它不过是**邋遢**罢了。那是一个**独特**的世界，那里的人懂得怎样**生活**。让我**平静地纪念**它，既不带**痛苦**，也不带**轻蔑**。

小镇坐落在一座大**工厂**的**外围**，**工厂**里那一格格管道日夜嘶嘶作响。我父亲是那里的一名**负责人**，一个**有抱负却倔强**的人，从不向业主**屈服**。他自己也写了一本回忆录，一本薄薄的小**册子**，**里面**满是对**管理层**各色各样的抱怨，吃晚饭时他会絮絮叨叨地念。我并**不憎恨**那地方，可如今我不禁**惊奇**，我们是怎么设法**克服**了日常的艰辛。把他对老板们的不满掂量一番——业主对工人——是他吃晚饭时最爱玩的游戏，他会扳着手指为双方各记一笔，他那**怨恨的「新陈代谢」**从不减慢。

母亲做的是简单的饭菜：炖**羊肉**配**厚厚一层面包**硬皮，在我们第一台**微波炉**里很快热一下，那在当时是种**反常**的奢侈。我们并不**富裕**，但吃得够饱；食物足以填饱肚子。冬天的早晨，她会替我整理好**连指手套**，平静而谨慎地提醒我注意那致命的寒冷，这是爱而非恐惧的表现。我会冲过去赶那辆**当作响的有轨电车**，一只报纸做的**风筝**急速掠过我的脚边，我在铃响时恰好赶到学校。我们的穿着自有一种朴素的样式，而四季给我们将要生活和劳作的地方赋予了一种独特的节奏。

我的**老师**是个对马活计很挑剔的**批评者**，他定下了一个**强制性的**标准。他持有**强烈的**看法，认为学生绝**不应低估**语法；他让我们列出每个**反义词**，弄懂每个句子内在的逻辑，还要翻查一本破旧的诗集**目录**。他会跑调地唱一首古老的**颂歌**，让我们暗暗**尴尬**，但我们之间有一种真诚的纽带。他怀着**敬畏**谈起遥远的城市，谈起进步那**无情的**前进步伐。我曾经认定他的每句话都是对的，也珍视他**亲密**的劝导；即便贫瘠庄稼的**收成**让人人都脾气暴躁，他也欢迎我的意见。

工厂的优势地位无法长久。随着需求在**动荡的**市场**中**开始**衰退**，公司试图**驱逐**整条街的居民，并对工会下达**禁令**。账**目**里传出有伪造的说法，一位警察前来裁决这场纠纷，他的结论与公司的说法很难**吻合**。意识到那个**时代**正在终结，这种感觉像**飓风**一样袭来。随后的岁月带来了**悲惨**的衰落；**污水**灌满了运河，他们曾经用来混合合金的那口**大缸**空空荡荡，所有**杂质**都任其生锈。

然而人们并没有伪装成受害者。从**最外面**的小屋到经理的宅子，各家各户都活了下来，**操作工**和劳工一样。从暮年的**方向**回望，我细细**品味**这些记忆。我想，传承这样的故事是一项紧迫的责任：什么都不要**消毒**抹去，既要记录太阳那**圆盘**般落在炉渣堆上的景象，也要记录第一架喷气机在新机场满怀**敬畏**的降落——那机场，孩子们有一天会称之为家。

83. The Biographer at the Excavation

English

As a **biographer** and a **Swedish** documentary maker, I had to **peruse** a **plethora** of dusty papers before I could **explore** the ruined fortress where the famous **German** general had endured a long **siege**. My **forte** was patience, and the work demanded the **best** of it. The local guide, a **cheerful baker** by trade and an amateur historian by **temperament**, met me at the **mailbox** of the old post house and offered me a glass of **herbal wine**.

We drove **farther** up the **angular** ridge, past a deep **chasm** and an **inactive** gas **pipeline**, until the **field** opened before us. The **coolness** of the dawn made me **exhale** slowly. There, half buried in **powder-fine dust**, lay a **corpse** of stone: a fallen **statue** whose **terse** inscription, by no **negligible oversight** of the original mason, named the wrong king. To the **credit** of earlier scholars, the error was an honest one. I took out my **digital** camera and my survey **kit** and began to record.

The **selection** of what to film was never simple. With grave **appreciation** I framed the **diamond-shaped** courtyard, then caught a sudden **glimpse** of a carved **porpoise** on a broken **seal**. My guide, who would sometimes **harangue** tourists about **foreign** looters, grew almost **hysteric** with delight. "Do not let this **gem rot** in obscurity," he said, his voice rising in an **upward** sweep. "To **dignify** the dead is no mere **imposition**; it is a sacred **standard**."

Inside, the air smelled of old **fodder** and damp **cartilage** left from some animal that had died here. I felt a **vague** unease, the kind that can **derive** from any ruin where men once chose **suicide** over surrender. A single **dart** of light pierced a crack and seemed to **envelop** a heap of rusted armor. I did not **complain**; such moments **expend** the soul yet feed it.

We worked to **rehabilitate** the site, not to exploit it. Every **gram** and every **ton** of debris was logged. To **agonize** over each fragment would be **unworkable**, so I set a simple **criterion** and let the team **supervise** themselves while I **worship**, in my own quiet way, the craft that originated here. A foreign foundation had agreed to **expose** the find to the public through a single **broadcast**, a true **milestone**, and to underwrite the **application** for a grant whose value, the curator joked, was **inestimable**.

By dusk a small **crowd** had gathered. I heard one boy **whistle** and **overhear** another claim, with comic **superiority**, that the fort had been built to **lubricate** trade between two valleys. It was, of course, an **exception** to no rule of history; an **ailment** of pride had brought it down, **simultaneous** with famine. We loaded the last **crate**, dodged a passing flock of **poultry**, and drove home through the **suburban** lanes, the engine's **reverse** gear whining, our minds set with full **concentration** on the ancient lives we would, **sometime** soon, **retroactive** justice fulfilled, bring back into the light. Back at my desk, the **receiver** of my old phone buzzed as the museum confirmed the find; I felt a **supreme** calm, free at last of the low-grade **neurosis** that any long **process** can **originate** in a tired mind. There was no **space** now for doubt. With sincere **sympathy** for the curators who feared the project might **fail**, I promised to **undo** every careless note and rewrite the report from the start.

中文翻译

作为一名**传记作者**，也是一名**瑞典**纪录片制作人，在我能够探访那座被毁的要塞之前——那位著名的**德国**将军曾在那里**苦撑**过一场漫长的**围城**——我必须**仔细研读**大量满是灰尘的文件。耐心是我的**长处**，而这项工作需要它发挥到极致。当地向导以烤**面包**为生，**性情**上是个业余历史爱好者，他在老驿站的**信箱**旁与我会合，递给我一杯**草药酒**。

我们沿着那道棱角分明的山脊往**更远处**开去，经过一道**深坑**和一条停用的天然**气管道**，**田野**终于在我们面前展开。黎明的**凉爽**让我缓缓吐气。那里，半埋在细如**粉末**的**尘土**中，躺着一具石头的「**尸体**」：一座倒下的雕像，它那**简洁**的铭文，由于**原来**石匠并非**微不足道的疏忽**，刻错了国王的名字。但凭良心说，前辈学者的判断错误是无心的。我取出数码相机和勘测工具，开始记录。

该拍什么从来都不简单。我怀着深深的鉴赏之情取景那座**菱形**的庭院，随后忽然瞥见一枚残破印章上雕着的海**豚**。我的向导有时会就**外国**掠夺者向游客高声训话，此刻他高兴得近乎**亢奋**。「别让这块瑰宝在默默无闻中**腐烂**，」他说，声音一路上扬。「让逝者**得到** **尊崇**绝非强加之举；这是一条神圣的准则。」

里面的空气闻起来有陈旧**饲料**的味道，还混着某只死在此处的动物留下的潮湿**软骨**气息。我感到一种模糊的不安，那种不安可能源自任何一处废墟——人们曾在此**选择自杀**而非投降。一束**光**如标靶般刺过一道裂缝，仿佛包裹住一堆生锈的盔甲。我没有**抱怨**；这样的时刻耗费灵魂，却也滋养灵魂。

我们努力修复此处遗址，而非利用它。每一克、每一吨碎石都被登记在册。为每一块碎片苦恼是**行不通的**，于是我定下一个简单的**标准**，让团队自行**监督**，而我则以自己安静的方式，崇敬这里所发源的技艺。一家外国基金会同意通过一次**广播**把这一发现公之于众，这是个真正的**里程碑**，并愿意资助那笔补助金的**申请**——馆长打趣说，它的价值**无法估量**。

黄昏时，一小群人聚拢过来。我听见一个男孩**吹口哨**，又**无意中听到**另一个带着**滑稽**优越感的男孩宣称，这座堡垒是为润滑两座山谷之间的贸易而建的。这当然不违背任何历史规律；是**傲慢**这种顽疾让它倒下，与饥荒**同时发生**。我们装上最后一只木箱，躲开**一群**路过的**家禽**，沿着**郊区**的小路开车回家，引擎的倒挡发出呜呜声，我们全神贯注，心思都放在那些古人的生命上——不久之后的某一天，迟来的公正得以实现，我们会把他们重新带回光亮之中。回到书桌前，当博物馆确认这一发现时，我这部旧电话的听筒嗡嗡作响；我感到一种至高的平静，终于摆脱了任何漫长**过程**都可能在疲惫头脑中引发的轻度**神经衰弱**。此刻已没有怀疑的**空间**。我真诚地**同情**那些担心项目会**失败**的馆员，并承诺要撤销每一条草率的笔记，从头重写报告。

84. The Sculptor's Vocational Journey

English

Ms. Adair, a **venerable Scotsman** by descent and a **learner** all her life, ran a **vocational** program that taught young people to **chisel stone**. Her own **maternal** grandmother had been an **elite** craftswoman, and Ms. Adair was **loth** to let that **backbone** of skill fade. "**Compare** any **chemical** shortcut to honest labor," she would say, "and you will **return** to the chisel." Her **exterior** was stern, yet her **cognitive** frankness made students less **envious** than grateful.

The **systematic** curriculum had a **predictable, seasonal pattern**. In the warm months students worked outdoors until **sunburn** forced them under the **bungalow** roof beside the **plantation** that bordered the school. Each pupil learned to **subtract** waste from a block, to **pave** a path, and to **react** calmly when a piece cracked. The **endurance** this demanded was no small **extent** of their training; an **unfortunate** slip could ruin a week's effort, and the **disillusion** that followed tested even the most **prepared**.

One **immediate** problem that **protracted** into the **eighth** and **seventh** week was a dearth of good **mineral** stone. The **consultant** they hired, a **frank** elderly **builder**, plugged a lamp into a wall **socket** near the **temple**-shaped studio, unrolled a **sketch**, and spoke with **exalted** certainty. "This region was **once** a **hinterland** of quarries," he said. "The **industry** here could pave the way for a true revival. Let **imagination**, not mere **want**, guide you."

He was a **namesake** of a long-dead sculptor, a coincidence that delighted the **dormitory** at night. The students would compare their work, **mourn** a failed **bud** of an idea, and feel a strange **sensation** of awe at how a **plump** lump of clay could, once shaped, **redound** to their pride. To **avail** themselves of every chance, they categorized each tool and stowed it with care, lest a careless mishap **miscarry** the whole project.

Winter brought **ultraviolet** warnings and thinning **ozone** in the news, plus a **tax** debate that reached even this quiet northern town. Ms. Adair remained **obedient** to her own rule: **beauty** first, profit later. She would not let the dead weight of **difficult** bookkeeping crush the **feeling** of joy. When a wealthy patron offered to **reimburse** the cost of marble shipped from **Oceania**, she accepted, then used part of the **cannon**-shaped fountain commission to buy **cosmetics** and small wares as prizes.

The final show was magnificent. An **orchestra** played while a **balloon** drifted over the courtyard and a single **liquid** line of light traced each finished statue. Critics from as far as the **upper** coast came; some, plainly envious, called the work a **prophecy** of a new school, comparing it to the **calcium**-white classical busts of old. Ms. Adair only smiled. Her **plasma** of ambition had never been about fame. The **fascination** she felt, watching a once-obedient student grow bold, was reward enough. She picked up a fresh **ware**, examined a **sneeze**-inducing cloud of dust in the **ambient** light, and, **ineffective** tools set aside, named her favorite piece after the **nostril**-flaring lad who had carved it, sealing his **adoption** into the long, proud line of her craft. History, she liked to say, would **vindicate** the slow trades: while empires **plunder** and armies **jam** the roads in panic, while waves of **emigration** empty whole villages, a **center** of patient skill endures. She paid the marble bill in a single **instalment**, refused to **categorize** art by price, and taught each pupil to **stow** a tool and to **name** a stone with equal respect, knowing how far one lesson could **ramify** through a life.

中文翻译

阿黛尔女士，祖籍是位令人尊敬的苏格兰人，一生都是个学习者，她开办了一个职业培训项目，教年轻人雕凿石头。她自己的外祖母曾是一位精英级的女工匠，而阿黛尔女士不愿让那一脊梁般的技艺消逝。「把任何化学捷径同诚实的劳作相比，」她常说，「你最终都会回到凿子这边来。」她外表严厉，但她在认知上的坦率，让学生们与其说嫉妒，不如说感激。

这套系统化的课程有着可预测的、随季节而变的规律。温暖的月份里，学生们在户外劳作，直到晒伤迫使他们躲进与学校相邻的种植园旁那栋平房的屋顶下。每个学生都要学会从石块上削去多余的部分，铺一条路，并在作品开裂时冷静应对。这所需要的耐力，是他们训练中不小的一部分；一次不幸的失手可能毁掉一周的努力，而随之而来的幻灭，连最有准备的人也会受到考验。

一个拖延到第八周和第七周的紧迫问题，是优质矿石的匮乏。他们聘请的顾问是位坦率的年长建筑工人，他把一盏灯插进神殿状工作室旁墙上的插座，摊开一张草图，带着得意的笃定说道。「这一带从前是采石场的腹地，」他说。「这里的产业能为一场真正的复兴铺平道路。让想象力——而非单纯的匮乏——来引导你们。」

他与一位早已去世的雕刻家同名，这个巧合在夜里的宿舍里令大家欣喜。学生们会比较彼此的作品，为一个夭折的念头之芽哀叹，并对一团丰满的黏土一经塑形竟能增添他们的自豪而感到一种奇异的敬畏。为了不放过任何机会，他们给每件工具分类，小心收存，以免一次粗心的意外把整个项目搞砸、运不到目的地。

冬天带来了新闻里的紫外线警告和臭氧层变薄的消息，还有一场连这个安静北方小镇都波及到的税收辩论。阿黛尔女士仍然服从她自己的规则：美在先，利在后。她不会让繁重记账的沉重负担压垮那份喜悦的感觉。当一位富有的赞助人提出报销从大洋洲运来的大理石费用时，她接受了，随后用那笔大炮形喷泉委托项目的一部分款项买了化妆品和小物件作为奖品。

最后的展览十分壮观。一支管弦乐队演奏着，一只气球飘过庭院，一道液体般的光线勾勒出每一尊完成的雕像。远至上游海岸的评论家都来了；有些人显然心怀嫉妒，称这些作品是一个新流派的预言，把它们比作旧时钙白色的古典半身像。阿黛尔女士只是微笑。她那如血浆般的雄心从来都不是为了名声。看着一个曾经顺从的学生变得大胆，她所感到的入迷，已是足够的回报。她拿起一件新出炉的作品，在环境光中端详那团令人打喷嚏的尘埃，把低效的工具搁在一旁，用那个鼻翼张大的小伙子——正是他雕出了这件作品——的名字为自己最喜爱的作品命名，将他的「收养」封进她那条悠长而骄傲的技艺传承之中。她爱说，历史终将为这些缓慢的行当正名：当帝国掠夺、军队惊慌中堵塞道路，当一波波向外移民掏空整座村庄时，一个耐心技艺的中心却能长存。她一次付清了大理石的账单，拒绝按价格给艺术分类，并教每个学生以同样的敬意去收存一件工具、去为一块石头命名，因为她深知一堂课能在一生中分叉延展到多远。

85. A Layman's Guide to Modern Medicine

English

Before you assume that medicine is only for the **genius** or the **autonomous** specialist, **hear** a **layman explain** it in **general** terms, preferably with a **daily**, **optimistic** attitude. A **famous statesman** once said that to **know** your own body is a **religious** duty; that **proposition**, though **archaic** in **wording**, still applies. This **chapter**, free of the **artificial** gloss of a glossy **commercial**, will **equip** you with a working **vocabulary**.

Start with the basics. The body has a remarkable **elasticity**, and doctors **classify** symptoms much as you would sort **miscellaneous** items into a **basket**. Doctors **assess** each case, often **unconditional** in their care, and rarely **fastidious** to the point of cruelty. When you **apply** for a hospital **membership** or seek a **loan** to cover surgery, an **arbitrator** or auditor may review your file; an **audit** is routine, not a sign of **guilty** wrongdoing.

Consider the **flu**. It seems trivial, yet for a **minority** of patients it is grave. A **neurotic** or hysteric reaction helps no one; calm **politeness** toward the nurse in her crisp **uniform** does. If a **downpour** soaks you on the **pavement** and you feel **sour** and **desolate**, that **misgiving** is natural, but it is no excuse to **wander** off your **itinerary** of care. The **gradual** return of health is the true **excellence**.

Modern surgery can **transplant** organs, **amputate** a ruined limb, or—through **vaccination**—prevent disease before it can **saturate** the blood. A surgeon may apply **hypnosis** to soothe a patient, equip a ward with an **amber** night-light, or **scatter** staff across a busy floor like seeds across a field. Even the **indigenous** herbal lore of remote villages, once thought **illusive**, now informs commercial research; the **gush** of new data is hard to classify.

Think of the **lining** of a coat, or the **watertight** seam of a **gown**: each layer has a purpose. So too the body. A **drunkard** who poisons his liver, a **widower** who lets grief gush unchecked, a **girl** who ignores a sore throat—each underestimates the cost. The **independent** statesman, the religious **gentleman**, the **Catholic** nun, the **granddaughter** learning **English** from a **dictionary**: none is exempt. **Unless** we **modernize** our habits, we pay later.

My **random** advice, drawn from a **magnificent** body of study, is simple. Equip yourself with knowledge. Treat the **prosecutor** of bad health—neglect—as your enemy. When a **distributorship** of clinics or a **wholesale** supplier markets a product, read the **asterisk** and the fine print. A proposition that sounds too magnificent is often a **preposition** away from a trap. Stay sober in judgment, keep your **image** of health clear, and let no **embankment** of fear, no **solvency** worry, no **reappraisal** of your worth keep you from the **dining-room** of good life. Equip, assess, and act. Hospitals now **employ** physicists who study how a single **neutron** behaves in scanning equipment, and good clinics **earmark** funds for prevention rather than cure. Health is no narrow **sexual** or private secret; it is an **outdoor** matter of clean air and sunlight, of a quiet hour on a **balcony**, of returning now and then to your own **birthplace** to walk familiar paths. Turn your attention **inwards**, plant the **seed** of one good habit, and let it grow.

中文翻译

在你认定医学只属于**天才**或自主行事的专科医生**之前**，先听一位**外行**用通俗的话来**解释**它，最好带着**每日的**、**乐观的**态度。一位著名的政治家曾说，**了解**自己的身体是一种近乎宗教的责任；这个**命题**尽管**措辞古老**，却仍然适用。本章不带光鲜广告那种**矫揉造作**的浮饰，将为你配备一套实用的**词汇**。

从基础开始。身体具有**惊人的弹性**，医生给症状**分类**，就像你把**形形色色**的杂物归入一个篮子。医生评估每一个病例，常常在照护上不附带任何条件，也很少**挑剔**到残忍的地步。当你**申请**一家医院的**会员资格**，或寻求**贷款**来支付手术时，**仲裁员**或**审计员**可能会审查你的档案；审计是例行公事，并不意味着你有**罪**。

想想**流感**。它看似无足轻重，但对**少数**患者却很严重。**神经质**或歇斯底里的反应于事无补；对那位身着挺括**制服**的护士保持冷静的**礼貌**才有用。如果一场**倾盆大雨**在**人行道**上把你淋透，你感到酸楚而孤寂，那种**疑虑**是自然的，但这并不能成为你偏离护理日程的借口。健康的**逐渐**恢复才是真正的**卓越**。

现代外科能**移植**器官、截去坏死的肢体，或者——通过**接种**——在疾病**浸透**血液之前就加以预防。外科医生可以用**催眠**来安抚病人，给病房配一盏**琥珀色**的夜灯，或像把**种子**撒在田里那样把员工分散到繁忙的楼层。就连偏远村庄那些**本土的**、曾被认为虚幻的草药学问，如今也为**商业**研究提供信息；新数据的涌流很难归类。

想想一件外套的**衬里**，或一件**长袍防水**的接缝：每一层都有其用途。身体也是如此。一个毒害自己肝脏的酒鬼，一个任由悲伤无节制**涌出**的**鳏夫**，一个忽视喉咙痛的**女孩**——每个人都低估了代价。**独立的**政治家、**虔诚的**绅士、**天主教**修女、跟着**字典**学英语的**孙女**：**无人**能够例外。**除非**我们使自己的习惯**现代化**，否则日后总要付出代价。

我那随意的建议，取自一大批宏大的研究，其实很简单。给自己配备知识。把损害健康的**检察官**——疏忽——当作你的敌人。当一家诊所的**分销**机构或一个**批发**供应商推销产品时，要读那个**星号**和小字。一个听起来过于宏大的主张，往往只差一个**介词**就成了陷阱。在判断上保持清醒，让你健康的**形象**清晰，别让任何恐惧的堤坝、任何对**偿付能力**的担忧、任何对自身价值的**重新评估**，把你挡在美好生活的**餐厅**之外。**装备**、评估、行动。如今医院聘用物理学家研究单个**中子**在扫描设备中的行为，好的诊所会划拨专款用于预防而非治疗。健康并非狭隘的性方面或私人的秘密；它是关乎清新空气与阳光的户外之事，关乎在**阳台**上安静的一小时，关乎时不时回到自己的**出生地**，走一走熟悉的小路。把注意力转向**内心**，种下一个好习惯的种子，让它生长。

86. The Carpenter Who Rebuilt the Harbor Town

English

In July, a gorgeous southern light fell over the seashore town, and a lad named Tomas stood in the yard behind his cellar workshop. He was a carpenter by trade, habitual in his work, and the message that reached him that morning would change everything. The local economy had suffered a great loss; the old superstructure of the wharf had begun to creep and crumble, and the bottom-line of the council's budget looked bleak. The success of any repair was uncertain, but Tomas was not indifferent.

He loaded a barge with timber, a carton of nails, and a soda for the road. A migrant crew, lawful and hardworking, helped him stow the cargo. The shipping company had sent finished beams and planks fresh from a processing yard; the manufacturer's catalog, quoted at a cif price, promised they would not flatten or warp. Tomas would measure each one, for accurate measurement was, in his view, a requisite of any honest craft. He refused to portray cheap work as good; he had nothing but contempt for advertising that hid the exact truth, and he would enumerate every fault aloud rather than stay silent. A former apprentice, now a meat-shop owner, lent him an old mincer to grind paint pigment and a sack of crushed ore for ballast.

As they worked, a puppy crept near, and an old hostess from the inn brought clothes and a pan of food. The men did not grumble; even when a sudden clash of opinion threatened to creep into a quarrel, prudence and the foreman's authentic kindness restrained it. One worker tried to sneer at the slow pace, but Tomas would not let impatience curb the perfection he sought. "We must not impair the frame," he said, "nor inflict a hidden flaw that doom will later expose."

The scene was picturesque, almost like a mirage: vines on the southern wall, a robot crane lent by a modern firm, a wedge of light over the water. Tomas would wrap a splint of oak around a cracked post, compress the joint, and nail a carton-thin board to hide the seam. He would eliminate every weak point, encircle each pillar with iron, and reduce the risk of collapse. He would not be the cause of the harbor's downfall.

By nine that evening the men were awake but weary. A surgeon from the next avenue, summoned for a minor cut, praised their measurement and their nerve. The poison of doubt had no hold here. Tomas thought of the mercantile glory the town once knew, of the gaudy festivals, the wedding processions down the main avenue, the trail of lanterns along the pavement. He would liberate the town from decay. He picked up his nozzle and hose to clear the drain, flicked a flap of canvas over the fresh wood, and felt, despite the shameful neglect of years past, a clear and gorgeous hope. The language of good work, he knew, needs no translation; it speaks in every yard of solid timber. The robot crane hummed; the lad smiled; the harbor would live.

Later, in the town stadium, the mayor gave a ponderous monologue that some called epoch-making, though a blunt fisherman muttered, "Oh, fuck the speeches." Tomas, a former apprentice now a master, was decidedly calm. He would not be the judge of politics. He let his plans materialize on paper, enumerate each cost on a line marked cif for the imported steel and iron ore, and restrain his impatient hopes. The automatic saw whirled near a vine-covered fence. A neighbor used a mincer to prepare stuffing for a roast, and Tomas would cook a simple supper at home. He clutched a worn garment to his bosom against the night chill. This was no fiction, no idle processing of dreams; it was real work, and it was good.

中文翻译

七月，一片绚丽的南方光线洒在这座海滨小镇上，一个名叫托马斯的小伙子站在他地窖作坊后面的院子里。他以木匠为业，做事一向有条不紊，而那天早上传到他这里的消息将改变一切。当地经济遭受了巨大的损失；码头那座古老的上层建筑开始一点点下陷崩塌，议会预算的结余看上去一片黯淡。任何修缮能否成功都没有把握，但托马斯并不漠然。

他往一艘驳船上装了木料、一纸箱钉子，还有路上喝的一瓶汽水。一支合法又勤劳的外来工队帮他把货物装好。航运公司送来了成品横梁和加工好的木板；制造商的目录承诺它们不会被压平或翘曲。托马斯会一一测量，因为在他看来，精确的测量是任何诚实手艺的必备条件。他拒绝把劣质活儿粉饰成好活儿；对于那种隐瞒确切真相的广告，他只有轻蔑。

他们干活时，一只小狗悄悄凑近，客棧里一位上了年纪的女主人送来衣服和一锅食物。工人们没有抱怨；即便突然爆发的意见冲突险些演变成争吵，谨慎和工头那真诚的善意也将它克制住了。一个工人想要嘲笑这缓慢的进度，但托马斯不让急躁束缚他所追求的完美。"我们绝不能损害骨架，"他说，"也不能埋下某个迟早会被厄运揭露的隐患。"

这景象如画，几乎像一场海市蜃楼：南墙上的葡萄藤，一家现代公司借来的机器人吊车，水面上一楔形的光。托马斯用一片橡木夹板箍住一根开裂的柱子，压紧接口，又钉上一块纸盒般薄的木板来遮住接缝。他要消除每一处薄弱点，用铁把每根支柱环绕加固，降低坍塌的风险。他不愿成为这港口衰败的原因。

到那晚九点，工人们虽然醒着却已疲惫。隔壁大街上请来处理小伤口的一位外科医生，称赞了他们的测量和胆识。怀疑的毒药在这里没有立足之地。托马斯想起小镇昔日的商业辉煌，想起那些华丽的节庆、沿主街而行的婚礼队伍、人行道上一串串灯笼的痕迹。他要把小镇从腐朽中解放出来。他拿起喷嘴和水管去清理排水沟，往新木料上掀过一片帆布，尽管为过去多年那可耻的疏忽而感慨，却感到一种清晰而绚丽的希望。他知道，好手艺的语言无需翻译；它在每一码结实的木料中诉说着。机器人吊车嗡嗡作响；小伙子微笑了；港口将会活下去。

后来，在镇上的露天运动场里，市长发表了一通冗长的独白，有人称之为划时代之作，尽管一个直率的渔夫嘟囔道：「哦，去他的演讲吧。」托马斯——一个昔日的学徒，如今已是师傅——显得格外平静。他不愿做政治的评判者。他让自己的计划在纸上成形，在标着「到岸价」的一行里逐项列出进口钢材和铁矿石的成本，并克制住自己急躁的期望。一台自动锯在爬满葡萄藤的篱笆旁嗡嗡作响。一位邻居用一台绞肉机准备烤肉的填料，托马斯则要回家做一顿简单的晚饭。他把一件破旧的衣服紧紧接在胸前，抵御夜里的寒意。这不是虚构，不是对梦想的空洞加工；这是实实在在的活儿，而且是好活儿。

87. A Hot-Air Balloon Festival in April

English

Certainly the most romantic event of our year is the ballooning festival held in April, nearly at the foot of the mountain. To be there at sunrise, when the first balloon lifts and the music of a brass band drifts over the field, is to feel a zest for life that no trivial worry can deprive. I will reply at once to anyone who calls it a freak hobby: they simply have not tried it.

My uncle, a grown-up who never lost his boyish wonder, taught me the trade. He would shave at dawn, light his pipe of tobacco, and forecast the weather with an accuracy the local viewer of the weekly broadcast could not match. "The wind is erratic today," he might gasp, half out of breath, "so we adjust the diet of fuel and watch the gauge." His anatomy of the sport was thorough, almost clinical, and his yearly notes filled a thick file.

Conversely, my aunt was inefficient with the ropes but a genius with people. She would console a nervous first-timer, hush a crying child, and offer popcorn and a glass of champagne to anyone who looked pale. Her zest for hospitality gave the festival its prominence. She disliked any deception; a salesman who once tried a sly back-call to upsell cheap gear got a mute, distinctly cold reply, and she sent him off with a limp wave and a yawn.

The science is real, though laymen find it enlightening. Hot air, being neutral and light, expands and the craft rises; cool it, and you descend. A periodic check of the network of valves is mandatory. One must never underestimate the strain on the fabric, nor the threat of a sudden gust. A humanitarian group even uses balloons to extend aid to flooded country districts, dropping a supplementary parcel of food where a bomber could never safely fly.

This year a contemporary artist, a luxurious dreamer with a fortune to spend, painted his balloon to imply the migration of the locust and the grasshopper across the plain, a strange but striking image. A clinical psychologist gave a talk on the temptation to overwork and the suffering it breeds; she urged us, economically and otherwise, to rest. Even the Egyptian consul, a descendant of an ancient line, came to acclaim the show, and an old Swede in a tan jacket wept with quiet pity at its beauty.

As the climax neared, fifty balloons rose at once. A volley of cheers went up. The performance was flawless. I felt my own anguish of the past year drain away. To imply that such joy is mere escape would be to misread it; it is, rather, a phase of healing. Whatever doom the headlines forecast, here, for a few apiece-bought hours, we were free. The literature of flight, I thought, is written not in books but in the slow, ginger ascent of a single bright sphere into the morning sky, and I would borrow that feeling for as long as I could, fully and without apology, before the limp ropes called me back to earth and sleep.

If I must give a brief synopsis of why this endeavor matters, it is this. The festival's success rate is no accident; we accommodate every type of visitor, from the child who points at a platypus drawn on a banner to the retiree living on a modest annuity. Volunteers work overtime without complaint, and any variance in the schedule is posted early so no one need disagree at the gate. We expand the program each year, replacing every dead bulb in the night display and refusing to let litter contaminate the field. The crew that runs the propane will not trigger a single careless spark; safety is the prime ingredient of the whole affair. No one is dragged off to jail for a mistake, but no one cuts a corner either.

中文翻译

我们这年里最浪漫的活动，无疑是四月间几乎在山脚下举行的热气球节。在日出时分到场，当第一只气球升起、铜管乐队的音乐飘过原野时，你会感到一种对生活的热情，是任何琐碎烦恼都无法夺走的。对任何把它称作古怪嗜好的人，我会立刻回应：他们只是没尝试过罢了。

我叔叔是个从未失去孩童般好奇心的成年人，是他把这门手艺教给我的。他会在黎明刮胡子，点上一斗烟草，预报天气的准确度连每周收看广播的本地观众都比不上。"今天的风变化无常，"他会气喘吁吁地说，"所以我们要调整燃料的'食量'，盯着仪表看。"他对这项运动的剖析十分透彻，几乎像临床分析，他每年的笔记装满了厚厚一摞文件。

相反，我婶婶摆弄绳索很笨拙，可与人打交道却是个天才。她会安慰紧张的新手，哄住啼哭的孩子，给任何脸色发白的人递上爆米花和一杯香槟。她待客的热情让这个节庆声名远扬。她讨厌任何欺骗；曾有个推销员想用狡猾的二次回访来推销廉价装备，得到的是一个无声、明显冷淡的答复，她对他懒懒地挥挥手、打个呵欠，就把他打发走了。

其中的科学是真实的，尽管外行人觉得颇受启发。热空气呈中性且轻盈，受热膨胀，飞行器便上升；让它冷却，你就下降。对那一整套阀门网络进行周期性检查是强制规定。人绝不能低估织物所承受的拉力，也不能低估突发阵风的威胁。一个人道主义团体甚至用气球把援助延伸到被洪水淹没的乡村地区，把额外的一包食物投放到轰炸机永远无法安全飞抵的地方。

今年，一位当代艺术家——一个挥金如土、爱好奢华的梦想家——把他的气球画成暗示蝗虫和蚂蚱跨越平原迁徙的图案，怪异却引人注目。一位临床心理学家做了演讲，谈到过度工作的诱惑及其滋生的苦难；她敦促我们无论从节俭还是其他角度都要休息。连那位古老家族的后裔、埃及领事也来为演出喝彩，一位穿棕褐色夹克的老瑞典人则带着安静的怜惜为它的美而落泪。

临近高潮时，五十只气球同时升空。一阵欢呼齐声爆发。表演完美无缺。我感到过去一年自身的痛苦渐渐流走。若把这种喜悦仅仅说成逃避，那是误读了它；它毋宁是疗愈的一个阶段。无论报纸头条预报了怎样的厄运，在这里，在花钱买来的、每人各享的几个钟头里，我们是自由的。我想，飞行的文学并不写在书本里，而写在一只明亮的球体缓慢、谨慎地升入晨空的过程中，我会尽可能久地借用那种感觉，毫无保留，毫不道歉，直到松垂的绳索把我唤回大地与睡眠。

如果我必须简要概述这项事业为何重要，那就是这样。节庆的成功率绝非偶然；我们容纳每一类访客，从指着横幅上画的鸭嘴兽的孩子，到靠微薄年金生活的退休者。志愿者们毫无怨言地加班，日程上任何变动都会提早公布，免得有人在入口处不一致而起争执。我们每年扩展项目，更换夜间灯光秀里每一只坏掉的灯泡，绝不让垃圾污染场地。负责丙烷的工作组不会触发任何一星半点粗心的火花；安全是整个活动最首要的成分。没人会因一个失误被拖进监狱，但也没人偷工减料。

88. The Painter and the Physicist Next Door

English

The inn at the edge of the wharf was a busy place, though its grey walls and the stain on the canvas awning made it look secondhand and dismal. Inside, a thin painter sat at a table set with a menu, a jar of olive paste, and a bowl of fresh carrot scraps the cook had spared. He had come to rest, yet his mind was an ongoing racket of ideas. He pinned a sketch to the wall with a single thumbtack, his old passion for science still burning like a fire. He would not divorce his art from science, he said, and that very claim made his work fresh. Painting, for him, was no juvenile pastime nor mere moonlighting; it was a manufactured world standing on the surface of real laws.

Next door, behind a rug that hung as a curtain, lived a quiet professor, a mathematician and sometime biologist who lectured on the curriculum of optics at the college to the south. His tongue could explain the theory of relativity as easily as a child describes snow. He spoke of the acceleration of light, the breadth of a sphere of stars, and the impact of one idea upon another, all as themselves a kind of mathematics. The painter would lick the tip of his brush, pinch a fresh tube of grey, and listen.

"Evidence," the professor said, "is the prime burden of any honest mind. A terrorist or a gangster hides behind secrecy; a scientist must seek publicity for the truth." He held that a society too permissive of deception would breed its own deadly decline. He would rejoice at a clean proof and grumble at a sloppy one. Computerization, he admitted, had changed his field; an ultrasonic scan or an X-ray now gave data he once had to fumble for by hand.

The painter, for his part, worked in a different setting. He would twist a coil of wire into a small sculpture, nestle it on a perch of driftwood, and call it done. A vender at the next stall, eager to repute himself a critic, would sneer, but the painter was willing to ignore him. Context, he believed, was everything; a scrap of color in the right place had more competence to move the heart than a whole museum.

One grey morning the two men shared a check-up of the season's plans. The professor proposed a referendum among their friends: should they introduce a joint show, mixing canvas and equation? The painter, twisting a grin, agreed at once. "A minimum of fuss," he said, "and a maximum of wonder." They would not conceal their aim. To honor an old appointment, they invited the grandparent of a neighbor, a retired commune organizer, to open it. As the snow fell outside in stillness, they drew up the plan, signed it, asked a witness to countersign, and felt, for the first time in a year, that their separate spheres had at last begun to touch. The next phase, they agreed, would prove harder, but neither doubted it was worth the burden, nor that the glamour of the idea would, in time, repay every hour of their labor.

There was, of course, no doubt left in their minds. They would seek no asylum in vanity and take no bribe of easy praise. The professor, who had once worked in banking before fleeing a capitalist scheme he found offensive, spoke of an intermediate plan: a slow removal of every weak piece, then a fierce, tigress-like defense of the strong. As a former defendant in a petty dispute, he knew how the law could repeal goodwill overnight; he would not contend with rivals of high rank, nor try to repatriate old grudges. He swatted a mosquito, smiled at the odd mixture of paint and chalk dust on his sleeve, and let the matter rest.

中文翻译

码头边的那家小客栈是个热闹的地方，尽管它灰色的墙壁和帆布雨篷上的污渍让它看上去像二手的，显得阴郁。屋内，一个瘦削的画家坐在一张桌前，桌上摆着菜单、一罐橄榄酱，还有一碗厨师匀出来的新鲜胡萝卜碎。他是来休息的，可他的脑子却是一连串源源不断的吵闹念头。他说他不会把自己的艺术与科学分离，正是这一主张让他的作品显得新鲜。

隔壁，在一张当帘子挂着的地毯后面，住着一位安静的教授，他是数学家，偶尔也搞生物学，在南边的学院里讲授光学课程。他的口才能像孩子描述雪一样轻松地解释相对论。他谈到光的加速度、群星这一球面的广度，以及一个想法对另一个想法的冲击，把这一切都当作某种数学。画家会舔舔画笔尖，捏一捏一管新鲜的灰色颜料，听他讲。

"证据，"教授说，"是任何诚实头脑的首要负担。恐怖分子或歹徒躲在秘密之后；科学家则必须为真理寻求公开。"他认为，一个对欺骗过分纵容的社会会孕育出自身致命的衰落。遇到一个干净的证明他会欣喜，遇到一个草率的便会发牢骚。他承认，计算机化改变了他的领域；如今一次超声扫描或一张X光片就能给出他过去得靠手摸索才能得到的数据。

画家这边则在另一种环境里工作。他会把一卷电线拧成一件小雕塑，安放在一根浮木的栖木上，就算完工。隔壁摊位上一个小贩，急于把自己说成评论家，会冷笑，但画家乐意不去理他。他相信，背景就是一切；一抹放对地方的颜色，比整座博物馆更有打动人心的能力。

一个灰色的清晨，两人一起核对这一季的计划。教授提议在朋友间搞一次公民投票：他们该不该推出一个把油画与方程混在一起的联展？画家咧嘴一笑，立刻同意。"麻烦最少，"他说，"惊奇最多。"他们不会隐瞒自己的目的。为了履行一个旧约，他们邀请一位邻居的祖辈——一位退休的公社组织者——来为展览揭幕。当外面的雪在寂静中飘落时，他们拟好计划，签了字，请一位见证人会签，并第一次在这一年里感到，他们各自分隔的领域终于开始触碰。他们一致认为，下一阶段会更难，但谁也不怀疑这份负担是值得的，也不怀疑这个想法的魅力终将报偿他们劳作的每一个小时。

当然，他们心中已不再有任何怀疑。他们不会在虚荣中寻求庇护，也不会接受廉价赞美的贿赂。教授曾在银行业工作过，后来逃离了一项他认为令人反感的资本主义计划，他谈起一个中间方案：先慢慢拆除每一处薄弱构件，再像母虎一样凶猛地守护牢固的部分。作为一桩小纠纷里曾经的被告，他深知法律能在一夜之间撤销人们的善意；他不会与高位的对手争斗，也不会试图把旧日的怨恨遣返回来。他拍死一只蚊子，对袖子上颜料与粉笔灰那奇特的混合物笑了笑，便把这件事搁下了。

89. The Museum of an Ancient Trade

English

On a small **Pacific** island once governed from far-off **Ireland**, an **academic** named Dr. Pace set out to **update** an old museum and **popularize** the **craftsmanship** of an **ancient** trade. The building was situated near the **water**, where the salt would **seep** into the foundations and the **monsoon** each year tested its **defence** against the storms. **Currently** the place was dismal, and visitors were few; he wanted to **reconcile** its dusty past with a **complete**, living future.

He began at the entrance **aisle**, where a **thermostat** now kept the rooms at an even temperature. On the wall, a fresh **rubric** printed in bold gave each exhibit a heading, and a glossy booklet served as a **handout** for every receiver. With a **screwdriver** and a steady **forefinger** he fixed a loose label himself; he would not **mishandle** a single relic, nor **conceal** a flaw, for he was a **truthful** and **loyal** man whose **heart** lay in honest work. He took care not to **violate** the spirit of the original collection, regardless of pressure from the new **publisher** who funded the show.

The museum told the **historical** story of the island's **peasantry**. There were tools worn smooth by use: an opener of carved bone, a **jar** that once held **shrimp** paste, a **saucer** of fired clay, and a **cylinder** press a long-dead **inventor** had built. A **soldier's costume** hung beside a robber's mask used in an old **pageant**. Glass cases displayed how the people would **breed** cattle, drive a single loyal **cow** to market, and **hatch** fish in shallow furrows of seawater. Nearby, a faded **magazine** described the whaling crews who once braved the deep, hunting **prey** that could, like a **brute**, smash a boat to **foam**.

Not everyone approved. One **entrenched** landowner, **indignant** and **pathetic** in his anger, claimed the new **tenancy** of the building was **disadvantageous** to him and **contractual** in name only. He sent an **uncalled-for** letter, almost a threat, hinting he might **alienate** the island's council. Dr. Pace refused to be intimidated. He would not let such a **brow-beating rebel** spoil the work. "I can **compute** the cost," he said calmly in the **auditorium**, before a **united assembly** of townsfolk and one visiting **pedlar**, "and I can vouch that the benefit is greater. This is no pretense."

When the doors finally opened, the response was **dazzling**. A **batch** of schoolchildren filed past the **blackboard** where a guide chalked diagrams; their **applause**, free of any **conventional** restraint, filled the hall. A **delectable** smell of grilled **hamburger** and **pineapple** drifted from a stall **outside**, near the **toilet** block and the rows of lockers. The **influence** of the day was plain: people lingered, took notes in **pencil**, and left with a sense that the **development** of their own heritage was, at last, an **entity** worth protecting. By the eleventh hour, as a soft mist rose over the **dorsal** ridge of the hills, Dr. Pace stood alone, secure in the **secrecy** of his own quiet pride, certain the museum's **slippery** decline had been halted and that no ruinous neglect, no **susceptible** weakness, no **death** of memory would claim it again. The campaign for **publicity** had not been **ruthless**; he had simply let people **pass** through and see for themselves. A retired farmer, his face lined like a **furrow**, said the museum had restored his failing **eyesight** for the past. A **college** choir sang beside an old **stereo**, and a reformed **gangster**, now a generous **giver** to charity, donated a relic from another **continent**, its **outward** shine masking a deeper worth. He offered no **apology** for caring so much, and added the day's small disbursement to the ledger with a **deposit** of hope. The **inference**, written **therein**, was simple: a trade preserved is a people preserved, and the **strategy** had worked.

中文翻译

在一座曾由遥远的爱尔兰管辖的太平洋小岛上，一位名叫佩斯博士的学者着手翻新一座旧博物馆，并推广一门古老行业的手艺。这座建筑坐落在水边，盐分会渗入地基，每年的季风都考验着它抵御风暴的防御能力。眼下这地方很阴郁，参观者寥寥；他想让它尘封的过去与一个完整而鲜活的未来相调和。

他从入口的通道着手，那里如今装了一台自动调温器，使各个房间保持均匀的温度。墙上，一行粗体印刷的新题目给每件展品都加了标题，一本光亮的小册子作为发给每位参观者的资料。他用一把螺丝刀和稳稳的食指亲手修好了一块松动的标签牌；他不会把任何一件文物装卸不慎，也不会掩盖瑕疵，因为他是个诚实而忠诚的人，他的心系于诚实的工作。无论出资办展的新出版商如何施压，他都注意不去违背原始藏品的精神。

博物馆讲述了岛上农民的历史故事。这里有被使用磨得光滑的工具：一把骨雕的起子、一只曾盛过虾酱的罐子、一个陶土碟子，还有一台早已作古的发明者造的圆筒压机。一套士兵的服装挂在一副旧庆典上用过的强盗面具旁。玻璃柜里展示着人们如何养牛、把唯一一头忠实的奶牛赶去集市，以及在浅浅的海水犁沟里孵鱼。附近一本褪色的杂志描述了当年勇闯深海的捕鲸队，他们追猎的猎物能像野兽一样把船撞成泡沫。

并非人人赞同。一位根深蒂固的地主，愤怒得既义愤又可怜，声称这座建筑新的租赁对他不利、徒有合同之名。他寄来一封多余的信，几乎是威胁，暗示他可能离间岛上议会。佩斯博士拒绝被恐吓。他不会让这样一个咄咄逼人的反叛者搅黄这项工作。“我能算出成本，”他在礼堂里平静地说，面对镇民们团结一致的集会 and 一名路过的小贩，“我也能担保收益更大。这不是装样子。”

当大门终于打开时，反响令人目眩。一批小学生鱼贯走过黑板，导览员在上面用粉笔画着图；他们的掌声毫无惯常的拘束，充满了大厅。外面一个摊位飘来烤汉堡和菠萝的诱人香味，就在厕所那栋楼和一排储物柜附近。这一天的影响显而易见：人们流连忘返，用铅笔记笔记，离开时都觉得自己这份遗产的发展终于成了一个值得保护的实体。到了第十一个小时，当一层薄雾在山丘的脊背上升起时，佩斯博士独自站着，安然守着自己那份静默骄傲的秘密，确信博物馆那滑坡式的衰退已被遏止，再没有毁灭性的疏忽、没有易受影响的弱点、没有记忆的死亡能够把它夺走。这场争取宣传的行动并不残酷无情；他只是让人们走进来，自己去看。一位退休农夫，脸上的皱纹深如犁沟，说博物馆为他修复了对往昔那衰退的「视力」。一支大学合唱团在一台旧立体声音响旁歌唱，一名改邪归正、如今对慈善慷慨解囊的前歹徒，捐出了一件来自另一个大洲的遗物，它外表的光泽掩盖着更深的价值。他不为自己如此用心而道歉，并把这一天小小的支出连同一份希望的存款记入账册。其中写下的推论很简单：一门行业被保存，便是一个民族被保存——这套策略奏效了。

90. The Queen's Charity and the Village Choir

English

It is **imperative**, the **local nun** told the children, that we **aid** one another, for **assistance** freely given is always **preferable** to charity offered as a mere **pretense**. She ran a small **parish** in the **countryside**, and her every **speech**, however short, seemed **worthy** of a **hymn**. Her **nephew**, a quiet boy with bright eyes, would **imitate** her **grammar** and her gentle tone, and the **likeness** made the whole village smile.

The parish was **situated** where a green hill adjoins a winding river, and a single **subway** line, recently extended, now linked it to the town. The local **landlord**, a **firm** but fair man whose family firm supplied grain to half the region, had agreed to **cater** the harvest feast. He would not **intimidate** his tenants; rather, he sought to **animate** the place, to **lift** its spirits and **lessen** its old burdens. He could **vouch**, he said, that the coming year held **plenty**.

This year the **queen** herself, **regardless** of the long road, planned to visit. The news did not **awaken** envy so much as joy. The children rehearsed a **dialog** and a **cartoon**-bright pageant; the choir practiced until each voice could **equal** the next. A **supplier** of costumes sent a **label**-stamped crate of robes; a **subsidiary** of the town's largest firm donated a **film** crew to record the day. **Deliberately** and with care, the committee drew up a **heading** for every part of the program and asked the bishop to **verify** the order of events.

Science, too, had its place. A visiting teacher gave a talk on the **molecular life** of the soil, on the **coefficient** of growth in a healthy field, and on how a single seed, properly tended, could **split**, sprout, and never **degenerate** into waste. He showed an **X-ray** of a leaf and a **generalization** drawn from years of study, urging the children to **envisage** a future they could build. "Do not imitate the past blindly," he said. "**Replace** what fails; **encourage** what works."

The day arrived under a thin **mist** that soon lifted. A **bead** of dew still clung to every blade as the queen stepped from her car, her **face** calm, her **hair** tied back with a simple band. She walked the avenue between two rows of villagers, paused before the firm's new **opener**-and-canning works, and admired the craftsmanship of the local carvers. A **drunk** reveler at the rear was gently steered away, and a **robber** who had once plagued the lanes was, the constable noted with **herein**-recorded relief, long since gone.

Her speech was **outstanding**, an **everyday** warmth raised to something fine. She spoke of equal worth, of the **interaction** between a people and their land, of a life lived in service. She did not animate the crowd with grand pretense but with truth. When she finished, the choir sang their hymn; the sound seemed to **constrict** every throat with feeling, then release it in applause. Even the oldest **husband** and wife, **side** by side near the **locker** of old tools, wept. The **whaling** songs of the coast, the **booklet** of local lore, the **romanticism** of the poets—all of it, for one bright afternoon, seemed to **hold** together, and no **ruinous** doubt could touch it. In the days that followed, a quiet **change** settled over the parish. Each **parent** helped to **manufacture** the small **adornment** that would **complement** the festival hall, whose **lower** wing would **adjoin** a new **pioneering** workshop. A printed **description**, no longer than a **ticket** stub, hung by the door, and the nun would **impress** upon every child that they **shall** keep the place clean. They learned to **separate** the good seed from the empty **shell**, to read a thermometer and note the **temperature**, and to **eke** out a living without bitterness. No **coffin** of old grief, no memory of past **persecution**, could lower their hope. Within the small **arena** of the courtyard, a boy with an artistic **bent** dropped a **dime** into the box for the **eleventh** time that week, a modest **disbursement** toward a brighter year, and the nun, her duty done, gave silent thanks for a day so plainly worthy of memory.

中文翻译

当地的修女对孩子们说，我们彼此相助是绝对必要的，因为自愿给予的援助，永远胜过仅仅作为借口而施舍的慈善。她在乡下管理着一个小教区，她的每一次讲话，无论多短，似乎都配得上首赞美诗。她的侄子是个安静、眼睛明亮的男孩，会模仿她的语法和温和的语气，那相似的样子让整个村子都笑了。

这个教区坐落在一座青山与一条蜿蜒河流相接的地方，一条最近延长的地铁线如今把它与镇子连了起来。当地的地主是个既坚定又公道的人，他家的公司向半个地区供应粮食，他答应承办这场丰收宴。他不会恐吓佃户；相反，他想给这地方注入活力，提振它的精神，减轻它旧日的负担。他说，他可以担保来年会有丰足的收成。

今年女王本人不顾路途遥远，计划前来访问。这消息唤起的与其说是嫉妒，不如说是喜悦。孩子们排练了一段对话和一场卡通般明快的庆典游行；唱诗班练习到每个声部都能与另一个相称。一家服装供应商送来一只贴着标签的长袍木箱；镇上最大公司的一家子公司捐出一支摄制组来记录这一天。委员会审慎而用心地为节目的每一部分拟定标题，并请主教核实活动的顺序。

科学也有它的位置。一位客座教师做了演讲，讲土壤的分子生命，讲健康田地里的生长系数，以及一粒种子若悉心照料，如何能裂开、发芽，永不退化为废物。他展示了一片树叶的X光片和一条由多年研究得出的概括，敦促孩子们去构想一个他们能够建造的未来。"不要盲目模仿过去，"他说。"替换掉失败的，鼓励奏效的。"

这一天到来时天上覆着一层薄雾，很快便消散了。女王下车时，每一片草叶上仍挂着一颗露珠，她神情平静，头发用一条简单的发带束在脑后。她走在两排村民之间的大道上，在公司新建的开罐与罐装工厂前停下，赞赏当地雕刻匠人的手艺。后排一个喝醉的狂欢者被轻轻引开，而一个曾在巷子里为患的强盗，警员在此记下并松了口气，早已不知去向。

她的讲话十分出色，把日常的温暖提升为某种美好的东西。她谈到平等的价值，谈到一个民族与他们土地之间的相互作用，谈到一生奉献于服务。她不是用浮夸的伪装来鼓动人，而是用真理。当她讲完时，唱诗班唱起赞美诗；那声音仿佛让每一个喉咙都因情感而收紧，随后又在掌声中将它释放。连那对最年长的夫妇，并肩站在装旧工具的储物柜旁，也落了泪。海岸的捕鲸歌谣、当地传说的小册子、诗人们的浪漫主义——所有这一切，在这个明亮的下午，似乎都融为一体，没有任何毁灭性的怀疑能够触碰它。在随后的日子里，一种宁静的变化笼罩了整个教区。每位家长都帮着制作那些小装饰，用以衬托节庆礼堂，礼堂较低的侧翼将与一间新建的开创性工坊相邻。门旁挂着一份不超过一张票根长的印刷说明，修女会让每个孩子铭记：他们应当保持这里整洁。他们学会把好的种子与空壳分开，学会读温度计、记录温度，学会不带怨恨地勉力谋生。任何旧日悲伤的棺材、任何过去迫害的记忆，都无法压低他们的希望。在院子这小小的竞技场里，一个有艺术天赋的男孩这一周第十一次把一枚一角硬币投进箱子，这是为更光明的一年所做的一笔微薄支出。修女在尽完本分之后，为这样一个分明值得铭记的日子默默致谢。

91. The Harbour Cafe

English

As a seasoned **traveler** keeping a **concise** journal, I learned that the best stories refuse to stay **dormant**. Last **weekday** I would **skip** the noisy main road and **resort** to a quiet **harbour cafe** near my **neighborhood**, a **public** spot open to all, where I could **chat** over a **pint** of **creamy** coffee **whilst** watching a **pigeon** and a stray **duck** **nibble** crumbs by the water. The place was never **pretentious**, and no **rival** cafe could match it; its **diverse**, **multifarious** crowd would **mingle** freely — a **poet** scribbling in **ink**, an off-duty **meteorologist** reading a weather **catalogue**, and a retired **stevedore** who once loaded a **railroad** car with **platinum** and **pyrite** ore.

The owner, a **sentimental** woman with great **tact**, kept **attendance** low so guests could **concentrate**. She told a **tale** about an ancient **treaty** signed under **moonlight**, when a **marshal** had to **salute** a **pharaoh**-like ruler and a **mercenary** army was ordered, by **sudden directive**, to **disobey** and lay down arms. To **suppress** a coming war, both sides reached a **concerted agreement**; the threat of mutual **extinction** was suddenly **null**.

I am no **spy**, **just** a **self-taught** listener with a quiet **internal** compass. Over the years a **cumulative** habit of note-taking gave me real **leeway** to wander. I have seen a **helicopter descend** onto **land** caked with **mud**, watched a **comet** streak across the **cosmos**, and studied **plankton** through an **audio-visual** lab on a university **campus**. None of it felt **stupid** or pretentious; every **tangible** detail mattered, and curiosity was the deciding **factor**.

That morning the harbour traffic sat **stationary**, a market **slump** having idled the docks. A **trumpet** rang out as a sports **rally** passed; runners completed one more **lap**, their steady **rhythm** broken only by one athlete's minor **injury** from a **deflection** off a metal **bar**. A **spike** in the crowd surged forward like a turning **wheel**, then settled behind a low **hedge**.

The **handicapped** veteran beside me, a man whose **liver** troubles made him avoid anything **alcoholic**, raised his cup as if to **shield** a memory. He had begun to **wear** the same coat for years. The **separation** of past and present, he said, is the only real **disadvantage** of growing old. There was no **absurdity** in that; it was the plain truth, hard-won on an **arduous** road. He would never **hitchhike**, never scheme for profit, and refused to let nostalgia **dominate** his days. Each **cog** of his routine turned with **purpose**, and that, more than money, was what **spread** warmth through the room.

中文翻译

作为一名经验丰富、记着**简明**日记的**旅行者**，我懂得最好的**故事**拒绝沉睡。上一个**工作日**，我会避开喧闹的主干道，转而去我家附近一间安静的**海港咖啡馆**——一个向所有人开放的**公共场所**，在那里我可以一边喝着一**品脱**奶油咖啡闲聊，一边看着一只**鸽子**和一只**野鸭**在水边轻啜面包屑。这地方从不**自命不凡**，没有哪家竞争对手的咖啡馆能与之媲美；形形色色、**各式各样**的人群在此自由地交融——一位用**墨水**涂写的**诗人**、一位下班后翻看天气**目录**的**气象学者**，还有一位曾把**白金**和黄铁矿装上**铁路**车厢的退休**码头工人**。

店主是位**多愁善感**、极有分寸的女子，她让**出席人数**保持很少，好让客人能专心。她讲了一个故事，关于一份在**月光**下签署的古老**条约**：当时一位**元帅**不得不向一位法老般的**统治者**致敬，而一支**唯利是图**的雇佣军接到**突然的命令**，要他们违抗军令、放下武器。为了**镇压**一场即将到来的战争，双方达成了一致**商定的协议**；相互灭绝的威胁顿时归于**无效**。

我不是**间谍**，只是一个自学成才的倾听者，怀着一只安静的**内在指南针**。多年来，做笔记的**累积**习惯给了我真正自由活动的余地，去四处漫游。我见过**直升机**降落在沾满**泥浆**的**陆地**上，看过**彗星**划过**宇宙**，还在大学**校园**的视听实验室里研究过**浮游生物**。这一切都不显得**愚蠢**或做作；每一个**切实**的细节都很重要，而好奇心正是决定性的**因素**。

那天早晨，海港的交通停滞不动，一场市场**不景气**让码头闲置**下来**。一阵**喇叭声**响起，一支体育集会队伍经过；跑者们又跑完**一圈**，他们平稳的节奏只被一名运动员的小伤打断——那伤来自一根金属横杠的**偏斜**反弹。人群中突然涌起一股尖峰，像转动的**车轮**般向前冲，随后又退到一道低矮的树篱后面。

坐在我旁边那位有残疑的老兵，**肝脏**不好，因而避开任何**含酒精**的东西，他举起杯子，仿佛要守护一段记忆。他已经把同一件外套**穿**了好多年。他说，过去与现在的**分离**，是变老唯一真正的**不利**之处。这话里没有**荒唐**；它是朴实的真理，在一条**艰苦**的路上来之不易。他从不免费搭便车，从不为牟利而算计，也拒绝让怀旧主宰他的日子。他日常生活的每一个齿轮都带着**目的**转动，而这一点，比金钱更能把温暖**散布**到整个房间。

92. The Oyster Farmer's Trial

English

My visit to the western coast began the day a shipowner agreed to sue a rival over a counter-offer he called dreadful. The dispute was largely about an oyster bed, a sizable quarry of shells that, since birth, had been the root of his livelihood. To examine the case, a judge had to mediate, and I was asked to learn the facts and dig into the records, however unbearable the informal paperwork seemed. Each tertiary clause, each segment of every proceeding, demanded a thorough reading.

The shipowner was a sturdy, capable man, righteous yet fickle, and his enthusiasm could strike you as both lasting and dreadful at once. He would catch the morning tide, drink a mug of strong tea, eat a slab of pudding, and clock in before the sunset of the previous day had even faded. A handful of workers, mostly young, would slack off whenever he turned his back, an idleness he could not suppress. To thrash out a routine, he set a strict mandate that would prohibit lateness; worse, he said, than a slave's chains is a blunder born of plain stupidity.

He explained, with vividness, how a hydraulic pulley driven by a small propellant pump in good tune could raise oysters from the muscle-aching deep. The requirement was teamwork; collaboration, he insisted, was elemental, and to retain a crew you must reward them, and vice versa. Cheap pay breeds envy and a consequent sense of inferiority, whereas a fair, sectional bonus can inspire loyalty. People misconceive the work, giving the wrong attribution to luck; in truth diligence helps a crew earn and even transcend old limits. He refused the abortion of a plan once begun, and would not displace a loyal hand for an obsolete machine.

Yesterday I learned how the trade had changed over a millennium. Methods once thorough are now obsolete; analogous to how an apple cart yields to a truck, the old ways lapse and a new governor of commerce takes the helm. Exposure to harsh weather can quiz even the bravest, like an infernal assault from the sea, and any lapse in care brings ruin. The work is intensive, the abundance never guaranteed, even when Jupiter shines bright as a far beacon and trade with Brazil booms.

As the rosy dawn rose over the gutter of a quiet street, a dancer in a clean collar walked by; a hen pecked at scraps, and a chemist, up early, examined a vial. The shipowner tugged his collar and, with a polite nod to a passing madam, returned to the cover of his shed to wait for the verdict.

中文翻译

我对西部海岸的那次拜访，始于一位船东决定就一份他称之为糟糕透顶的还价起诉其对手的那一天。争议主要围绕一片牡蛎床——那是一处可观的贝壳采集场，从他出生起就是他生计的根本。为了审查此案，法官得出面调解，而我被要求去了解事实并深挖记录，哪怕那些非正式的文件看似令人难以忍受。每一条第三级条款，每一份诉讼程序的每一段，都需要认真阅读。

这位船东强壮而有能力，正直却反复无常，他的热情可能让你觉得既持久又可怕。他会赶上清晨的潮水，喝一杯浓茶，吃一块布丁，赶在前一天的日落还未退去之前就打卡上工。一小批工人多半年轻，一转身就偷懒，这种懒散他无法压制。为了碎定一套规矩，他定下严格的指令禁止迟到；他说，比奴隶的锁链更糟的，是由赤裸裸的愚蠢造成的失误。

他生动地解释了一台由小型推进泵驱动的液压滑轮，只要调校得当，就能从让肌肉酸痛的深处括起牡蛎。要求是团队协作；他坚持说，协作是最基本的，要留住一支队伍就必须奖励他们，反之亦然。廉价的薪酬会滋生嫉妒与随之而来的自卑感，而公平的分部奖金则能激发忠诚。人们误解这份工作，错误地归因于运气；其实勤奋能让队伍赚钱，甚至超越旧日的极限。他拒绝中途放弃已经动工的计划，也不会为了一台过时的机器而辞退一名忠心的伙计。

昨天我了解了这一行业在一千年里的变迁。曾经周到的方法如今已过时；就像苹果手推车让位于卡车一样，旧方式逐渐消退，一位新的商业主宰接过舷柄。他警告说，暴露于恶劣天气中会考验哪怕是最勇敢的人，如同来自大海的可怖袭击，任何护理上的疏忽都会带来毁灭。这份工作强度大，丰收从不可保证，即使木星像遥远的灯塔一样明亮、与巴西的贸易蓬勃也一样。

当玫瑰色的黎明升起，映在一条宁静街道的阳沟上时，一位身着干净衣领的舞者走过；一只母鸡在启碎屑，一位早起的化学家正在检验一小瓶样本。船东拽了拽衣领，对路过的一位太太礼貌地点头，随后退回他棚屋的遮蔽处，等待裁决。

93. The Invigilator's Afternoon

English

Only a fractionally trained dean could foresee how a single afternoon would unravel. The plan was to computerize the exam hall, yet a breakdown of the main server displeased everyone. The story is true, though it sounds far-fetched, and properly told it should make you glance twice.

I had come to invigilate, a duty I expect to be dull. On the eve of the test, a rapid remittance from the secretariat had confirmed my pay, so I felt no envy. Students arrived in a long procession and would huddle against a bumpy wind, each carrying an umbrella against the rain, papers ready to sprawl across the top of every desk. One blond boy gripped a pair of scissors he had no legal reason to bring; a fussy girl clutched a tattered biography of a poet whose loyalty and patriotism had won him a strange notoriety. A toad of a man, the proctor, told them to skim no notes and to skip nothing on the page. He would utilize a strict, grammatical script for the rules, biting his lip after each line as if to interview the room with his eyes.

The room was meant to exhilarate the mind, not displease it. On the wall a faded carving and a school motto in disuse hung above the boarding-house list. Somewhere a clock ticked. To conclude the briefing, the dean read out each regulation in a sound, justifiable voice, his aim to guide rather than to scold. He invoked the heroine of an old tale, a near-idol whose courage, like a unicorn's, seemed virtual yet stirring.

Then the tremor came. It was a real, faint quake, felt far underground where alluvial soil and limestone lie. A male student's pen began to roll; another, overcome by fatigue, gave a tired crow of alarm. I had to confirm no one was hurt. Adverse rumor spread of smuggling and of a make-shift bomb, but I would not vex the room with panic. A crow flew past the window; a melon rolled off a desk and would surely fall and split its skin like a torn stitch. The dull routine, a killer of nerves, had turned thrilling. The principal, frantic yet refined, came round on a tram from the far campus to investigate.

No one was liable for the gravitation of events. The civilian crowd outside, fed false counsel by a criminal, nearly knocked down the gate. A herbalist offered ice-cream to calm the children; a nightingale-like singer hummed an overture to soothe them. The cubism on a nearby poster looked grim, its stitched edges torn. When help did come, we found the panic insufficient cause for alarm; the danger, we concluded, stemmed therefrom no real threat. Ultimately, with steady guidance, calm was restored. His report, signed with a careful rivet of ink, called it the ninth quiet ending to a noisy day, and the clan of weary staff went home to a deserved rest, the bathroom queue at last short, while Saturn rose pale over the rooftops.

中文翻译

只有一个仅受过一点点训练的系主任，才能预见一个下午会如何崩溃。计划是把考场电脑化，但主服务器的故障让所有人都不满。这件事是真的，尽管听起来很离谱，但若讲得得当，会让你多看两眼。

我来监考，这是一项我预料会很乏味的职责。考试前夕，秘书处一笔快捷的汇款确认了我的报酬，所以我毫无嫉妒。学生们排着长队进场，在颠簸的风中挤作一团，人人都拿着一把伞挡雨。一个金发男孩握着一把他根本没有合法理由带来的剪刀；一个挑剔的女孩紧攥着一本破旧的传记，传主是一位因忠诚与爱国而赢得奇怪名声的诗人。一个像蟾蜍般的人——那位监考——告诉他们不要偷看笔记，也不要跳过页上的任何内容。

这间屋子本该令人振奋，而非令人不快。墙上一幅褪色的雕刻和一句早已废弃的校训，挂在寄宿名单上方。某处一只钟在滴答。为了结束说明，系主任用稳健、有理的声音逐一读出每条规定，他的目的是引导而非责骂。他提起一个古老传说中的女主角，一个近乎偶像的人物，她的勇气如独角兽一般，虚幻却振奋人心。

然后震动来了。那是一场真实、微弱的地震，在冲积土与石灰岩深埋的地下被感知到。一个男生的笔开始滚动；另一个因疲惫而发出一声疲倦的惊呼。我得确认没有人受伤。关于走私和一枚临时炸弹的负面谣言四处传播，但我不愿用恐慌去骚扰这间屋子。一只乌鸦飞过窗口；一个甜瓜从桌上滚落。校长狂乱却不失文雅，从遥远的校区乘电车赶来调查。

没有人对这一连串事件的引力负责。外面的平民人群被一个罪犯灌输了错误的劝告，差点撞倒大门。一位草药师给孩子们送来冰淇淋安抚他们；一位夜莺般的歌手哼起一段序曲来抚慰他们。附近海报上的立体派画作看起来阴森，缝合的边缘已经破裂。等到救援真的赶到，我们发现这点恐慌不足以构成警报；我们断定，危险由此并未带来真正的威胁。最终，在稳定的引导下，平静得以恢复。他的报告用墨水仔细铆定签字，把这称作嘈杂一天里第九个安静的结尾，疲惫的一群工作人员各自回家好好休息，卫生间的队伍终于短了，而土星在屋顶上空苍白地升起。

94. The Undergraduate's Summer Job

English

On the **inaugural Monday** of summer, I took a job at a small **hotel** in **Japan**, a **marvelous** old building with a wide **patio** and a tiled **window** that would **shine** in the morning sun. As an **undergraduate** with little money, I could not afford to **starve**, so I jumped at the **vacancy** the moment an **agent** confirmed it. The pay was **equitable**, the contract was **incorporated** into a tidy **document**, and a kindly **sponsorship** from the owner made the deal **exceedingly** fair.

My duties seemed **minor** but never let up. I had to **itemize** the **goods** in the pantry, **mix** batter for **cake**, fry an **egg** or boil a **chicken**, and **insert** fresh flowers into every vase. I learned to **shun** shortcuts and to **resist** the urge to skip a task, since any **backlog** would only **sicken** the schedule and **trouble** the staff. A **restrictive** house rule warned that no one should be **oblivious** to a guest's **need**, and I tried to **honor** it with a calm **countenance** and never a **fiery** temper.

The other **recruit** was a **naughty** boy whose **timidity** hid behind loud jokes. He would **shamble** across the lobby pushing a baby's **stroller** for a young mother, then **snap** a photo with a grin. Once he dropped a **pebble** into the **gas** burner as a prank and seemed **seemingly** proud of it, an **idiot** move that earned him a light **slap** of warning from the cook. I had to **remember** that he was the real **culprit**, yet I gave him the **consolation** of a second chance.

Guests arrived from everywhere. A **deaf artist** sketched the **arctic** light; a scholar of **Islam** discussed **freedom** and faith in the **vernacular** over tea; a singer with the voice of a **nightingale** practiced each **syllable** beside the **organ** in the hall. The **amplification** of her **loudness** filled the patio, and people would **nod** and **confer** in low tones, oblivious to time. We would **still** confer **warrant** for late check-ins, a **reciprocal** courtesy.

One afternoon a pipe burst, and the **result** was instant chaos. **Molten** residue from an old **axle** had clogged a **cavity** in the boiler, and a worker had to **excavate** the **filthy clay** around it. Water rose **heavily**, so I had to **scoop** it out and **instantly divide** the wet towels into a neat **package** for the laundry. An **off-duty** plumber, watching a **hind** leg of his dog twitch in sleep, refused to let the leak **bewilder** him. He said a steady crew should **embody** calm, never panic. We used a small **calculator** to itemize the cost of an **amendment** to the lease, then ran a **shuttle** to **import** spare parts. The **franchise** office **bitterly** disputed the bill, but the manager set a **preset** budget, fed the chickens by the **hive**, and ate from his **appetite** of patience. By the end my whole **personality** felt remade, and I would not slap that summer from memory; it had become, on a humble **mat**, a true import to my growing self.

中文翻译

夏天第一个**星期一**，我在**日本**一家小**旅馆**找了份工作，那是一栋很棒的老建筑，有宽阔的**天井**和一扇**瓷砖窗**，清晨**阳光**下闪闪发亮。作为一个没什么钱的本科生，我可不能**挨饿**，所以一位中介刚一确认有**空缺**，我就立刻抓住了机会。报酬公道，合同被并入一份整齐的文件，房东的一笔好心赞助让这桩交易格外**公平**。

我的职责看似不起眼，却从不停歇。我要把储藏室的物品逐项列出，调好做**蛋糕**的面糊，煎个蛋或煮只**鸡**，还要把鲜花插进每个花瓶。我学会了避开捷径、克制跳过任务的冲动，因为任何积压都只会让日程变糟、让员工**烦恼**。一条严格的旅馆规定警告说，谁都不该对客人的需求视而不见，我努力以平静的神情去恪守它，绝不动怒。

另一个新人是个调皮的男孩，他的**胆怯**藏在大声的玩笑**后面**。他会推着婴儿车**蹒跚**地穿过大堂帮一位年轻母亲，然后咧嘴一笑拍张照。有一次他把一颗小石子丢进**煤气灶**搞恶作剧，似乎还颇为得意，这种**白痴**举动招来厨师一记轻轻的警告耳光。我得**记住**他才是真正的罪魁祸首，但我还是给了他第二次机会作为**安慰**。

客人来自各地。一位失聪的画家画着**北极**的光线；一位研究**伊斯兰教**的学者用方言喝着茶谈论**自由**与信仰；一位嗓音如**夜莺**的歌手在大厅的**风琴**旁练习每一个**音节**。她的洪亮经过**放大**充满了天井，人们会**点头**并低声商谈，浑然不觉时间流逝。我们仍会为迟到入住的客人开具许可，这是一种**互惠**的礼节。

一天下午，一根管子爆裂了。一根旧**车轴**上的熔渣堵住了锅炉的一个空腔，一名工人不得不**挖**开周围肮脏的黏土。我们用一个小**计算器**逐项算出**修改**租约的成本，然后开了一趟班车去**进口**备件。加盟总部对账单极为不满，但经理拒绝被弄糊涂；他设定了一份预设预算，在**蜂箱**旁喂了鸡，并以耐心的胃口面对一切。到夏末时，我整个人性格仿佛被重塑，我不会把那个夏天从记忆中抹去；在那张朴素的草垫上，它已成为我成长中自我的真正馈赠。

95. The Ranch Get-Together

English

The **deposition** of fresh **frost** on the **broad** valley was **reminiscent** of my childhood on a **native ranch**. Last autumn I drove out to a **get-together** hosted by an **elderly acquaintance**, a **distinguished** and **decent** rancher whose **generosity** was as **sincere** as it was famous. He had sent a **proper** invitation, signed with a flowing **signature**, and I could **predict** the day would be a **happy** one as I took the **approach** road past the **dock** and the old **rail** line.

The ranch was a hive of honest work. At dawn the **livestock** would stir, and a hired **retailer** of feed arrived to **mount** a delivery, his truck **rough** on the **uneven**, bumpy track. I watched a **worm** wriggle in the **ripe** soil and a green **sprout** **pry** its way up through a **chunk** of softened earth. The rancher would **pore** over a seed catalogue, deciding which **plant** to grow, and he kept an old **gun** by the door against coyotes. He liked **detailed statistics**; he would **argue**, with a **sensible humor**, that the **salability** of his beef was a **relatively** steady, if **middling**, business, dependent on the **duration** of good weather and on a fair **rebate** from the market. To **possess** such land, he said, demanded that one **check** every figure and **beware** of every **faulty** calculation.

Inside, the kitchen smelled of **soap** and fresh bread. A **ceramic** bowl held a **soluble** powder for the **meringue** his niece was beating into a happy froth. We ate a **hotdog** each, then went to **wash** up. An **Irish** guest in a thick **sweater** told us, with rough good cheer, of an **American pilgrim** whose pry into family records had uncovered an **heiress** and a long-lost **portrait**. An **onlooker**, a quiet **intellect**, gave an **interesting recital** of a poem whose **intonation** and **inclination** toward melancholy made us all **shrug** and smile.

Not everything was easy. A **nasty bug** had bitten the herd, and the **gene** pool, the rancher feared, had grown too thin; the **radium**-bright sun of the **equator** seemed to mock his **cumbersome**, **demanding** routine. He had a **scheme** to **disguise** the loss and to redistribute the **strong** calves, but he would **forbid** any plan that proved immoral. **Regretfully**, a **constraint** on water put real **privacy** and rest out of reach.

We knocked off at dusk, and a sudden **knock** at the door announced a late guest. My **playmate** from years past, now a **selfish** but charming man, liked to **shuffle** a deck of cards by the **tile** stove. A **thinner**, **aching** cold crept in, and I felt a pang of **carelessness** for having stayed so long. Yet the **social** warmth, granted **unconditionally**, was a fine **hobby** of the heart, and I would **approve** of such a gathering again, without **trial** or doubt.

中文翻译

新霜沉积在宽阔的山谷上，令我回想起在故乡牧场度过的童年。去年秋天，我开车去参加一位年长熟人举办的聚会，他是一位德高望重、正派的牧场主，慷慨之心与其名声一样真诚。他寄来了一份正式的请柬，签着流畅的签名，当我沿着小路驶过码头和旧铁路线时，便能预见这将是愉快的一天。

这座牧场是诚实劳作的繁忙之地。黎明时分，牲畜开始骚动，一位受雇的饲料零售商赶来卸货，他的卡车在坑洼不平的小路上颠簸。我看着一条虫子在成熟的土壤里蠕动，一株嫩芽从一块松软的泥土中艰难钻出。牧场主喜欢详尽的统计数据；他会带着明智的幽默争辩说，他牛肉的销路取决于好天气的持续时间，以及市场上公道的回扣。他说，要拥有这样的土地，就必须提防每一次错误的计算。

屋里飘着肥皂和新鲜面包的香味。一个陶瓷碗里盛着可溶的粉末，是他侄女打成蛋白霜的原料。我们各吃了一个热狗，然后洗了碗。一位穿着厚毛衣的爱尔兰客人，带着粗犷的好心情，给我们讲了一个美国朝圣者的故事，他对家族记录的探究揭出了一位女继承人和一幅久已失落的肖像。一位旁观者，一个安静的才智之士，朗诵了一首诗，其语调和忧郁的倾向让我们都耸耸肩，会心微笑。

并非事事顺利。一种讨厌的虫子叮咬了牛群，牧场主担心基因库已变得太单薄；赤道般锃光刺眼的太阳似乎在嘲笑他繁重而苛刻的日常。他有一个计划，想掩盖损失并重新分配强壮的小牛，但他禁止任何被证明不道德的方案。遗憾的是，水源的限制让真正的私密与休息变得遥不可及。

黄昏时我们收了工。我多年前的玩伴，如今是个自私却迷人的男人，在瓷砖火炉旁洗着一副扑克牌。一股更瘦削、酸痛寒意悄然袭来，我为自己逗留如此之久而生出一丝懊悔。然而那无条件给予的社交温暖，是心灵的一种美好嗜好，我愿意再次赞同这样的聚会，毫无疑问或迟疑。

96. A Canadian Family Reunion

English

Every year during the long winding road home for Thanksgiving Day, our homely Canadian family would gather in a rented farmhouse to celebrate a festival of food and memory. The rental was plain but warm, and the key to the front door hung from a faded ribbon like a small private treasure. I cannot bear to miss it; the anticipation alone could enchant me for weeks.

My grandmother, a proud lady whose marriage had lasted fifty years, ruled the kitchen with quiet gravity. She would govern the stove, harden the toffee, and puff flour across a tray as she rolled the filling for the pies. Namely, she made three: pumpkin, apple, and a Danish pastry she had learned to bake abroad. She liked to cite an old written recipe, an heirloom whose ink had begun to fade, and she would not modify it for anything, not even to cut a single calorie. To loosen the dough she added cream, and the rich, fabulous smell could fascinate any child in the house.

My uncle, a reticent man, worked in telecommunication and could explain any system of automation, from a barrel-shaped engine to the machinery that ran the local ministry of transport. He spoke of progress with pride, citing protectionism and indemnity clauses as if they were poetry. He could even explain each abbreviation on a circuit board entirely from memory, pausing only to play a slow tune on the upright piano. He once showed me an odometer he had taken from a deceased neighbor's car, hoping to reclaim and restore it, and a coupon book, a monthly rebate scheme, that he kept like a fossil of thriftier days. He never let his curiosity falter.

After dinner we played games. A comic cousin would mimic a panther creeping, then a frog leaping, while the youngest cradled an ivory chess piece like a sled-bound toy. We held a contest of riddles; the prize was a globe and a worn map of Rome. I cannot disentangle one memory from another, for they all puff together like smoke.

Not every year was easy. One winter influenza, a sharp respiratory illness, left two of us sick and mournful, and a continental cold snap froze the tar on the road. An ominous telephone call once warned of a smuggler caught at the border, an immoral man whose retrial in court was front-page news; the case, undeniable in its detail, had to be settled by a fair measure of law. We would mail a card to the lonesome, the rose-cheeked nursery children, and to relatives who could not travel.

Finally, plumb tired and happy, we would throw the last logs on the fire with a thick glove to guard our hands. An aquatic calm settled, as if the whole globe had paused in motion. Like a slow, steady puff of breath, the evening closed; it was available to us only once a year, etc., yet it never lost its meaning, and the reproach of distance melted away.

中文翻译

每年感恩节,我们沿着漫长蜿蜒的回家之路返乡时,这个朴实的加拿大家庭都会聚在一间租来的农舍里,庆祝一场关于美食与回忆的节日。这租来的房子简朴却温暖,前门钥匙系在一条褪色的丝带上,像一件小小的私人珍宝。我无法忍受错过它;光是这份期待就能让我陶醉好几个星期。

我的祖母是一位骄傲的女士,她的婚姻已经维系了五十年,她以一种安静的庄重统治着厨房。她会掌管炉灶,把太妃糖熬硬,一边把馅料擀进馅饼一边让面粉喷洒在烤盘上。也就是说,她做三种:南瓜派、苹果派,还有一种她在外国学会烤的丹麦酥皮点心。她喜欢引用一份古老的手写食谱,那是一件墨迹开始褪色的传家宝,无论如何她都不会修改它,哪怕只是少放一卡路里。为了让面团松软,她会加奶油,那浓郁奇妙的香味能让屋里任何一个孩子着迷。

我的叔叔是个沉默寡言的人,从事电信工作,能解释任何自动化系统,从桶形发动机到运营当地交通部的机械。他谈起进步时满怀自豪,引用贸易保护主义和赔偿条款仿佛它们是诗。他曾给我看一只从已故邻居车上拆下来的里程表,还有一本优惠券册,一个按月返利的方案,他把它当作节俭年代的化石珍藏。他的好奇心从不动摇。

晚饭后我们玩游戏。一个滑稽的表亲会模仿黑豹潜行,然后学青蛙跳跃,而最小的孩子像抱着雪橇玩具一样捧着一枚象牙棋子。我们举行猜谜比赛;奖品是一个地球仪和一张破旧的罗马地图。我无法把一段记忆与另一段分开,因为它们都像烟一样喷涌交融。

并非每年都顺利。有一年流感——一种凶猛的呼吸道疾病——让我们两人病倒、心情忧伤,而一场大陆性的寒潮冻住了路面上的柏油。曾有一通不祥的电话警告说边境抓到一名走私者,那个不道德之人的重审成了头条新闻;此案细节确凿无疑,只能由公正的法律尺度来裁决。我们会寄一张卡片给孤独的人,给那些脸蛋红润的托儿所孩子,以及无法远行的亲戚。

最后,累得筋疲力尽却心满意足,我们会把最后几块木柴扔进火里。一种水一般的宁静降临,仿佛整个地球都在运动中停顿了。像一口缓慢平稳的呼吸,夜晚落幕;它每年只对我们开放一次,如此等等,却从未失去它的意义,而距离带来的责备也烟消云散。

97. The Old Carpenter's Workshop

English

I still remember the **hubbub** of my grandfather's **carpentry** shop, a place that could **muffle** the noise of the **windy** street and replace it with the steady **flow** of honest work. As a boy of **seventeen** I would **bike** there after school, **hungry** for the **warmth** and **serenity** of the **four** cluttered walls. He kept the place in **optimal** order, every chisel and saw on **par** with the next, every **accessory** in its proper **category**. An old **aphorism** hung above the door, **wrought** in iron: a **steadfast** hand and a **logical** mind together **denote** a true craftsman.

Grandfather was a **renowned** **weaver** of wood, though he was **color-blind** and could not always trust his eyes. He would **consult** a worn manual, **calculate** each angle, and **adhere** to a plan that was always **definitive**. To **prepare** a fresh board he would measure twice, his **attention** never wavering. I watched, in something close to **ecstasy**, as a plain plank was transformed **downwards** from rough timber into a thing of beauty, and the **joy** of it was **inextricable** from my earliest **memory**.

He disliked **drudgery** for its own sake, yet he refused to **relinquish** patience. 'Luck is **unavoidable**,' he would say, 'but you cannot **bait** it; you must earn it.' He had no **intention** to **deceive** a customer, and any **flimsy** or **unsuitable** job he would tear apart and begin again. He never showed **indifference** to a flaw. A single misaligned **rib** of a chair could cause **havoc** to the whole frame, and he refused to **conform** to shoddy taste merely to win **patronage**.

The shop sold many things. A **king** of customers, a wealthy man, once placed an **invitation** to build a cabinet adorned with carved leaves, a **cardinal** piece for his hall. Grandfather wrought it so the joints were perfectly **congruent**, then sent me on an **errand** to **inform** the buyer. The man's **delight** was a small **victory**, an **advantage** of good name that money could not buy.

Over the years a quiet **disintegration** set in. His old **washing-machine** broke; a leak in the **roof** let **evaporation** rot a beam; the **displacement** of the trade by automation made the **awkward** future hard to **translate** into hope. Yet he remained **courageous**. He would not **swerve** from his **quest**, nor **lock** the door on his calling. A **manifold** of small **mushroom**-like worries could **occur**, but he met each with an **easy** grace.

I am forever **indebted** to him. When a child would **toddle** in and a dog would **bark** and **paw** at a **quart** pail, he would smile, **dose** out a sweet, and **adorn** the moment with a story. His shop was a kind of **forum**, a place of **wholesome** talk where every **outlook** met. He had a clear **conception** of craft, and he would **use** no shortcut; a clumsy joint, **notably**, could **deflate** his pride faster than a snapped **sword**. He gave my **mental** world its shape, and his **holding** of one **hectare** of dignity, **mechanical** and human at once, taught me what it means to be a **friend** to one's own work.

中文翻译

我至今仍记得祖父木工坊里的喧闹，那地方能把街上的风声压下去，代之以诚实劳作的稳稳节奏。十七岁那年，我放学后骑车去那儿，渴望那四壁杂乱却温暖宁静的氛围。他把店铺收拾得井井有条，每把凿子和锯子都摆得整整齐齐，每件配件都归在恰当类别里。门上方挂着一句铁打的古老格言：稳健的手和缜密的头脑，二者合一，才显出真正的工匠。

祖父是远近闻名的木工巧匠，尽管他色盲，眼睛并不总能信赖。他会查阅一本破旧的手册，计算每一个角度，并坚持一份始终确定无疑的方案。为了备好一块新木板，他会量两遍，注意力从不松懈。我看着一块普通的木板从粗糙的原木被一点点削制成美丽之物，那种近乎狂喜的喜悦，与我最早的记忆密不可分。

他厌恶为苦工而苦工，却从不肯放弃耐心。他常说：'运气无可避免，但你不能去诱它；你得去挣得它。'他无意欺骗顾客，任何粗劣或不合格的活儿，他都会拆掉重做。他对瑕疵从不漠然。一把椅子上一根没对齐的横档，就可能毁掉整个框架，他也绝不迎合粗劣品味、博取主顾而将就。

店里卖各种东西。一位富有的大主顾曾下了订单，要做一只镌刻着叶纹的橱柜，是他厅堂里最重要的一件。祖父把它做得接榫严丝合缝，然后差我去跑腿通知买主。那人的欢喜是一场小小的胜利，是金钱买不到的好名声带来的优势。

岁月里，一种悄然的衰败开始了。他的旧洗衣机坏了；屋顶漏雨，水汽蒸腾，腐蚀了一根梁；自动化对这门行当的取代，使得别扭的未来难以化作希望。然而他依旧勇敢。他不肯偏离自己的追求，也不肯对自己的天职关上门。无数蘑菇般冒出的小忧虑会接踵而至，但他都以从容的优雅去面对。

我永远感激他。每当一个孩子蹒跚走进来，一条狗吠叫着用爪子去扒一只夸脱的桶，他便会微笑，分出一颗糖果，再用一个故事点缀那一刻。他的店铺像是一个论坛，是个人人畅谈的健康之地，各种观点都在此相会。他对手艺有清晰的认知，从不走捷径；一处笨拙的接榫，尤其会比折断的剑更快地令他的自尊泄了气。他塑造了我精神世界的模样，而他那一公顷尊严的坚守——既是机械的，又是人性的——教会了我何为对自己的事业忠诚。

98. The Provincial Boxer

English

It is **unlikely** that anyone in our **provincial** town will forget the **hard-working boxer** who once trained behind the old **cathedral**. He was **born** in a **solitary brick** house near the **airport**, the son of a **gardener**, and **from** an early age he had an **absolute, heartfelt motive**: to escape the **dropout's** fate and make something **terrific** of his life. His **physique** was **ungainly** at first, **chiefly** because a childhood **surgery** had left one shoulder stiff, but he learned to **pronounce** each ambition aloud, dwelling on every **vowel** as if the very sound were a **referent** for his dream, a quiet creed of **humanism** that put human effort above all. Years of **experience**, stacked one upon the next like a tall **stack** of worn gloves, would **standardize** his own resolve.

He would **bypass** the noisy **cafeteria** and ride his **bicycle** past the **zebra** crossing to a humble gym above a **kitchen** that always smelled of **butter** and toast. There he would **devote** whole afternoons to the **chase** of skill, working a single **tactic** until it ran **smoothly**. A **bossy** old coach, a former **commissioner** of the regional league, did not spare the **rebuke**; his harsh words could **seize** a man's pride, yet they were never pure **cruelty**. 'Comply with the **protocol**,' he would **say**, 'or **simply** leave.'

The coach loved to elaborate. His **elaboration** on footwork was a kind of **verse**, and he could **compile** a whole **canon** of drills from memory. He taught the boy to **understand** each **facet** of the ring, to **contrast** a clumsy lunge with a clean one, and to **ascertain** an opponent's weakness before the first **horn**. 'Hatred has no place here,' he said. 'Neutrality of mind, and a **fruitful** patience, will **produce** the win.' It was a **fallacy**, he insisted, that rage alone could **shoot** a man to victory; that was an **awful** and **prohibitive** lie.

Life outside the gym was harder. **Inflation** had made even **postage** dear, and the cost of clean **linen** and good **fabric** for his robe was nearly prohibitive. A provincial **reporter**, eager for an **issue** to fill the page, once wrote a **doubtful** piece that seemed to **trespass** on his privacy, citing a faked **facsimile** of a contract. The boy felt **mean** and **blue** for a day, then would **refresh** his focus and let the slight pass like a **breeze**.

On **Boxing-Day**, the **eleven**-year mark of his career and his eleventh fight, he stepped onto the **stage**. The hall, thick with **smog** from outside and the heat of the crowd, would **hinge** on a single round. He would not **hurl** wild blows; he moved in a calm **orbit**, a **compound** of speed and grace, until the **executive** judges, with absolute fairness, named him the winner. A **typhoon** of cheers rose. **Royalty** itself, they joked, would envy such **comfort** and delight. He sipped a cold **beverage**, **qualify** at last for the national stage, and offered a quiet **specimen** of thanks, a **delicacy** of feeling that no **isolation** or fame could ever take from him.

中文翻译

我们这座外省小镇上，大概没有人会忘记那位曾在老教堂后面训练的勤奋拳手。他**出生**在**机场**附近一栋孤零零的**砖房**里，是一位**园丁**的儿子，从小他就怀着一个绝对而真挚的**动机**：摆脱辍学者的命运，让自己的人生有所成就。起初他的**体格**笨拙，但他学会把每一个志向大声**说**出来，仿佛要把自己的决心**规范化**。

他会绕开喧闹的食堂，骑着**自行车**经过**斑马线**，来到一间**厨房**楼上的简陋拳馆，那厨房里总飘着**黄油**和烤面包的味道。在那里他会把整个下午奉献给对技艺的**追逐**，反复练一个战术，直到它运转流畅。一位专横的老教练——地区联赛的前任**专员**——从不吝惜责备；他刻薄的话能攫住一个人的自尊，但那从不是纯粹的残忍。‘遵守规程，’他会说，‘否则干脆走人。’

教练喜欢详加阐述。他对步法的阐述像是一种**韵文**，他能凭记忆编纂出一整套训练教规。他教这男孩**理解**拳台的每一个**方面**，把**笨拙**的出击与利落的出击作对比，并在第一声号**角**响起前就探明对手的弱点。‘这里没有仇恨的位置，’他说。‘心境的中立，加上**富有成效**的耐心，才能赢下比赛。’他坚称，以为单凭狂怒就能把一个人射向胜利，那是一种**谬误**；那是个**可怕**而要命的谎言。

拳馆之外的生活更艰难。**通货膨胀**让连**邮费**都变贵，做拳袍要用的干净亚麻和好布料几乎贵得离谱。一位急于找个话题填版面的外省**记者**，曾写过一篇可疑的报道，似乎侵犯了他的隐私，还引用了一份伪造的合同**传真件**。男孩**沮丧**消沉了一天，随后重整专注，让这点轻慢像**微风**一样**掠过**。

在**节礼日**，他职业生涯的**第十一**场比赛中，他登上了擂台。大厅里弥漫着外面飘来的**烟雾**和人群的热气，胜负系于一个回合。他不会胡乱挥拳；他在一个沉稳的轨道里移动，是速度与优雅的结合，直到**执行**裁判们以**绝对的**公正**宣布**他获胜。一阵欢呼如**台风**般涌起。他们打趣说，连王室都会羡慕这样的**舒适**与喜悦。他啜了一口冰凉的饮料，终于有资格登上全国**舞台**，并献上**一份**安静的谢意样本，一种任何**孤独**或名声都夺不走的细腻情感。

99. The Inventor of Iceland

English

How a refined governess from Iceland came to hold a copyright on a super wireless generator is a tale worth the daily grind of telling. Her name, hereinafter the Inventor, was known across society for her analytical mind and her steady, almost ethereal calm. She never let a single germ of doubt grind her down. Each daytime she would scramble up a massive hill at a brisk pace, trot home, and abide by a strict budget, principally to fund her secret undertaking.

The core of her work was a translucent filament that, when fed a dual current, could weld itself to a stainless bracket and glow with a light pliable enough to bend. She had to calibrate it with great detail, adapt the design again and again, and counterbalance the inefficiency of the early models. A frantic period followed; she would grunt over the equations, paint diagrams across the wall, and treat each failure as a lesson rather than a defeat. Her deep understanding of physics made safety her first priority.

Her sister, a fisherman's wife, and her young niece helped without complaint. They would canvass the village for parts, declare every honest cost, and abide by a managerial discipline that no thief or careless hand could spoil. The Inventor took the initiative to elect a small board, responsible and virtuous, to guard against piracy of her idea. A brutal controversy soon arose: a rival in America, negligent of all ethics, tried to redistribute her plans under a false name. The undermentioned clause of her contract, however, gave her the affirmative right to fight back.

The project would ultimately culminate on a quiet evening when Venus hung bright in the sky. With a single clap she switched on the generator; a hose of coolant hissed, and the device hummed toward infinity. Her champion supporters cheered. The light, steadily brightening, seemed to coincide with the dawn of something new. It was not a missile of war but an inducement to peace, a thing of permanence rather than spectacle.

That night she ate a simple meal of beef and a vitamin tonic, then arranged a bouquet on the windowsill in remembrance of her late mother. A doctor friend rode in on the last tram to say hello and to tackle a small repair. She would not strew her success across the headlines; instead she set a modest target, accept the praise eastward toward the harbour, and let a rhyme of gratitude settle in her heart. The dye of her ambition had set; her livelihood, built on the firm constitution of patience, was finally her own.

中文翻译

一位来自冰岛、举止文雅的女家庭教师，是如何拥有一台超级无线发电机的版权的，这是个值得费力讲述的故事。她的名字——下文称为发明家——以其善于分析的头脑和稳定得近乎飘逸的沉静而闻名于社会。她从不让一丝怀疑的萌芽把自己磨垮。每个白天她都会快步爬上一座巨大的山丘，再小跑回家，并恪守严格的预算，主要是为了资助她那秘密的事业。

她工作的核心是一根半透明的灯丝，当通入双向电流时，它能把自己焊接到一个不锈钢托架上，并发出柔韧到可以弯曲的光。她必须极其细致地校准它，一次次调整设计，并抵消早期型号的低效。一段疯狂的时期随之而来；她会对着方程嘟囔，把图表画满墙壁，把每一次失败都当作教训而非挫败。

她的姐姐——一位渔夫的妻子——和她年幼的侄女毫无怨言地帮忙。她们会到村里四处搜集零件，如实申报每一笔诚实的成本，并遵守一种任何窃贼或粗心之手都无法破坏的管理纪律。发明家主动提议选出一个小小的董事会，既负责又正直，以防她的创意被剽窃。一场残酷的争议很快爆发：美国的一个竞争者，毫无道德顾忌，企图用假名重新散布她的方案。然而，她合同中下述的那一条款，赋予了她反击的正当权利。

这个项目最终在一个金星高悬、明亮的安静夜晚迎来高潮。她一拍手就开启了发电机；一根冷却液软管发出嘶嘶声，装置朝着无限嗡鸣运转。她的拥护者们欢呼。那道光稳稳地变亮，仿佛与某种崭新事物的黎明相吻合。它不是战争的导弹，而是和平的诱因，是一种持久之物，而非一时的奇观。

那夜她吃了一顿简单的牛肉和一剂维生素补品，然后在窗台上摆了一束花，以纪念她已故的母亲。一位医生朋友乘最后一班电车赶来打招呼，并顺手处理一处小小的修理。她不会把自己的成功撒满头条；相反，她设定了一个适度的目标，朝着海港方向向东接受赞誉，让一段感恩的韵律在心中安顿下来。她抱负的染色已经定型；她的生计，建立在耐心这坚实的体质之上，终于属于她自己。

100. The Charity Bazaar

English

The annual **charity bazaar** in our **oriental** seaside town was a **genial, energetic** affair, and this year it carried a special weight of **commemoration**. We held it in remembrance of a beloved **missionary** who had spent her life helping the **homeless**, and the **preparation** alone took months. **Without** her, the work would have been **infinitely** harder, and her **introduction** of small kindnesses had, **over** the years, helped to **fortify** the whole community.

The square was a **paradise** of color. Stalls lined every **wall**, each one **suitable** for a different trade. One booth sold **tulip** bulbs and seeds; a **second** offered an **up-to-date pictorial** catalogue printed by a **duty-free** importer. An elderly tailor had hauled out his old **sewing-machine** and a battered **typewriter**, and beside him a clerk made **photostatic** copies for a **fractional** fee. A vendor of cameras let children peer through one **camera's** clean **lens**, while a fishmonger laid out a fresh **halibut** on ice. I bought a plain **shirt** and an **innocuous** little **ashtray** as a gift.

The day was not without its **dilemma**. A **frequent** visitor, a man once nearly **bankrupt**, arrived **homesick** and weary; his **confidence** had grown **inferior** to his old **vigor**, and he seemed ready to **doze** in a corner rather than join the fun. We urged him, **urgently** but gently, to **cope** and to **receive** the warmth of the crowd. Slowly his **grit** returned. He helped **irrigate** the flower beds, carried a child **piggyback** through the **laughter**, and would **clench** his fists in a **gesture** of renewed **greatness**.

There were games of every **figure**. A **naval** veteran ran a ring-toss; a strong-arm **competition** tested who could **combat** fatigue the longest, the **championship** decided by a single **concurrent** throw. Energy seemed to **swell** and **reel** through the square. Now and then a **weird** hush would **halt** the noise as a **melody** drifted from a **fan-cooled** bandstand, only for the din to **activate** again like a **capillary** catching the tide.

Profits would **fund** a clinic. A doctor explained, with quiet **piety**, how a **scarce medication**, mixed with **glycerin**, could keep a wound from turning septic, and how iron in the blood could **oxidize** and **darken** if a patient went untreated. He cited one **instance** of a sailor whose arm, crushed by a falling **shaft**, had healed only after a long **confinement** in bed, the daily **irritation** of the dressings a small price for survival. An **injure** to the body, he said, must be met second by second, **irrespective** of cost, lest a small hurt swell into a **devastating recurrence** that could **devastate** a family. The **effectiveness** of early care was, he insisted, **appreciably** greater.

By **night**, the lamps glowed at their **peak** over the **edge** of the harbour. A child fell **asleep** on a **bookcase** bench near a **gear-driven** music box; a peak of joy settled over us all. There had been no **burial** of hope here, only its revival. The **product** of our labor was **nought** less than belonging, and as people drifted home **around** the quiet streets, no one needed to **apologize** for a single tear of gratitude.

中文翻译

我们这座**东方**海滨小镇一年一度的慈善义卖会是个**亲切**而充满活力的盛事，今年它还承载着特殊的**纪念**意义。我们举办它是为了缅怀一位深受爱戴的**传教士**，她一生致力于帮助**无家可归者**，光是筹备就花了好几个月。**没有**她，这项工作会艰难**无数倍**，而多年来她带来的种种小小善举，已让整个社区变得更加坚强。

广场是色彩的天堂。每面**墙边**都排着摊位，每个摊位都适合一种不同的行当。一个摊位卖**郁金香**球茎和种子；**第二个**摊位提供一份由**免税**进口商印制的**最新**图文目录。一位年长的裁缝搬出了他那台旧**缝纫机**和一台破旧的**打字机**，他旁边一位职员以零头的费用提供影印复印件。一个卖相机的小贩让孩子们透过干净的镜头张望，而一个鱼贩则把一条新鲜的大比目鱼摆在冰上。我买了一件朴素的**衬衫**和一个**无害**的**小烟灰缸**当礼物。

这一天也并非没有难题。一位常客，一个曾几近**破产**的男人，带着**思乡**和疲惫到来；他的**自信**已不及往日的**精力**，似乎宁愿在角落里打盹，也不愿加入欢乐。我们急切而温和地劝他振作起来，去接受人群的温暖。渐渐地，他的毅力回来了。他帮忙浇灌花圃，背着一个孩子穿过**笑声**，攥紧拳头，做出重焕生机的姿态。

各种各样的游戏都有。一位**海军**老兵主持套圈；一场比力气的**比赛**考验谁能最久地**对抗**疲劳，冠军由一次并行的投掷**决定**。活力似乎在广场上涨潮、回旋。时不时会有一阵诡异的寂静让喧闹停下，因为一段**旋律**从**风扇**降温的乐台飘来，随后嘈杂声又像毛细血管接住潮水般重新涌起。

收益将用来资助一家诊所。一位医生带着安静的**虔诚**解释道，一种稀缺的**药物**，与**甘油**混合后，可以防止伤口化脓；血液中的铁若得不到治疗，会**氧化**并变暗。他说，身体的**伤害**必须分秒必争地处理，不计代价，免得小伤膨胀成毁灭性的复发，进而毁掉一个家庭。他坚称，及早护理的效果要明显得多。

入**夜**时分，灯火在海港边缘升至最盛。一个孩子在台**齿轮**驱动的音乐盒旁的书架长椅上**睡着**了；一阵喜悦的**高峰**笼罩着我们所有人。这里没有希望的**葬礼**，只有它的复苏。我们劳动的成果不亚于归属感，当人们绕着安静的街道渐渐回家时，没有人需要为一滴感激的泪水**道歉**。